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Song of Songs

Song of Solomon 1:1

Section 1:1 Song of Songs

Most scholars agree that the phrase “Song of Songs,” which occurs in 1:1, is like a title for the book. Some scholars call 1:1 a “superscription.” A superscription functions like the title page of a modern book. It gives information such as the title or content of the book and its author. For English versions, a separate title based on 1:1 is usually also included. There are two different titles that are commonly used in English Bibles:

1. “The Song of Songs” or “Song of Songs” (BSB, CEV, GW, NCV, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB, GNT)
2. “The Song of Solomon” or “Song of Solomon” (ESV, NASB, NET, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It is a better translation of the Hebrew title, which expresses the idea “the best song.” (See the note on 1:1 for translation suggestions for the phrase “Song of Songs.”) However, option (2) is also acceptable, especially if a national version in your area uses it.

1:1

This is Solomon’s Song of Songs.

- The song that is written here is the sweetest/loveliest song that Solomon composed/wrote.
- Here is Solomon’s most beautiful song.

This is Solomon’s Song of Songs: This verse begins the book with a title Song of Songs. The possessive Solomon’s may imply that Solomon was the author or it may imply that someone composed it for him. In some languages, it is helpful to translate 1:1 as a complete sentence. For example:

This is the most beautiful song, which is Solomon’s.

This is the Song of Songs, which Solomon wrote/sang.

Here begins the Song of Songs by Solomon.

This is Solomon’s: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as This is Solomon’s probably indicates that Solomon was the author. This was the traditional interpretation. But many modern scholars doubt that Solomon was the author. They interpret the expression

“which is Solomon’s” to mean that the book was associated with him or belonged to him in some way. But nearly all English versions either imply or state that Solomon was the author. Some of the doubt about Solomon being the author is based on the fact that the Hebrew preposition *le* can have various meanings. For example: (1) It may mean “written by” Solomon; (2) “belonging to” Solomon; (3) “part of” Solomon’s collection; (4) “dedicated to” Solomon; or (5) “about” Solomon. Barbiero (2011) says that the phrase “‘which is of Solomon’ is ‘an expression of authorship’ (page 45). He suggests that this is a “fictional attribution.” In that ancient cultural context, authorship may have been understood more flexibly than in our present day culture. Attributing a writing to a famous author was a common practice and probably would not have been considered unethical nor as plagiarism. Barbiero believes that the Song was probably not written by Solomon, yet because he believed that the Song’s author/editor intended to ascribe authorship to Solomon, it should be translated that way. Actually this might be close to the truth if one considers the broader ancient understandings of “authorship.” So, the most natural way to translate *asher lishlomo* in this context would probably be as indicating Solomonic authorship, even though by our definition it may not be literally true that Solomon was the author by our modern standards. There are two ways to translate the phrase:

- Use a phrase that implies Solomon was the author. For example:

The Song of Songs, which is Solomon’s (RSV)

- Use a more specific expression that clearly identifies Solomon as the author. For example:

The Song of Songs, written/composed by Solomon

Solomon’s: Solomon was one of the most famous kings of Israel. He was known for his great wisdom, and his name in 1:1 gives the book status and authority. Since Solomon wrote proverbs and other wise instruction, his name here may also imply that this is a type of Wisdom Literature (which includes Job, Ecclesiastes, and Proverbs). However, he is not an active character in the book. When most modern English versions use headings to identify the male speaker in the Song, they use general headings such as “he,” “man,” “young man,” “lover,” or “groom.” (BSB, CEV, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB, GNT) rather than “Solomon.” Most modern commentators who follow

the “love poetry” interpretation agree that Solomon is not an active character in the Song. Solomon was not the man whom the woman loved. The author did not tell the name of the man whom she loved.

Song of Songs: The phrase Song of Songs is a type of comparison called a “superlative.” It indicates that something is the greatest or best of its kind. Other superlatives in the Old Testament include “holy of holies” (the most holy place) and “Lord of lords” (the Lord over all other lords). Song of Songs means “the most beautiful song,” “the best song.” A few Bible scholars suggest that this phrase means “the song consisting of many songs.” But by far the most common understanding of this construction is that it functions as a Hebrew superlative, meaning “the best song.” Other ways to translate Song of Songs are:

This is Solomon’s song of songs, more wonderful than any other. (NLT)

The most beautiful song of Solomon. (GW)

In some languages it is not possible to translate a superlative literally. Use a natural way in your language to describe a song that is more excellent and beautiful than other songs. Some other ways to describe it are:

Here is a song by Solomon that is sweeter than any other song.

This song that Solomon wrote/sang is wonderful. No one has heard a song like it.

Song: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Song identifies the book as a type of poetry that people can sing. They can also play musical instruments as they sing or chant the Song. The theme of the Song is romantic love (love between a man and a woman), so it is “love poetry.”

The Hebrew word for Song here is a general word that can refer to different types of joyful songs. Use an appropriate word in your language to refer to a joyful love song. Notice that the word is singular. This suggests that the book is one unified song, not a collection of many songs.

Song of Solomon 1:2

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they

loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7–8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3–4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

Lines 1:2–4 are the introduction to Section 1:2–2:7. In these lines, the poet summarizes the Song’s message and introduces its main characters: the woman, the man, and a group of young women. In the Song the woman spoke more often than the man spoke. After the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2–4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 1:2–4b The woman said that she desired her beloved

In the Hebrew text of 1:2–4b, the woman spoke about the man, using forms like “him” and “his.” Then she seemed to speak to him with forms like “you” and “your.” In 1:4b she spoke about him again, calling him “the king.” Most scholars agree that the phrase “the king” refers to the same man whom she loved, not to a different man.

In Hebrew poetry it is common to have such changes in the way people refer to each other. These changes can have different functions. See “Shifting persons” in Zogbo and Wendland, pages 50–53 for more discussion of such changes. This change of person reference is one type of grammatical substitution called “enallage.” This type of enallage may also function as: 1) an indication of the poem’s structure (e.g., the beginning or end of a poem); 2) morphologic parallelism; 3) movement from distance to proximity; 4) expressing awe or respect (3rd person). One possible explanation of the enallage in this context is that in 1:2 the change from “him” to “your” indicates an increase of emotion and intimacy. In 1:3–4 it changes back from “your” to third person “king.” This indicates a decrease in intimacy as she comes to realize in her dream how unlikely it is that this wonderful man could choose to love her. Assis, pages 34–37. Here the changes probably emphasize that the woman desired the man. In some languages such changes may be confusing or imply a wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, some other ways to translate the verses are:

- Make the changes clear by introducing them in some way. For example, notice the phrases in brackets:

Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth!

I want to tell him,

“For your love is more delightful than wine.

The fragrance of your perfume is pleasing;

your name is like perfume poured out.

No wonder the maidens adore you.”

Take me away with you—let us hurry!

He is like a king, my king.

May the king bring me to his chambers.

- Translate all the woman’s words in 1:2–4b as spoken directly to the man. For example:

Your lips cover me with kisses; (GNT)

your love is better than wine,

There is a fragrance about you;

the sound of your name recalls it.

No woman could keep from loving you.

Take me with you,

and we’ll run away;

be my king

and take me to your room.

Probably these verses tell the woman’s private thoughts and desires. Jensen (page 16) says, “The woman’s shifts between third person and second

person reference to her lover are initially disconcerting, but we should probably think of verses 2–3 as soliloquy spoken in the physical absence of the lover, and so as encompassing both absence and imagined presence....” The poet did not imply that the man was actually with her while she was saying these things. In some languages there are ways to indicate that a person is talking to someone who is not there to listen to what is said.

1:2a–b

This verse (1:2a–b) begins immediately with words that the woman spoke. There is no introduction to tell who spoke or who was spoken to. In Hebrew, the forms of the words often indicate this information. In many languages it is necessary to indicate it more explicitly. The headings in the Display give one clear model for indicating who speaks and who is spoken to throughout the Song.

1:2a

Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth!

- I yearn/hunger for your^(sing)/his kisses on my lips!
- Kiss^(sing) me again and again, my love!
- The woman said/exclaimed, Oh, I wish that the man I love would kiss me tenderly/passionately!

Let him kiss me: The verb here expresses strong desire or longing. This emotion of desire continues throughout the Prologue. For this reason, the Prologue heading speaks of “desire.” The Hebrew verb form that the BSB translates as Let him kiss me is more literally “he will kiss me.” In this context most Bible scholars interpret the form as a wish or desire. It has been traditionally translated as a jussive form. See Garrett, page 125, note 2.a. It may also imply that the action is intense or repeated.

Some English versions express the wish with the verb “let” or “may.” However, such verbs may wrongly imply a request for permission. Your translation should clearly indicate that the woman wanted the man to kiss her.

Some ways to translate this meaning are:

- As a wish or desire. For example:

How I long for him to kiss me...!

Oh, I wish that he would kiss me...

- As a request. For example:

Kiss me again and again (NLT96)

Bathe/Shower me with kisses Hiligaynon back translation.

- As a statement or exclamation. For example:

Your lips cover me with kisses (GNT)

O that you would kiss me (RSV)

Translate the verb form in a natural way in your language.

with the kisses of his mouth: The phrase kisses of his mouth refers to romantic kisses in which the lips or mouth of the man and woman come together. In ancient Israel, “kissing” with the nose They would rub their noses together to express affection. was also common. Kissing with the mouth is a more intimate kind of kissing.

In some languages the phrase kisses of his mouth is not natural or it does not communicate the right meaning. If that is true in your language, some other ways to translate it are:

- Use a more general phrase with an emphatic sense. For example:

How I wish he would kiss me passionately!

Oh that he would show how much he loves me!
UBS, page 12.

- Use a more specific phrase. For example:

How I long for him to kiss my lips/mouth!

Translate the phrase in a natural way in your language.

kisses: In some cultures, kisses on the lips may be unknown. A different way to show romantic love may be appropriate here, such as an intimate hug or touch. In some cultures a man and woman rub their noses together to show love. Use a way that is appropriate in your language.

1:2b–4a

In 1:2b–4a, the woman seemed to speak directly to her beloved, since she referred to him with the words “you” and “your.” However, probably the woman was only thinking about what she wanted to say to him. In Hebrew words like “you” and “your” express her strong desire for him in a more vivid way than using “he” and “his.” The shift to second person is done for

poetic reasons or for emphasis, and not because there has been a change in their physical proximity to one another. This division of the Song is a poem of longing or desire, probably not desire fulfilled.

1:2b

For your love is more delightful than wine.

- For your^(sing)/his love is more delicious than wine.
- Your^(sing) caresses thrill/delight me. No wine thrills/delights like that!
- His loving pleases/intoxicates me more than drinking wine.

For: The Hebrew word *kī* that the BSB translates as For is used in different ways in different contexts. There are different ways to interpret it here.

1. It introduces the reason why the woman desired the man's kisses. For example:

because your love is better than wine. (NCV) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, RSV)

1. It indicates an emphatic sense such as “truly” or “indeed.” (Sometimes this sense is only implied in the translation.) For example:

Oh, your loving is sweeter than wine! (CEB) (CEV, GW, REB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) with the majority of English versions. However, either option fits this context. If a national language version follows option (2), that is also acceptable.

Consider how to express this connection in an appropriate way for poetry. In some languages a conjunction may not be natural or necessary. For example, the CEV does not have a conjunction between 1:2a and 1:2b:

^{2a}Kiss me tenderly! ^{2b}Your love is better than wine. (CEV)

your love is more delightful than wine: In this clause, the woman did not say how the man's love was more delightful than wine. Wine is like love in more than one way. Both give pleasure, and both can also make a person behave in unusual ways. Use a description that fits both love and wine. In some languages it is necessary to translate love as an action. The woman was more delighted by the way the man caressed her than by drinking wine.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a statement that does not specify in what way the man's love was better. For example:

For your love is better than wine... (NRSV)

Wine is good, but his love is very good.

- Use a more specific way to refer to pleasure or delight. For example:

For your lovemaking is more delightful than wine. (NET)

- Compare the actions of making love and drinking wine. For example:

The way you love me is more intoxicating/blissful than drinking wine.

Use a natural comparison in your language that fits this context. The comparison should imply good effects, not bad effects, because the woman was praising the way the man showed love for her. See the note on wine later in 1:2b.

your love: There may be some translations or commentaries that say “your breasts” rather than “your love.” The reading “your breasts” is based on the ancient Latin Vulgate or Greek Septuagint translations (for example, see the Douay-Rheims version). The Hebrew text has the better reading, your love. There is no reason to follow the LXX here. In this context the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as love refers mainly to physical lovemaking such as kisses, caresses, or sexual intercourse. See especially the detailed lexical discussion in Mitchell, pages 562–569. He says it may also include other aspects of love involving the whole person. This may include affection, friendship, romance, companionship, and acts of kindness or generosity. However, most occurrences in the OT emphasize the physical aspect. Some ways to translate your love in 1:2b are:

- Use verbs or phrases to describe these actions. For example:

the ways you love/caress me

- Use a term that refers to physical acts of love. For example:

your lovemaking

- Use a more general term for “love” or for “expressions of love.” Try to choose a term that implies physical or romantic love in this context. For example:

your love (NIV)

Your expressions of love (GW)

Consider how to translate love here in a way that is poetic and appropriate in your language.

wine: wine is an alcoholic drink. It is made from the juice of a fruit called grapes. When grape juice ferments, it becomes wine.

In some areas, people may not be familiar with grapes or with wine. If that is true in your area, some other ways to translate wine are:

- Use a general term for an alcoholic drink.
- Use a specific term that can also be used to refer to alcoholic drinks in general. For example:

millet beer

palm wine

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

fermented grape juice

At that time wine was a common beverage in areas where people farmed grapes. It was often used in celebrations. In the Song, it is sometimes used in metaphors for love. (For example, see 5:1d.) Wine is mentioned often in the OT. It is used for the first time in Genesis 9:21. You may translate it here in the same way as you translated it there.

Song of Solomon 1:3

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7–8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3–4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

Lines 1:2–4 are the introduction to Section 1:2–2:7. In these lines, the poet summarizes the Song’s message and introduces its main characters: the woman, the man, and a group of young women. In the Song the woman spoke more often than the man spoke. After the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2–4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 1:2–4b The woman said that she desired her beloved

In the Hebrew text of 1:2–4b, the woman spoke about the man, using forms like “him” and “his.” Then she seemed to speak to him with forms like “you” and “your.” In 1:4b she spoke about him again, calling him “the king.” Most scholars agree that the phrase “the king” refers to the same man whom she loved, not to a different man.

In Hebrew poetry it is common to have such changes in the way people refer to each other. These changes can have different functions. See “Shifting persons” in Zogbo and Wendland, pages 50–53 for more discussion of such changes. This change of person reference is one type of grammatical substitution called “enallage.” This type of enallage may also function as: 1) an indication of the poem’s structure (e.g., the beginning or end of a poem); 2) morphologic parallelism; 3) movement from distance to proximity; 4) expressing awe or respect (3rd person). One possible explanation of the enallage in this context is that in 1:2 the change from “him” to “your” indicates an increase of emotion and intimacy. In 1:3–4 it changes back from “your” to third person “king.” This indicates a decrease in intimacy as she comes to realize in her dream how unlikely it is that this wonderful man could choose to love her. Assis, pages 34–37. Here the changes probably emphasize that the woman desired the man. In some languages such changes may be confusing or imply a wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, some other ways to translate the verses are:

- Make the changes clear by introducing them in some way. For example, notice the phrases in brackets:

Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth!

I want to tell him,

“For your love is more delightful than wine.

The fragrance of your perfume is pleasing;

your name is like perfume poured out.

No wonder the maidens adore you.”

Take me away with you—let us hurry!

He is like a king, my king.

May the king bring me to his chambers.

- Translate all the woman’s words in 1:2–4b as spoken directly to the man. For example:

Your lips cover me with kisses; (GNT)

your love is better than wine,

There is a fragrance about you;

the sound of your name recalls it.

No woman could keep from loving you.

Take me with you,

and we’ll run away;

be my king

and take me to your room.

Probably these verses tell the woman’s private thoughts and desires. Jensen (page 16) says, “The woman’s shifts between third person and second person reference to her lover are initially disconcerting, but we should probably think of verses 2–3 as soliloquy spoken in the physical absence of the lover, and so as encompassing both absence and imagined presence....” The poet did not imply that the man was actually with her while she was saying these things. In some languages there are ways to indicate that a person is talking to someone who is not there to listen to what is said.

1:3a**The fragrance of your perfume is pleasing;**

- The scent of your^(sing)/his ointments is pleasing/sweet,
- You have anointed your skin with perfumed oil that smells wonderful,
- His skin is rubbed with sweet-smelling oils,

The fragrance of your perfume is pleasing: In Hebrew this clause more literally says, “For fragrance, your oils are good.” The phrase “for fragrance” is emphatic. It indicates that the odor of the oils was very pleasing. The word “good” was also used to describe the man’s name in 1:3b.

Some other ways to translate the clause are:

The smell of your perfume is pleasant (NCV)

The fragrance of your cologne is delightful (NET)

Your ointments yield a sweet fragrance (NJPS)

perfume: In Israel and nearby countries at that time, people added sweet-smelling spices to olive oil to make perfume. Some of the spices were expensive, and both men and women used these fragrances. Your translation should emphasize the wonderful fragrance of the perfume, rather than how the oils were made.

In some cultures men do not use scented oil, spices or other types of scent on their bodies. If that is true in your language, you may focus on the pleasing odor of the man himself. For example:

You smell so sweet (CEV)

You have a good fragrance

1:3b**your name is like perfume poured out.**

- your^(sing)/his name/reputation is like the spreading fragrance of your^(sing)/his ointments.
- and your^(sing) character is as good as the scent of that perfumed oil when it spills.
- and his good name/reputation spreads like scented oil spilling/pouring from its container.

In 1:3b there are special features of Hebrew poetic style. For example, in Hebrew the words for “perfume” (shemen) and “name” (shem) sound similar. This helps to show the connection between 1:3a and 1:3b.

Such use of similar sounds is common throughout the Song. However, these similar sounds usually cannot be translated into another language, so the Notes will not usually focus on them. If you are especially interested in Hebrew poetic features, you may learn about them from other commentaries that discuss them. See especially the commentary by Richard Hess. However, it is good for you to consider special ways in your own language that could make your translation poetic or beautiful like a song.

your name is like perfume poured out: This statement is a simile. It indicates that the man’s name was as pleasing as the smell of the fragrant oil when it was poured from a container. In some languages this metaphor may be hard to understand. Other ways to translate it are:

- Use a metaphor. For example:

your name is oil poured out. (RSV)

- Include the meaning of the comparison in the simile. For example:

your name is pleasant like expensive perfume. (NCV)

- Translate the comparison without using a figure of speech. This option can be used when a metaphor or simile would give a wrong meaning. For example:

How fragrant your cologne, and how pleasing your name! (NLT96)

Use an appropriate option for your language.

your name: In Hebrew, the word name often represents the person himself, including the person’s character and reputation. So when the woman praised her beloved’s name here, she praised his wonderful character. She compared his good character to the good fragrance of cologne. Some other ways to translate your name here are:

your good reputation

your fine character

the good things you do and say

perfume poured out: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as perfume poured out is difficult

to interpret. Some scholars think there is a problem with interpreting the Hebrew word *Turaq* as a verb meaning “poured out.” The grammatical gender of poured out is feminine. But the gender of “perfume” is masculine. Since they are used together here, we would normally expect the gender of the two words to be the same. So, some of these scholars say that the word may be a place called “*Turaq*” where costly perfumes were made. Other scholars think that the Hebrew text needs to be corrected on the basis of the Greek Septuagint to read *tamruq*, which means “purification.” So they think the word means “purified oil.” But many scholars say that unmatched gender is fairly common in Hebrew. So they say it really is not a problem, and they understand *turaq* as a verb meaning “poured out.” (This interpretation is reflected in options 1 and 2.) Some different interpretations are based on how scholars understand the Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as poured out. Here are the two main options:

1. The phrase refers to the spreading fragrance of the oil. For example:

your name is like the spreading fragrance of scented oils. (NLT) (BSB, CEV, ESV, NIV, NJB, NLT, For 1:3a–b, the NLT96 translates in a more general way: “How fragrant your cologne, and how pleasing your name!” REB, RSV, GNT)

1. The phrase refers to the quality of the oil. For example:

your name is like the finest perfume. (NET) (NASB, NCV, NET, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as more English versions do.

1:3c

No wonder the maidens adore you.

- That is why the young women love you^(sing)/him.
- For this, girls adore/admire you!^(sing)
- It is no surprise that all women love him.

No wonder: The phrase No wonder refers back to what the woman said about the man in 1:3b. It was because of his wonderful character and reputation that maidens loved him.

the maidens: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as maidens refers to young women who were old enough to be married. In the context of the Song, it probably refers to young women who were still virgins.

adore: The Hebrew word *adore* here is different from the word translated “love” in 1:2b. Here it means that the young women admired the man and were attracted to him. Express this type of admiration in a natural way in your language. Other ways to translate it are:

No woman could keep from loving you. (GNT)

Song of Solomon 1:4

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7–8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3–4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

Lines 1:2–4 are the introduction to Section 1:2–2:7. In these lines, the poet summarizes the Song’s message and introduces its main characters: the woman, the man, and a group of young women. In the Song the woman spoke more often than the man spoke. After the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2–4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 1:2–4b The woman said that she desired her beloved

In the Hebrew text of 1:2–4b, the woman spoke about the man, using forms like “him” and “his.” Then she seemed to speak to him with forms like “you” and “your.” In 1:4b she spoke about him again, calling him “the king.” Most scholars agree that the phrase “the king” refers to the same man whom she loved, not to a different man.

In Hebrew poetry it is common to have such changes in the way people refer to each other. These changes can have different functions. See “Shifting persons” in Zogbo and Wendland, pages 50–53 for more discussion of such changes. This change of person reference is one type of grammatical substitution called “enallage.” This type of enallage may also function as: 1) an indication of the poem’s structure (e.g., the beginning or end of a poem); 2) morphologic parallelism; 3)

movement from distance to proximity; 4) expressing awe or respect (3rd person). One possible explanation of the enallage in this context is that in 1:2 the change from “him” to “your” indicates an increase of emotion and intimacy. In 1:3–4 it changes back from “your” to third person “king.” This indicates a decrease in intimacy as she comes to realize in her dream how unlikely it is that this wonderful man could choose to love her. Assis, pages 34–37. Here the changes probably emphasize that the woman desired the man. In some languages such changes may be confusing or imply a wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, some other ways to translate the verses are:

- Make the changes clear by introducing them in some way. For example, notice the phrases in brackets:

Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth!

I want to tell him,

“For your love is more delightful than wine.

The fragrance of your perfume is pleasing;

your name is like perfume poured out.

No wonder the maidens adore you.”

Take me away with you—let us hurry!

He is like a king, my king.

May the king bring me to his chambers.

- Translate all the woman’s words in 1:2–4b as spoken directly to the man. For example:

Your lips cover me with kisses; (GNT)

your love is better than wine,

There is a fragrance about you;

the sound of your name recalls it.

No woman could keep from loving you.

Take me with you,
and we'll run away;
be my king
and take me to your room.

Probably these verses tell the woman's private thoughts and desires. Jensen (page 16) says, "The woman's shifts between third person and second person reference to her lover are initially disconcerting, but we should probably think of verses 2-3 as soliloquy spoken in the physical absence of the lover, and so as encompassing both absence and imagined presence...." The poet did not imply that the man was actually with her while she was saying these things. In some languages there are ways to indicate that a person is talking to someone who is not there to listen to what is said.

1:4a

Take me away with you—let us hurry!

- Take me with you^(sing), and we^(incl) will hurry away.
- Take me away with you^(sing) without delay.

Take me away with you—let us hurry!: Here the woman asked the man to hurry and take her with him. She said this because of her great desire to be alone with him. She did not imply that she wanted him to take her hand and lead her. The request also does not imply that she wanted them to elope (go away secretly to have sexual relations or to get married).

Other ways to translate her request are:

Take me with you; let's run together. (NCV)

Let's go. Lead me quickly!

1:4b

May the king bring me to his chambers.

- Oh how I want my prince to take me to his bedchamber!
- Be my king and bring me to the marriage bed.
- Bring me to our^(incl) wedding chamber, King of love.

May the king bring me to his chambers: There are different ways to interpret the Hebrew verb form that the BSB translates as bring in this verse. The grammatical form of the verb is the perfect. There are many uses of the Hebrew perfective form. In this context it seems to express desire or wish. Another option is

that it expresses a command, but this requires a slight change in the Hebrew text. This suggested textual change is from the ancient Syriac translation. Current linguistic thinking is moving away from the past tense use of the perfect. The two main options are:

1. The verb form expresses a desire or request. For example:

be my king and take me to your room. (GNT) (BSB, CEV, GNT, NET, NIV, REB)

1. The verb describes a completed action. For example:

The king has brought me into his bedroom. (NLT) (ESV, GW, NASB, NJB, NJPS, NLT, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It repeats the theme of desire expressed in 1:2a. The woman thought or dreamed about the time when her desire to be with her beloved will be fulfilled.

the king...his: Here the woman referred to her beloved as the king. She was still referring to the same man as in 1:4a and in 1:2-3. This use of third person forms an "inclusio" and indicates the unity of 1:2-4. She probably spoke directly to the man or imagined what she wanted to say to him.

Use a natural way in your language to indicate that the king is the same man as in 1:2-3. In some languages it is necessary to make that clear by using forms like "you" and "your." For example:

Hurry, my king! Let's hurry.

Take me to your home. (CEV)

king: In this context the word king is a special term of affection that the woman used for her beloved. In the past, most scholars thought that king referred to King Solomon (or Yahweh or Christ in allegories). The figurative use of "king" has been found in recent studies of Egyptian love poetry. A study note in the NJB says that engaged couples were called "king" and "queen" in Syrian wedding songs. The word king is just one of several poetic ways that the woman used to refer to him. She also referred to him as a shepherd (1:7), an apple tree (2:3), a gazelle or stag (2:9), and a magnificent statue (5:14-15). She described him in poetic hyperboles as lovers often do. She probably spoke of her beloved as king to show her admiration. Other ways to say this are:

my Chief

my royal Darling

Show this admiration in a natural way in your language.

to his chambers: The phrase his chambers refers to the man's bedroom (the room where he usually slept). The plural chambers may refer to one room that has different parts, rather than to more than one room. In this context chambers may have a figurative sense. It may actually refer to a meeting place under the trees. (See 1:16–17 where their bedroom seems to be under the trees in the forest.)

The word chambers may refer to the place where the man and woman experienced intimate union. It may imply here that the woman was thinking of the time when they will be married.

Paragraph 1:4c–d The women of Jerusalem praised the man that the woman loves

The original Hebrew does not identify the speaker or speakers in 1:4c–d. Scholars suggest two main options:

1. The speakers in 1:4c–d were a group (chorus) of young women who praised the man. Some scholars believe that it is the woman who is speaking here, but that she is quoting the young women. However, even if the woman is quoting the other young women, the words are theirs. Other scholars believe that the woman speaks along with the chorus in their praise of the man. (These were probably the maidens mentioned in 1:3c.) For example:

We rejoice and delight in you; we will praise your love more than wine. (NIV) (BSB, CEV, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT, ESV, GW, NASB, REB)

1. The speaker in 1:4c–d was the woman, and she spoke to the man. When she said “we,” she referred to herself and the man. She did not include the other young women mentioned in 1:3c and 1:4e. For example:

We will be happy together, drink deep, and lose ourselves in love. (GNT) (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It provides the simplest explanation of the words in 1:4c–d. It seems less likely that the women spoke in 1:4e, since the text refers to them with a “they” form rather than with a “we” form.

1:4c

We will rejoice and delight in you;

- We^(excl) will celebrate and be happy because of you^(masc,sing).
- The young women said to the man, We^(excl) will rejoice in you^(masc,sing) with great delight.
- You^(masc,sing) give us great pleasure, and we are thrilled with you^(masc,sing)!

1:4d

we will praise your love more than wine.

- We^(excl) will praise your^(sing) love/loving more than we^(excl) praise the pleasures of wine.
- Your^(sing) love for your beloved is more worthy of our praise than the finest wine!

1:4c–d

We will rejoice and delight in you; we will praise your love: Here the women told what they will do. They will rejoice because of the man, and they will praise his love. The Hebrew verbs in this verse part are cohortative in form. Verbs in the cohortative mood or form express encouragement or exhortation. Some other ways to translate this intention are:

We will exult and rejoice...will extol your love.... (RSV)

Let us rejoice and be glad....praise your love... (REB)

We are happy....we praise your love. (CEV)

rejoice and delight in you: The phrases rejoice in you and delight in you have similar meanings. The phrases indicate that the women will celebrate and praise the man because of his wonderful qualities, especially his love for the woman. When rejoice and delight are used together, they emphasize the meaning. Emphasize the meaning in a natural way in your language.

In some languages it may be more natural to use a different way to emphasize the meaning. For example:

greatly rejoice UBS A Handbook on Song of Songs, page 24.

will praise your love: Some ancient versions say “your breasts” (see note under 1:2b). “Love” is the correct reading of the text. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as love here was also used in 1:2b (see the explanation of love in 1:2b). In that context it refers to the man's love toward the woman. The women of

Jerusalem agreed with the woman's opinion that the way her beloved showed his love for her was wonderful. They did not personally experience his love, but they agreed that it was wonderful.

It is also possible that the speech of the young women is a poetic way to emphasize how wonderful the man was. It may not imply that a particular group of women was speaking.

more than wine: This type of comparison was also used in 1:2b. Here it means:

we will praise your love more than we will praise the pleasures of drinking wine.

In Hebrew and in the BSB, the words “we will praise” are not stated twice because the second “we will praise” is already implied. In some languages it may be necessary to say it twice, as in the example above. Some languages may also need to include some of the other implied information in the example above.

1:4e

It is only right that they adore you.

- The young women are so right to love you!^(sing)
- It is natural that all the girls adore/admire you!^(sing)

It is only right that they adore you: At the end of 1:4d the women of Jerusalem stopped speaking, and here in 1:4e the woman addressed her beloved. She commented on the attitude of the daughters of Jerusalem. She told him that it was natural and right that they loved him. Some scholars believe that the women of Jerusalem are the ones who continue to praise the man in 1:4e. (This view is represented by the ESV, GW, NASB, and REB.)

Here the word right indicates that a response of love is the natural and correct response to someone so wonderful. For example:

How right they are to adore you! This interpretation is followed by most English versions, including BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, RSV, and GNT. There are at least two other interpretations. Some scholars believe that the Hebrew word translated “rightly” means “smooth.” Scholars who take this view divide the previous sentence differently so that the last word “wine” is part of the sentence along with the word “smooth.” Then, line 1:4e reads “More than smooth wine do they love you.” The LXX has a word that means “upright,” and the KJV has followed that interpretation. (NIV)

they adore you: Here the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as adore is the same word that was used in 1:3c. The statement they adore you implies that the young women admired the man and were attracted to him.

Song of Solomon 1:5

Section 1:2-2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2-2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2-4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5-6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3-6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7-8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3-4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh's chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

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Paragraph 1:5–6 The woman spoke about herself to the young women of Jerusalem

In these two verses, the woman spoke to the women of Jerusalem. They were the same women who spoke in 1:3–4. She asked the women not to disapprove of her because her skin was darkened by the sun. Then she explained that her brothers became angry with her and made her work in the vineyards.

1:5a

I am dark, yet lovely,

- I am dark/black, but I am still beautiful,
- She said to the young women of Jerusalem, My skin is darkened/tanned, and yet I am lovely.

I am dark: The word translated dark is literally “black” in Hebrew. It describes the color of the woman’s skin after she worked in the sun for some time, as 1:6 explains. It does not describe the natural color of her skin. The women who worked in the fields often had darker skin than other people, because the hot sun

darkened it. The woman implied here that she did not think that her darkened skin was a sign of beauty.

Use a natural way in your language to describe skin that has been darkened by the sun.

yet lovely: A major interpretation question involves the woman’s attitude in verses 5–6. Was she being humble and apologetic about her appearance? Or was she making a positive statement about her beauty? How we interpret her attitude depends partly on how we understand the Hebrew conjunction. This conjunction has different meanings, which depend on context. Some scholars think that in this context it means “but” while others think it means “and.” Scholars who say the conjunction means “and” think that the woman is expressing how beautiful she is. In other words, she is both dark and beautiful. Her darkness is part of her beauty. Most other scholars, who say the word means “but” think that the woman made a modest statement about her beauty. But they do not think that she expressed pride in her beauty. In verse 6 where she told the daughters of Jerusalem not to stare at her, she seemed embarrassed by her dark color, not proud of it. She felt she needed to explain how she became so dark. But even though she was so dark and of lower social status, she was still attractive, at least to her man. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as lovely means “beautiful,” and it refers to beauty that is especially appropriate. When it describes a beautiful woman, as it does here, it implies that she is just what a man desires.

The word yet in the BSB translates the Hebrew conjunction *w-*. It connects the two descriptions “dark” and lovely. Scholars have two different views about the connection between the descriptions:

1. The descriptions contrast with each other. The woman implied that even though she was dark, she was still attractive. In that culture, people did not normally consider dark skin to be beautiful. For example:

I am dark, but comely... (NJPS) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, RSV, GNT)

1. The second description adds to the first. The woman meant that she was both dark and beautiful. Her darkness added to her beauty. For example:

My skin is dark and beautiful... (CEV) (CEV, GW, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of versions and many commentaries follow this option. It seems to be the best interpretation in the context of 1:6 and the way the woman explained why her skin was dark.

1:5b

O daughters of Jerusalem,

- women of Jerusalem.
- I tell you,^(plur) Jerusalem women/girls,

O daughters of Jerusalem: Here the phrase daughters of Jerusalem probably refers to the same women who were already mentioned as “the maidens” in 1:3c and in 1:4e in the phrase “they adore you.” You should refer to them in a clear way here, so that readers will know that the text refers to the same group of women.

The word O is not in the Hebrew text here. It is a way to indicate in English that the woman spoke directly to the Jerusalem women. Use a natural way in your language to speak directly to a group of women. Some other ways to translate this in English are:

Young women of Jerusalem (GW)

I tell you, Jerusalem girls

In some languages it is more natural to put the phrase daughters of Jerusalem in a different place in the sentence. See the General Comment on 1:5a–d at the end of the notes for 1:5c–d for examples.

General Comment on 1:5a–b

In some languages, a direct address comes first or last in a sentence, or it may come in a different place in the sentence. Put it in a natural place in your language. For example:

^{5b}O daughters of Jerusalem,

^{5a}I am dark, yet lovely.

Though I have dark skin, I am beautiful, you Jerusalem women.

I have dark skin, daughters of Jerusalem, but I am beautiful.

1:5c–d

like the tents of Kedar, like the curtains of Solomon:

Here the woman compared her dark beauty (1:5a) to tents and curtains. Scholars have two views about how

the tents of Kedar and the curtains of Solomon are related in this verse:

1. The tents and curtains are different. For example:

dark as the desert tents of Kedar, but beautiful as the draperies in Solomon’s palace. (GNT) (NET, GNT)

1. The tents and curtains are similar: both are dark (and possibly lovely). For example:

dark as the tents of Kedar, dark as the curtains of Solomon’s tents. (NLT) (NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). Most English versions are ambiguous, but the context suggests a contrast. The woman’s skin was darkened by the sun, yet she was still lovely. These verses also use a special feature of Hebrew poetic style that takes each part of a contrast as the basis for another contrast. This feature is called “redistribution.” In 1:5a, “dark but comely” contrasts qualities of the woman’s skin. In 1:5c–d it contrasts the dark tents of Kedar with the lovely curtains of Solomon. See the General Comment on 1:5a–d for another translation suggestion.

1:5c

like the tents of Kedar,

- I am dark like the tents of the tribe of Kedar,
- my skin is darkened like the tents that the Kedar people live in,

like the tents of Kedar: The name Kedar refers to one or more nomadic tribes in the Arabian desert. These tribes lived in tents that had a dark color. People used the hair of black goats to weave the tents. The woman thought that her skin was dark and rough like the tents of Kedar. Some other ways to translate the phrase like the tents of Kedar are:

like the tents of the people of Kedar

like the tents where the Kedar people live

1:5d

like the curtains of Solomon.

- but I am beautiful like the curtains in the palace of King Solomon.
- yet I am lovely like the draperies in Solomon’s palace.

like the curtains of Solomon: The curtains of Solomon contrast with the dark weather-beaten

“tents of Kedar.” The fine curtains that Solomon had (possibly in his palace) were elegant and beautiful. They may also have been dark, as some versions suggest. However, the focus is on the beauty of Solomon’s curtains in contrast to the dark weather-worn tents of Kedar.

Solomon: When the Song was first written, only the Hebrew consonants were written, not the vowels. The consonants of the words Solomon and “Shalmah” were the same. (Shalmah was another tribe that also lived in tents.) Only the context where the name was used indicated whether it referred to Solomon or “Shalmah.” Vowels were later supplied by Hebrew scholars to help people read the text. The vowels in this context identify the name as Solomon. When you spell the name, you should follow the spelling rules of your language. Some modern scholars and versions (NET, NJB, and REB) say that the correct reading should be Shalmah or Salmah. However, since the Hebrew text as we have it favors “Solomon,” it is good to follow that text. On the other hand, translators should remember that the actual spelling of the name should be based on the spelling rules of their language.

General Comment on 1:5a–d

Consider how to translate the comparisons in this verse in a natural way in your language. In some languages it may be necessary to reorder some of the information. It may also be necessary to supply some implied information to make complete sentences or clauses. For example:

^{5b}Young women of Jerusalem, ^{5a}I am dark but attractive/lovely. ^{5c}My skin is dark like the tents of Kedar, ^{5d}but I am attractive/lovely like the curtains of Solomon.

Song of Solomon 1:6

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1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

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beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

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In these two verses, the woman spoke to the women of Jerusalem. They were the same women who spoke in 1:3–4. She asked the women not to disapprove of her because her skin was darkened by the sun. Then she explained that her brothers became angry with her and made her work in the vineyards.

1:6a

Do not stare

- Do^(plur) not gaze at me
- Do^(plur) not look at me with disgust

1:6a-b

Do not stare because I am dark: In this verse the woman continued to speak to the young women of Jerusalem. Scholars have different views about the way she interpreted their attitude toward her here:

1. She thought that they stared at her because they disapproved of her.
2. She thought that they stared at her because they admired her and were amazed that she was so beautiful.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) for these reasons:

1. It seems likely that they did not approve of her because in 1:6d–e she explained to them why her skin was dark.
2. The Hebrew text of 1:6 uses a “play on words” that has three parts:

The women gazed at her (1:6a)

the sun gazed-at/burned her skin (1:6c)

her brothers burned with anger (1:6d) In 1:6c and 1:6d there is obviously a harsh sense, so it is likely that 1:6a also implies a harsh sense.

It is helpful to translate in a way that implies that the brothers had a harsh attitude toward their sister. Some English versions use an idiom. For example:

Don’t look down on me.... (GNT)

1:6b

because I am dark,

- because I am swarthy
- because you^(plur) think my darkened/tanned skin makes me ugly.

because: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew connector. Most versions interpret the Hebrew relative pronoun in this context with a causal meaning, “because I am dark.” A few versions and commentaries interpret it as a relative pronoun, “who am dark.” that the BSB translates as for in this verse:

1. It introduces the reason that the people might stare at the woman. For example:

Do not stare at me because I am dark, because I am darkened by the sun. (NIV) (BSB, CEV, GW, NASB, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, RSV, GNT)

1. It introduces a clause that describes the woman: “Do not stare at me who (I) am dark.” The literal wording is not natural in English, so English versions translate the connection in a different way. For example:

Don’t look at how dark I am, at how dark the sun has made me. (NCV) (NCV, NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is followed by the majority of English versions.

1:6c

for the sun has gazed upon me.

- from being burned by the sun.
- It was the sun that burned my skin.

for the sun has gazed upon me: This clause tells what caused the woman’s dark skin. The sun burned the woman and made her skin dark. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

for the sun has burned my skin. (NET)

because I was scorched by the sun. (REB)

In some languages there may be a figure of speech to translate this meaning, as in the BSB.

It is important to translate in a way that implies harshness, like “scorched,” as in the RSV, or “burned.” A more neutral expression like “tanned” does not imply the right meaning in many cultures.

General Comment on 1:6a–c

In 1:6a–c there are two clauses that begin with a purpose word:

Do not stare at me because I am dark,

do not stare at me for the sun has gazed upon me.

In some languages it may be difficult to translate two purpose clauses in the same sentence like this. If that is true in your language, you may be able to combine the clauses. (Notice the implied information before the second purpose clause.) For example:

Don’t stare at me just because the sun has darkened my skin. (CEV)

1:6d

My mother’s sons were angry with me;

- My older brothers were angry with me,
- The sons of my mother were upset with me,

My mother’s sons were angry with me: In 1:6d–e the woman explained that she was exposed to the sun, not by her own choice, but because her brothers were angry with her. In some languages it may be helpful to make this connection explicit. For example:

That happened because my brothers became angry with me

My mother’s sons: This phrase refers to the woman’s brothers who were sons of her mother. They may have a different father or the same father. Use the appropriate term in your language for this relationship. Some English versions use the more general term “brothers.”

In some languages it is necessary to specify whether the brothers were older or younger than the woman. Probably at least some of her brothers were older because in 8:8a her brothers said that they “have a little sister.”

were angry with me: The reason for the brothers’ anger with the woman is not stated in the text, and the context also does not indicate the reason.

1:6e

they made me a keeper of the vineyards,

- so they made me take care of the family vineyards.
- they forced me to take care of the vineyards,
- and they sent me out to guard the family vineyards

they made me a keeper of the vineyards: The word they refers to the woman’s brothers. Their decision to make her keeper of the vineyards was a result of their being angry with her (1:6d). In some languages it may be helpful to make this connection explicit. For example:

so they made me

The context implies that they forced her rather than just appointed her to care for the vineyard. It was because of their decision that she was often in the sun. She had no choice. Here is another way to translate this:

they forced me to care for their vineyards... (NLT)

keeper of the vineyards: The phrase keeper of the vineyards indicates that the woman took care of the family vineyards. Her responsibilities probably included protecting the vineyards, cultivating them, and pruning the vines. To do that work, she had to spend many hours in the hot sun. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

to watch over the vineyards

work in the vineyard (CEV)

vineyards: The word, vineyards, refers to farms where people plant and cultivate grapes. Grapes can be eaten as fruit or used to make wine.

Some ways to translate vineyards are:

grape farm

fields of grape plants

1:6f

but my own vineyard I have neglected.

- Then I was not able to care for my own vineyard!

- but I was not able to take care of myself, my own vineyard.
- so I had to neglect my appearance.

but: The statements in 1:6e and 1:6f contrast with each other. The Hebrew text does not have a conjunction. It indicates the contrast within the statements themselves. Most English versions also emphasize the contrast within the statements, often by adding the word “own.” Some versions also add a conjunction. The UBS Handbook points out that the contrast here is also indicated by a chiasmic structure between the two clauses. For example:

but my own vineyard I have not kept! (ESV)

so I haven’t tended my own vineyard! (NCV)

Show the contrast in a natural way in your own language.

my own vineyard I have neglected: This clause indicates that the woman did not take care of her own vineyard. The word vineyard is often used as a metaphor in the Song. In this verse also, it is a metaphor. It refers to the woman’s appearance, not to a real vineyard. Some scholars believe that in this context the phrase “my own vineyard” refers here to the woman’s sexuality. They suggest that the woman had not been able to guard her own sexuality and so was no longer a virgin. This view raises serious moral problems regarding what was considered proper sexual behavior in ancient Israel. It also does not seem appropriate in the context of the biblical canon. Here in the Song, this interpretation does not seem to be consistent with the woman’s virtuous character. She was forced to work long hours outside in the hot sun. As a result, her skin was burned and very dark.

In some languages this metaphor may be confusing, or it may communicate a wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, there are two other possibilities for translation:

- Keep the metaphor and indicate its meaning. For example:

so I couldn’t care for myself—my own vineyard (NLT)

- Translate only the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

I had no time to care for myself. (GNT)

and so I neglected my complexion. (CEV)

Use an appropriate option for your language in this context.

Song of Solomon 1:7

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7–8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3–4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

Lines 1:2–4 are the introduction to Section 1:2–2:7. In these lines, the poet summarizes the Song’s message and introduces its main characters: the woman, the man, and a group of young women. In the Song the woman spoke more often than the man spoke. After the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2–4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 1:7–8 The woman spoke and the man replied

There are some difficult interpretation issues in 1:7–8. One issue is the attitude of the man and woman. In 1:7, did the woman ask for information in a serious manner or did she speak in a flirting way? In 1:8, did the man scold the woman or did he reply in a flirting way? Possibly, the woman was more serious in 1:7, while the man replied in a flirting way in 1:8.

The Song uses several figurative themes that occur at different places in the book. The theme of 1:5–6 was the vineyard. In 1:7–8 the focus shifts to the theme of shepherds and pastures.

1:7a–c

There are parallel parts in 1:7a–c. The woman asked her beloved where he pastured his flock and where he made them lie down at noon. The Hebrew text is more literally:

^{7a}Tell me...

^{7b}where you pasture your flock

^{7c}where you cause it/them to rest at noon?

Other ways to translate this request are:

My love, please tell me where you take your sheep to graze and where you will let them rest at noon.

Tell me, my love, where will you lead your flock to graze? Where will they rest from the noonday sun?

1:7a

Tell me, O one I love,

- Tell^(sing) me, you^(sing) whom I love,
- Darling/Beloved, tell me

Tell me, O one I love: Here the woman used the phrase O one I love like a name for her beloved. In Hebrew the phrase is only two words which sound poetic together. In some languages it may be more natural to put the direct address first in the sentence. For example:

O one I love, tell me

In some languages it may be more natural not to use direct address. For example:

You are the one I love. Tell me

Tell me: The phrase Tell me is a request and an indirect question. Some other ways to translate it are:

Please tell me (GW)

I would like you to let me know

O one I love: The phrase O one I love is a term of affection that the woman used as she spoke to the man. Languages often have a special term of affection that is natural for the woman to use in this context. For example:

my love (GNT)

My darling (CEV)

sweetheart (NJB)

1:7b**where do you pasture your sheep?**

- where do you^(sing) pasture your flock of sheep?
- where are you^(sing) going to feed your sheep today?
- where you take your^(sing) animals to graze,

where do you pasture your sheep: This phrase refers to the place where the man usually led his flock to graze. On some days he might lead them to a different place, so the woman wanted to be sure exactly where her beloved planned to be. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

Where will you lead your flock to graze (GNT)

where do you feed your sheep (NCV)

where you plan to lead your flock to eat today?

pasture your sheep: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as pasture refers to caring for animals like sheep and goats. It especially refers to leading them to areas where they will be able to eat grass or other plants. The BSB supplies the implied phrase your sheep, which is not in the Hebrew text.

Some other ways to translate the meaning are:

feed your sheep (CEV)

take your animals to graze/eat

1:7c**Where do you rest them at midday?**

- Where do you^(sing) let them rest at noontime?
- Where will they/your^(sing) sheep lie down today during the noontime heat?
- and where you^(sing) let them rest at noon.

Where do you rest them at midday: This clause is parallel to the clause in 1:7b. It has basically the same meaning. The woman was still asking the man where he would take his flock (them). However, it adds the meaning rest and the time of day (midday). Some other ways to translate the clause are:

At noon, where will you make your sheep lie down?

Where do you let them rest at noon? (NCV)

In this verse it is important to understand that the woman was not primarily interested in the sheep. She asked the question because she wanted to know where her beloved planned to be.

1:7d**Why should I be like a veiled woman**

- Why should I have to walk around like a prostitute
- Why should I have to walk aimlessly around
- Tell^(sing) me so that I will not wander

1:7d-e

In 1:7a-c, the woman asked the man to tell her where he usually led his flock to graze. Here in 1:7d-e, she gave her reason for wanting to know where he will be. She wanted to know so that she did not need to search for him near the other shepherds. If she wandered around the shepherds' tents, they might think that she was an immoral woman looking for pleasure.

In some languages it may be necessary to repeat part of the request from 1:7a to make the connection clear. For example:

Tell me so that I will not have to wander around beside the flocks of your companions! (similarly, the NET)

Why should I be like a veiled woman beside the flocks of your companions:

Here the woman asked a rhetorical question. The question indicates that she did not want to be like a woman who wanders around the shepherds' tents. If she did that, others might think that she was a prostitute. In some languages it is necessary to make this explicit in some way. For example:

For why should I wander like a prostitute among your friends and their flocks? (NLT)

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

- As a rhetorical question:

Why should I need to look for you among the flocks of the other shepherds? (GNT)

Will it be good/proper if I walk here and there looking for you where the other shepherds pasture their flocks?

- As a request:

Let me not be as one who strays

Beside the flocks of your fellows. (NJPS)

Please don't cause me to wander around looking for you where other men take their sheep.

- As a statement:

I do not want to wander around looking for you where other men take their sheep.

Translate the meaning in a natural way in your language.

veiled: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as veiled can also mean “wander.” In ancient Israel, a prostitute sometimes wore a veil. (See Genesis 38:13–15.) That may be a reason for the different interpretation options “veiled” and “like a prostitute” here. There is also a third option which interprets the word as “picking lice.” It is followed by the REB and a few scholars, including Garrett. This interpretation seems unlikely. These two meanings are more similar than they seem. In that culture a prostitute often wore a veil over her face, so the BSB has “like a veiled woman.” However, it is better to translate the meaning “wanders,” since there are other reasons for wearing a veil.

The woman wanted to know where the man was going so that she did not have to wander around searching for him when she came to meet him at noon (1:7c). In 1:7a–c the woman asked where to find the man. She asked this because if she did not know where to find him she might need to wander around looking for him. This might imply that she was an immoral woman, and that would humiliate her. However, the context does not necessarily explain why the woman wanted to avoid being like a “veiled” woman because it was not only prostitutes who wore veils. Women in mourning or women who did not wish to be recognized for some reason often wore veils. It is logical that if the woman does not know where the man is, she must wander around in order to find him. There are several reasons why this might make her feel uneasy, including a fear that the shepherds might think she was an immoral (veiled) woman. The theme of searching for a person and finding him is common in the Song.

1:7e

beside the flocks of your companions?

- near the flocks of your^(sing) friends?
- around the sheep/animals of the other shepherds.

beside the flocks of your companions: The phrase beside the flocks of your companions implies that the

man often pastured his flocks near other shepherds. They were probably his friends or a group of shepherds who went out together to graze their flocks. The woman implied here that she did not want to go near those other shepherds to search for her beloved. She was afraid that she might be mistaken for an immoral woman.

Other ways to translate this phrase are:

among your friends and their flocks (NLT)

near your friends' sheep (NCV)

Song of Solomon 1:8

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7–8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3–4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh's chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

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1:2-4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

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The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

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The Song uses several figurative themes that occur at different places in the book. The theme of 1:5-6 was the vineyard. In 1:7-8 the focus shifts to the theme of shepherds and pastures.

1:8a-c

If you do not know...follow the tracks of the flock, and graze your young goats near the tents of the shepherds: Here the man answered the woman’s question. He seemed to tell her to do exactly what she said that she did not want to do (1:7). She did not want to wander near the other shepherds. Some Bible scholars think that the man was giving her a harsh answer. But the way he spoke to her as “O fairest among women” is certainly not harsh. Some other scholars think that the man was speaking playfully or flirting in this verse. However, here the man implied that she did not have to fear. She should bring her own goats and follow the tracks of his sheep. The sheep would lead her to him, and everyone would see that she had a good reason to be there.

Some other ways to translate the verse are:

Don’t you know the place, loveliest of women? Go and follow the flock; find pasture for your goats near the tents of the shepherds. (GNT)

If you do not know, O most beautiful of women, simply follow the tracks of my flock, and pasture your little lambs beside the tents of the shepherds. (NET)

My dearest, if you don’t know, just follow the path of the sheep. Then feed your young goats near the shepherds’ tents. (CEV)

1:8a

If you do not know, O fairest of women,

- If you^(sing) do not know where I will pasture my sheep, O fairest of women,
- Most beautiful woman, if you^(sing) do not know where I lead my sheep to graze,

If you do not know: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as If you do not know is more literally: “If you do not know for yourself.” For a discussion of this use of the Hebrew referential l-, see Rivka Halevy, “The Subject Co-referential l- Pronoun in Hebrew,” in T. Bar & E. Cohen (eds.), *Studies in Semitic and General Linguistics in Honor of Gideon Goldenberg* (Ugarit Verlag, Munster 2007), 299-321. The phrase “for yourself” probably implies that the man was surprised that the woman did not know. Its meaning is similar to the meaning of “really” in the phrase, “If you really do not know.” Some other ways to translate the surprise are:

Surely you know (NCV)

How is it that you do not know

not know: The words not know refers here to not knowing where the man would pasture his sheep. In some languages it is helpful to make explicit what the woman did not know. For example:

not know the place

not know where I pasture them

O fairest of women: The phrase fairest of women is more literally “the beautiful one among women.” The man used this phrase like a “praise name” to show his admiration for the woman. He compared her to other women, saying that she was more beautiful than any of them. Translate this comparison in a natural way in your language.

In some languages it may not be natural to use a phrase like this as direct address. Some other ways to translate it are:

- As a statement. For example:

You are the most beautiful of women. (NCV)

You are very beautiful. Other women are not beautiful beside you.

- As an exclamation. For example:

Oh very beautiful woman among all other women!

Translate the phrase in a natural way for this context.

1:8b

follow the tracks of the flock,

- follow the path of my flock,
- then follow the trail that my sheep leave/make,

follow the tracks of the flock: Here the man advised the woman that she could find him if she looked at the tracks that the sheep and goats made as they walked. Other ways to translate this are:

just follow the path of the sheep (CEV)

follow the trail of my flock (NLT)

Notice that the NLT refers specifically to the flock of the man.

tracks: The word tracks refers to the marks (footprints) that the sheep made as they walked. It probably does not refer to a well-used trail, but to recent tracks left by his flock. Some other ways to translate it are:

footprints

marks

1:8c

and graze your young goats near the tents of the shepherds.

- and graze your^(sing) kids by the tents of the shepherds.
- and feed your^(sing) flock of young goats near the shepherds' camps/shelters.

and graze your young goats: The phrase and graze your young goats is similar to the phrase “pasture your flock” in 1:7b. See how you translated it there.

young goats: The woman had young goats that she led to places where they could graze. Some languages have a specific term for young goats, such as “kid” in the RSV. If goats or kids are not common in your language, you may be able to refer to a different animal that people herd, or you may be able to use a more general term. For example:

animals

lambs/sheep

near the tents of the shepherds: Here the man suggested that the woman should let her goats graze near the tents of other shepherds. That is where she would find him, and he could also find her. He may also imply that the other shepherds could protect and help her. Garrett (page 139) says, “when she goes out and joins him she will no longer be an outsider—a woman among the shepherds—but will find her community and family. Her lover’s community will be hers, and she need have no fear or discomfort.” Another way to translate the phrase near the tents of the shepherds is:

near the tents where the shepherds usually rest.

tents: These tents were simple temporary shelters. The shepherds could rest there while their sheep grazed nearby. In contrast, the “tents of Kedar” in 1:5c–

d were more substantial dwellings. The Hebrew words for “tent” are different in 1:5 and 1:8. Use a word or phrase in your language that refers to a temporary shelter.

Song of Solomon 1:9

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7–8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3–4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

Lines 1:2–4 are the introduction to Section 1:2–2:7. In these lines, the poet summarizes the Song’s message and introduces its main characters: the woman, the man, and a group of young women. In the Song the woman spoke more often than the man spoke. After the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2–4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 1:9–11 The man spoke to the woman

In these lines the author introduces new comparisons that use Pharaoh’s chariot horses and jewelry. The man expressed his admiration for the woman. He focused especially on her face adorned with jewelry.

1:9a–b

I compare you, my darling, to a mare among Pharaoh’s chariots: In this verse the man compared the woman to a female horse (mare) among the horses that pulled the king’s chariots. Those horses were famous for their beauty and majesty. When the man compared the woman with a chariot horse, he implied that she was beautiful and majestic. It does not imply that the woman actually looked like a horse.

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate how the woman and the horse were alike. For example:

You are as beautiful as a mare among Pharaoh’s chariot horses

You are majestic like the horses that pull the king's chariots

The word chariots probably refers here to the horses that pulled the chariots, not to the chariots themselves. In many languages chariots are unknown, and the term may be distracting here. If that is true in your language, you may refer only to the horses without mentioning chariots, as several English versions do. For example:

I compare you to a mare among Pharaoh's stallions. (GW)

1:9a

I compare you, my darling,

- My love, I compare you^(sing)
- My dearest, you^(sing) are like
- You^(sing), my love, are adorned like

my darling: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as my darling literally means "my friend" or "my companion." But in a context like the Song, it has a romantic sense. This word is the most common way the man referred to the woman in the Song. It is a different term than the one used in 1:7. Use an appropriate term of affection in your language. Some other ways to translate it in English are:

my love (RSV)

my dearest friend

In some languages it may be more natural to put this direct address in a different place in the sentence, for example:

My true love, I compare you... (GW)

You, my love... (GNT)

To a mare...I compare you, my love

In some languages it may be more natural not to use direct address. For example:

You are my true love. I compare you to...

1:9b

to a mare among Pharaoh's chariots.

- to a mare among the horses that pull Pharaoh's chariots.
- one of the horses that belong to the king of Egypt.

a mare among Pharaoh's chariots: There are two ways to interpret the word mare in the phrase a mare among Pharaoh's chariots:

1. The author used the word for female horse, mare. This is the only occurrence of the feminine form for horse, susi, in the whole Bible. because he compared the woman to a horse. It does not imply a contrast with male horses. For example:

I liken you, my darling, to a mare harnessed to one of the chariots of Pharaoh. (NIV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, NASB, NIV, NJB, NJPS, REB, RSV)

1. He used the word mare to imply a contrast with male horses. Usually, chariots were pulled by male horses. If a female horse came among the males, they would become excited. The contrast implies that the woman was exciting to men. For example:

You, my love, excite men as a mare excites the stallions of Pharaoh's chariots. (GNT) (GW, NCV, NET, NLT, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Verses 10-11 focus on the woman's beautiful jewels, not on the way she affected men.

a mare: This feminine form of "horse" occurs only here in the Old Testament. There are two ways to interpret the exact meaning of the form:

1. It means "a mare." For example:

I compare you, my love, to a mare of Pharaoh's chariots. (RSV) (BSB, ESV, GW, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, RSV, GNT)

1. It means "my mare." For example:

I compare you, my love, to my mare harnessed to Pharaoh's chariot. (NJB) (NASB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), since it fits this context better. Also, most English versions and Bible scholars follow it. The suffix on the Hebrew word for "mare" is the ancient remnant of a possessive form and appears to mean "my mare." But in this context it is not to be understood as possessive, and it means "a mare." Several ancient versions mis-

takenly interpreted it “my mare” (LXX, Vulgate, Syriac). See the NET Bible for more details.

Pharaoh’s: The word Pharaoh is a title that the people of Egypt gave to their king. It is not a personal name. Some ways to translate it are:

king

ruler

chief

chariots: A “chariot” is a cart that has wheels and is pulled by horses. Pharaoh’s chariots probably held two or three men. Such chariots were often used in war and sometimes for royal processions. Other ways to translate it are:

war carts

vehicles

Song of Solomon 1:10

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7–8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3–4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

Lines 1:2–4 are the introduction to Section 1:2–2:7. In these lines, the poet summarizes the Song’s message and introduces its main characters: the woman, the man, and a group of young women. In the Song the woman spoke more often than the man spoke. After

the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2–4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 1:9–11 The man spoke to the woman

In these lines the author introduces new comparisons that use Pharaoh's chariot horses and jewelry. The man expressed his admiration for the woman. He focused especially on her face adorned with jewelry.

1:10–11

In 1:10–11, the man compared the woman's beautiful jewelry with the elaborate ornaments that a chariot horse wore. The main focus is not on the beauty of the woman's body, but on the jewelry that added to her own beauty.

1:10a–b

The poetic lines in 1:10a and 1:10b are parallel. Both lines describe parts of the woman's body that are decorated with jewelry, making her look even more beautiful. The parallel parts are marked below with underlining or with bold type:

^{10a} Your cheeks are beautiful **with ornaments**:

^{10b} your neck **with strings of jewels**.

In 1:10b there is an ellipsis, and the words “are beautiful” are understood. In some languages, this ellipsis may not be natural. If that is true in your language, other ways to translate it are:

- Supply implied words in the second line, either the same words or other words with the same meaning. For example:

^{10a}Earrings adorn your cheeks,

^{10b}and your neck is beautiful with strings of jewels.

- Combine 1:10a and 1:10b. For example:

¹⁰Your cheeks and neck are beautiful, decorated with beads and jewels.

1:10a

Your cheeks are beautiful with ornaments,

- Your^(sing) cheeks are beautifully decorated with ornaments,
- Your^(sing) ornaments make you look even more lovely,
- Just like the king's/Pharaoh's horses the sides of your^(sing) face are beautifully ornamented,

Your cheeks are beautiful with ornaments: This clause indicates that the sides of the woman's face were beautifully decorated with jewelry. The orna-

ments may be strings of beads or possibly earrings. It was probably not simply her hair that decorated her cheeks.

A good way to translate this is to use a general term for jewelry which hangs down both sides of a woman's face. If you do not have a general term in your language, you could use a more specific term such as “earring.” For example:

Your cheeks are beautiful with earrings. (NIV)

1:10b

your neck with strings of jewels.

- and your^(sing) neck is beautifully decorated with necklaces of beads/jewels.
- and you^(sing) look beautiful with strings of beads/jewels around your neck.
- and your^(sing) neck has beautiful strings of jewels.

your neck with strings of jewels: The strings of jewels are probably necklaces that are made of beads. TWOT (on TW) has “string of beads.”

Song of Solomon 1:11

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7–8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3–4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh's chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

Lines 1:2–4 are the introduction to Section 1:2–2:7. In these lines, the poet summarizes the Song's message and introduces its main characters: the woman, the man, and a group of young women. In the Song the woman spoke more often than the man spoke. After

the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2-4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 1:9–11 The man spoke to the woman

In these lines the author introduces new comparisons that use Pharaoh’s chariot horses and jewelry. The man expressed his admiration for the woman. He focused especially on her face adorned with jewelry.

1:11a

We will make you ornaments of gold,

- We will make golden jewelry for you^(sing),
- I will have/cause expensive earrings to be made for you^(sing). They will be made of gold,

We will make you ornaments of gold: Scholars differ about who the speaker is in 1:11, because the subject shifts from “I” in 1:9–10 to the plural We in 1:11. English versions use headings to suggest who speaks here. The options are:

1. The speaker is the man. He probably used the form “we” because he himself did not plan to make the jewelry. He probably planned to hire others to make it. For example, the NCV includes 1:11 with 1:9–10 under the heading:

The Man Speaks to the Woman (NCV) (CEV, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, GNT)

1. The speaker is a group of other people. For example, the ESV indicates a new speaker at 1:11 with the heading:

Others (ESV) (BSB, ESV, GW, NASB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as a majority of versions and most scholars do. In 1:9 the man was identified as the speaker in this verse.

ornaments of gold: It is uncertain exactly what these ornaments were. It is possible that they were earrings or necklaces. In 1:10a the word for ornaments was used for jewelry that decorated the woman’s cheeks. There are two options for translation:

- Use a general term such as “ornaments” or “jewelry.” For example:

Let’s make you some jewelry of gold... (CEV)

- Use a more specific term such as “earrings” or “necklace.” For example:

We shall make you golden earrings. (NJB)

a gold necklace/chain

Use an option that sounds natural in your language.

1:11b

studded with beads of silver.

- and decorate it with silver.
- and decorated/adorned with silver.

studded with beads of silver: This phrase describes the way the man planned for the gold ornaments in 1:11a to be decorated. He probably planned for someone to decorate the gold ornaments (1:11a) with silver. The text does not give details about these silver decorations. There are two options for translation:

- Use a general expression that refers to silver decorations. For example:

We will make you earrings of gold and decorate them with silver.

We will make for you a gold necklace with silver ornaments.

- Use a more specific expression such as “beads of silver.” For example:

We will make gold ornaments with silver beads for you. (GW)

Use an option that is natural in your language.

Song of Solomon 1:12

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7–8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3–4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will

discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

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- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2–4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 1:12–14 The woman replied to the man

In 1:12–14 the woman replied to what the man said in 1:9–11 about her beauty. Here in 1:12–14 she also admired him and indicated that she desired him. She mentioned the sweet fragrance that was present when they were together. In 1:12 it was the fragrance of the woman’s perfume that affected the man. A few Bible commentators (e.g., Fox and Murphy) think that “my nard” refers to the king. In other words, they view it as a metaphor describing the king, as in 1:13–14. However, 1:12 does not at all parallel the form of the two comparisons in verses 13–14. It seems more likely that nard in 1:12 refers to the woman’s perfume, not to the king himself.

In 1:13–14 the woman used two metaphors to compare the man with fragrances. The metaphors imply that the man delighted her like a wonderful fragrance. In these lines she probably imagined or dreamed about being with her beloved. She was probably not actually with him.

1:12a–b

While the king was at his table, my perfume spread its fragrance: The clause While the king was at his table (1:12a) tells where the king was while the scent of the woman’s perfume was in the air. In OT times, people reclined, or lay, on couches when they ate, so the REB has “While the king reclines on his couch.” Use natural verb forms in your language to describe this. Some ways to do this in English are:

While the king reclines on his couch, my spike-nard gives forth its scent. (REB)

My king is sitting at his table, and the scent of my perfume is in the air.

1:12a

While the king was at his table,

- My “king” sits at his table,

the king: In this context the woman used the word king as a poetic term of affection to refer to her beloved. He was not an actual king. It is good to translate the term here as you did in 1:4b. For example:

my chief

my king

at his table: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as table describes something round. The phrase at his table is more literally “in his circle/round.” Scholars differ about what the word “circle/round” refers to here:

1. It refers to a “couch.” For example:

his couch (REB) (CEV, ESV, NCV, NJPS, NLT, REB, RSV, GNT)

1. It refers to a “table.” For example:

his table (NIV) (BSB, GW, NASB, NET, NIV)

1. It refers to “an enclosure,” maybe to his room or to a different enclosed place. For example:

his own room (NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as most versions and scholars do. It is possible that the word is another way to refer to the same couch that is mentioned in 1:16c.

1:12b

my perfume spread its fragrance.

- my nard spread its fragrance.
- and the odor of my perfume fills the room/air.

my perfume spread its fragrance: The Hebrew word translated as perfume in the BSB, is more literally, “nard.” Nard refers to an expensive perfume imported from India. It had a beautiful fragrance, and it seemed to encourage sexual desire in that culture. The clause my perfume spread its fragrance indicates that the smell of the woman’s perfume spread through the air. Everyone around could smell it. Other ways to translate this are:

my perfume fills the air with its fragrance. (GW)

the smell/odor of my perfume spread throughout the room.

Describe the spreading fragrance of perfume in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages, it may be possible to translate the idea with an idiom that would fit the poetic style.

my perfume: The phrase my perfume refers here to a type of perfumed oil that the woman spread on her body. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

the perfume that I rubbed on my body

my expensive nard perfume

perfume: The word perfume refers here to perfumed oil that was made from the nard plant. This plant grows in the Himalaya mountains far away, so the nard oil was rare and expensive in Israel. For more information about the nard plant and a picture of it, see the note on perfume in 4:13c.

General Comment on 1:12

In some languages, a time clause does not occur first in the sentence. So the order of the two clauses in this verse may need to be reversed. For example:

My perfume spread its fragrance while my king was at his table.

Song of Solomon 1:13

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7–8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3–4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

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- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

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In 1:13–14 the woman used two metaphors to compare the man with fragrances. The metaphors imply that the man delighted her like a wonderful fragrance. In these lines she probably imagined or dreamed about being with her beloved. She was probably not actually with him.

1:13a–b

My beloved is to me a sachet of myrrh resting between my breasts: Allegorical interpreters said that the two breasts referred to something other than actual breasts of the woman. For example, some said that it refers to the Old and New Testaments. There are many different allegorical interpretations that have been suggested here. But there is nothing in the immediate context or in the book to suggest such interpretations. It is recommended to take "breasts" literally. Here the author used a metaphor. The woman compared the man to a sachet, or bag, of myrrh. The BSB supplied the verb *is*, but in the Hebrew text such a verb does not occur, since the meaning is already implied. *lying between her breasts*. Myrrh has a delightful fragrance. As the woman smelled it, she imagined the man being close to her like the myrrh was. His presence was delightful like the fragrance of the myrrh. This metaphor is similar in some ways to the comparison in 1:3 where the man's fragrance figuratively represents his wonderful character.

In some languages this metaphor may not communicate the meaning well. If that is true in your language, other ways to translate it are:

- Use a simile. For example:

My beloved is to me like a sachet of myrrh resting between my breasts.

- Indicate how the man was like the sachet of myrrh. For example:

My lover has the scent of myrrh as he lies upon my breasts. (GNT)

My beloved is close to me like a sachet of myrrh between my breasts.

Translate the metaphor in a meaningful way in your language.

bag of myrrh: sachet of myrrh: myrrh is an expensive perfume, which at that time was imported into Israel from other countries. It was made from the resin of a myrrh tree. The resin could be obtained in both solid and liquid forms. As a solid, it was put in a small sachet made of cloth or leather. The woman hung the sachet around her neck. Then the fragrance of the myrrh made her body smell sweet.

In some languages myrrh may not be known. If that is true in your language, some ways to translate it are:

- Use a general term for something that people put on their bodies to make them smell sweet. For example:

perfume (CEV)

- Indicate the meaning by other words in the context. For example:

a fragrant pouch of myrrh (NET)

sweet-smelling myrrh

It may also be helpful to include a footnote. For example, the NET has this footnote:

Myrrh is a fragrant resin used for perfumes. (NET)

1:13a**My beloved is to me a sachet of myrrh**

- My love is to me like a sachet/bag of myrrh,
- My darling is a bag of sweet-smelling perfume,
- As a bag of sweet-smelling myrrh lies between my breasts, so my beloved king

My beloved: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *My beloved* is the most common way that the woman used to refer to the man in the Song. It implies that he was the one whom she loved. It does not imply that she and he had sexual relations. Try to translate the word in a way that does not imply sexual union. For example:

my love

my darling

the one I love

1:13b

resting between my breasts.

- lodging between my breasts.
- lying on my chest.
- spends the night with me in close embrace.

resting: There are two main interpretations of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as resting.

1. It means “stay” or “spend the night.” For example:

spending the night between my breasts. (NET)
(NASB, NCV, NET, NJPS)

1. It means “lie” or “rest.” For example:

resting between my breasts. (NIV) (BSB, CEV, ESV,
NIV, NJB, NLT, REB, RSV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The verb form used here suggests an extended time such as “all night.”

between my breasts: In some languages the word breasts here may seem too sexually explicit. Some interpreters in the early Church also felt uncomfortable interpreting the word “breasts” here in a literal way. Breasts were thought to represent something else, for example, the Old and New Testaments. However, this interpretation is not the best way to understand the verse. The best interpretation is the natural meaning. If that is true in your language, you may need to translate in a more general way. For example:

My beloved lies close to me just like a sweet-smelling bag of myrrh lies next to my chest.

Song of Solomon 1:14

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy

for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7–8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3–4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

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- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

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1:2–4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 1:12–14 The woman replied to the man

In 1:12–14 the woman replied to what the man said in 1:9–11 about her beauty. Here in 1:12–14 she also admired him and indicated that she desired him. She mentioned the sweet fragrance that was present when they were together. In 1:12 it was the fragrance of the woman’s perfume that affected the man. A few Bible commentators (e.g., Fox and Murphy) think that “my nard” refers to the king. In other words, they view it as a metaphor describing the king, as in 1:13–14. However, 1:12 does not at all parallel the form of the two comparisons in verses 13–14. It seems more likely that nard in 1:12 refers to the woman’s perfume, not to the king himself.

In 1:13–14 the woman used two metaphors to compare the man with fragrances. The metaphors imply that the man delighted her like a wonderful fragrance. In these lines she probably imagined or dreamed about being with her beloved. She was probably not actually with him.

1:14a

My beloved is to me a cluster of henna blossoms

- My love is like a cluster of henna blossoms
- The one I love is as pleasing/delightful to me as the fragrant flowers

My beloved is to me a cluster of henna blossoms:

This clause is a metaphor. The woman compares the man to the fragrance of henna blossoms. There is no verb in the Hebrew text, but in English a “to be” verb (is) can be supplied here. He was as pleasing as those sweet-smelling flowers. If a metaphor does not communicate the meaning clearly, some other ways to translate it are:

- Use a simile. For example:

My beloved is to me like a cluster of henna blossoms

- Indicate explicitly how the man was like the henna blossoms. For example:

My beloved is as delightful to me as the sweet-smelling henna flowers

Translate the metaphor in a way that will communicate clearly in your language.

a cluster of henna blossoms: henna The botanical name is *Lawsonia inermis*. is a large shrub with clusters of fragrant flowers that grows in tropical climates. It may be called by a different name in your area, so you may want to consult an expert on plants to determine the local name.

In some languages it is helpful to mention the fragrant quality of henna in the translation. For example:

My beloved is pleasing like the fragrance of henna flowers...

If henna flowers are unknown or if its fragrance is not considered pleasing, it is better to translate it in a more general way. For example:

My beloved is to me a cluster of sweet-smelling flowers

1:14b

in the vineyards of En-gedi.

- in the vineyards of En-gedi/Engedi oasis.
- that grow among the grapevines in Engedi.

Here in 1:14b, the vineyards may represent the woman, as in 1:6f. In the Song, vineyards, grapes, and wine often symbolize the pleasure of romantic love.

in the vineyards of En-gedi: There are two ways to interpret the phrase in the vineyards of En-gedi in this context:

1. It indicates that the henna blossoms were located in vineyards at En-gedi. For example:

My beloved is to me a cluster of henna blossoms in the vineyards of Engedi. (RSV) (BSB, ESV, GW, NASB, NET, NLT, RSV, GNT)

1. It indicates that the henna blossoms came from vineyards at En-gedi. For example:

My beloved is to me a cluster of henna blossoms from the vineyards of En Gedi. (NIV) (CEV, NCV, NIV, NJPS, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It helps to show that the metaphor in 1:14 is parallel to the one in 1:13 and has a similar meaning. In 1:13 the bag of myrrh is a metaphor for the man lying between the woman's breasts. In 1:14 the henna blossoms in the vineyards of En-gedi is probably a metaphor for the woman's fragrant body.

vineyards of En-gedi: The word vineyards refers here to farms where grapes are grown. Grapes were an important fruit in Palestine. They were used to make wine and were also eaten raw. You may want to include a picture of a grape vine or a grape farm in your translation. For example:

En-gedi: En-gedi is a beautiful oasis (a watered area in the midst of a desert). It is located near the western shore of the Dead Sea in a lush valley between barren rocky cliffs. The En-gedi, or Engedi, oasis is a refreshing/beautiful place with a stream and waterfalls that provide water for vineyards and other plants. It is also known for its fragrant spices.

Other ways to translate the phrase “in the vineyards of En-gedi” are:

in the grape farms of beautiful/lush En-gedi

from the gardens in the oasis called En-gedi

Song of Solomon 1:15

Section 1:2-2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2-2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2-4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5-6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3-6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7-8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3-4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,”

and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh's chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

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- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

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- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

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Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

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1:15a-b

How beautiful you are, my darling! Oh, how very beautiful! Here the man spoke directly to the woman with an exclamation that emphasizes her beauty. He repeated the word beautiful to emphasize it. In some languages, this repetition is not natural. If that is true in your language, use a different way to translate the emphasis. For example:

You are a very beautiful woman.

you are really lovely

1:15a

How beautiful you are, my darling!

- Oh, you^(sing) are beautiful, my dearest,
- How lovely you^(sing) are, my darling!
- My dearest, you^(sing) are so beautiful,

my darling: See 1:9a-b for a discussion of my darling. In some languages a direct address comes first in the sentence. For example:

My darling, how beautiful you are...

1:15b

Oh, how very beautiful!

- oh, you^(sing) are beautiful!
- You^(sing) are truly gorgeous/lovely!
- you^(sing) are so very beautiful!

Oh: The Hebrew word *hinneh* that the BSB translates as Oh means “Look!” It calls attention to the woman’s beauty and emphasizes it. Consider how to do that in a natural way in your language. Some languages may use an emphatic word or phrase. For example:

Behold, you are beautiful...! (RSV) See also NIV, NJPS, NRSV, REB.

Look at you! You are beautiful...! (GW)

Wow/Ah, you are so beautiful!

1:15c

Your eyes are like doves.

- Your^(sing) eyes are doves.
- Your^(sing) eyes are as gentle as doves.
- Your^(sing) eyes are gentle, yes, as gentle and beautiful as doves.

Your eyes are like doves: The clause Your eyes are like doves is a simile. It indicates that the woman’s eyes reminded the man of doves in some way. It does not imply that her eyes looked like doves. It implies that her eyes had a quality that reminded him of doves.

Scholars do not know exactly how the woman’s eyes were like doves. But in this context it is obvious that the simile was a compliment to describe her beautiful eyes. Doves are gentle birds, and gentle eyes are beautiful.

Some ways to interpret the compliment are:

1. Her eyes were gentle and beautiful like doves.
2. Her eyes caused the man to feel more intense love for her. Doves were sometimes used as symbols of love.
3. Her eyes were lively or sparkling like a dove’s lively movements.

English versions do not make explicit which interpretation they follow. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It seems to be the most natural interpretation based on the common characteristics of doves.

In some languages it may be necessary to make this interpretation explicit so that people will not understand a wrong meaning. For example:

Your eyes show that you are as gentle as a dove.

your eyes, they are beautiful like doves.

In some areas doves are not known. If that is true in your language, some other ways to translate it are:

- Use a bird in your area that is known as gentle and beautiful.
- Use a more general phrase. For example:

a shy, beautiful bird

doves: doves are small birds that people raised in that culture for meat. In the Bible doves are often used as a metaphor to describe gentleness, human mourning, or beauty. A man could use “dove” or “my dove” as a

name for his beloved as he spoke to her in a loving way.

General Comment on 1:15

In some languages you may want to use parallel phrases to translate 1:15c, just as in 1:15a–b. For example:

^{15a}How beautiful you are, my darling!

^{15b}Oh how very beautiful!

^{15c}Your eyes are like doves,

yes, just like doves.

Song of Solomon 1:16

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7–8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3–4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

Lines 1:2–4 are the introduction to Section 1:2–2:7. In these lines, the poet summarizes the Song’s message and introduces its main characters: the woman, the man, and a group of young women. In the Song the woman spoke more often than the man spoke. After the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2–4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

1:16a

How handsome you are, my beloved!

- Oh, how handsome you^(sing) are, my dear one,
- My love, you^(sing) are very handsome.

How handsome you are, my beloved!: The woman’s reply to the man here is very similar to his words in 1:15a.

How: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as How is the same Hebrew word translated as Oh in 1:15a–b.

handsome: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as handsome is the same Hebrew word translated as beautiful in 1:15. Here, it is used to describe the man. In 1:15a, the form was feminine, yapah. But here in 1:16a, the form is masculine, yapeh.

my beloved: The Hebrew word *dodiy* that the BSB translates as beloved is the most common way that the woman referred to the man in the Song. Translate it with an appropriate term of affection that a woman would use to speak to the man whom she loves. For example:

my love

darling

In some languages, you may need to put the direct address, my beloved, first in the sentence. For example:

My beloved, how handsome you are!

For more information, see the note on my beloved in 1:13a–b.

1:16b

Oh, how delightful!

- really handsome!
- You^(sing) are truly pleasing.

Oh, how delightful!: There is an ellipsis here. The words in 1:16a, “you are” are understood after the phrase how delightful. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as delightful can refer to pleasing physical appearance or to excellent character. Because 1:15 and 1:16 have similar structures, it is likely that in 1:16b the woman referred to the man’s appearance. Two other ways to translate the verse are:

- In 1:16b use a word or phrase that has a similar meaning as the word used in 1:16a for physical beauty. For example:

^{16a}How handsome you are my love,

^{16b}how very good looking!

- Use a more general word or phrase that can include physical beauty. For example:

^{16a}How handsome you are, my dearest; (GNT)

^{16b}how you delight me!

- Repeat the word in 1:16a, making it emphatic. For example:

^{16a}My love, you are handsome, (CEV)

^{16b}truly handsome...

Use an option that is natural in your language.

1:16c–17b

These verses describe a secret meeting place. There are two ways to interpret the type of meeting place that it describes:

1. It refers to an actual or imaginary place in a forest. For example:

The green grass will be our bed; the cedars will be the beams of our house, and the cypress trees the ceiling. (GNT) (BSB, GNT, REB, GW, CEV, NCV, NLT, NET)

1. It refers figuratively to a real bedroom with beams made of cedar planks. English versions that may follow this interpretation are ambiguous.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The context implies that the author wants readers to imagine a forest scene.

1:16c

The soft grass is our bed.

- Our^(incl) bed is green plants,
- The green grass is our^(incl) couch.
- Our^(incl) bed is shaded by leaves,

The soft grass is our bed: The clause The soft grass is our bed is figurative. It implies that the man and woman rested together in a garden or forest. The point is not that the color of their bed is green.

grass: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as grass means “lush.” In the OT it generally refers to foliage of trees. In this context, it is possible that it refers to the grass where the couple made their bed under the green trees. In 1:17 the author mentioned the green roof of their forest “house.” The Song seems to take place in springtime. In the Middle East this would be the time for new green growth.

bed: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as bed refers to any place used for lying down, such as a couch (RSV).

There are at least three ways to translate “The soft grass is our bed”:

- Refer to grass or other plants as the bed or resting place. For example:

Our bed is the grass. (NCV)

- Refer to the leaves of the trees over the bed. For example:

Our couch is shaded with branches. (REB)

- Use a more general phrase that can refer to either the grass or the green leaves of the surrounding trees. For example:

Our resting/sleeping place is a verdant place in the forest.

Any of these options are acceptable. It is probably more important in this passage to maintain poetic quality than to give an exact description of the place.

Song of Solomon 1:17

Section 1:2-2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2-2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2-4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5-6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3-6), she felt secure that he loved her.

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the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

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Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

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1:17a

The beams of our house are cedars;

- the roof beams of our^(incl) house are made of cedar branches,
- The roof of our^(incl) house is supported by branches of cedar trees,
- and fragrant/sweet-smelling tree branches are the beams of our^(incl) house,

The beams of our house are cedars: The Hebrew form of this word is plural, “houses.” But in this context it probably has a singular meaning, “house.” This clause continues the figurative description of the couple’s forest house. The trees surround the man and woman, providing protection and privacy. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Branches of cedar trees are the “roof” of our house

Branches of cedar trees are like the roof of a house for us

Our roof is the sky, and the cedar trees are like its frame/supports

The beams: The word beams refers to large pieces of wood that support the roof of a house. In this context, the branches of the cedar trees are like these large pieces of wood in a house. The man and woman looked up at these branches of the trees, as though they were in a forest “house” looking up at the beams that support the roof.

cedars: The word “cedar” is a kind of evergreen tree that grows large and tall. Its wood is hard and smells sweet, and it is valuable for building.

1:17b

our rafters are fragrant firs.

- and the rafters are made of fragrant fir branches.
- and its roof is covered by boughs of fragrant fir trees.
- pine branches are its roof.

our rafters are fragrant firs: This line is parallel to 1:17a, and the rafters here refer to the rafters of their “house,” that was mentioned there. The full form is:

the rafters of our house are fragrant firs.

In both lines the beams and rafters are figurative. In some languages you may need to make this clear. For example:

and the fragrant fir trees are like rafters for it.

rafters: The meaning of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as rafters is uncertain. Another possible translation is “roof.” This also fits the parallel structure of the verse.

fragrant firs: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as fragrant firs is another variety of tall evergreen tree. The exact type is uncertain, and English versions translate it in different ways. For example:

cypress trees (GNT)

pine (RSV)

juniper wood (NCV)

Since the exact type of evergreen tree is uncertain, you may use a general term for “tree” or the word for a tree that is common in your area.

General Comment on 1:16c–17b

In these verses it is important to use a poetic way to describe a place where the man and woman could be together privately. The woman described that place as their “bed,” because the beautiful trees that surrounded them were like the walls and roof of a bedroom.

It is not necessary to find words in your language that refer exactly to “beams,” “cedar,” “rafters” and “pine.” It is more important to use a poetic way to compare a beautiful place in the forest to a private “bedroom.” The Notes follows the “forest” interpretation of 1:17, but it is also possible that the verse is a figurative description of an indoor bedroom. If people in your culture consider making love in the forest as taboo or sinful, you may follow the “indoor” interpretation.

Song of Solomon 2:1

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

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- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

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Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

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The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 2:1–7 The man and woman praised each other

Lines 2:1–7 are the end of the first poetic section in the Song. In them, the man and woman praised each other. He brought her to his banquet room and embraced her. In 2:7 she cautioned the women of Jerusalem not to awaken love before the right time.

2:1a

I am a rose of Sharon,

- I am a crocus on the plains of Sharon,
- I am like a wild flower on the Sharon plains,
- I’m just a common wild flower on the Sharon plains,

I am a rose of Sharon: This verse was mistakenly thought by some early scholars to be spoken by the man (who was allegorically considered to be Christ). In the sixteenth century, English versions began to translate the wildflower in 2:1a incorrectly as “the rose of Sharon” (probably based on Aquila and Origen) and the verse found its way into Christian hymns, for example, calling Christ the “Rose of Sharon” (and “Lily of the valleys”). However, the context makes it clear that it is the woman speaking here to describe herself, not the man. Nearly all modern scholars and versions acknowledge this. The statement I am a rose of Sharon is a metaphor. The woman compared herself to a flower on the plains of Sharon. There are three ways to interpret this statement:

1. She was being humble. She implied that she was only an ordinary girl, and she had a common beauty like many other girls. For example:

I am only a wild flower in Sharon... (GNT) (CEV, NEB, NET, GNT)

1. She was being proud or self-confident. She implied that she was unusually beautiful. For example:

I am the rose of Sharon. In this context the use of the English definite article “the” seems to imply that there are no other roses in Sharon worth

looking at beside her, that is, she is the most beautiful rose or flower in Sharon. (NJB) (KJV, NASB, NJB, NLT)

1. The statement does not indicate clearly whether she was humble or proud. For example:

I am a rose of Sharon. (NIV) (BSB, GW, NCV, NIV, NJPS, REB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). She implied that she was pretty like a common flower, but she was not unusually beautiful. Some scholars who follow this interpretation include: Carr, Delitzsch, Elliott, Estes, Fox, Gledhill, Longman, Mitchell, Murphy, Ogden & Zogbo, Pope, and Snaith. In 2:2 the man responded by reassuring her that she was indeed very beautiful and not common. The discussion in 1:5-6 also suggests that the woman was humble about her appearance. Some other ways to translate 2:1a are:

I am only a wild flower in Sharon... (GNT)

I am a meadow flower from Sharon... (NET)

I am an asphodel in Sharon... (NEB)

rose: The exact meaning of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates rose is uncertain. The word is used only one other place in the OT, in Isaiah 35:1, where most English versions translate it “crocus” or “flower.” Many English versions translate it as “rose.” These versions follow an early tradition of English Bible translation from the sixteenth century. but nearly all Bible scholars agree that the flower was not a rose. Most modern versions include a footnote such as “Hebrew crocus” or “probably a member of the crocus family.” Roses were unknown in ancient Israel. The Hebrew word more likely refers to a “crocus,” “asphodel” or “narcissus.” Versions that use an expression other than the traditional “rose” include the NAB, NLT, NEB, NET, and GNT. Some ways to translate the word are:

- Use a general term for a common flower that grows naturally without being cultivated. For example:

wildflower

meadow flower

- Use a specific word that refers to a beautiful wildflower that grows in your area. Some examples of wildflowers that grow in Israel are:

crocus

asphodel

narcissus

Here the woman described herself in a humble way, so it is probably best not to use a flower that is grown for its special beauty.

Sharon: Sharon was the name of a large level plain in Israel. It was located between the Mediterranean Sea and the mountains. In some languages it may be helpful to indicate what the name Sharon refers to. For example:

the plain of Sharon

You may also choose to include a footnote with more information. For example:

The name Sharon refers to a large plain beside the coast. It is a well-watered and fertile land, and many wild flowers grow there.

2:1b a lily of the valley.

- I am just a valley lily.
- I am like a common lily of the valley.

In this part of the verse the woman gave another example of a common wild flower to which she compared herself. In some languages it may be more natural to connect 2:1a and 2:1b with a conjunction.

a lily of the valley: There is an ellipsis here. In the phrase a lily of the valley the woman gave another example of a wild flower that she was like. The full form is “I am a lily of the valley.” This lily is a common flower that is usually red or purple.

Here the phrase is a metaphor like the one in 2:1a. The woman used it to indicate that she was as ordinary as one of the many lilies that grow in the valleys. Some other ways to translate the metaphor are:

- Use a simile. For example:

I am like a lily of the valley.

like a lily growing in the valley.

- Indicate how the woman was like a lily of the valley. For example:

as common as a lily in the valley.

Translate the metaphor in a natural way in your language.

Song of Solomon 2:2

Section 1:2-2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2-2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2-4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5-6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3-6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7-8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3-4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

Lines 1:2-4 are the introduction to Section 1:2-2:7. In these lines, the poet summarizes the Song’s message and introduces its main characters: the woman, the man, and a group of young women. In the Song the woman spoke more often than the man spoke. After the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a differ-

ent form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2-4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 2:1-7 The man and woman praised each other

Lines 2:1-7 are the end of the first poetic section in the Song. In them, the man and woman praised each other. He brought her to his banquet room and embraced her. In 2:7 she cautioned the women of Jerusalem not to awaken love before the right time.

2:2a

Like a lily among the thorns

- Just like a pretty lily among thorns,
- You^(sing) are like a beautiful flower surrounded by thorns,

2:2b

is my darling among the maidens.

- so is my girl among the other girls.
- when you^(sing) are with the other young women.

2:2a-b

Like a lily among the thorns is my darling among the maidens: In 2:1 the woman compared herself to a common lily among many other lilies (pretty girls). Here in 2:2 the man agreed that she was like a lily. But he added that other women were like thorns compared to her. Thorns are ugly, and a lily is beautiful. The man used this contrast to emphasize that the woman was much more beautiful than other women.

In some cultures people are not familiar with lilies or with thorns. If that is true in your culture, some other ways to translate the comparison are:

- Use a plant that people in your culture consider beautiful and contrast it with one that they consider ugly. For example:

Like a daisy in a field of pigweed, my love is much more beautiful than other girls.

- Use a more general comparison. For example:

My beloved is like a lovely flower among ugly weeds.

maidens: The word maidens probably refers to other young women in general. The Hebrew text has “the maidens,” but it refers here to any women that the man’s beloved might be compared to. Garrett (page 149) says, “He declares that, compared to all other young women, she is a lotus among thorns.” Pope (page 370) also indicates that the author refers to “women in general” here. Use a natural way in your language to refer to women or young women in general.

General Comment on 2:2

In some languages, it may be clearer to reorder 2:2. It may also be helpful to indicate explicitly that it is a comparison. For example:

^{2b}Yes, compared to other women, ^{2a}my beloved is like a lily among thorns. (NLT96)

Song of Solomon 2:3

Section 1:2-2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2-2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2-4) the woman

spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5-6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3-6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7-8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3-4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

Lines 1:2-4 are the introduction to Section 1:2-2:7. In these lines, the poet summarizes the Song’s message and introduces its main characters: the woman, the man, and a group of young women. In the Song the woman spoke more often than the man spoke. After the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2-4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 2:1-7 The man and woman praised each other

Lines 2:1-7 are the end of the first poetic section in the Song. In them, the man and woman praised each other. He brought her to his banquet room and embraced her. In 2:7 she cautioned the women of Jerusalem not to awaken love before the right time.

2:3a-b

Like an apple tree among the trees of the forest is my beloved among the young men: Here the woman implied that the apple tree is the best type of tree in the wood. Then she implied that her beloved is the best man among all the other young men. Some other ways to translate this verse are:

Compared to other young men, my beloved is like a fruitful apple tree in a forest of trees without fruit.

Like an apple tree among the other trees, my love is more delightful than all the other young men.

It is good to translate this verse in a similar way as you translated 2:2.

2:3a

Like an apple tree among the trees of the forest

- Like an apple tree among the other trees of the forest,
- As a tree with delicious fruit is more desirable than unfruitful trees in the woods,

- You^(sing) are like a fruitful tree among other trees with no fruit,

apple tree: Scholars are not sure exactly what type of tree the Hebrew text refers to here. It is not certain that the tree was the same tree that people call apple tree in English. Some scholars argue that the apple tree was unknown in ancient Israel and that the meaning of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as “apple tree” is uncertain. Some other suggestions include “apricot” or “quince.” However, other scholars point out that the apple tree was known in Mesopotamia and could easily have been known in Israel. The important facts for a translator to consider are that the tree had edible fruit and a pleasant scent.

If the apple tree is unknown in your language, some other ways to translate it are:

- Use a general term to describe a tree that bears fruit that is good to eat. For example:

fruit tree

- Use a word for another edible fruit tree with a pleasant smell. For example:

apricot tree

mango tree

The apple tree was a symbol for romantic love. If people in your culture do not think of an apple tree or any other fruit tree as a symbol for love, you may include a footnote with this information. For example:

In the Hebrew culture, this kind of tree was a symbol for romantic love.

among the trees of the forest: The apple tree is located among the other trees in a forest. It is near them but it is different from them. It is delicious and fragrant compared to the other forest trees.

trees of the forest: The phrase trees of the forest refers to the other common trees of the forest that do not produce fruit. The word forest does not refer to a tree farm or orchard. The trees in this verse were uncultivated trees.

2:3b

is my beloved among the young men.

- so too is my beloved among the other young men.
- my love is more desirable than other young men.

- my beloved. None of the other men are like you^(sing).

is my beloved among the young men: The woman's words here are parallel to what she said in 2:2b. There she compared the apple tree with forest trees. Here she compared the man to other men in a similar way. Just as the apple tree was better than the other trees, so her beloved was better than other young men. He was the most desirable among all of them. It is good to translate this statement in a similar way as you translated 2:2b.

General Comment on 2:3a–b

In some languages it may be necessary to change the order of the clauses. For example:

^{3b}Among the young men, my lover is ^{3a}like an apple tree in the woods! (NCV)

2:3c

I delight to sit in his shade,

- With great delight I sat in his shadow, (RSV)
- Sitting in his shade is delightful,
- Being with you^(sing) refreshes me like sitting in the shade,

I delight to sit in his shade: The statement I delight to sit in his shade is a figure of speech. It indicates that the man refreshed the woman, as if she were sitting in the shade of an apple tree (see 2:3a). There is a subtle transition from apple tree to the man. As Roland Murphy says, “The metaphors of “shadow” and “fruit” melt into the reality of their relationship, symbolizing the delights of love.” Part of this “melting” is due to the ambiguity in Hebrew where the masculine person marker might refer to either the man or the tree. Most English versions take the pronoun to refer to the man and therefore translate it “his shadow” and “his fruit.” In the climate of Israel, people need shade so that they can have relief from the hot sun. When the woman was with the man, he refreshed her, just as sitting in the shade of an apple tree refreshes people and pleases them with its coolness.

Some other ways to translate this are:

I sit in his delightful shade (NLT)

I love/want to sit resting in his shade

The word sit can also have the general meaning “to be in the presence of.” Another way to translate the meaning is:

Your shade brought me pleasure (CEV)

Sitting near him is a delight to me.

Use an option that is natural in your language.

in his shade: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as in his shade can refer to the man's shadow or to the shade of the tree. This sort of ambiguity is common in the Song, and the author probably had a poetic purpose for it. This kind of ambiguity also occurred in 1:13 where it seemed unclear grammatically whether the woman was referring to the bag of myrrh or the man. This was also true in 1:14 with the man and the henna blossoms.

In some languages it is confusing or impossible to translate the ambiguity. If that is true in your language, you can indicate that the man is the focus of the comparison, not the tree. Most English versions follow this option.

shade: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as shade refers here to the cool shade under a tree. It also has figurative meanings. It is a metaphor for “protection,” and it can also mean “refreshment.” Here the meaning “refreshment” is probably in focus.

In some languages a word like shade implies a wrong meaning. It is important to use a natural way in your language to speak about the coolness and refreshment that trees provide.

2:3d

and his fruit is sweet to my taste.

- and his fruit is sweet in my mouth.
- and his fruit tastes sweet.
- and you^(sing) are desirable to me like sweet fruit.

and his fruit is sweet to my taste: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as his fruit is ambiguous in this context. There are two ways to interpret it here:

1. It means his fruit (it refers to something sweet or desirable about the man himself). For example:

His fruit tastes sweet to me. (GW) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB, RSV)

1. It means “its fruit” (it refers to the tree's fruit). For example:

...and its fruit is sweet to my taste. (GNT) (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with almost all English versions. It is the man who is in focus, not the tree.

his fruit: The phrase his fruit is a metaphor. It refers to something about the man that is “delicious” or “refreshing” like fruit. It does not refer to edible fruit that belongs to the man. In this context his fruit may imply the man’s kisses. But it probably refers more generally to various ways that he showed his love for the woman.

In some languages the metaphor may not be understood. If that is true in your language, some other ways to translate it are:

- Use a simile. For example:

He is like sweet/delicious fruit to me.

- Use a simile and indicate the meaning in some way. For example:

He is desirable/wonderful to me like sweet fruit.

Like sweet fruit, he delights me.

is: Here the Hebrew text does not have a verb like is. The woman referred to her present feelings about the man, and that agrees with her statement in 2:3c. Use a natural way in your language to describe present or ongoing feelings.

sweet to my taste: The phrase sweet to my taste describes something that is pleasant to a person when he tastes it. In this context it is used as a metaphor. It means that the man’s characteristics pleased the woman. Be sure that your translation of the phrase does not only refer to tasting sweet but can refer in general to the pleasure that the man gives the woman. For example:

pleases me very much.

fills me with delight.

Song of Solomon 2:4

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of

her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7–8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3–4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in this section.

Lines 1:2–4 are the introduction to Section 1:2–2:7. In these lines, the poet summarizes the Song’s message and introduces its main characters: the woman, the man, and a group of young women. In the Song the woman spoke more often than the man spoke. After the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2–4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also

decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 2:1–7 The man and woman praised each other

Lines 2:1–7 are the end of the first poetic section in the Song. In them, the man and woman praised each other. He brought her to his banquet room and embraced her. In 2:7 she cautioned the women of Jerusalem not to awaken love before the right time.

2:4a

He has brought me to the house of wine,

- He has led me to the banquet room,
- He leads me to the place of celebration,

He has brought me to the house of wine: Here the woman imagined the man bringing her to a house of wine, or banquet hall, as in the NIV. The BSB translates this as a past action. However, here it probably describes what the woman wanted the man to do. In her thoughts she imagined him doing it. Use a natural verb form in your language. This is the Jussive use of the perfect aspect, also called the precative perfect. It expresses a strong wish or desire using the third person (e.g., “may he” or “let him”). It fits well in the context of the following verse’s imperatives. Both the ancient Septuagint and Syriac versions interpreted the Hebrew verb as a second person imperative (re-vocalizing the consonants).

Some other ways to translate this wish or imagination are:

Let him lead me to the banquet hall... (NIV)

He brings me to the banquet hall... (NLT96)

The same verb is used in 1:4b, and it functions in a similar way. Older grammatical theories saw the Hebrew verb system as tense-based, similar to Indo-European languages. However, newer, more linguistically informed, views understand the Hebrew verb conjugations as marking various aspectual (perfective and non-perfective) nuances rather than time. The time is determined in the larger context by time words, syntax, genre, etc. rather than verbal endings.

house of wine: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates literally as house of wine is also translated as “banquet hall,” as in the NIV. *bet hayyayin* It can refer to any place where people go to drink wine. It does not necessarily imply a house or building. Here it probably does not refer to a formal banquet hall, because the man and woman met in a private place. It may refer to the figurative house in the forest that was mentioned in 1:17a.

In some languages it may be helpful to translate house of wine with a more general term. For example:

the place of celebration

the feasting place

wine: wine often has a romantic meaning in the Song, so the house of wine may be a euphemism for the “place of love.” It may be helpful to include a footnote to explain what the term implies in this verse. For example:

The phrase house of wine in the Hebrew text probably does not refer to a house where people come to drink wine together. It is a poetic way to say that the man took the woman to a romantic place where they could show their love for one another.

2:4b

and his banner over me is love.

- and put his flag/sign of love over me.
- and shows everyone that he loves and protects me.

and his banner over me is love: There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. The Hebrew word in the Masoretic Text means “banner,” “standard” or “flag.” For example:

and his banner over me is love. (NASB) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NJPS, RSV, GNT)

1. In other ancient Hebrew manuscripts, the word has different vowels but the same consonants as in the Hebrew Masoretic Text. It means to “look” or “glance.” This meaning is based on a homophonous consonant root that means “look, glance.” It seems to be related to a cognate Akkadian word dagalu, “to see/look.” Originally, Hebrew did not mark vowels, so scholars who follow this interpretation suggest that perhaps the later Masoretic text incorrectly marked the vowels here. For example:

and he looked at me lovingly. (NET) (GW, NET, REB)

1. The word comes from a related language. It means “intention.” This interpretation is based on an Akkadian cognate diglu, “desire” or “intent.” For example:

and his intention toward me was love. (NRSV) (NLT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as most English versions and commentators do. However, the meaning of the word is figurative in this context. See the next note on banner for more information.

banner: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as banner refers to a big flag (a large cloth attached to a long, thin piece of wood). It was carried or set in a place where people could see it from far away. Each of the tribes of Israel had a banner, and kings and armies had banners. Most other occurrences of this word in the OT are found in the book of Numbers, where the [0] tribes of Israel had banners to identify their different encampments. They also used them in battle so that the members of each tribe would gather near their tribal banner to fight together. A king’s banner had symbols or pictures that identified him and his kingdom.

When a king conquered a city, he set up his banner over it to indicate that it now belonged to him. Here in 2:4, the word banner is a metaphor. It implies that the man took responsibility for the woman to love and protect her.

Some ways to translate the metaphor “his banner over me is love” are:

- Translate the metaphor literally. For example:

He raised a flag of love over me.

- Translate the metaphor as a simile. For example:

As a king sets his flag over his people, he shows that I am protected by his love.

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

He took me as his own and protected me with his love.

In some languages there may be a similar metaphor with the same meaning. Translate the meaning in a natural and appropriate way in your language.

is: The BSB supplies the word is, which implies present time, but the Hebrew text does not indicate when the events happened. Translate the statement in a way that fits with the way you translated in 2:4a. See the General Comment on 2:4 for examples.

General Comment on 2:4

Translators use different tenses and moods for the two clauses in 2:4. You should translate 2:4a and 2:4b so that the tenses and moods fit with each other. For example:

^{4a}He brought me to his banquet hall ^{4b}and raised the banner of love over me. (GNT)

He brings me to the banquet room, and puts his flag of love over me.

How I wish he would bring me to his celebration place and raise his flag of love over me!

Song of Solomon 2:5

Section 1:2-2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2-2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2-4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5-6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3-6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7-8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3-4) to her.

The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

Lines 1:2–4 are the introduction to Section 1:2–2:7. In these lines, the poet summarizes the Song’s message and introduces its main characters: the woman, the man, and a group of young women. In the Song the woman spoke more often than the man spoke. After the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2–4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 2:1–7 The man and woman praised each other

Lines 2:1–7 are the end of the first poetic section in the Song. In them, the man and woman praised each other. He brought her to his banquet room and embraced her. In 2:7 she cautioned the women of Jerusalem not to awaken love before the right time.

2:5a

Sustain me with raisins;

- Strengthen me with raisins,
- Feed^(sing) me raisin cakes to support/revive me,

2:5b

refresh me with apples,

- revive me with apples,
- give^(sing) me apples to strengthen me,

2:5a–b

The clauses “sustain me with raisins” (2:5a) and “refresh me with apples” (2:5b) are parallel and have a similar meaning.

Sustain me...refresh me: The Hebrew verbs that the BSB translates as Sustain and refresh are plural. Such plural forms usually imply that the woman was speaking to more than one person. However, in this context the plural forms indicate that the woman spoke with strong emotion. She probably spoke only to her beloved.

Many languages do not use plural forms in this way. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that the woman spoke to her beloved with strong emotion. For example, some languages use an exclamation word or punctuation to show extra emphasis:

Oh, sustain me with raisins, and strengthen me with apples!

The emphasis might also be translated as urgency:

Quick! Sustain me...refresh me

Sustain...refresh: The Hebrew verbs that the BSB translates as Sustain and refresh have similar meanings. Both verbs are intense forms, which empha-

size the meaning. The verb Sustain probably means “strengthen, support,” and the verb refresh means “to renew strength.” Together the verbs emphasize that the woman needed to be strengthened in spirit to continue to receive the man’s love and to give her love to him. She was overwhelmed by the love that she felt for him and received from him.

For translation examples, see the General Comment on 2:5 at the end of the Notes on 2:5c.

with raisins...with apples: In that culture people thought of raisins and apples as special foods that strengthen people for love. In some languages people may not be familiar with raisins or apples. If that is true in your language, you may choose to use a general term. For example:

special foods to strengthen me for love

No English versions make explicit what raisins and apples symbolize. If this symbolism is not implied in your translation, you may want to include a footnote about it. For example:

These foods (raisins and apples) symbolize that romantic love is sweet/good.

raisins: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as raisins refers to the fruit of the grape vine. The English word raisins implies that the fruit has been dried, but scholars differ about whether the Hebrew word implies that. The word may refer here to cakes made from grapes.

People ate raisins for enjoyment, not mainly to satisfy hunger. Grapes and raisins were often used as a symbol that had romantic or sexual meaning. Here the author implied that eating the raisin cakes would encourage her romantically.

Some other ways to translate raisins here are:

raisin cakes

cake made from grapes

fruits from the grape vine

For more information about grapes, see the note on “vineyards of En-gedi” in 1:14b.

apples: The word apples refers to the fruit of the “apple tree” that was mentioned in 2:3. This fruit was also

used often as a symbol that had romantic or sexual meaning, just as raisins were. Like raisins, apples were eaten for enjoyment, not mainly to satisfy hunger. Here the woman implied that eating the apples would encourage her romantically. Some scholars think the fruit the BSB translates apples were actually apricots. They think it is uncertain whether apples as we know them were known in ancient Israel.

For more information about apples, see the note on “apple tree” in 2:3a.

General Comment on 2:5a–b

The two clauses in 2:5a–b are parallel. The woman requested two foods to encourage her in expressing love. In some languages it may be more natural to combine the requests in one clause. For example:

^{5a-b}Bring raisin cakes and apples to encourage me.

2:5c

for I am faint with love.

- because I feel faint/weak from love.
- for I am lovesick.
- because I am overwhelmed by love.

for: The Hebrew connector that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason why the woman wanted raisins and apples in 2:5a–b. It is because she was “faint with love.”

I am faint with love: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as faint can mean “ill” or “weak.” Here it means “weak.” When the woman said I am faint with love, she indicated that she was so overwhelmed by her feelings of love that she felt weak. She was not actually sick with an illness.

The phrase faint with love emphasizes her strong emotions. She did not want to avoid this “faintness.” She wanted to be strengthened and refreshed so that she could continue to receive and give love to the man.

Some other ways to translate 2:5c are:

for I am faint with love. (NRSV)

I feel sick from love, so...

because I am overwhelmed by love.

General Comment on 2:5

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of clauses in this verse. For example:

^{5c}I am faint with love, so encourage me with raisin cakes and apples.

This order puts the reason for the woman's request before the request itself.

Song of Solomon 2:6

Section 1:2–2:7: The woman and man admired each other

In Section 1:2–2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2–4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5–6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3–6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7–8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3–4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh's chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

Lines 1:2–4 are the introduction to Section 1:2–2:7. In these lines, the poet summarizes the Song's message and introduces its main characters: the woman, the man, and a group of young women. In the Song the woman spoke more often than the man spoke. After the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2–4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 2:1–7 The man and woman praised each other

Lines 2:1–7 are the end of the first poetic section in the Song. In them, the man and woman praised each other. He brought her to his banquet room and embraced her. In 2:7 she cautioned the women of Jerusalem not to awaken love before the right time.

2:6–7

These two verses are a refrain that is repeated in 8:3–4.

2:6a

His left hand is under my head,

- His left hand is under my head,
- The left arm of my love is a pillow for my head,

2:6b

and his right arm embraces me.

- and he uses his right arm to embrace me.
- and with his right arm he holds me close to him.

2:6a-b

His left hand is under my head, and his right arm embraces me: In Hebrew this verse is more literally, “his left hand under my head and his right hand embraces me.” The Hebrew clause in 2:6a does not have a verb. Scholars interpret this verse in different ways:

1. The woman described what the man was doing. He was embracing her. For example:

His left arm is under my head, and his right arm embraces me. (NIV) (BSB, ESV, GW, NAB, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB, GNT, NJPS)

1. The woman wished or requested that the man would embrace her. For example:

O that his left hand were under my head and his right hand embraced me! (NRSV)

Put your left hand under my head and embrace me with your right arm. (CEV) (CEV, NASB, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

His...his: In this verse the pronoun his refers to the man whom the woman loved. In some languages it may be more natural to make this explicit. For example:

my love

left hand...right arm: In Hebrew there is a word that means “left hand/arm” and a different word that means “right hand/arm.” Both words refer to either a person’s hand or his whole arm (from shoulder to fingertips).

Use an appropriate word to refer to the part of the hand or arm that would be used in this context. In some languages different words may be needed in 2:6a and 2:6b. For example:

^{6a}My lover’s left hand is under my head, ^{6b}and his right arm holds me tight. (NCV)

His left hand...under my head: This clause probably indicates that the man supported the woman’s head with his left arm as she lay in his arms. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

His left arm/hand is the place where I rest my head

His left arm pillows my head

his right arm embraces me: The word that the BSB translates as embraces can refer generally to any embrace or specifically to a sexual caress. Most English versions translate it in the general way. Use an appropriate expression in your language. Some other ways to translate it are:

his right arm is round me. (REB)

he holds me lovingly with his right arm.

Song of Solomon 2:7**Section 1:2-2:7: The woman and man admired each other**

In Section 1:2-2:7, the woman and man praised each other, and they became more confident that they loved each other. In the introduction (1:2-4) the woman spoke about her desire for the man. Then she spoke of her humble life working in the family vineyard (1:5-6), and she seemed to question whether she was worthy for him to love her. Then he praised her, and she praised him. When she spoke at the end of the section (2:3-6), she felt secure that he loved her.

In this section, the woman used several comparisons to speak of her feelings about the man. She spoke as though he were a shepherd (1:7-8) or a king (1:4; 1:12), implying that he was like a shepherd or king to her in certain ways. He was also like a bag of myrrh (1:13), henna blossoms (1:14), and an apple tree (2:3-4) to her. The woman compared herself to “a rose of Sharon,” and “a lily of the valleys” (2:1). The man compared her to “a mare of Pharaoh’s chariots” (1:9). The Notes will discuss the meaning of each of these comparisons as it occurs in its section.

Lines 1:2-4 are the introduction to Section 1:2-2:7. In these lines, the poet summarizes the Song’s message and introduces its main characters: the woman, the man, and a group of young women. In the Song the woman spoke more often than the man spoke. After the title (1:1), she began the Song by saying that she wanted him to kiss her. She referred to him only as “him” or “you.” In Hebrew poetry, the authors do not introduce their characters as they do in stories, but in some languages it may be more natural to introduce them and identify them. Some ways to do this are:

- Provide headings to identify the characters. Some headings may apply only to a verse or part of a verse. For example:

1:4e The Woman commented about the young women of Jerusalem You may need to use a different form the first time a character is introduced. For example:

1:2-4b A woman speaks to the man she loves

- Use a speech introducer in the first part of the verse. If you use this option, you may want to indicate in some way that the speech introducer is not in the text itself. For example:

1:4e (The woman said to her beloved,) “Rightly do they love you.”

1:2a [There were a certain woman and man. She said to/about him,] “Let him kiss me...”

Choose an option that fits your situation, and use it consistently throughout the book. You should also decide how you will refer to the speakers in the headings. Some ways to do that are:

woman, man, women (GNT)

beloved, lover, friends (NIV)

bride, groom, companions (REB)

she, he, others (ESV)

The woman often referred to the man as “my beloved” (RSV), and she also called him “the one whom my soul loves,” “the king,” and “my friend.” The man often referred to her as “my love” and also as “fairest among women,” “my dove,” “my sister,” “my bride,” and “queenly maiden.”

Paragraph 2:1-7 The man and woman praised each other

Lines 2:1-7 are the end of the first poetic section in the Song. In them, the man and woman praised each other. He brought her to his banquet room and embraced her. In 2:7 she cautioned the women of Jerusalem not to awaken love before the right time.

2:7

The speaker in this verse is probably the woman (as indicated by most English versions). Some English versions do not specify who is speaking. Most English versions that do specify speakers indicate that the

woman speaks here. These versions include BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, HCSB, NAB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT, and GNT.

2:7a-b

I adjure you by the gazelles and does of the field:

The verb adjure means “to urge (someone) to swear an oath.” The woman urged the women of Jerusalem to swear an oath to her. This oath was a serious promise. Breaking the oath would cause harmful results.

In the Hebrew culture, people usually swore oaths in God’s name. Such an oath implies that God will punish the person who does not do what he swore to do. The oath is a poetic way to say that the women must keep their promise. In this context, the woman asked the Jerusalem women to swear by gazelles and does. These animals probably symbolize love. Many scholars also comment on the fact that the Hebrew words for gazelles and does are similar to two of the names of God: El Shaddai (the All-Powerful) and YHWH Sabaoth (Lord of Hosts). Some other ways to translate the clause are:

swear to me by the gazelles or by the does in the field (GW)

promise me by the power of deer and gazelles (CEV)

Consider the ways that people make promises or swear oaths in your language. Use a natural way to translate the meaning of the woman’s request.

2:7a

O daughters of Jerusalem, I adjure you

- I charge you^(plur), women of Jerusalem,
- You^(plur) women of Jerusalem, promise me,
- Swear/Take an oath, you^(plur) Jerusalem women,

O daughters of Jerusalem, I adjure you: In this verse the woman spoke to the Jerusalem women. In some languages it is more natural to begin the sentence with the phrase O daughters of Jerusalem. For example:

O daughters of Jerusalem, I adjure you...

The phrase O daughters of Jerusalem was also used in 1:5b. You may translate it in the same way here.

2:7b

by the gazelles and does of the field:

- in the name of the wild gazelles or the deer.
- by the graceful gazelles and the wild does,
- by the beautiful animals that represent love.

the gazelles and does: gazelles and does are gentle animals that live wild in forests, mountains, or plains. They eat grass and other plants. They run fast, and they are graceful and beautiful. In the Song they symbolize grace and beauty, and they especially symbolize love.

gazelles: The “gazelle” is a member of the antelope family. There are two types of gazelles that were found in Palestine during the time that Song of Solomon was written: the dorcas gazelle and the gazella gazelle. It is a fairly small animal (2 or 3 feet tall at the shoulder). It is known for its grace and beauty.

does: A “doe” is a female deer or “hind.” Like a gazelle, a doe is also a small animal.

of the field: The phrase of the field indicates here that the animals were wild rather than domesticated. They did not have an owner. The word field refers here to uncultivated land. It does not refer to farm land.

2:7c–d

In 2:7c–d the woman told the women of Jerusalem what she wanted them to swear (promise).

Do not arouse or awaken love until the time is right: There are two ways to interpret what the woman said to the women of Jerusalem here:

1. It means that they should not arouse romantic love before the right time for it. For example:

not to awaken love until the time is right. (NLT)
(BSB, CEV, GW, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)

1. It means that they should not disturb the lovers in their lovemaking. For example:

that you will not interrupt our love. (GNT) (NASB, NJB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as most English versions and many commentators do. Some scholars who follow this interpretation include Assis, Bloch & Bloch, Carr, Estes, Exum, Garrett, Gledhill, Hess, Kinlaw, Longman, Murphy, and Pope. The woman gave general advice to the women of Jerusalem about the serious nature of love. A man and woman should not begin a romantic relationship too quickly. They should wait until the appropriate time. Neither of the verbs in 2:7c–d imply the meaning “interrupt,” as interpretation (2) requires.

For more examples of how to translate interpretation (1), see the General Comment on 2:7c–d at the end of the notes on 2:7d.

2:7c

Do not arouse or awaken love

- Do^(plur) not arouse love
- that you^(plur) will not stimulate feelings of erotic love
- Swear/Promise that you^(plur) will not excite someone to love you

Do not arouse Even though the verbs stir up (2:7c) and awaken (2:7d) are masculine, it is clear in the context that the sentence is addressed to the women of Jerusalem. Hebrew sometimes allows this extended use of the masculine form. **or awaken love:** Here the word love refers to the way people feel and act when they love someone in a romantic way. To arouse... love and awaken love means to cause or encourage feelings of romantic love. The phrases are used in a figurative way and have almost the same meaning. They imply that romantic love causes intense excitement and desire.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

Do not arouse love and excite it

that you will not stimulate feelings of love and intensify them

In many languages it is more natural to translate love as an action and to indicate who loves and who receives the love. Here the woman made a general statement about romantic love to a group of women. There are two ways to interpret the statement:

1. A woman should not arouse romantic feelings in herself before the proper time. For example:

Do not cause yourselves to love someone

1. A woman should not arouse romantic feelings in another person before the proper time. For example:

Do not arouse someone to love you

English versions are ambiguous. If you choose between these interpretations, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Use a natural way in your language to refer to the action of arousing romantic love before the right time.

arouse or awaken: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as arouse and awaken are different forms of the same verb. The verbs arouse (2:7c) and awaken (2:7d) are based on the same Hebrew root. In this context they have the same meaning. The forms are used together to add emphasis. In some languages it may be more natural to use only one verb. For example:

excite

arouse

love: Here the noun love is a figure of speech. It is spoken of as though it were a person. In some languages it is more natural to translate the meaning without this figure of speech. For example:

excite yourself to love

In some languages there are other figures of speech that express this meaning. For example:

Do not fan love into flame

Do not feed your sexual love/desire

Translate the meaning in a natural way in your language.

2:7d

until the time is right.

- until that love can be satisfied.
- before/until it is right to satisfy those feelings.
- before it pleases.

until the time is right: The clause until the time is right is literally “until love desires/decides.” It implies that there is an appropriate time to arouse romantic love. The author continues to use “love” as a figure of speech, as in 2:7c. He speaks of it as though it is a person who can decide when the time is right for romantic love.

Other ways to translate the figure of speech here are:

- Use the figure of speech. For example:

before it is ready. (CEV)

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

when it is not yet the right/proper time.

Translate the meaning in a natural way in your language.

General Comment on 2:7c–d

Some other ways to translate 2:7c–d are:

Do not arouse your feelings of sexual love until the proper time.

Be careful that intimate love for someone does not overwhelm you before you are ready.

Song of Solomon 2:8

Section 2:8–3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1–2:7). At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8–3:5. In the first poem (2:8–17) the man came and stood outside the woman’s room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring day. The second poem (3:1–5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2–6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8–17 and 3:1–5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

Paragraph 2:8–17

This beautiful poem (2:8–17) describes springtime. In springtime, new plants begin to grow, flowers bloom, and fruit trees begin to blossom. In these lines springtime symbolizes that love was growing between the woman and the man. The woman first spoke to herself, but then she quoted the man as he invited her to come out of her house and go away with him.

This poem begins and ends in a similar way. At the beginning (2:8–9) the man came to the woman over the mountains like a gazelle or stag. At the end (2:17) he again roamed on the mountains like a gazelle or stag.

In these lines the woman spoke. However, from 2:10b through 2:14 she quoted what the man said. Then she continued speaking in 2:15–17.

2:8a–10a

Here the woman began the section by saying that she heard the voice or sound of her beloved (2:8a). In 2:8b–2:9e she described how he came to her family’s home where she lived. Then in 2:10a she introduced what he said to her.

2:8a**Listen! My beloved approaches.**

- I hear the voice of my beloved!
- Listen! I hear my beloved!

Listen! My beloved approaches: The Hebrew word *qol* that the BSB translates as Listen has different meanings in different contexts. Here it may refer specifically to the beloved’s voice or more generally to the sound of his coming. Some ways to translate it are:

- Refer to the voice of the beloved. For example:

I hear my beloved’s voice. (GW)

- Refer more generally to the sound of his coming. For example:

Ah, I hear my lover coming! (NLT)

Listen! My beloved is coming!

The author uses the same Hebrew word in this way in 2:14 when the man wants to hear his beloved’s voice. Use a natural way in your language to communicate excitement in this context.

My beloved: Suggestions for translating My beloved are given in the notes on 1:13a–b.

2:8b–9e

There is parallelism in 2:8b–9e. In the following example, the similar phrases are indicated in similar ways:

^{8a}Listen! My beloved approaches.

^{8b}Look! Here he comes,

^{8c}**leaping across the mountains,**

^{8d}**bounding over the hills.**

^{9a}**My beloved is like a gazelle,**

^{9b}**or a young stag.**

^{9c}Look, he stands behind our wall:

^{9d}**gazing through the windows,**

^{9e}**peering through the lattice.**

The phrase “Look! Here he comes” (2:8b) is parallel to “Look, he stands behind our wall” (2:9c). After 2:8b, there are two more parallel phrases “leaping across the mountains” (2:8c) and “bounding over the hills” (2:8d). These phrases have almost the same meaning. Line 2:9c is followed by two more parallel lines “gazing through the windows” and “peering through the lattice” (2:9d–e).

In some languages it is more natural to combine the parallel lines that follow each other. See the General Comment on 2:9d–e following the notes for 2:9e for an example.

comes...leaping...bounding...stands...gazing...

peering: The Hebrew verb forms that the BSB translates as comes, leaping, bounding, stands, gazing, and peering do not indicate when these actions happened. They are participles, which may indicate continuing action in the past, present, or future. The verb forms help people imagine the actions happening as they read about them. That makes the action seem more vivid and exciting. Use a natural way in your language to do that.

2:8b**Look! Here he comes,**

- Here he comes!
- Behold! I see him coming.

Look! Here he comes: The phrase Look! Here he comes is an exclamation. It indicates that the woman was excited and happy that her beloved was approaching her. It implies that she wanted others to share her excitement that he was coming.

Some ways to translate this exclamation are:

Behold, he comes... (RSV)

Here he comes... (NCV)

He’s coming!

Many languages have special ways to express excitement like this. Sometimes there is a special exclamation or form of the verb. For example:

Oh listen! I hear him coming!

Indicate the woman's excitement or surprise in a natural way in your language.

Look!: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Look calls attention to the statement, word, or phrase that follows it. In this context, it also communicates excitement. Consider how you call attention to a word or phrase in your language. You may be able to use an exclamation word like "Behold!" or "Listen!" or you may be able to communicate the excitement by making the sentence itself more emphatic or exciting.

Look occurs four times in the Song. Three of these are in this section (2:8, 9, 11). In each context translate its function in a natural way in your language.

2:8c-9e

In these lines there is a complex simile that continues for several lines. It describes a gazelle or stag, and it also describes the man whom the woman loves. The author used verbs that can refer to both the man and to an animal, but the actions are more like an animal's actions. It is easy to imagine a lively animal running to the window to gaze into it. The woman implied that her beloved did that. The tone of the simile can be described as "playful."

Other places in the OT that mention the leaping and swift running of gazelles or stags are 2 Samuel 2:18, 1 Chronicles 12:8, Psalm 18:33, and Isaiah 35:6. Keil-Delitzsch Commentary on the Old Testament, Volume 6, page 48.

2:8c

leaping across the mountains,

- He is leaping on the mountains,
- He jumps/bounds over the rugged hills

2:8d

bounding over the hills.

- he is jumping over the hills.
- and soars across the highlands.

2:8c-d

leaping across the mountains, bounding over the hills: The two phrases leaping across the mountains and bounding over the hills have similar meanings. leaping and bounding describe the way the man hurried toward the woman. It emphasizes that he was eager to see her. It also implies her excitement as she saw him jump across the hills and rush toward her. Translate this excited description in a natural and poetic way in your language. For example:

running over the mountains,

racing across the hills to me. (GNT)

The two parallel lines have the same meaning. In some languages it may be more natural to combine them. For example:

Oh, look! He's coming toward me, bounding over the mountains!

He runs and leaps on the mountains and hills!

Song of Solomon 2:9

Section 2:8-3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1-2:7). At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8-3:5. In the first poem (2:8-17) the man came and stood outside the woman's room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring day. The second poem (3:1-5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2-6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8-17 and 3:1-5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

Paragraph 2:8-17

This beautiful poem (2:8-17) describes springtime. In springtime, new plants begin to grow, flowers bloom, and fruit trees begin to blossom. In these lines springtime symbolizes that love was growing between the woman and the man. The woman first spoke to herself, but then she quoted the man as he invited her to come out of her house and go away with him.

This poem begins and ends in a similar way. At the beginning (2:8-9) the man came to the woman over the mountains like a gazelle or stag. At the end (2:17) he again roamed on the mountains like a gazelle or stag.

In these lines the woman spoke. However, from 2:10b through 2:14 she quoted what the man said. Then she continued speaking in 2:15-17.

2:9a

My beloved is like a gazelle

- My true love is a gazelle,
- My love reminds me of a beautiful deer,

2:9b**or a young stag.**

- he is a young stag.
- a strong, young deer.

2:9a–b

In this clause the woman continued the comparison that she began in 2:8c. In 2:9 she mentioned two animals that her beloved was like. In some languages it may be helpful to mention the animals earlier in 2:8. See the General Comment on 2:8–9 after the notes on 2:9c for an example.

My beloved is like a gazelle or a young stag: Here the author used a simile to compare the man to a gazelle and a young stag. The man moved fast and gracefully like a gazelle and a stag move. In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit how the man was like a gazelle or stag. For example:

My beloved is as fast/strong and graceful as a gazelle, as a young stag.

In other languages it may be more natural to use a metaphor. For example:

My love is a gazelle, a wild stag. Bloch and Bloch, page 59.

a gazelle or a young stag: The words gazelle and stag refer to two animals that belong to the antelope family. A stag is a male deer. The female deer, called a “doe,” was mentioned in 2:7. Gazelles and stags are fast, graceful, and beautiful. If two similar animals like these are unknown in your area, you can compare the man to one animal with these characteristics. For example:

My beloved is like a young deer.

In some cultures there are no animals like the gazelle and stag. If that is true in your language, some ways to translate the words are:

- Use a general word that refers to a graceful animal that runs and jumps on rocky hillsides. For example:

like a fast-moving, beautiful animal

like an animal that is swift and beautiful

- Use a loan word from the national language with a descriptive word. For example:

a graceful gazelle

- Substitute an animal with similar characteristics that is known in your area. It should also fit the joyful tone that the woman used to describe the man. Some dangerous animals (like lions) are fast and graceful, but they would not fit this context. Similar advice is given in *A Handbook on the Song of Songs*, Ogden and Zogbo, page 69.

Gazelles were also mentioned in 2:7b, but their specific characteristics were not in focus.

or a young stag: There is an ellipsis in the phrase or a young stag. The full form is:

or he is like a young stag.

The word *or* introduces an animal that is similar to the gazelle in 2:8. The woman implied that her beloved was like both a deer and a young stag. Comparing him to both of these animals emphasizes the comparison. Other ways to connect 2:9a and 2:9b are:

like a gazelle, like a young stag (GNT)

like a deer, a beautiful deer

2:9c**Look, he stands behind our wall,**

- Look! He is standing there on the other side of my wall.
- There he stands outside our^(excl) family home!

Look, he stands behind our wall: In this clause the woman was excited and joyful that her beloved was there, standing near the wall of her house. She emphasized this excitement by using the word *Look*. Some other ways to translate her excitement are:

Behold, there he stands behind our wall. (RSV)

There he is standing behind our wall!

The phrase *Look, he stands* is similar to “Look! Here he comes” in 2:8b. It is good to translate these two phrases in a similar way. That emphasizes the contrast between the man’s leaping on the hills as he comes to

the woman (2:8b–d) and his quiet waiting as he stands by her window (2:9d–e).

he stands behind our wall: Here the woman continued to compare the man to a gazelle or stag. She thought of him and the gazelle/stag at the same time.

In some languages it may be difficult to refer to both a man and a deer in the same way (as English does with the pronoun *he*). If you must choose to refer either to the man or the deer, it is better to refer to the man. It is he who stood outside and invited the woman to come with him. For example:

There my beloved stands behind our wall

behind our wall: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *wall* occurs only here in the Old Testament. It probably refers to a wall of the house rather than to a courtyard wall. The phrase *behind our wall* indicates that the man was outside the house near one of its walls. The woman was inside the house. In 2:9d–e the man spoke to her from outside the wall of the house near her window. The house was probably her family’s home.

Some other ways to translate *behind our wall* are:

outside the wall of our^(excl) house

beside the house wall

The wall probably refers to a wall in her family’s home. Be careful not to imply that the house belonged to the man and woman. In some languages it may be necessary to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

the wall of my family home

General Comment on 2:8–9

In 2:8–9 the woman compared her beloved to a gazelle or young stag. However, she did not mention those animals until verse 9. In some languages it is clearer to introduce the animals in verse 8. One way to do this is to combine 2:8–9 and move 2:9a–b before 2:8c–d. For example:

^{8a}Listen! My beloved approaches. ^{9a}My beloved is like a gazelle ^{9b}or a young stag. ^{8b}Look! Here he comes

^{8c}leaping upon the mountains,

^{8d}bounding over the hills.

2:9d–e

There is parallelism in 2:9d and 2:9e:

^{9d} gazing **through the windows,**

^{9e} peering **through the lattice.**

The lines have similar meanings. The parallel parts are marked in similar ways. In some languages it may be more natural to express the meaning only once. For example:

^{9d–e}looking in through the window

windows...lattice: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as *windows* and *lattice* (2:9e) are both plural in Hebrew. There are at least two ways to interpret these plural forms:

1. It is a special use of the plural form in Hebrew, and it should be translated as singular. This use of the plural is called “the plural of generalization.” For example:

He looks in at the window, (NJB)

he peers through the opening. (GNT, CEV, GW, NJB, NET, NLT)

1. It indicates that the man was moving around the house looking into different windows and lattices. He was trying to see the woman. For example:

peeking through the windows, (NCV)

looking through the blinds. (BSB, NCV, RSV, ESV, NIV, NASB, REB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The text says that the man was standing there. It does not indicate that he was moving from one window to another. However, both (1) and (2) have support from versions and commentaries, and either is acceptable.

Since the BSB follows interpretation (2), the Notes will use the NET as the source line for 2:9d.

2:9d

gazing through the windows,

- He peers into the window

- He stares through the window

(NET) gazing through the window: The phrase gazing through the window indicates that the man was looking through the window into the house. The author had just compared the man to a gazelle or stag, so readers can imagine either the man or a curious gazelle or stag standing beside the window.

The man looked into the window to attract the woman's attention. He wanted to invite her to come outside and be with him. There was nothing improper in his actions.

(NET) gazing: The Hebrew word that the NET translates as gazing means "staring at" or "looking at intently." The man stood outside the house and looked through the window into the inside of the house. See Bloch & Bloch, page 154, "When windows, doors, holes, gaps, etc. are involved, *min* acquires a secondary sense of 'through.' " He hoped to see the woman there.

2:9e peering through the lattice.

- and looks through the openings in the window covering.
- to see into the house.

peering through the lattice: This phrase has almost the same meaning as 2:9d. For a suggestion on combining these parts of the verse, see the General Comment on 2:9d-e at the end of the notes for 2:9e.

peering: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as peering occurs only here in the Old Testament. It means "to gaze" or "to peer." It has almost the same meaning as "gazing" in 2:9d. The Hebrew verb form implies that the man was peering through the window as the woman spoke.

lattice: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as lattice occurs only here in the OT. A lattice is a small framed opening in the wall. It has almost the same meaning as windows in 2:9d. Sometimes, a lattice had small wooden bars across it to make it stronger.

General Comment on 2:9d-e

The lines in 2:9d-e have similar meanings. In some languages it may be more natural to combine the two parallel lines into one line. For example, the CEV says:

Now he stands outside our wall, (2:9c)

looking in through the window (2:9d-e)

Song of Solomon 2:10

Section 2:8-3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1-2:7). At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8-3:5. In the first poem (2:8-17) the man came and stood outside the woman's room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring day. The second poem (3:1-5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2-6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8-17 and 3:1-5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

Paragraph 2:8-17

This beautiful poem (2:8-17) describes springtime. In springtime, new plants begin to grow, flowers bloom, and fruit trees begin to blossom. In these lines springtime symbolizes that love was growing between the woman and the man. The woman first spoke to herself, but then she quoted the man as he invited her to come out of her house and go away with him.

This poem begins and ends in a similar way. At the beginning (2:8-9) the man came to the woman over the mountains like a gazelle or stag. At the end (2:17) he again roamed on the mountains like a gazelle or stag.

In these lines the woman spoke. However, from 2:10b through 2:14 she quoted what the man said. Then she continued speaking in 2:15-17.

2:10-13

The poem in 2:10-13 begins and ends with the man repeating an invitation to the woman. This identical beginning and ending indicates this section as a poem within the larger poem of the Song. It is one of the most beautiful poems in the Old Testament about the beauty of nature. Look for special ways to translate this portion in a beautiful way in your language.

2:10a

My beloved calls to me,

- He is my true love! He says to me:
- Then my love speaks, he calls to me, saying,

My beloved calls to me: In this verse the woman began to tell what her beloved said to her. In the Hebrew, two speech verbs, speaks and says, are used to introduce his words. It is common in Hebrew to use two verbs to introduce quoted speech. In some languages it may be more natural to use only one verb, as in the BSB.

This quote of what the man said extends from 2:10b–14f. Some ways to indicate the quote are:

- Begin the quote with a quote formula. For example:

My lover spoke to me, saying (NET)

My beloved says to me

My love calls to me Holman Christian Standard Bible.

- End the quote in 2:14 with a quote formula. For example:

....” That is what my beloved said.

- Indicate the change of speaker with a heading. For example:

The man speaks to the woman Then in 2:15, indicate that the woman spoke again.

2:10b

“Arise, my darling. Come away with me, my beautiful one.

- Get^(sing) up, my love, my beautiful one, and come away with me.
- My darling, you^(sing) are so beautiful. Come let’s go!

Arise, my darling. Come away with me, my beautiful one: Here the man used the phrases my darling and my beautiful one as names for the woman, as he invited her to come with him. The names showed that he loved her and thought that she was beautiful. The BSB puts these names in a different place in the sentence. In some languages it is more natural to put these names in the center. In Hebrew the words are arranged as a chiasm: a Arise b my love b’ my fair one a’ and come away. The RSV keeps this chiastic arrangement of the words. For example:

Arise, my love, my fair one, and come away (RSV)

Arise...Come away with me: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Arise. The word “arise” is a literal translation of the Hebrew word *qum*. This verb is often used with another action verb to indicate the beginning of an action (Ogden and Zogbo, 1998, page 71). It often adds emphasis to the next action. It implies that the action is important and should be started quickly. The man wanted the woman to leave whatever she was doing and come with him. The verb Arise probably does not imply here that the woman was sitting or lying down.

In some languages it is more natural to use a different way to add emphasis to the action Come away. For example:

Come then...come with me. (GNT)

Hurry...and come away with me!

Come away with me, my beautiful darling—please, let’s hurry!

Use a natural way in your language to persuade someone.

my darling: The phrase my darling also occurred in 1:9a–b. See the note there for advice on how to translate it.

Come away with me: The man used the phrase Come away with me to invite the woman to come out with him. She was probably inside her house, and he called her to come out to enjoy the beginning of springtime with him.

Some other ways to translate the phrase Come away with me are:

and come with me. (GW)

come out and go with me!

my beautiful one: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as beautiful means “fair.” For example:

my fair one (RSV)

Song of Solomon 2:11

Section 2:8–3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1–2:7).

At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8–3:5. In the first poem (2:8–17) the man came and stood outside the woman's room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring day. The second poem (3:1–5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2–6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8–17 and 3:1–5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

Paragraph 2:8–17

This beautiful poem (2:8–17) describes springtime. In springtime, new plants begin to grow, flowers bloom, and fruit trees begin to blossom. In these lines springtime symbolizes that love was growing between the woman and the man. The woman first spoke to herself, but then she quoted the man as he invited her to come out of her house and go away with him.

This poem begins and ends in a similar way. At the beginning (2:8–9) the man came to the woman over the mountains like a gazelle or stag. At the end (2:17) he again roamed on the mountains like a gazelle or stag.

In these lines the woman spoke. However, from 2:10b through 2:14 she quoted what the man said. Then she continued speaking in 2:15–17.

2:11–13

In these verses the man spoke about the beautiful season of springtime after the cold time ended. The plants were growing again and were fruitful. He implied to the woman that it was also the season for their love to grow. It was the “time of singing,” and he wanted her to come with him.

Notice that 2:13d is exactly the same as 2:10b, making 2:10–13 a chiasm that emphasizes the man's invitation. Translate 2:10b and 2:13d in the same way in your language.

2:11

The two parts of this verse are parallel to each other. In some languages it may be more natural to combine 2:11a and 2:11b. See the General Comment on 2:11 at the end of the notes for 2:11b for an example.

2:11a

For now the winter is past;

- Look^(sing), the winter is past!
- The cold season/time is over

For now the winter is past: In this verse the man began to talk about the weather to persuade the woman to come out with him. He implied that in winter she might not want to come out. The winter is the cold time, when many plants die or stop blooming. Animals try to find a covered place to hide from the cold weather. That cold time was over.

Some other ways to translate For now the winter is past are:

for the cold season/time is already over

Look, the cold/bad weather is gone!

For now: The phrase For now introduces the man's statements in 2:11–13c in an emphatic way. The word that the BSB translates as now indicates that what comes after it is especially important or interesting. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

for lo (RSV)

For see (NJB)

In some languages it is not necessary to have a word like For because it is already clear that in 2:11–13 the man gave reasons why the woman should come away with him. Here is another way to translate this:

Look! The winter is past. (GW)

In other languages it may also not be natural to use extra emphasis. Here is another way to translate this:

Winter is past (CEV)

Translate the invitation in a way that is natural and poetic in your language.

winter: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as winter is used only here in the OT. In Palestine, winter is a cold and rainy season of the year, which extends from October to March. Some other ways to translate winter are:

wintertime

rainy season

2:11b**the rain is over and gone.**

- The rains have ended!
- and no more rains will beat/disturb us^(incl).

the rain is over and gone: The clause the rain is over and gone has a similar meaning to “the winter is past” in 2:11a. In Palestine the heavy rains occurred in winter. The man implied that if the woman comes out with him now, she will enjoy nice weather. The author was probably thinking of April or May, early springtime months in the northern hemisphere. Another way to translate the clause is:

the rains have stopped (GNT)

the winter rains are over and gone (NET)

Translate the clause in a way that will appeal to a woman in your culture.

is over and gone: In Hebrew the phrase is over and gone is more literally “it has passed away, it has gone.” Using two verbs adds emphasis to the change of season. The man implied that there was no rain now, so it was fine weather for the woman to join him outside.

In some languages it may be more natural to add emphasis in a different way. For example:

the rains are completely gone.

the rainy time has ended.

General Comment on 2:11

The two clauses in this verse have almost the same meaning. In some languages it may be more natural to combine the clauses. For example:

The cold rainy season has definitely ended.

Song of Solomon 2:12**Section 2:8–3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him**

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1–2:7). At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8–3:5. In the first poem (2:8–17) the man came and stood outside the woman’s room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring day. The second poem (3:1–5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2–6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8–17 and 3:1–5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

Paragraph 2:8–17

This beautiful poem (2:8–17) describes springtime. In springtime, new plants begin to grow, flowers bloom, and fruit trees begin to blossom. In these lines springtime symbolizes that love was growing between the woman and the man. The woman first spoke to herself, but then she quoted the man as he invited her to come out of her house and go away with him.

This poem begins and ends in a similar way. At the beginning (2:8–9) the man came to the woman over the mountains like a gazelle or stag. At the end (2:17) he again roamed on the mountains like a gazelle or stag.

In these lines the woman spoke. However, from 2:10b through 2:14 she quoted what the man said. Then she continued speaking in 2:15–17.

2:12a–13c

In verses 12a–13c the man described how beautiful the countryside is in the springtime. He wanted the woman to imagine the sights (2:12a, 13a–b), sounds (2:12b–c), and smells (2:13c) of spring. He implied that it is a wonderful time for the woman to come and enjoy spring with him.

2:12a**The flowers have appeared in the countryside;**

- Flowers are blossoming on the earth.
- Beautiful flowers cover the land,

The flowers have appeared in the countryside: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as have appeared is more literally “have been seen.” It indicates that people can see flowers sprouting and blooming in the springtime. Wildflowers are common in Palestine during that time.

Some other ways to translate The flowers have appeared in the countryside are:

Flowers/Blooms are covering the earth.

Flowers bloom throughout the land.

In some languages there may be an idiom to describe this season when many flowers start to bloom. For example:

wildflowers spring up in the fields. Ariel and Chana Bloch, *The Song of Songs*, page 59.

flowers: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as flowers can refer to any blossom. It includes blooms on flowering trees, bushes, and vines.

2:12b–c

In some languages it may be more natural to combine 2:12b and 2:12c. See the General Comment on 2:12b–c at the end of 2:12c for an example.

2:12b

the season of singing has come,

- It is the time to sing!
- birds are singing their songs,

the season of singing has come: There are three ways to interpret the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as singing here:

1. It means “singing.” For example:

the season of singing has come (NIV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB, RSV, GNT)

1. It means “pruning” (of grapevines). Some ancient versions (Greek and Latin) follow this interpretation. For example:

the time has arrived for pruning the vines (NASB) (NAB, NASB, NJPS)

1. It means both singing and pruning. This demonstrates special artistic skill on the part of the poet. Several scholars follow this view. For example:

the time for pruning and singing has come (NET) (NET)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This has the best support from English versions. It also seems to fit the context best. It parallels 2:12c “the cooing of turtledoves is heard in our land.” There are also several other reasons for following this option. (a) There is some doubt whether pruning was done at this time of the year. (b) To go outside to hear the singing seems like a reason that is more likely to appeal to

the woman than to go outside because it was the time of pruning. (c) The poet does not introduce grapevines until 2:13b. (d) The flowers referred to in 2:12a are probably wildflowers rather than blossoms in the vineyard, so they have nothing to do with pruning in 2:12b.

singing: Here singing probably refers to the singing of birds, since the following line refers to the voice of the “turtledove” (a kind of bird). However, the context may also imply that spring is a joyful time and therefore a time for human singing.

Some other ways to translate “the season of singing has come” are:

This is the time for singing (GNT)

The time has come to sing

2:12c

and the cooing of turtledoves is heard in our land.

- The voice of the turtledove is heard across the countryside.
- and doves make their pleasant sounds in the fields.

and the cooing of turtledoves is heard in our land:

This clause is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to translate it using an active clause. For example:

You can hear turtledoves cooing in our land.

People hear the song of the turtledove throughout our land.

turtledoves: The “turtledove” is a small songbird of the pigeon family. During the cold winters of Palestine, it migrates to a warmer climate. But each springtime it returns in the month of April. People thought of the sound of the turtledoves as a sign that springtime had come.

If people in your area are not familiar with the “turtledove,” some other ways to translate it here are:

General Comment on 2:12b–c

- Substitute a bird in your area that fits this context. It should be a bird that sings when the time of nice weather arrives. It should be a bird that people like, not one that disturbs them.
- Use a more general term. For example:

songbird (GW)

singing birds

In some languages it is helpful to combine 2:12b and 2:12c. For example:

^{12b-c}Birds sing sweetly in the fields.

Song of Solomon 2:13

Section 2:8–3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1–2:7). At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8–3:5. In the first poem (2:8–17) the man came and stood outside the woman's room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring day. The second poem (3:1–5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2–6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8–17 and 3:1–5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

Paragraph 2:8–17

This beautiful poem (2:8–17) describes springtime. In springtime, new plants begin to grow, flowers bloom, and fruit trees begin to blossom. In these lines springtime symbolizes that love was growing between the woman and the man. The woman first spoke to herself, but then she quoted the man as he invited her to come out of her house and go away with him.

This poem begins and ends in a similar way. At the beginning (2:8–9) the man came to the woman over the mountains like a gazelle or stag. At the end (2:17) he again roamed on the mountains like a gazelle or stag.

In these lines the woman spoke. However, from 2:10b through 2:14 she quoted what the man said. Then she continued speaking in 2:15–17.

2:13a

The fig tree ripens its figs;

- The fig trees form their first figs,
- Figs ripen on the fig trees,
- The fruit trees are producing their fruit,

The fig tree ripens its figs: When the fig tree begins to produce figs, it is another sign that springtime has begun.

The fig tree is one of the most important fruit trees in Palestine. Here the term fig tree refers to fig trees in general. In some languages it is more natural to use a plural form. For example:

The fig trees are producing figs...

In many parts of the world fig trees do not grow or they are unknown. If that is true in your language, you may need to use a general expression that refers to fruit trees. For example:

The fruit trees are ripening their fruit...

ripens: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as ripens is rare in the OT. The only other references occur in Genesis 50:2, 26, and refer to embalming a dead body. Here it probably refers to the process that causes the figs on a fig tree to become ripe and sweet. Another interpretation is that it refers to the fig trees producing buds (e.g., “The fig tree has budded” (NET) or to the formation of the young figs (e.g., The fig tree forms its early fruit (NIV)). It may also refer to the forming of the first figs. Languages have different ways to describe this process. For example:

Figs are beginning to ripen (GNT)

The fig tree puts forth its figs (RSV)

Fig trees form their new figs

Describe this process in a natural way in your language.

figs: figs are small edible fruits that taste sweet when they ripen. While a fig is growing, it is green, and when it becomes ripe, it becomes dark (purple). The Hebrew word occurs only here in the OT. It refers here to a fig that is not yet ripe.

2:13b

the blossoming vines spread their fragrance.

- and the blossoms on the grapevines smell sweet.
- and grapevines have fragrant blooms.

the blossoming vines spread their fragrance: This part of the verse describes grapevines when they bloom. The small blooms of the vines smell sweet, and

the blooms are another sign of springtime. Some other ways to translate 2:13b are:

and the blossoms on the vines smell sweet (NCV)

The grapevines are producing fragrant flowers.

and the grapevines have blooms that smell good/
delicious

blossoming: The word blossoming indicates that the grapevines have produced small blooms (flowers).

vines: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as vines refers specifically to grapevines. They produce edible fruit called “grapes,” from which people also make wine.

spread their fragrance: The phrase spread their fragrance refers to the sweet (pleasing) odor of the blossoming vines in 2:13b. It probably does not refer to the odor of the fig trees in 2:13a. In some languages it is helpful to make the subject more explicit:

and their flowers smell sweet.

2:13c

Arise, come away, my darling; come away with me, my beautiful one.”

- Get^(sing) up, my beautiful one. Come away with me, my beloved.
- My darling, you^(sing) are so beautiful. Come away with me.

Arise, come away, my darling; come away with me, my beautiful one: In Hebrew this clause is almost identical to 2:10b, and it has the same meaning. The slight difference in the Hebrew text is reflected in the NIV where 2:13d reads: “Arise, come, my darling; my beautiful one, come with me.” (Also see the NET.) The first occurrence of “come” is not translated in most versions. It is best understood as an archaic form of a second feminine singular pronominal suffix rather than the verb “come.” These identical clauses show that 2:10b–13c is a poetic unit. It is best to translate the two clauses in the same way.

For a discussion of the meaning of the words and phrases used in 2:10b and also here in 2:13c, see the notes for 2:10b.

Song of Solomon 2:14

Section 2:8–3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1–2:7). At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8–3:5. In the first poem (2:8–17) the man came and stood outside the woman’s room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring day. The second poem (3:1–5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2–6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8–17 and 3:1–5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

Paragraph 2:8–17

This beautiful poem (2:8–17) describes springtime. In springtime, new plants begin to grow, flowers bloom, and fruit trees begin to blossom. In these lines springtime symbolizes that love was growing between the woman and the man. The woman first spoke to herself, but then she quoted the man as he invited her to come out of her house and go away with him.

This poem begins and ends in a similar way. At the beginning (2:8–9) the man came to the woman over the mountains like a gazelle or stag. At the end (2:17) he again roamed on the mountains like a gazelle or stag.

In these lines the woman spoke. However, from 2:10b through 2:14 she quoted what the man said. Then she continued speaking in 2:15–17.

2:14

This verse (2:14) indicates the man’s desire to be with the woman, just as 2:10b–13 did. In 2:10b–13 he invited her to come outside. She lived behind walls in her family home, so it was hard for him to reach her. In 2:14 he compared her to a dove. A dove is timid, so it hides in the cliffs. The woman did not actually hide in the cliffs, but she was hidden from the man in her house.

Remember that in 2:10b–14 the woman quotes what the man said to her. In both 2:10b–13 and 2:14 he invited her to leave her home and come to him. In 2:10b–13, he invited her to come out to enjoy springtime with him. In 2:14 he invited her to come out so

that he could enjoy her. So 2:10b–13 and 2:14 have a similar meaning.

2:14a

O my dove in the clefts of the rock,

- My dove, you^(sing) hide in crevices/holes in the rocks
- You^(sing) the one I love, are like a dove hiding
- Please do^(sing) not hide like a shy bird in a small hole

2:14a–b

O my dove: Here the man used the phrase my dove as an affectionate nickname for the woman. It implies that she was like a shy dove. It also implies that he used a gentle tone of persuasion to invite her to come to him. He did not try to force her to come. The BSB added the word O to show that he spoke directly to the woman. It is not in the Hebrew text.

In some languages it may be confusing or unnatural to use my dove as a nickname. If that is true in your language, you may need to use a sentence to compare the woman to a dove. For example:

You are like a dove (GNT)

you are my own gentle dove

dove: The Hebrew word used for dove in this verse is different from the Hebrew word for turtledove in 2:12, but the two birds are similar. The term dove probably refers here to the common rock pigeon, which is a bit larger than a turtledove.

Two characteristics of a dove are relevant to this verse:

1. The dove is a shy, timid bird.
2. It is also beautiful and gentle. It is used as a symbol for love.

In this verse the first characteristic, shyness, is probably in focus, but its love symbolism is probably also implied here.

in the clefts of the rock: The phrase clefts of the rock refers to cracks in a steep, rocky cliff. The doves use these cracks for hiding places. The rocky cliffs are hard for most animals to climb, so the spaces between the rocks are safe places for the doves to make their nests.

Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

hiding places of the rocky crevices (GW)

hides in holes in the cliffs (REB)

Use a natural way to refer to such places in your language.

2:14b

in the crevices of the cliff,

- or in a remote place on a cliff/mountain.
- in holes/cracks on a rocky/big hill where I cannot reach you^(sing).
- on a big cliff.

in the crevices of the cliff: The phrase in the crevices of the cliff refers to a hiding place in the side of a steep place. It has almost the same meaning as the phrase in 2:14a.

In some languages it may be more natural to combine the phrases in 2:14a and 2:14b or to translate the meaning only once. For example:

You, my love, are a dove hiding in crevices high on a cliffside.

cliff: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as cliff only occurs twice in the Old Testament. It is difficult to know exactly what it refers to, and English versions translate it in different ways. It is probably a small ledge or hole hidden high on a rocky cliffside that is hard to climb or reach.

2:14c–f

There is a chiasm in the Hebrew text of 2:14c–f. Notice the similar words and phrases:

a let me see your face

b let me hear your voice

b' for your voice is sweet

a' and your countenance is lovely

In some languages it is more natural to translate the phrases without the chiasm. For example:

Let me see your lovely face (GNT)

and hear your enchanting voice.

2:14c

let me see your face,

- Let me see you^(sing)
- Come out so I can look at you,

let me see your face: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as face means “form” or “appearance.” It is different from the Hebrew word that is usually translated as face. There are two ways to interpret the word here:

1. It means “form” or “appearance.” It refers here to the woman’s whole appearance or to the woman herself. For example:

let me see your form... (NASB)

Let me see you... (NLT96) (CEV, GW, KJV, NAB, NLT96)

1. It means “face.” For example:

show me your face... (NIV) (BSB, ESV, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB, RSV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The man wants to see the woman herself, not just her face. Even though more versions follow interpretation (2), many Bible scholars (UBS Handbook, Hess, Keel, Exum, Estes, Carr, Fox, Longman, Mitchell, Gledhill, Bloch & Bloch, Garrett; BART; lexicons: HALOT, BDB) follow interpretation (1). The word also occurs in 5:15, where most versions translate it as referring to the man’s form or appearance. (These versions include the BSB, NIV, NJB, RSV, and GNT, which translate it as face here). In 5:15 it is followed (in 5:16) by reference to the man’s mouth or his speech, so the context is similar to 2:14 where her overall appearance is followed by reference to her “voice.”

Because the BSB follows interpretation (2) here, the Notes will use the NASB as the source text for 2:14c in the Display.

let me see: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as let me see literally means “cause me to see.” The man used it here to tell the woman that he wanted to see her. He wanted her to stop hiding in her room. Her room was like “the clefts of the rock” because he could not reach her there.

Some other ways to translate the man’s request are:

allow me to look at you

Let me see how lovely you are! (CEV)

please come out so I can see you

2:14d

let me hear your voice;

- and hear you^(sing) speak,
- and you^(sing) can speak to me

let me hear your voice: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as let me hear literally means “cause me to hear.” It is similar to “let me see” in 2:14c. The man wanted the woman to speak to him so that he could listen to her beautiful voice (2:14e). Some other ways to translate 2:14d are:

Let me hear you speak

Please speak to me

Cause me to hear your voice

2:14e

for your voice is sweet,

- because your^(sing) voice has a beautiful sound,
- so I will be delighted by your^(sing) sweet voice

for your voice is sweet: The phrase for your voice is sweet tells the reason that the man wants to hear the woman’s voice. There are two ways to interpret the word sweet in this context:

1. It means that her voice has a pleasing sound. For example:

for the sound of your voice is beautiful/sweet

1. It means that what she says is pleasing. For example:

for what you say is sweet/pleasing

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). English versions are ambiguous, but interpretation (1) fits the context. The man indicated that the sound of the woman’s voice was beautiful, and that is why he wanted to hear it.

your voice is sweet: Here the man tells the woman that the sound of her voice is beautiful to him. It implies that he enjoys listening to her when she speaks. Her voice gives him pleasure. In some languages there may be an idiom to describe this. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

the sound of your voice is beautiful

you speak so sweetly

For the man and woman, hearing each other's voice was wonderful. In 2:8 and 2:10 the woman referred excitedly to the man's voice, and then he spoke.

sweet: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sweet occurs only twice in the Old Testament. The other occurrence in Proverbs 20:17 refers to food that tastes delicious. Here it refers to sweet-sounding, enchanting or pleasant speech. If a "sweet voice" or "sweet speech" is not properly understood, use another word that is appropriate to describe beautiful speech. For example:

pleasant (NLT)

has a sweet/beautiful sound

delights me

2:14f

and your countenance is lovely.

- and your^(sing) form is beautiful.
- and your^(sing) great beauty.

(NASB) And your form is lovely: The phrase your form is lovely tells the reason that the man wants to see the woman. It is connected to his request in 2:14c "let me see your face." He wants to see her because she is lovely. Indicate the connection in a natural way in your language.

As in 2:14c, the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as "your countenance" and that the NASB translates your form means "form" or "appearance" here. For that reason, the Notes will use the NASB as the source line for this part of the verse. See the note on "let me see your face" in 2:14c for more information.

lovely: The Hebrew word that the NASB translates as lovely means "beautiful in a way that is appropriate." When it describes a beautiful woman, as it does here, it implies that she is just what a man desires. It was also used in 1:5, where the BSB translated it as "lovely." You may translate it here in the same way as you did there.

General Comment on 2:14, 15–17

At the end of 2:14 the woman stopped quoting what the man said to her. In 2:15 she began her own response to what he said. In many languages it may be necessary to indicate the beginning of her response in

some way. One way to do that is to use a new heading to introduce 2:15–17. The Notes has:

The woman replied to the man

Song of Solomon 2:15

Section 2:8–3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1–2:7). At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8–3:5. In the first poem (2:8–17) the man came and stood outside the woman's room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring day. The second poem (3:1–5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2–6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8–17 and 3:1–5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

Paragraph 2:8–17

This beautiful poem (2:8–17) describes springtime. In springtime, new plants begin to grow, flowers bloom, and fruit trees begin to blossom. In these lines springtime symbolizes that love was growing between the woman and the man. The woman first spoke to herself, but then she quoted the man as he invited her to come out of her house and go away with him.

This poem begins and ends in a similar way. At the beginning (2:8–9) the man came to the woman over the mountains like a gazelle or stag. At the end (2:17) he again roamed on the mountains like a gazelle or stag.

In these lines the woman spoke. However, from 2:10b through 2:14 she quoted what the man said. Then she continued speaking in 2:15–17.

2:15

Many scholars agree that in the preceding verses (2:8–14) the woman quoted what the man said to her. However, scholars have different views about who spoke in 2:15. It is sometimes difficult to determine which interpretation the English versions follow, so lists of supporting English versions are not provided for this issue. The main view is it is also possible that

the man and woman speak together in unison to an unspecified person or chorus. are:

1. The woman spoke. Some versions use a heading to indicate this. For example:

The Beloved to her Lover (NET)

1. The man spoke (or the woman quoted what he said). For example, the NCV has this heading for 2:14-15:

The Man Speaks (NCV)

1. The young women of Jerusalem (or an unspecified group) spoke. For example, the NLT has this heading:

Young Women of Jerusalem (NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with many Bible scholars. This interpretation is supported by a number of careful Bible scholars, including Bergant, Davidson, Delitzsch, Elliott, Exum, Fox, Gledhill, Gordis, Mitchell, Murphy, Snaith, and the UBS Handbook. In 2:14, the man told the woman that he wanted to hear her voice, so it is likely that here in 2:15 the woman replied to him.

The literal meaning of 2:15 is fairly clear. However, scholars do not agree on its figurative meaning and what it implies. One likely interpretation is that the man must try to remove the small disagreements or problems that damage their love for each other. The General Comment on 2:15 suggests ways that translators may help readers to understand the figurative meaning.

2:15a

Catch for us the foxes—

- Catch^(sing) the foxes for us,
- Grab^(sing) those foxes for us^(incl).

Catch for us the foxes: The phrase Catch for us the foxes is a request to more than one person. It means “you^(plur) catch the foxes for us.” However, the woman was speaking only to the man. There are different ways to interpret the plural form here. The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as Catch is a masculine plural imperative verb (“you^(plur) catch”). Scholars debate the function and meaning of the plural form here. One likely interpretation is that the form intensifies the meaning, indicating the urgency of catching the foxes. It may imply urgency. It was urgent for the man to

catch the foxes to prevent them from spoiling the vineyards. Other ways to translate this request are:

Catch the foxes for us (GW)

we must catch the little foxes (CEV)

us: The word us refers here to the man and the woman. It implies that catching the foxes will help both of them. It may be possible that the woman included the daughters of Jerusalem also in the people to benefit from this request (though the Notes does not take that view). She occasionally addressed them in other places in the Song (for example, 1:5; 2:7; 3:5, and 5:16). However, in those cases she referred to them with an explicit title (such as “daughters of Jerusalem”), whereas here she did not. So it seems less certain that they were included here.

foxes: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as foxes can refer to either foxes or jackals. A **fox** is any canine mammal of the genus *Vulpes*. Foxes are small predators that do not hunt in packs. They typically have large pointed ears, a pointed muzzle, and a bushy tail.” A **jackal** is a canine mammal of the genus *Canis*, closely related to the dog, with long legs and pointed ears and muzzle. Jackals are predators and carrion-eaters. These animals are wild, though they look like small dogs. They live in holes in the ground or in natural shelters like caves. In the Bible the foxes are known for being crafty and destructive.

If neither foxes nor jackals are known in your area, some options to consider are:

- Use an animal that is similar to a fox. For example:

coyote

wild dog

wolf

- Use a different animal that has characteristics that are appropriate in this context (like being small and destructive).
- Use a more general term. For example:

those little animals

those small, pesky animals

2:15b**the little foxes that ruin the vineyards—**

- those little foxes that spoil the vineyards,
- They are pesky/troublesome little animals that destroy our^(incl) grape farms/vines.

the little foxes that ruin the vineyards: Foxes (or jackals) are destructive. They may damage vineyards by digging around grapevines and eating the new shoots and blossoms. Some other ways to translate 2:15b are:

These little foxes damage the grapevines

before they ruin our vineyard (GNT)

Here the little foxes represent things that may damage the love between the man and woman. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that in some way. For example:

those things/problems that damage our love like small foxes damage a vineyard

little foxes: The word little probably implies that the foxes are small and hard to catch. It may be hard to notice them until they have done a lot of damage. The word little probably does not imply that the foxes were only a small problem.

2:15c**for our vineyards are in bloom.**

- because our^(incl) vineyards are blossoming.
- ¶The vines in our^(incl) grape farms are blossoming and vulnerable.

for our vineyards are in bloom: This clause gives the reason for the command to catch the foxes in 2:15a. Because the vineyards are in bloom, it is important to catch the little foxes. Otherwise, the foxes may damage the blossoms so that the vines do not produce fruit. The meaning of this clause is similar to 2:13b, which says that “the vines are in blossom.” Blooming grapevines are one of the signs of springtime.

Some other ways to translate the clause are:

because our grapevines have little flowers

for the grapevines in our farm are blooming

our vineyards: The word our implies that the vineyards belonged to the man and woman. So they were

personally concerned about the damage that the foxes did. Here vineyards refers figuratively to the love between the man and woman. In some languages it may be helpful to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

the vineyard of love (NLT)

the grape farm of our love

See the General Comment on 2:15 for more information.

General Comment on 2:15

This verse has both a literal and a figurative meaning. Literally, it means that foxes may damage the new blooms of the grapevines. Figuratively, it implies that the man and woman were beginning to love each other, and “foxes” represent dangers that may damage their new love. (It is possible that the foxes may represent other young men, but that is not certain.) It was common in Ancient Near Eastern love literature for wild animals to symbolically represent threats to romantic relationships. So, here the woman asks the man to guard against anything that might endanger their growing relationship. She may also be asking for his physical protection over her. This interpretation fits the woman’s action of hiding behind a wall (2:9) and on rocky cliffs (2:14). She wanted the man to protect her and not allow anything to harm their love.

It may be helpful to add a footnote here about the figurative sense of “foxes” and “vineyards.” Here is a possible footnote:

Here foxes represent dangers (for example, other young men) that may try to damage or hinder the growing love between the man and woman.

Song of Solomon 2:16**Section 2:8–3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him**

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1–2:7). At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8–3:5. In the first poem (2:8–17) the man came and stood outside the woman’s room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring

day. The second poem (3:1–5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2–6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8–17 and 3:1–5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

Paragraph 2:8–17

This beautiful poem (2:8–17) describes springtime. In springtime, new plants begin to grow, flowers bloom, and fruit trees begin to blossom. In these lines springtime symbolizes that love was growing between the woman and the man. The woman first spoke to herself, but then she quoted the man as he invited her to come out of her house and go away with him.

This poem begins and ends in a similar way. At the beginning (2:8–9) the man came to the woman over the mountains like a gazelle or stag. At the end (2:17) he again roamed on the mountains like a gazelle or stag.

In these lines the woman spoke. However, from 2:10b through 2:14 she quoted what the man said. Then she continued speaking in 2:15–17.

2:16–17

In these verses the woman is probably now outside in the countryside with her beloved.

2:16a

My beloved is mine and I am his;

- My beloved belongs to me and I belong to him.
- My love, you^(sing) are mine and I am yours.

My beloved is mine and I am his: Here the woman probably spoke directly to her beloved. However, she spoke as though she were speaking to someone else about him. In Hebrew poetry it is common to speak that way. In some languages it is more natural to indicate that the woman spoke directly to the man. For example:

My beloved, you are mine, and I am yours.

This statement implies that the man and woman loved each other in a way that they did not love anyone else. Try to find a poetic way to say this. Some other ways to say it in English are:

My beloved, you belong to me, and I belong to you.

My love, you are my own, and I am your own.

You are the one I love, and I am the one you love.

2:16b

he pastures his flock among the lilies.

- He grazes in fields of lilies.
- You^(sing) feed yourself where the fragrant flowers grow.

he pastures his flock among the lilies: There are two ways to interpret the verb that the BSB translates as he pastures:

1. It means “he grazes.” In this context it implies that the man feeds or nourishes himself among lilies. For example:

he grazes among the lilies. (NET) (ESV, NAB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT)

1. It means “he pastures (his flock),” and it implies that he feeds his flock. For example:

he pastures his flock among the lilies. (RSV) (BSB, RSV, CEV, GW, NASB, NJB, REB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The emphasis in this context is on the shepherd himself, not on his sheep. The author does not mention sheep or shepherding anywhere else in this section (2:8–3:5). The author compares the man to a stag in 2:17, so interpretation (1) fits the context well. Similarly, in 2:8 the man (or gazelle) is leaping across the hills before it is made clear in 2:9 that it is a simile. However, in some languages a literal translation gives a wrong meaning. See the next note for more information.

Because the BSB follows interpretation (2), the NET will be used as the source line in the Display.

(NET) he grazes among the lilies: In Hebrew the phrase he grazes among the lilies literally means that he stands among the lilies and eats them. Figuratively, the woman referred to herself as lilies, as she did in 2:1b. In 2:2 the man compared her to a lily among thorns. Here in 2:16 the woman said that the man feeds himself among the lilies. Figuratively, this means that he was happy and nourished by being with her.

It may be helpful to include a footnote to make this figurative meaning clear. For example:

“Grazing among the lilies” has a figurative meaning here. It probably refers back to 2:1–2 where the

woman described herself as a common lily, and the man described her as a lily among thorns. This implies that in 2:16 lilies are also a symbol for the woman. The man enjoys being with her.

This same figure of speech also occurs in 6:3. (Other figurative uses of “lilies” occur in 4:5, 5:13, 6:2 and 7:2. But those figures do not have the same significance as the figures in 2:16 and 6:3.)

In some languages it is necessary to make explicit that the author used a metaphor or simile. It may also be necessary to mention the gazelle and young stag in 2:16, as well as in 2:17. For example:

^{16a}My beloved is mine and I am his.

^{17c} Like a gazelle ^{17d}or young stag, ^{16b}he browses among the lilies.

^{17a}Until the day breathes

^{17b}and the shadows flee,

^{17c}turn, my beloved, be like a gazelle ^{17d}or a young stag upon rugged mountains.

Song of Solomon 2:17

Section 2:8–3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1–2:7). At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8–3:5. In the first poem (2:8–17) the man came and stood outside the woman’s room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring day. The second poem (3:1–5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2–6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8–17 and 3:1–5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

Paragraph 2:8–17

This beautiful poem (2:8–17) describes springtime. In springtime, new plants begin to grow, flowers bloom, and fruit trees begin to blossom. In these lines springtime symbolizes that love was growing between the woman and the man. The woman first spoke to herself, but then she quoted the man as he invited her to come out of her house and go away with him.

This poem begins and ends in a similar way. At the beginning (2:8–9) the man came to the woman over the mountains like a gazelle or stag. At the end (2:17) he again roamed on the mountains like a gazelle or stag.

In these lines the woman spoke. However, from 2:10b through 2:14 she quoted what the man said. Then she continued speaking in 2:15–17.

2:17

This important verse ends the poem that began in 2:8–9. It also prepares readers for the next paragraph (3:1–5). There are different ways to interpret the verse. Bible scholars ask a number of interpretive questions about this verse, including: (a) Was the time of day evening or morning? (b) Did the woman invite the man to stay with her or did she ask him to leave? (c) Were the woman and man married? Were they fulfilling their sexual desires for each other or did they only imagine fulfilling them? (d) In what way did the woman want the man to be like a gazelle or young stag? (e) Does the phrase “mountains of Bether” refer to a place or to the woman’s body? These questions are related to differences of opinion about the meaning of the words and phrases that the BSB translates as “Before,” “day breaks,” “shadows flee,” “turn,” “be like,” and “mountains of Bether.” Some scholars conclude that the woman and man spent the night together at this point. However, it is unlikely that 2:17 describes a night of lovemaking. The poem may imply sexual desires, but it does not indicate that the couple fulfilled their desires at that time. The Notes interprets it to refer to a time before the woman and man had sexual relations. In this section, their love was still like the first blossoms in springtime. The Bible indicates that a couple must wait until they marry to have sexual relations. The author of the Song probably assumes those beliefs, a point which is convincingly argued by Brevard Childs (page 575). Intimate sexual behavior that the unmarried couple is keeping secret would be at odds with Hebrew cultural and biblical norms. This could cast doubt over the book’s inclusion in the canon. See also Garrett’s “Excursus: Virginity in the Bible and the Ancient World,” pages 164–168.

2:17a

Before the day breaks

- When the cooling breeze rises
- As the gentle wind blows

2:17b**and shadows flee,**

- and shadows disappear,
- and the shadows of evening lengthen,

2:17a–b

Before the day breaks and shadows flee: The statements in 2:17a and 2:17b are parallel. The subjects and the verbs are also parallel. The similar parts are underlined or written in bold print here:

^{17a}Before the day **breaks**

^{17b}and shadows **flee**

In 2:17b the word “before” is implied before the phrase shadows flee. The parallel lines, 2:17a and 2:17b refer to the same time of day. Scholars differ about the time of day that the phrases refer to:

1. The phrases refer to evening. In the evening, breezes cool the land. Keel (page 115) says, “The Hebrew [for “the day breathes”] is literally ‘the blowing of the day,’ which alludes to the daily wind (Gen. 3:8) that begins to blow from the sea in the course of the afternoon. The “fleeing” of the shadows means they are getting longer (cf. Jer. 6:4).” The shadows become longer and then disappear into the darkness of night. For example:

When the day brings a cooling breeze and the shadows flee (GW) (GW, NAB, NJB, Footnotes in both the NAB and NJB make clear that the translators understand the time of day to be evening, possibly NASB) Français Courant and Parole de Vie also follow this interpretation.

1. The phrases refer to morning (or specifically to dawn). In the morning or at dawn, cool breezes blow and shadows disappear in the sunlight. For example:

until the morning breezes blow and the darkness disappears (GNT) (BSB, NLT, REB, GNT, CEV, NCV, NET, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), which refers to an evening breeze. Some reasons for this choice are:

1. In Palestine, the west wind is the breeze that cools the land. It typically blows in the afternoon or evening, not in the morning. The east wind is associated with strong storms, the south wind with desert heat, and the north wind with rain.
2. Two of three lexicons, as well as several reliable commentaries, support evening. BDB and Holladay (but not HALOT) suggest evening here. Some of the commentaries supporting the evening interpretation are Barbiero, Delitzsch, Elliott, Ginsburg, Snaith, Falk, and Keel.
3. Evening fits the context of 2:8–16 better than morning. In these verses the woman seemed too shy to come out when the man called, so it is not likely that they spent the night together. As the sun set, the man probably returned home through the “mountains” (2:8).

Use a natural or poetic way in your language to describe a cool, pleasant time toward evening. Some ways to translate it in English are:

When the day brings a cooling breeze and the shadows flee (GW)

As the setting sun causes a cool wind to blow and shadows disappear in the darkness

My love, when the sun sets and you feel the cool air of evening

Before: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Before can express different meanings depending on the context. English versions translate it in different ways here. The lexicons give a wide range of meanings, which are largely dependent on context. The variations in the versions are largely due to different interpretations of the overall context.

1. It means “until.” For example:

Until the day breathes (ESV) (ESV, NCV, CEV, NASB, NIV, RSV, GNT, NET)

1. It means “before.” For example:

Before the day breeze rises (NJB) (BSB, NJB, NLT)

1. It means “when, while.” For example:

When the day blows gently (NJPS) (NJPS, GW, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In this context, the word Before sets a time limit for a particular continuing action. It implies that this action will continue Before the evening breeze blows and shadows begin to lengthen. The text may imply that at evening time, the gazelle (man) would leave.

2:17c

turn, my beloved, and be like a gazelle

- roam, my love, like a graceful gazelle
- return to where you^(sing) came from swiftly like a gazelle

2:17c-d

Notice the parallelism in 2:17c-d:

^{17c}turn, my beloved, and be like a gazelle,

^{17d} or a young stag on the mountains of Bether.

turn, my beloved, and be like a gazelle or a young

stag: In the Hebrew text 2:17c is more literally “turn, be like, my love, a gazelle.” Notice that the verbs turn and be like occur next to each other. Scholars disagree about which verb is the main verb in the clause. Most English versions are ambiguous about this. The Notes take the view that the main verb is be like, and the verb turn adds to its meaning adverbially. The word turn in this case would mean something like “to go around.” However, most scholars focus on the first verb turn. These scholars usually follow one of two interpretations: Either the woman was inviting the man to turn toward her (stay with her) or to turn away from her (leave). However, these latter interpretations seem a bit awkward when translating the first word “until.” The context seems to need some sort of continuing action whereas “turn towards” or “turn away” are not continuous actions. There are different interpretations of the verbs here. The two main interpretations are:

1. The verb turn means “go around” or “turn about.” The issue here is whether or not this is an example of verbal hendiadys (where two verbs occur together and one of the verbs qualifies the other). In Hebrew my beloved does not separate the two verbs “turn” and “be like” as it does in most English versions. The two verbs in Hebrew are juxtaposed: “turn, be like.” This may be similar to the hendiadys in Jonah 1:2, “arise, go.” Both passages have two adjacent qal imperative verbs; the first verbs (“turn” or “arise”) belong to a similar semantic class of directional verbs. In the case of Jonah 1:2, “arise” does not necessarily mean “get up” from

a sitting or reclining position, but functions in a more subordinate rather than coordinate way. Some take it as intensive (for example, “go immediately to Nineveh” as in the NET). Others don’t translate it at all (for example, the GNT says: “Go to Nineveh”). See the note in the NET for Jonah 1:2 regarding “verbal hendiadys” and the adverbial function of the first of the two verbs. Othmar Keel states this regarding the interpretation of Song 2:17: “At this time the man is supposed to go his way. The two imperatives, “turn” and “be like” may be an example of hendiadys, that is, a single expression formed from two seemingly unrelated contiguous words. If so, the meaning could be something like: “Be like a gazelle again and again” (cf. Eccl. 1:6).” (p.115) This “hendiadys” option is obscured by most English versions that keep the verbs separate with an intervening “my beloved.” The lexicons all include a possible meaning of “turn” as “to go around on a circuit” (or its equivalent). The NABRE seems to be using “turn” to modify “be like” in this way: “Until the day grows cool and the shadows flee, roam, my lover, like a gazelle or a young stag upon the rugged mountains.” So the similarity of the man to the gazelle is the fact that he roams (or grazes). This is what the NAB seems to express. This continuative action (roaming) fits better with the sense of “until” than “turn/leave” which seems more punctiliar. The effect of this approach is to place the focus on the man “being like” (i.e., acting the part of) a gazelle or young stag for the remainder of the day rather than on whether he remains or leaves. So the verse is a further description of this idyllic spring day, perhaps parallel to 2:16b where he browses among the lilies. It is a highly romantic and exquisite, though non-explicit, statement about their romantic time together. In the textual, as well as cultural and greater biblical context, and assuming that the temporal context is “until evening,” this implies then that he is playing out the “being like” a gazelle until evening. At that time he appropriately (though implicit in the text) leaves for home. Along with be like in this context, it probably indicates that the man should roam/run as a gazelle does. It may also imply that he should turn and return to where he came from. For example:

roam, my lover, like a gazelle or a young stag
(NAB)

turn around....Run like a gazelle or a young stag
(GW) (BSB, NAB, GW, possibly NJPS, NASB)

1. It means to “turn towards.” This is an invitation for the man to stay with her (perhaps for the night). For example:

return to me, my love, like a gazelle or a young stag (NLT) (NLT, NCV)

Some English versions are ambiguous or translate in a unique way. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The woman seemed to want the man to behave like a gazelle on the mountains—running and leaping. The context, which refers to evening breezes and shadows (2:17c), may imply that he would return home before dark. This interpretation fits the context well.

be like a gazelle or a young stag: In 2:8–9 the author also compared the man to a gazelle or young stag. There the comparison implied characteristics such as speed, strength, and grace. In 2:16b the author also uses animal imagery to imply calm and contentment (“he pastures his flock among the lilies”).

In 2:17, the gazelle leaping on hills and feeding on flowers may symbolize the man’s happiness about enjoying the beautiful spring day with the woman until sunset. It is similar to his feelings in 2:16b as he fed among the lilies.

2:17d

or a young stag on the mountains of Bether.

- or young stag on the rugged hills.
- or a young stag over the split/cleft mountains.

on the mountains of Bether: The meaning of the Hebrew word *beter* that the BSB translates as Bether is uncertain. Some ways to interpret it are:

1. It is related to a similar Hebrew root that means “split” or “divided.” It refers to rugged hills or to a mountain that has more than one peak. For example:

rugged hills (NIV)

cleft mountains (NRSV) (RSV, NIV, NLT, ESV, NRSV)

1. It is the name of a certain town or of certain mountains located near Jerusalem. Versions that follow this interpretation transliterate the Hebrew name. For example:

on the mountains of Bether (GNT) (BSB, NAB, NASB, NJB, GNT)

1. It refers to spices, and the phrase means “hills of spices.” This interpretation is based on an alternate Hebrew textual reading *besamiym*, “spices,” harmonizing this verse with 8:14. For example:

the hills where aromatic spices grow (REB) (NJPS, REB)

Both interpretations (1) and (2) have good support, but it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It helps readers picture the man moving over the mountains. You may want to mention interpretation (2) in a footnote. It is possible that “Bether” has a figurative meaning here: (a) A similar Hebrew root means “divide, separate.” [0] This meaning symbolizes the man and woman leaving each other at the end of the day. The idea of separation is a theme in 3:1–5. (b) The “gazelle” or “young stag” romping and grazing in the mountains symbolizes the man enjoying the woman’s presence. In a general way the mountains of Bether symbolize the woman. (c) Some scholars agree with the meaning “split mountains” and interpret it as referring to the woman’s breasts. This implies that she invited the man to enjoy sexual intimacy with her. There are several problems with this interpretation, and it conflicts with the standards of the Bible and of Hebrew culture at that time.

Song of Solomon 3:1

Section 2:8–3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1–2:7). At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8–3:5. In the first poem (2:8–17) the man came and stood outside the woman’s room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring day. The second poem (3:1–5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2–6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8–17 and 3:1–5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

Paragraph 3:1–5 The woman described searching for her beloved at night

In the preceding poem (2:8–17) the author described the man and woman as they were together on a beautiful spring day. Here in Paragraph 3:1–5 the woman was alone in her bed at night, and she longed to be with her beloved again. Her joy in 2:8–17 changed to being troubled in 3:1–5 as she searched for her beloved and then clung to him when she found him.

Bible scholars are not sure whether this poem tells about a dream, the woman's feelings, or an actual event. It seems more like a dream than an actual event. In that culture it would not be likely for a woman to go out into the city at night, as the author described in 3:1–5, but in a dream almost anything is possible.

Some versions (including BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NJPS, and GNT) have a section heading or footnote at 3:1 to indicate that 3:1–5 describes a dream. The GNT mentions in the text that it was a dream, saying, "Asleep on my bed, night after night I dreamed of the one I love..." Other scholars interpret 3:1–5 as a description of the woman's feelings. The Song is lyric poetry, which often uses such descriptions. It does not necessarily describe actual events. The Notes interpret 3:1–5 as a dream.

It is likely that 3:5 functions as a refrain, probably for the entire section (2:8–3:5). It is identical to the refrain in 2:7.

3:1a

On my bed at night I sought the one I love;

- While I was in my bed at night, I searched for the one whom my heart loves.
- At night on my bed I dreamed that I was looking for my true love.

On my bed...I sought the one I love: There are different ways to interpret this clause. The two main interpretations are:

1. It indicates that while the woman was on her bed, she searched for her beloved, probably in a dream. For example:

On my bed by night I sought him whom my soul loves (ESV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NJPS, REB, RSV, GNT)

1. It is a figurative way to say that she longed for her beloved. For example:

All night long on my bed, I longed for my lover (NET) (NET, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It fits the context, which continues to describe the woman searching. When she did not find her beloved in her bed (3:1), she went out into the city streets to continue searching for him (3:2–4). In some languages it is natural to combine the idea of searching and longing in options (1) and (2). For example:

On my bed at night I longingly searched for the one my soul loves.

On my bed: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as bed is the common word for "bed." By itself it does not imply anything about sexual relations. Context determines the connotations of the word. By itself, the word is neutral. It is used both in scriptural contexts where sexual actions are in focus (for example, Gen 49:4, Prov 7:17–18) and in contexts where no sexual actions are involved (for example, Ps 4:4). The word is also used to refer to a sick bed (Ps 41:3) or even to a bed that represents abstinence from sexual activity. For example, it is used when Uriah the Hittite (2 Sam 11:13) slept among the servants on his mat instead of going home to sleep with his wife. Use an appropriate word in your language. For example:

in the place I sleep

as I lay in bed (NLT)

at night: There are different ways to interpret the Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as at night:

1. It means "at night," "during the night." For example:

On my bed at night (NJB) (BSB, CEV, ESV, NAB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, RSV)

1. It means "night after night." For example:

Asleep on my bed, night after night (GNT) (GW, NASB, REB, GNT)

1. It means "all night long." For example:

All night long on my bed (NIV) (NET, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as a majority of English versions do. Although the word

for night is plural in the Hebrew text, it is a special use of the plural that refers to nighttime in general. This is called a “plural of composition.” (See Waltke and O’Connor, *An Introduction to Biblical Hebrew Syntax*, 7.4.1b and Longman, p. 128.)

the one I love: The phrase the one I love is used four times in 3:1–4. It indicates that the woman loved the man very much. She had strong feelings of love for him. The word that the BSB translates as I is literally “my soul.” It literally refers to the part of a person that feels emotions like love, joy, sorrow, or anger. Figuratively, it refers to the woman herself.

Some ways to translate this figure of speech are:

- Use a figure of speech in your language that refers to strong feelings of love. Some languages use a part of the body such as the “heart,” “liver” or “stomach” or a special idiom. For example:

the one I love with heart and soul (CEV)

the one who is in my heart

- Translate the meaning without a figure of speech. For example:

the one I love (GNT)

my true love (REB)

3:1b

I sought him, but did not find him.

- I searched for him, but I did not find him.
- I looked all around for him, but he was not there.

I sought him, but did not find him: Here the woman repeated the phrase I sought him from 3:1a to emphasize her strong desire to be with the man. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the emphasis in a different way. For example:

Though I searched desperately for him, I could not find him.

Some English versions do not mention “search” and “find” here at all. For example, the NLT and NET mention only that the woman longed for the man, but he did not come. However, this section emphasizes the woman’s search, and it is important to communicate that in your language.

but did not find him: The woman dreamed that she was searching for her beloved, but she did not find him nearby. It is not necessary for readers to expect that descriptions of a dream should be completely logical and consistent. If she were awake, it would seem silly for the woman to be searching for her beloved in her small room. But dreams often are not logical or consistent. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

I did not see him anywhere/nearby.

but he was not there.

Some versions include a statement at the end of 3:1, as in the RSV, which says, “I called him, but he gave no answer.” There is a textual issue concerning the statement. Some manuscripts include this statement, and others do not.

1. The Hebrew text of 3:1 does not include this statement about the woman calling her beloved. For example, in 3:1 the NIV does not mention that the woman called the man:

All night long on my bed I looked for the one my heart loves; I looked for him but did not find him. (NIV) (BSB, NIV, ESV, GNT, CEV, GW, REB, NASB, NLT, NET, NCV, KJV)

1. The LXX (Greek translation) of 3:1 includes the statement, “I called him, but he gave no answer.” For example, in the NRSV, 3:1 ends with that statement:

Upon my bed at night I sought him whom my soul loves; I sought him, but found him not; I called him, but he gave no answer. (NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), which does not include the statement about the woman calling the man. The LXX translators probably included it because it is found in 5:6, which is similar to 3:1.

Song of Solomon 3:2

Section 2:8–3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1–2:7). At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8–3:5. In the first poem (2:8–17) the man came and stood outside the woman's room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring day. The second poem (3:1–5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2–6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8–17 and 3:1–5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

Paragraph 3:1–5 The woman described searching for her beloved at night

In the preceding poem (2:8–17) the author described the man and woman as they were together on a beautiful spring day. Here in Paragraph 3:1–5 the woman was alone in her bed at night, and she longed to be with her beloved again. Her joy in 2:8–17 changed to being troubled in 3:1–5 as she searched for her beloved and then clung to him when she found him.

Bible scholars are not sure whether this poem tells about a dream, the woman's feelings, or an actual event. It seems more like a dream than an actual event. In that culture it would not be likely for a woman to go out into the city at night, as the author described in 3:1–5, but in a dream almost anything is possible.

Some versions (including BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NJPS, and GNT) have a section heading or footnote at 3:1 to indicate that 3:1–5 describes a dream. The GNT mentions in the text that it was a dream, saying, "Asleep on my bed, night after night I dreamed of the one I love..." Other scholars interpret 3:1–5 as a description of the woman's feelings. The Song is lyric poetry, which often uses such descriptions. It does not necessarily describe actual events. The Notes interpret 3:1–5 as a dream.

It is likely that 3:5 functions as a refrain, probably for the entire section (2:8–3:5). It is identical to the refrain in 2:7.

3:2a

I will arise now and go about the city,

- I said to myself: I will get up now and go out into the city.
- I decided to go out looking around town for him

I will arise now and go about the city: The verb will goes with both arise and go about. The Hebrew verb forms indicate that the woman made a decision about

what she will do. She will get up, leave her room, and walk around in the city. She spoke or thought these things to herself. She did not speak them aloud. Probably she was still dreaming about making this decision.

In some languages it may be necessary to introduce this line with a speech introducer. For example:

So she thought to herself, "I will rise now and roam the city..."

I said, "I will rise and go the rounds of the city..." (REB)

In other languages it may be more natural to introduce the verse as an indirect quote or as a decision. For example:

Then I decided to get up and roam around the city.

I will arise now: The phrase I will arise now indicates that the woman decided to get up out of her bed. In some languages it may be necessary to include the implied information that she intended to leave her house and go outside. For example:

I will go out now

Now I will leave my/the house

and go about the city: This phrase is the second part of the woman's decision. She intended to look all around in the city until she found her beloved. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

and look all around in the city (NET)

I will walk/search through the whole city

the city: The city refers to the city where the woman lived. Some scholars think that this city was Jerusalem (for example, Exum, Carr, Hess, Garrett, and Mitchell).

3:2b

through the streets and squares.

- I will go about in the streets and public squares.
- on/by the roads and in/at the gathering places.

through the streets and squares: This phrase implies that the woman searched throughout the whole city. She went around the city's streets and other outdoor

public places. In some languages it may be helpful to combine 3:2a–b and use a phrase that refers to going throughout the public places in the town. For example:

throughout the town

squares: The squares were broad open public places. These squares were often located near the gates through which people entered the city. Many languages use different words for these public places. For example:

public/city meeting places

3:2c

I will seek the one I love.

- I will search for the one I love with all my heart.
- I told myself that I must look all around for my true love.

I will seek the one I love: This clause tells the woman's purpose for going throughout the city. She intended to search it for her beloved. This clause is the third time the "search" language is used, and it emphasizes the woman's search. Other ways to translate 3:2c are:

I will look for the one I love. (GW)

I shall seek my sweetheart. (NJB)

the one I love: This same phrase was used in 3:1a. It refers again to the woman's beloved. In some languages it is not necessary to repeat such a phrase. For example:

searching for him (NLT96)

3:2d

So I sought him but did not find him.

- I searched for him, but I did not find him.
- Then/Truly I did look all around for him, but I did not see him anywhere.

So I sought him but did not find him: In this part of the verse, the woman repeated exactly what she said in 3:1b. You should translate both clauses in the same way. Here in 3:2d the woman was probably still dreaming. In her dream she did what she decided to do in 3:2a–c—she searched for her beloved. However, she did not find him. Some other ways to translate 3:2d are:

I sought him, but found him not. (RSV)

I continued to search for him—I did not see him.

I sought him: Here the author repeated the Hebrew verb for "search" for the fourth time in this verse. This repetition implies that as the woman searched, she became more tense. Some other ways to translate the phrase here are:

I kept on searching for him

I looked and looked for him

Translate the repetition in a natural way in your language.

but did not find him: Although the woman searched so much, she did not see her beloved in any of the places where she looked. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

but I could not find him.

but I never saw him.

Song of Solomon 3:3

Section 2:8–3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1–2:7). At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8–3:5. In the first poem (2:8–17) the man came and stood outside the woman's room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring day. The second poem (3:1–5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2–6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8–17 and 3:1–5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

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Some versions (including BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NJPS, and GNT) have a section heading or footnote at 3:1 to indicate that 3:1–5 describes a dream. The GNT mentions in the text that it was a dream, saying, "Asleep on my bed, night after night I dreamed of the one I love..." Other scholars interpret 3:1–5 as a description of the woman's feelings. The Song is lyric poetry, which often uses such descriptions. It does not necessarily describe actual events. The Notes interpret 3:1–5 as a dream.

It is likely that 3:5 functions as a refrain, probably for the entire section (2:8–3:5). It is identical to the refrain in 2:7.

3:3a

I encountered the watchmen

- Then the guards found me
- The men who watch/protect the town saw me

3:3b

on their rounds of the city:

- as they patrolled the city,
- as they went through its streets.

3:3a–b

I encountered the watchmen on their rounds of the city: These watchmen were men who guarded the city. They walked about in it at night to ensure that people were safe from dangers. In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of some information in this verse. For example:

^{3b}As the people who guard the town walked through it, ^{3a}they saw me.

It also may be helpful in some languages to introduce the city guards more explicitly. For example:

There were some watchmen who guarded the city.
They saw me as they walked through the streets.

The city guards were walking through the streets,
and they met/saw me.

encountered: The verb encountered does not imply here that the watchmen were searching for the woman. They probably saw her as they went about in the city to keep people safe from possible dangers. Use an appropriate verb in your language. Notice that some examples in the preceding note use the verb "saw."

In Hebrew a form of this verb is the last word in 3:2 and the first word here in 3:3. It emphasizes a contrast: In 3:2 the woman did not find her beloved, but here in 3:3 the watchmen found her instead.

on their rounds of the city: This clause implies that the watchmen were doing their regular work of patrolling the city. They walked around in it to make sure that the town and its people were safe from danger. They were going through the city like that when they saw the woman. She was also roaming the city to look for her beloved. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

as they went about in the city (RSV)

while they were guarding the town

3:3c

"Have you seen the one I love?"

- and I asked them, "Have you seen the one whom I love with all my heart?"
- I asked them if they had seen my true love.

Have you seen the one I love: This question has no introduction, but the context indicates that the woman asked this question to the watchmen. In some languages it may be necessary to introduce the question with this information. For example:

I asked them, "Have you seen my true love?"

the one I love: This phrase was also used in 3:1a and 3:2c. It refers to the woman's beloved. Refer to him here in a natural way in your language.

Song of Solomon 3:4

Section 2:8–3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1–2:7). At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8–3:5. In the first poem (2:8–17) the man came and stood outside the woman's room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring day. The second poem (3:1–5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2–6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8–17 and 3:1–5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

Paragraph 3:1–5 The woman described searching for her beloved at night

In the preceding poem (2:8–17) the author described the man and woman as they were together on a beautiful spring day. Here in Paragraph 3:1–5 the woman was alone in her bed at night, and she longed to be with her beloved again. Her joy in 2:8–17 changed to being troubled in 3:1–5 as she searched for her beloved and then clung to him when she found him.

Bible scholars are not sure whether this poem tells about a dream, the woman's feelings, or an actual event. It seems more like a dream than an actual event. In that culture it would not be likely for a woman to go out into the city at night, as the author described in 3:1–5, but in a dream almost anything is possible.

Some versions (including BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NJPS, and GNT) have a section heading or footnote at 3:1 to indicate that 3:1–5 describes a dream. The GNT mentions in the text that it was a dream, saying, "Asleep on my bed, night after night I dreamed of the one I love..." Other scholars interpret 3:1–5 as a description of the woman's feelings. The Song is lyric poetry, which often uses such descriptions. It does not necessarily describe actual events. The Notes interpret 3:1–5 as a dream.

It is likely that 3:5 functions as a refrain, probably for the entire section (2:8–3:5). It is identical to the refrain in 2:7.

3:4a

I had just passed them

- Then I passed them, and immediately
- As soon as I left them, (GNT)

The text does not give any response to the question that the woman asked the watchmen in 3:3. It does not say whether or not they offered her any help, but probably they did not. By not focusing on the watchmen, the author probably emphasized the fact that the woman was totally focused on her search for her beloved.

I had just passed them: The phrase I had just passed them refers to the time after the woman asked the watchmen her question in 3:3. When they did not answer, she left them and continued to look for her beloved. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

As soon as I left them (GNT)

Then I passed them. Immediately...

Scarcely had I passed them (RSV)

3:4b–f

From the beginning of chapter 3 until this verse, the woman's search for her beloved became more intense. She searched and longed for her beloved. But here in 3:4b she found him. Her relief and joy was especially strong after her intense search.

In each line of 3:4c–f the woman seemed to express more intimacy with the man. She embraced him (3:4c–d) and brought him into her mother's chamber (3:4f). Lines 3:4c and 3:4d are parallel, but 3:4d is more intense and specific. Lines 3:4e and 3:4f are also parallel, and 3:4f is more intense and specific.

3:4b

when I found the one I love.

- I found the one whom I love with all my heart.
- I saw him, my true love!

when I found the one I love: This line is closely connected with 3:4a. It indicates that immediately after the woman left the watchmen, she found her beloved. Connect this line with 3:4a in a natural way in your language. Some other ways to translate it are:

immediately I saw my love!

As soon as I had left them, I found the one I love
(NCV, 3:4a–b)

3:4c I held him

- I held on to him,
- I clung to him tightly

I held him: The phrase I held him indicates that the woman held onto the man tightly. It implies that she was happy and relieved to be with him. She did not want to risk being separated from him again. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

I held onto him tightly (NET)

I clung to him

I grabbed/gripped him

3:4d and would not let go

- and I did not let go of him
- and continued to cling to him

and would not let go: This clause is parallel to 3:4c and adds emphasis. It means that the woman would not stop holding on to the man. She kept clinging to him. It implies that she felt an intense desire to keep him with her. Other ways to translate this clause are:

I did not loosen my hold on him

and I kept holding him tightly

**3:4e–f
until I had brought him to my mother's house, to the chamber of the one who conceived me:** The clauses in 3:4e and 3:4f are parallel and have a similar meaning. In 3:4e the woman said that she brought the man into her mother's house. In 3:4f she brought him even into her mother's bedroom.

3:4e until I had brought him to my mother's house,

- until I led him into my mother's house.
- as/while I took him home to my mother's house,

until I had brought him to my mother's house: This clause tells the place where the woman brought her beloved. She was determined to bring him to her mother's house, so she held him tightly until they arrived. Some other ways to translate the clause are:

then I brought him to my mother's house. (NLT)

I did not stop holding him before I took him with me into my mother's house

to my mother's house: There is uncertainty about what my mother's house implies here. Scholars also have different ideas about why the young woman took the man there. Here are some important facts to consider:

1. The phrase my mother's house is a common way to refer to the place (house) where an unmarried woman lives.
2. Marriage plans were made at the mother's house. The text may imply that the woman and man went there to make preparations for their marriage, which happens in 3:6–11.
3. Her mother's house in her "chamber" (3:4f) is the place where the man and woman will be intimate with each other after they marry.

These three suggestions about what the phrase mother's house implies here may all be true. The phrase probably refers to the house where the woman and her mother lived. There plans could be made for the marriage of the man and woman.

3:4f to the chamber of the one who conceived me.

- I led him into the room of my mother who conceived me.
- all the way into the room where my mother conceived me.

to the chamber of the one who conceived me: The phrase to the chamber of the one who conceived me is parallel to the phrase "into my mother's house" in 3:4e. In 3:4f the woman used a more specific phrase, and the meaning is more intense. It implies that the woman hoped that in the future she and the man would be intimate with each other there. The next section (3:6–5:1) figuratively describes their wedding and their intimate union as a married couple.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

into the room where my mother conceived me.

into my mother's bedroom, where I had been conceived. (NLT96)

the chamber of the one who conceived me: The word chamber means "room." The phrase the chamber of the one who conceived me refers to the bedroom

of the woman's mother. Most English versions follow this view, including NIV, RSV, NET, NASB, ESV, GW, REB, and NJPS. It may also imply that the woman was conceived in this room. NLT and NJB follow this view. The NJB has, "to my mother's house, to the room where she conceived me!" and/or that she was born in that room. It may refer to the room where the woman was born, as GNT and NCV indicate. The NCV has, "the room where I was born." It may also imply that her mother's blessing was on her daughter's relationship with her beloved.

Another way to translate the chamber of the one who conceived me is:

the room of the one who conceived me (NIV)

General Comment on 3:1-4

This dream in 3:1-4 is told from the woman's point of view. In these verses she searched for him and committed herself to him again. The woman's dream ends here in 3:4. The man did not speak often in this section (2:8-3:5), but he spoke more often in the next section, especially in 4:1-15.

Song of Solomon 3:5

Section 2:8-3:5: The man called the woman, but later she could not find him

The author began this scene at a different place and time from the ending of the preceding section (1:1-2:7). At the end of that section, the woman and man were together, but at the beginning of this section (2:8) the woman was in her room at home, and the man was coming to her over the hills.

There are two poems in Section 2:8-3:5. In the first poem (2:8-17) the man came and stood outside the woman's room. She quoted what he said as he invited her to come out with him and enjoy a beautiful spring day. The second poem (3:1-5) describes a time when the woman searched for her beloved at night. This second poem has much in common with Section 5:2-6:3. See the discussion of similarities at the beginning of that section.

Both parts of this section (2:8-17 and 3:1-5) may describe what the woman imagined or what she dreamed. The descriptions may not refer to actual events in the poem.

Paragraph 3:1-5 The woman described searching for her beloved at night

In the preceding poem (2:8-17) the author described the man and woman as they were together on a beautiful spring day. Here in Paragraph 3:1-5 the woman

was alone in her bed at night, and she longed to be with her beloved again. Her joy in 2:8-17 changed to being troubled in 3:1-5 as she searched for her beloved and then clung to him when she found him.

Bible scholars are not sure whether this poem tells about a dream, the woman's feelings, or an actual event. It seems more like a dream than an actual event. In that culture it would not be likely for a woman to go out into the city at night, as the author described in 3:1-5, but in a dream almost anything is possible.

Some versions (including BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NJPS, and GNT) have a section heading or footnote at 3:1 to indicate that 3:1-5 describes a dream. The GNT mentions in the text that it was a dream, saying, "Asleep on my bed, night after night I dreamed of the one I love..." Other scholars interpret 3:1-5 as a description of the woman's feelings. The Song is lyric poetry, which often uses such descriptions. It does not necessarily describe actual events. The Notes interpret 3:1-5 as a dream.

It is likely that 3:5 functions as a refrain, probably for the entire section (2:8-3:5). It is identical to the refrain in 2:7.

3:5a

O daughters of Jerusalem, I adjure you

- Swear to me, women of Jerusalem,
- You women of Jerusalem, promise me,
- Please promise me, you young women of Jerusalem,

3:5b

by the gazelles and does of the field:

- in the name of the wild gazelles or the deer,
- by the graceful gazelles and the wild does,

3:5c

Do not arouse

- that you will not cause
- do^(plur) not excite yourselves
- that you will not stimulate

3:5d

or awaken love

- feelings of love to arise
- with longings/desires for love
- desire to love someone intimately/sexually

3:5e

until the time is right.

- until it please. (RSV)
- before the proper time.

3:5a-e

O daughters of Jerusalem, I adjure you by the gazelles and does of the field: Do not arouse or awaken love until the time is right: For information and translation advice on this verse, refer to the notes for 2:7a-e.

General Comment/summary for 2:8-3:5

In this section (especially in 2:8-17) the author describes the new spring plants and blossoms. He implies that the love between the man and woman was also growing. In 3:1-4 the woman searched for her beloved and longed for union with him. In 3:4 she dreamed that she found him and brought him home with her. As the man and woman became more ready to be intimate with each other, the woman warned the Jerusalem women to be careful to not influence them to express that intimate love before the right time (3:5).

Song of Solomon 3:6**Section 3:6-5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her**

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1-5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple's wedding day. The section has several parts:

3:6-11 The man and woman came to their wedding in a grand procession

4:1-15 The man described his beautiful bride

4:16-5:1 The man and woman consummated their marriage

Paragraph 3:6-11 The poet described the wedding procession

There are several questions that translators need to ask about the meaning of 3:6-11:

1. What does the author imply when he refers to Solomon in the poem? The name "Solomon" refers figuratively to the man whom the woman loves. At a literal level 3:6-11 seems to be a historical description of Solomon on his wedding day. But which wedding? He had numerous wives! It is more probable that Solomon was the author of the Song, but

not one of the characters in it. (For more information about that, see the discussion in 1:1.) The Song describes a nearly ideal love relationship between one man and one woman in which neither of them had other lovers, and the man had no other wives. Yet Solomon was known for having many wives and for his spiritual failure (see 1 Kings 11:1-3). He was not known for his pure love. New Testament passages that mention Solomon refer to his wisdom (Luke 11:31) and his material splendor (Luke 12:27), but not to his love. Solomon's personal life did not demonstrate the pure monogamous love that we see in the woman's beloved. If Solomon did write the book, he did so as Israel's greatest wise man, not as Israel's ideal lover. References to Solomon in the Song seem to focus on his royal splendor, rather than on Solomon himself or his love. This is certainly true in 1:5 that speaks of the curtains of Solomon. It implies that on his wedding day, the man felt as happy, rich, and powerful as King Solomon. Other verses that refer to Solomon figuratively are 1:4-5; 1:12; 3:6-11; 6:12; and 7:1. The Song uses other figurative motifs, such as a "shepherd" (1:7-8; 6:2-3), gazelle (2:8-9; 2:16-17; 8:14), dove (1:15; 2:14; 4:1; 5:12), lily (2:2; 2:16), vineyard (1:6; 2:15; 8:11-12) mare (1:9-11) and garden (4:12-5:1; 6:2).

2. Who speaks in this section? Probably the author speaks. If the woman was in the procession, she probably did not describe herself. Some scholars give other suggestions for the speaker here, for example, the man, the daughters of Jerusalem, a chorus, or an unknown speaker.
3. Does this poem describe an event that really happened? The poem probably does not describe an event that really happened. It uses figurative language, including hyperbole and similes. Bloch and Bloch make a strong point here. Referring to the three passages using this opening formula, "Who is this (fem)...?" (Song 3:6, 6:10, 8:5), they state, "None of these three scenes is realistic; all are hyperboles, evoking images of the triumphant appearance of a majestic, numinous, even godlike figure." The rhetorical question here calls attention to the radiant and majestic bride's approach. Bergant understands this poem in 3:6-11 as a metaphorical characterization rather than a description of an actual event. The UBS Handbook leans toward the poetic, non-historical view, as do Munro, Garrett, Gledhill, Keel, and others. The poem begins, "Who is this woman coming up from the wilderness like a column of smoke..." It probably implies that she was surrounded by the smoke of fragrant incense. Like a queen, the woman also had soldiers around her to protect and honor her. The woman was

carried in luxury to the man, who waited for her in Jerusalem. He was compared to the greatest of kings. This hyperbole may come from a marriage custom where the bride and groom wore royal crowns on their wedding day.

3:6a

Who is this coming up from the wilderness

- Who is this woman ascending with her escorts from the wilderness?
- Look^(plur), is that the bride approaching in procession from the wilderness?

In this verse the author describes a magnificent wedding procession. It makes the listeners curious about the woman who was coming from the wilderness. But no one was able to see her as she rode inside a carriage.

Who is this coming up from the wilderness: There are two main ways to interpret this question:

1. It means “who is this.” The word “this” is feminine and refers to the woman. For example:

Who is this young woman coming up from the wilderness... (GW) (BSB, NIV, GW, NCV, NET, NJPS, NLT, REB)

1. It means “what is that.” The word “that” probably refers to the litter (see 3:7a). For example:

What is that coming up from the wilderness... (RSV) (RSV, CEV, ESV, NAB, NASB, NJB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Who usually refers to a person. The Hebrew word used here is *miy* ‘who.’ If the meaning “what” were intended, the author would probably have used the word *mah* (‘what’). Also, in this verse the form of the word is feminine. It probably refers to the woman. The Hebrew word *zo t[0]* “this,” is feminine. But some scholars say that the feminine “this” refers to the grammatically feminine “litter” in 3:7a. And they say that the Hebrew *miy*, “who,” can sometimes be translated “what.” However, this same expression, Who is this also occurs in 6:10 where it clearly refers to the woman. In the Deuterocanonical book, 1 Maccabees 9:37–41, we find an account of a royal wedding procession escorting the bride, a picture very similar to what we find in Song of Songs 3:6–11. Here are the relevant portions of the passage: “After these things it was reported to Jonathan and Simon his brother, ‘The sons of Jambri are celebrating a great wedding, and are conducting the bride,

a daughter of one of the great nobles of Canaan, from Nadabath with a large escort’...They raised their eyes and looked, and saw a tumultuous procession with much baggage; and the bridegroom came out with his friends and his brothers to meet them with tambourines and musicians and many weapons. Then they [some enemies] rushed upon them from the ambush and began killing them....Thus their wedding was turned into mourning...” (RSV). Common elements with the Song of Songs account include the elaborate procession, the bride, the escort, and the groom waiting to welcome his bride upon her arrival. We can understand the importance of an armed escort, which in this case did not provide adequate protection. Keel also refers to this practice, which dates at least back to the 13th century B.C. in Egypt. He states, “Rameses II sent the army and the princes to accompany a daughter of the Hittite king to Egypt and to him for their wedding ceremony.” Exactly the same question is used in 8:5a, where it obviously refers to the woman.

Who is... coming up from the wilderness: This question probably implies that people were watching the procession as it came from the wilderness. When they saw the litter, they probably assumed that the bride was coming. In some languages it is necessary to indicate that the question refers to the woman. For example:

Who is she that comes up from the desert (NJPS)

Who do we see approaching from the desert

This question is probably rhetorical. In some languages it is more natural to translate this rhetorical question as a statement or exclamation. For example:

What a wonderful woman/bride this must be who is coming up from the wilderness!

Look! The bride is coming up from the wilderness!

coming up from the wilderness: Here the text implies that the woman was coming in a formal way with a group of people to honor her. It probably implies that they were coming toward Jerusalem. The city of Jerusalem was located high in the hill country, and many roads led to it. The procession probably came up from the lower wilderness country on the east side of Jerusalem.

Some other ways to translate the action are:

approaching from the wilderness

ascending out of the wilderness

coming toward us from the dry/uninhabited places

coming up: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as coming up indicates that the woman was coming to a place that was higher than the one she came from. Jerusalem was higher than the regions around it. However, the word does not indicate that she was climbing a high mountain. The elevation of Jerusalem is 2556 feet (779 meters). Use an appropriate word in your language.

wilderness: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as wilderness refers to a dry region where few people lived. The regions to the south and east of Jerusalem were wilderness like that. However, the land was not as dry as a true desert where very few plants grow and there are large areas of dry sand. Use a word or phrase that is natural in your language to describe such a wilderness region.

3:6b

like a column of smoke,

- She is hidden in a cloud of incense,
- Sweet-smelling smoke hides her like a cloud.

like a column of smoke: This phrase indicates that the woman's coming in procession was surrounded by something that looked like smoke from a distance. The phrase may describe a "cloud of dust," since land near Jerusalem is often dusty. But the poet implies that her coming was like a column (or cloud) of fragrant smoke. Duguid (Kindle edition, page 1475) says, "The word here for column (timara) is a rare form that specifically describes a pillar shaped like a palm tree (tamar). This provides another point of contact between the description of the person coming from the desert and the woman, whose stature is likened to a palm tree in 7:7-8." In some languages it is common to describe sweet-smelling perfume as being like a "cloud" of fragrance. Describe it in a natural way in your language.

Some ways to connect this phrase to the context are:

Who is this young woman coming up from the wilderness like clouds of smoke...She is perfumed... (GW)

Who is this coming up from the desert like a column of smoke, like a fragrant billow of myrrh and frankincense (NET)

column of smoke: In Hebrew, the word column is plural, but some versions translate it as singular, as in the BSB. The phrase column of smoke indicates that the dust of the procession looked like a tall, thick cloud of smoke. Use a natural way in your language to describe it.

3:6c

scented with myrrh and frankincense

- of sweet-smelling myrrh and frankincense
- It is better than the most expensive perfume

scented with myrrh and frankincense: The phrase scented with myrrh and frankincense refers to the woman. It indicates that her scent was pleasing. It implies that she wore perfume made of the spices called myrrh and frankincense, so her fragrance was delightful. Some ways to translate this meaning are:

She smells sweet/good with myrrh and incense...

Her scent is like the best spices...

there is the fragrance of sweet-smelling sap/perfume

myrrh: myrrh is a fragrant ointment that is made from the resin of a myrrh tree. Because of its pleasing scent, it was expensive and highly prized. For more information, see the note on "bag of myrrh" in 1:13a-b. The myrrh tree has long thorns and small leaves.

frankincense: frankincense is a kind of fragrant incense. This type of incense was associated with worship. It comes from the resin of a plant called "Boswellia sacra."

Some ways to translate it are:

sweet-smelling incense

fine/expensive incense

If frankincense is not known in your area, it may be helpful to use a more general term like "incense."

General Comment on 3:6b-c

The clauses in 3:6b and 3:6c are closely connected. Some ways to translate the clauses and their connection are:

Who is this young woman coming up from the wilderness like clouds of smoke...She is perfumed... (GW)

Who is this coming up from the desert like a column of smoke, like a fragrant billow of myrrh and frankincense (NET)

Who is this, coming up from the wilderness, like pillars of smoke? She is perfumed with myrrh and frankincense... (CEB)

3:6d

from all the spices of the merchant?

- and all the other wonderful/best spices imported by merchants.
- and the finest spices sold in the market.

from all the spices of the merchant: The meaning of the word *miḵkol*. “With all.” that the BSB translates as from all affects the relationship between 3:6c to 3:6d. There are two ways to interpret this relationship:

1. The phrase in 3:6d is parallel to 3:6c, and the two lines have similar meanings. The line in 3:6d tells more about the spices in 3:6b–c. For example:

fragrant with incense and myrrh, (GNT)

the incense sold by the traders (BSB, ESV, NASB, NET, NJPS, REB, RSV, GNT)

1. The line in 3:6d refers to other spices in addition to the two spices in 3:6c. For example:

Who is this that smells like myrrh, incense, and other spices? (NCV) (NAB, NCV, NJB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with a majority of scholars.

the spices of the merchant: The word spices refers to different types of sweet-smelling powder ground from spice plants. People in Israel bought these powders from a merchant (seller), who brought the powders from foreign places. Because the powders were rare and special, a woman seemed more mysterious and beautiful when she wore them.

Some other ways to translate the spices of the merchant are:

all the powdered spices that merchants bring (REB)

the ointments sold by traders

and other fragrant things that sellers bring from far away

spices: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as spices occurs only here in the OT. It refers to different types of sweet-smelling powder. People make these powders from sweet-smelling resins (sap from trees), rocks and other substances. They grind these resins very fine so that they become like powder. Some other ways to translate the Hebrew word are:

fragrant powders

rare/special ointments

Song of Solomon 3:7

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple’s wedding day. The section has several parts:

3:6–11 The man and woman came to their wedding in a grand procession

4:1–15 The man described his beautiful bride

4:16–5:1 The man and woman consummated their marriage

Paragraph 3:6–11 The poet described the wedding procession

There are several questions that translators need to ask about the meaning of 3:6–11:

1. What does the author imply when he refers to Solomon in the poem? The name “Solomon” refers figuratively to the man whom the woman loves. At a literal level 3:6–11 seems to be a historical description of Solomon on his wedding day. But which

wedding? He had numerous wives! It is more probable that Solomon was the author of the Song, but not one of the characters in it. (For more information about that, see the discussion in 1:1.) The Song describes a nearly ideal love relationship between one man and one woman in which neither of them had other lovers, and the man had no other wives. Yet Solomon was known for having many wives and for his spiritual failure (see 1 Kings 11:1–3). He was not known for his pure love. New Testament passages that mention Solomon refer to his wisdom (Luke 11:31) and his material splendor (Luke 12:27), but not to his love. Solomon's personal life did not demonstrate the pure monogamous love that we see in the woman's beloved. If Solomon did write the book, he did so as Israel's greatest wise man, not as Israel's ideal lover. References to Solomon in the Song seem to focus on his royal splendor, rather than on Solomon himself or his love. This is certainly true in 1:5 that speaks of the curtains of Solomon. It implies that on his wedding day, the man felt as happy, rich, and powerful as King Solomon. Other verses that refer to Solomon figuratively are 1:4–5; 1:12; 3:6–11; 6:12; and 7:1. The Song uses other figurative motifs, such as a “shepherd” (1:7–8; 6:2–3), gazelle (2:8–9; 2:16–17; 8:14), dove (1:15; 2:14; 4:1; 5:12), lily (2:2; 2:16), vineyard (1:6; 2:15; 8:11–12) mare (1:9–11) and garden (4:12–5:1; 6:2).

2. Who speaks in this section? Probably the author speaks. If the woman was in the procession, she probably did not describe herself. Some scholars give other suggestions for the speaker here, for example, the man, the daughters of Jerusalem, a chorus, or an unknown speaker.
3. Does this poem describe an event that really happened? The poem probably does not describe an event that really happened. It uses figurative language, including hyperbole and similes. Bloch and Bloch make a strong point here. Referring to the three passages using this opening formula, “Who is this (fem)...?” (Song 3:6, 6:10, 8:5), they state, “None of these three scenes is realistic; all are hyperboles, evoking images of the triumphant appearance of a majestic, numinous, even godlike figure.” The rhetorical question here calls attention to the radiant and majestic bride's approach. Bergant understands this poem in 3:6–11 as a metaphorical characterization rather than a description of an actual event. The UBS Handbook leans toward the poetic, non-historical view, as do Munro, Garrett, Gledhill, Keel, and others. The poem begins, “Who is this woman coming up from the wilderness like a column of smoke...?” It probably implies that she was surrounded by the smoke of fragrant incense.

Like a queen, the woman also had soldiers around her to protect and honor her. The woman was carried in luxury to the man, who waited for her in Jerusalem. He was compared to the greatest of kings. This hyperbole may come from a marriage custom where the bride and groom wore royal crowns on their wedding day.

3:7–10

In 3:7–10 the author responded to the rhetorical question in 3:6 (“Who is this...”). People asked that question about the woman and the people coming with her. However, the response in 3:7 does not really answer that question. Instead, it describes the procession. It tells about the guards that surrounded the litter (3:7b–8d) and about how the litter was made (3:9–10).

It may seem strange that the author did not mention the woman again in 3:7–10. However, the way he described the litter and her guards shows that the woman was worthy of royal honor. The author seems to hide her from readers by not describing her until 4:1. She wore a veil, and it was also difficult to see her inside the litter. This mystery makes the woman seem even more interesting.

3:7a

Behold, it is Solomon's carriage,

- Look, it is Solomon's wedding couch that they are carrying!
- That is King Solomon's royal seat/palanquin that she is lying/sitting on!

Behold, it is Solomon's carriage: Scholars interpret this clause in different ways. There are two main views about who is riding in Solomon's carriage:

1. The woman was riding in the litter that her beloved Solomon sent. For example:

Look! She is riding in Solomon's wedding litter!
This translation was suggested by OT scholar David Dorsey (personal correspondence, April 20, 2006).

1. The woman's beloved (who is called Solomon here as a praise name) was riding in his litter. For example:

Look! It is Solomon carried in his state litter...
(REB) (BSB, CEV, REB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Another view is that the author did not describe a procession here. He described Solomon's bed in his wedding chamber. For example, Michael

Fox (page 120) translates this as “Look! Solomon’s own couch.” Although no English version makes this interpretation explicit, it is supported by many commentaries. Commentaries supporting this interpretation include Barbiero, Bergant, Carr, Delitzsch, Dorsey, Elliott, Garrett, Goulder, Hess, Keel, Mitchell, NJB (note c), Pope. The commentaries represent about half of the commentaries consulted. It fits the context of 3:6–11 and helps readers understand the poem as a whole. Here the name Solomon is probably used to refer to the woman’s beloved.

Behold: The word Behold means “Look!” Here it indicates that the speaker wanted people to pay attention to what was coming from the wilderness. The bride was coming in Solomon’s litter. In this context the word “Look!” probably indicates excitement. In many languages there are special words or phrases to communicate such excitement. Other ways to translate it in English are:

Look (NRSV)

Oh look over there!

Do you see that? It is...

it is Solomon’s carriage: This clause continues to describe the wedding procession, as in 3:6. In this context the author implies that the man sent his own litter and an armed guard to carry the woman from her family home to her new home in Jerusalem. They had to travel through dangerous areas, so he sent soldiers to guard her.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

There is the palanquin that Solomon sent

King Solomon’s litter is coming!

carriage: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as carriage is a general word for “bed.” However, here people carried it in a wedding procession. Use a word in your language that describes a type of bed or couch that can be carried. In this context it may have had curtains around it so that people could not see the bride.

The author refers to the bride only indirectly here. But the elaborate way that the author described the procession and litter (3:6–10) implies that she was magnificent. The carriage was appropriate for a queen

to ride in. Some other ways to translate this meaning of carriage are:

litter

couch

royal seat

Solomon’s: Here the name Solomon is used as a praise name for the woman’s beloved. The word Solomon’s indicates that the litter belonged to her beloved. The context implies that he sent the litter for the woman to ride in as she came to him.

3:7b

escorted by sixty

- Sixty strong men are walking beside it as guards/escorts for her.
- Around the royal seat/carriage, there are sixty skilled fighters to guard her.

3:7b–c

escorted by sixty of the mightiest men: This clause indicates that sixty strong men were around the carriage on all sides. They surrounded it to protect the woman inside it. They prevented anyone from getting close to her, and they made sure that no one was able to harm her.

Only kings, queens, and their relatives or very rich people were able to pay for so many soldiers to escort them. A more common number of people in an escort, even for royalty, was probably about 30. See 2 Samuel 23:18–19, 23. When the man provided such a large escort for his bride, it emphasized how much he esteemed her. It caused all the people who saw her to know her great status.

Some other ways to translate the clause escorted by sixty of the mightiest men are:

Sixty soldiers are escorting it

Sixty strong men are all around it

sixty of the mightiest men: The sixty of the mightiest men were an elite guard of trained soldiers. It was unusual to have such a large number of guards to escort a person to Jerusalem. The large number of guards emphasizes the security and protection that the man gave his bride. Other ways to translate sixty of the mightiest men here are:

sixty strong guards

sixty warriors (NJPS)

sixty soldiers (GW)

3:7c

of the mightiest men of Israel.

- They are the best of Israel's soldiers.
- They are some of Israel's strongest soldiers,

of the mightiest men of Israel: The phrase of the mightiest men of Israel indicates that the sixty men were chosen from among the best soldiers of Israel. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

of Israel's best soldiers (CEV)

the finest soldiers in Israel (GNT)

some of Israel's mightiest warriors. (NET)

and braver than any other in Israel.

Song of Solomon 3:8

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple's wedding day. The section has several parts:

3:6–11 The man and woman came to their wedding in a grand procession

4:1–15 The man described his beautiful bride

4:16–5:1 The man and woman consummated their marriage

Paragraph 3:6–11 The poet described the wedding procession

There are several questions that translators need to ask about the meaning of 3:6–11:

1. What does the author imply when he refers to Solomon in the poem? The name "Solomon" refers figuratively to the man whom the woman loves. At a literal level 3:6–11 seems to be a historical description of Solomon on his wedding day. But which wedding? He had numerous wives! It is more probable that Solomon was the author of the Song, but not one of the characters in it. (For more information about that, see the discussion in 1:1.) The Song describes a nearly ideal love relationship between one man and one woman in which neither of them had other lovers, and the man had no other wives. Yet Solomon was known for having many wives and for his spiritual failure (see 1 Kings 11:1–3). He was not known for his pure love. New Testament passages that mention Solomon refer to his wisdom (Luke 11:31) and his material splendor (Luke 12:27), but not to his love. Solomon's personal life did not demonstrate the pure monogamous love that we see in the woman's beloved. If Solomon did write the book, he did so as Israel's greatest wise man, not as Israel's ideal lover. References to Solomon in the Song seem to focus on his royal splendor, rather than on Solomon himself or his love. This is certainly true in 1:5 that speaks of the curtains of Solomon. It implies that on his wedding day, the man felt as happy, rich, and powerful as King Solomon. Other verses that refer to Solomon figuratively are 1:4–5; 1:12; 3:6–11; 6:12; and 7:1. The Song uses other figurative motifs, such as a "shepherd" (1:7–8; 6:2–3), gazelle (2:8–9; 2:16–17; 8:14), dove (1:15; 2:14; 4:1; 5:12), lily (2:2; 2:16), vineyard (1:6; 2:15; 8:11–12) mare (1:9–11) and garden (4:12–5:1; 6:2).
2. Who speaks in this section? Probably the author speaks. If the woman was in the procession, she probably did not describe herself. Some scholars give other suggestions for the speaker here, for example, the man, the daughters of Jerusalem, a chorus, or an unknown speaker.
3. Does this poem describe an event that really happened? The poem probably does not describe an event that really happened. It uses figurative language, including hyperbole and similes. Bloch and Bloch make a strong point here. Referring to the three passages using this opening formula, "Who is this (fem)..." (Song 3:6, 6:10, 8:5), they state, "None of these three scenes is realistic; all are hyperboles, evoking images of the triumphant appearance of a majestic, numinous, even godlike figure." The rhetorical question here calls attention to the radiant and majestic bride's approach. Bergant understands this poem in 3:6–11 as a metaphorical characterization rather than a description of an actual event. The UBS Handbook leans toward the

poetic, non-historical view, as do Munro, Garrett, Gledhill, Keel, and others. The poem begins, “Who is this woman coming up from the wilderness like a column of smoke...?” It probably implies that she was surrounded by the smoke of fragrant incense. Like a queen, the woman also had soldiers around her to protect and honor her. The woman was carried in luxury to the man, who waited for her in Jerusalem. He was compared to the greatest of kings. This hyperbole may come from a marriage custom where the bride and groom wore royal crowns on their wedding day.

3:8a

All are skilled with the sword,

- They are all skilled in fighting with a sword,
- and all of them are experts in fighting with long, sharp knives.

All are skilled with the sword: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as All are skilled with the sword is literally, “all of them are grasped by a sword.” The exact meaning of this statement is uncertain. There are two main ways to interpret it:

1. It means that the men were skilled in using a sword. For example:

All of them skilled swordsmen... (REB) (BSB, GW, NAB, NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB, GNT)

1. It means that each man had a sword with him. For example:

all equipped with swords... (NRSV) (NRSV, CEV, ESV, NASB, NCV, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It fits the parallelism, and it is also supported by the parallel passive verbs in 3:8a and 3:8b (“are grasped”). This use of “grasped” is probably a figurative expression meaning “experienced” that is common in other ancient languages, Akkadian and Ugaritic, which are related to Hebrew. and “are trained”). Both verbs describe well-trained soldiers. The word sword is probably a metonymy referring to war. One way to translate the parallelism Option 2 may also be acceptable. Here 3:8a would be parallel with 3:8c, and 3:8b would be parallel with 3:8d. This is a type a-b-a'-b' parallel structure. One way to translate this structure is: 8a All of them carry a sword; (a)b They are all trained in war (b)8c Each one has a sword ready for use, (a')d prepared to battle the terrors of night. (b'). is:

8a All of them are skilled with the sword;

8b all of them are trained in war.

skilled with the sword: This clause indicates that all the men who guarded the bride were well trained in fighting with a sword. A sword is a long knife that is used as a weapon. A person usually needed to be trained to use a sword well. Other ways to translate this clause are:

Each of them is well trained in fighting with long knives.

All of them are skilled with a sword (NET)

3:8b

experienced in warfare.

- and they are all experienced in warfare.
- They are well-trained warriors/fighters,

experienced in warfare: The phrase experienced in warfare means “well-trained in battle.” It indicates that the men had been taught the skills that they needed to be good fighters. It also indicates that they were experienced soldiers who had fought in battles. Other ways to translate this phrase are:

trained in combat

experienced soldiers/fighters

3:8c

Each has his sword at his side

- Each one has his sword ready at his thigh,
- and each man is ready to use his long knife

Each has his sword at his side: In 3:8c the author continued to describe the same group of soldiers whom he described in 3:8a-b. Each of these well-trained soldiers had a sword. The phrase at his side indicates that the sword was easy for him to reach and use. It was right beside him whenever he needed it. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

each of them has his sword right at his thigh

each one has his sword ready

3:8d

prepared for the terror of the night.

- to fight against dangers that may come at night.
- to fight for her against enemies who attack at night.

prepared for the terror of the night: The phrase, the terror of the night, probably refers to any physical danger that might occur at night. These dangers included anything that could harm the woman or the people who were traveling with her in the procession to Jerusalem.

The procession probably needed more than one day to travel to Jerusalem, so the travelers had to set up camp at night and sleep there. It was dangerous to travel at night. Armed robbers often watched the roads to attack the people who passed by in the darkness.

In some languages it is necessary to make this danger more explicit. For example:

they are ready for anyone who might attack them at night.

they are prepared to defend her against anyone/ anything who tries to harm her during the night.

Each of them is prepared to fight against any danger that threatens her in the dark night.

The theme of protection against harm was also found in 2:15 where foxes tried to damage the love between the man and woman.

Song of Solomon 3:9

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple's wedding day. The section has several parts:

3:6–11 The man and woman came to their wedding in a grand procession

4:1–15 The man described his beautiful bride

4:16–5:1 The man and woman consummated their marriage

Paragraph 3:6–11 The poet described the wedding procession

There are several questions that translators need to ask about the meaning of 3:6–11:

1. What does the author imply when he refers to Solomon in the poem? The name "Solomon" refers figuratively to the man whom the woman loves. At a literal level 3:6–11 seems to be a historical description of Solomon on his wedding day. But which wedding? He had numerous wives! It is more probable that Solomon was the author of the Song, but not one of the characters in it. (For more information about that, see the discussion in 1:1.) The Song describes a nearly ideal love relationship between one man and one woman in which neither of them had other lovers, and the man had no other wives. Yet Solomon was known for having many wives and for his spiritual failure (see 1 Kings 11:1–3). He was not known for his pure love. New Testament passages that mention Solomon refer to his wisdom (Luke 11:31) and his material splendor (Luke 12:27), but not to his love. Solomon's personal life did not demonstrate the pure monogamous love that we see in the woman's beloved. If Solomon did write the book, he did so as Israel's greatest wise man, not as Israel's ideal lover. References to Solomon in the Song seem to focus on his royal splendor, rather than on Solomon himself or his love. This is certainly true in 1:5 that speaks of the curtains of Solomon. It implies that on his wedding day, the man felt as happy, rich, and powerful as King Solomon. Other verses that refer to Solomon figuratively are 1:4–5; 1:12; 3:6–11; 6:12; and 7:1. The Song uses other figurative motifs, such as a "shepherd" (1:7–8; 6:2–3), gazelle (2:8–9; 2:16–17; 8:14), dove (1:15; 2:14; 4:1; 5:12), lily (2:2; 2:16), vineyard (1:6; 2:15; 8:11–12) mare (1:9–11) and garden (4:12–5:1; 6:2).
2. Who speaks in this section? Probably the author speaks. If the woman was in the procession, she probably did not describe herself. Some scholars give other suggestions for the speaker here, for example, the man, the daughters of Jerusalem, a chorus, or an unknown speaker.
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rhetoical question here calls attention to the radiant and majestic bride's approach. Bergant understands this poem in 3:6–11 as a metaphorical characterization rather than a description of an actual event. The UBS Handbook leans toward the poetic, non-historical view, as do Munro, Garrett, Gledhill, Keel, and others. The poem begins, "Who is this woman coming up from the wilderness like a column of smoke..." It probably implies that she was surrounded by the smoke of fragrant incense. Like a queen, the woman also had soldiers around her to protect and honor her. The woman was carried in luxury to the man, who waited for her in Jerusalem. He was compared to the greatest of kings. This hyperbole may come from a marriage custom where the bride and groom wore royal crowns on their wedding day.

3:9–10

In 3:9–10 the author describes Solomon's carriage (litter, couch). Some of the Hebrew words in 3:9–10 are rare, and their meanings are uncertain. There are several ways to interpret these verses. However, the main point of this description is the excellent quality of the materials used to build the carriage. The overall purpose is to emphasize the magnificence of the bride.

3:9a

King Solomon has made his carriage

- King Solomon made a wedding couch for himself
- King Solomon caused/had a wedding litter to be made to carry his bride.

King Solomon has made his carriage: This clause probably implies that King Solomon hired craftsmen to make a carriage for him. It probably does not indicate that King Solomon himself made it. The context seems to imply that he intended to send the carriage for his bride so that she could travel in it to Jerusalem for their wedding.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as carriage is different from the Hebrew word for "carriage" in 3:7. The Notes interprets the two words to refer to the same couch. Some other ways to translate it here are:

King Solomon caused a portable couch to be made for him.

King Solomon made himself a palanquin (RSV)

In some languages a word like carriage may imply a vehicle with wheels, and the couch here did not have wheels. Men carried it on their shoulders. Use an appropriate word in your language to describe it.

For more information, see the note on carriage later in this verse.

King Solomon: In this context King Solomon is probably a symbol for the man who is about to be married. For more information about the author's use of King Solomon as a poetic symbol, see the section on Solomon in the introduction to 3:6–11. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate in some way that the name King Solomon is used figuratively here to refer to the woman's beloved. For example:

her beloved "King Solomon"

carriage: The word in Hebrew, *appiryon*, (translated carriage in the BSB) only occurs here in the entire OT. There is debate about its meaning and origin. Some scholars consider it a loan word from Greek, Sanskrit or Persian. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as carriage occurs only here in the OT. It probably refers to the same couch that the author mentioned in 3:7. In that verse he used a more general word that can refer to any kind of bed or couch. Here in 3:9 the word is more specific. It refers to a bed or chair that was carried on poles by several strong men. Such a carriage is also called a "litter," "sedan chair," or "palanquin."

In this context the couch probably had a small roof and curtains. It is likely that the curtains could be closed to hide the woman as she rode in it. It may have had small walls that could hide her when she lay down. When she was seated with the curtains open, people could see her.

Some ways to translate carriage (3:9a) and "carriage" (3:7a) are:

- Use the same word in your language to translate carriage (3:9a) and "carriage" (3:7a). For example, the NIV uses "carriage" in both 3:7 and 3:9:

It is Solomon's carriage... (3:7)

King Solomon made for himself the carriage... (3:9)

- Use two different words in your language to translate carriage (3:9a) and "carriage" (3:7a). The word that you use in 3:7 can be more general than the one in 3:9. For example, the GW has:

sedan chair (3:7)

carriage (3:9)

Translate these words in a clear way in your language.

3:9b

out of the timber of Lebanon.

- with lumber from Lebanon.
- It was made of the finest cedar wood, which comes from the forests of Lebanon.

out of the timber of Lebanon: The wood that was used to build the palanquin came from the region called Lebanon. Lebanon was famous for its fine cedar trees, and cedar wood from Lebanon was of high quality. So the author implied here that the carriage was made of the best wood available. This wood was used for the frame of the carriage and its base.

Some other ways to translate the phrase out of the timber of Lebanon are:

is made of trees from Lebanon (CEV)

made of wood imported from the country/region of Lebanon

made of the finest wood (GNT)

Lebanon: Lebanon was a mountainous region north of Israel. It was well known for its cedar forests.

Song of Solomon 3:10

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

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Paragraph 3:6–11 The poet described the wedding procession

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1. What does the author imply when he refers to Solomon in the poem? The name “Solomon” refers figuratively to the man whom the woman loves. At a literal level 3:6–11 seems to be a historical description of Solomon on his wedding day. But which wedding? He had numerous wives! It is more probable that Solomon was the author of the Song, but not one of the characters in it. (For more information about that, see the discussion in 1:1.) The Song describes a nearly ideal love relationship between one man and one woman in which neither of them had other lovers, and the man had no other wives. Yet Solomon was known for having many wives and for his spiritual failure (see 1 Kings 11:1–3). He was not known for his pure love. New Testament passages that mention Solomon refer to his wisdom (Luke 11:31) and his material splendor (Luke 12:27), but not to his love. Solomon's personal life did not demonstrate the pure monogamous love that we see in the woman's beloved. If Solomon did write the book, he did so as Israel's greatest wise man, not as Israel's ideal lover. References to Solomon in the Song seem to focus on his royal splendor, rather than on Solomon himself or his love. This is certainly true in 1:5 that speaks of the curtains of Solomon. It implies that on his wedding day, the man felt as happy, rich, and powerful as King Solomon. Other verses that refer to Solomon figuratively are 1:4–5; 1:12; 3:6–11; 6:12; and 7:1. The Song uses other figurative motifs, such as a “shepherd” (1:7–8; 6:2–3), gazelle (2:8–9; 2:16–17; 8:14), dove (1:15; 2:14; 4:1; 5:12), lily (2:2; 2:16), vineyard (1:6; 2:15; 8:11–12) mare (1:9–11) and garden (4:12–5:1; 6:2).
2. Who speaks in this section? Probably the author speaks. If the woman was in the procession, she probably did not describe herself. Some scholars give other suggestions for the speaker here, for example, the man, the daughters of Jerusalem, a chorus, or an unknown speaker.
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rhetoical question here calls attention to the radiant and majestic bride's approach. Bergant understands this poem in 3:6–11 as a metaphorical characterization rather than a description of an actual event. The UBS Handbook leans toward the poetic, non-historical view, as do Munro, Garrett, Gledhill, Keel, and others. The poem begins, "Who is this woman coming up from the wilderness like a column of smoke...?" It probably implies that she was surrounded by the smoke of fragrant incense. Like a queen, the woman also had soldiers around her to protect and honor her. The woman was carried in luxury to the man, who waited for her in Jerusalem. He was compared to the greatest of kings. This hyperbole may come from a marriage custom where the bride and groom wore royal crowns on their wedding day.

3:10a

He has made its posts of silver,

- He overlaid its posts with silver,
- Its support posts he covered with silver,

He has made its posts of silver: The phrase He has made probably implies that Solomon (the woman's beloved) hired someone to make the silver posts. It probably does not indicate that Solomon himself made them. (In 3:10d–e, the Jerusalem women helped to make the interior of the carriage.) Some ways to indicate this are:

He had its posts made out of silver (GW)

Its posts were made of silver (NET)

posts of silver: The palanquin had four posts, one at each of its four corners. These four posts supported the roof (canopy) of the carriage. The posts were of silver. This phrase probably implies that the posts were made of wood that was overlaid with silver. For example:

He overlaid its posts with silver

Its posts are covered with silver (GNT)

3:10b

its base of gold,

- the back of the seat he covered with gold,
- its canopy he made of gold,

its base of gold: The phrase its base of gold indicates that the base of the carriage was made of gold or

gold cloth. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as base occurs only here in the OT, and its meaning is uncertain. There are three ways to interpret it here:

1. It means "the back of (a) chair," as in the ancient Greek and Latin versions. The Septuagint and Vulgate. For example:

its back was made of gold. (NET) (RSV, CEV, ESV, NASB, NET, NJPS, REB)

1. It means "cover," as in the ancient Syriac version. I.e., the Peshitta version. For example:

the canopy of gold (NJB) (GW, NAB, NJB, NLT, GNT)

1. It means "base" or "foundation." For example:

its base of gold. (NIV) (BSB, NCV, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) or (2). The exact meaning is uncertain, but both interpretations make good sense. The main point is the luxurious nature of the materials used.

of gold: The phrase of gold tells what the back of the palanquin was made of. Gold was the most valuable of all metals. Some scholars suggest that fabric made of gold thread was used. This material was sometimes used by kings, queens, and other members of their families. Psalm 45 referred to "gold-woven robes" (RSV). The poetic description of the palanquin implies that it was magnificent. Other ways to translate 3:10b are:

the back is gold (CEV)

he made its base of gold.

3:10c

its seat of purple fabric.

- and he made the seat cushion of purple fabric.
- he covered its cushion with expensive/beautiful purple cloth.

its seat of purple fabric: Here the author continues to describe the palanquin and how it was made. The phrase its seat refers to the chair or to the cushion (or cushions) inside the palanquin where the rider sat. The phrase of purple fabric indicates that the seat was made of purple cloth. Purple cloth was expensive, and it was often worn by kings. It was also used in the Temple and in the king's palace.

If this information about purple cloth is not known in your area, it may be helpful to make it explicit in some way. For example:

Its cushions were covered with rare purple cloth.

The seat was made of expensive purple fabric.

In some languages the color purple is not known or implies a wrong meaning, such as mourning or danger. If that is true in your language, you may translate the meaning without mentioning the color. For example:

The seat cushions were covered with expensive cloth.

The cloth of its cushion was dyed with the color that kings wear.

3:10d

Its interior is inlaid with love by the daughters of Jerusalem.

- Its interior was lovingly arranged by the women of Jerusalem.
- The women in Jerusalem decorated its interior with loving care.

Its interior is inlaid with love by the daughters of Jerusalem: Scholars are uncertain about whether the phrase daughters of Jerusalem is connected with 3:10d or with 3:11a-b. The Notes connects the phrase with 3:10d and gives details later in 3:10d.

There are two main ways to interpret the phrase inlaid with love: The meaning of the Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as inlaid is uncertain. It may mean “inlaid,” “decorated” or “woven.” The meaning of the Hebrew noun that the BSB translates as with love is also uncertain here. The two possible meanings are “love” and “leather.” Some scholars interpret this as a double meaning or word play. In other words, it means both “leather” and “love.” The word “love” might be used adverbially as manner, i.e., “lovingly,” or it might be a synecdoche where “love,” which decks out the interior, stands for the beloved. But this would be difficult to express in the translation.

1. It describes the manner in which the palanquin’s interior was decorated. It was done lovingly and carefully. For example:

its interior lovingly inlaid (NIV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJPS, NLT, RSV, GNT)

1. It describes the material that was used to decorate the interior. Several options have been suggested by scholars and versions for this material. Leather seems most likely, but some versions also translate this as “ivory,” “ebony” or “scenes of love.” For example:

fitted out with leather (NET) (NAB, NET, NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This option has the most support from English versions. The manner, “lovingly,” is an appropriate way to interpret the Hebrew word used about the women’s actions, since the Song is poetry about love. It is also possible that there is a double meaning here, “loving” and “leather,” but this would be difficult to express artistically in a translation. Some other ways to translate this interpretation are:

The women in Jerusalem carefully decorated its interior because of their love for the bride and groom.

The beautiful weavings inside the palanquin were lovingly made by the women of Jerusalem.

by the daughters of Jerusalem: Scholars differ about whether this phrase should be part of 3:10 or part of 3:11:

1. It is part of 3:10. It tells who decorated the inside of the palanquin. For example:

its interior was inlaid with love by the daughters of Jerusalem. (ESV) (BSB, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NLT, RSV, GNT, CEV)

1. It is part of 3:11. It is a direct address to the daughters of Jerusalem. This arrangement makes it part of a parallel chiasm (a-b-b'-a') with the following phrase. For example, the NRSV says:

Daughters of Jerusalem, come out. (a-b)

Look, O daughters of Zion... (b'-a') (NIV11, NRSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English versions and many Bible scholars. It is probably best to interpret the Hebrew prefix m- attached to daughters as the agent marker. In 3:10a-c Solomon is the agent. But in 3:10d the pas-

sive verb, “is inlaid,” seems to introduce a new agent, the daughters of Jerusalem (3:10e). This use of the preposition m- (or min) with a passive verb commonly marks agent. Another way to translate this meaning is:

^{10a-c}He made its posts of silver, its back of gold, and its seat of purple cloth, ^{10d}and the daughters of Jerusalem decorated its interior with loving care.

General Comment on 3:10

It is difficult to know exactly what the carriage looked like from the description in 3:10, because the meanings of several of the words are uncertain. However, it is certain that the carriage was made of the finest materials: cedar from Lebanon, silver, gold, and purple cloth. The women of Jerusalem decorated its interior with loving care. It was a beautiful, luxurious vehicle for bringing the bride to her waiting groom.

Song of Solomon 3:11

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple’s wedding day. The section has several parts:

3:6–11 The man and woman came to their wedding in a grand procession

4:1–15 The man described his beautiful bride

4:16–5:1 The man and woman consummated their marriage

Paragraph 3:6–11 The poet described the wedding procession

There are several questions that translators need to ask about the meaning of 3:6–11:

1. What does the author imply when he refers to Solomon in the poem? The name “Solomon” refers figuratively to the man whom the woman loves. At a literal level 3:6–11 seems to be a historical description of Solomon on his wedding day. But which wedding? He had numerous wives! It is more prob-

able that Solomon was the author of the Song, but not one of the characters in it. (For more information about that, see the discussion in 1:1.) The Song describes a nearly ideal love relationship between one man and one woman in which neither of them had other lovers, and the man had no other wives. Yet Solomon was known for having many wives and for his spiritual failure (see 1 Kings 11:1–3). He was not known for his pure love. New Testament passages that mention Solomon refer to his wisdom (Luke 11:31) and his material splendor (Luke 12:27), but not to his love. Solomon’s personal life did not demonstrate the pure monogamous love that we see in the woman’s beloved. If Solomon did write the book, he did so as Israel’s greatest wise man, not as Israel’s ideal lover. References to Solomon in the Song seem to focus on his royal splendor, rather than on Solomon himself or his love. This is certainly true in 1:5 that speaks of the curtains of Solomon. It implies that on his wedding day, the man felt as happy, rich, and powerful as King Solomon. Other verses that refer to Solomon figuratively are 1:4–5; 1:12; 3:6–11; 6:12; and 7:1. The Song uses other figurative motifs, such as a “shepherd” (1:7–8; 6:2–3), gazelle (2:8–9; 2:16–17; 8:14), dove (1:15; 2:14; 4:1; 5:12), lily (2:2; 2:16), vineyard (1:6; 2:15; 8:11–12) mare (1:9–11) and garden (4:12–5:1; 6:2).

2. Who speaks in this section? Probably the author speaks. If the woman was in the procession, she probably did not describe herself. Some scholars give other suggestions for the speaker here, for example, the man, the daughters of Jerusalem, a chorus, or an unknown speaker.
3. Does this poem describe an event that really happened? The poem probably does not describe an event that really happened. It uses figurative language, including hyperbole and similes. Bloch and Bloch make a strong point here. Referring to the three passages using this opening formula, “Who is this (fem)...?” (Song 3:6, 6:10, 8:5), they state, “None of these three scenes is realistic; all are hyperboles, evoking images of the triumphant appearance of a majestic, numinous, even godlike figure.” The rhetorical question here calls attention to the radiant and majestic bride’s approach. Bergant understands this poem in 3:6–11 as a metaphorical characterization rather than a description of an actual event. The UBS Handbook leans toward the poetic, non-historical view, as do Munro, Garrett, Gledhill, Keel, and others. The poem begins, “Who is this woman coming up from the wilderness like a column of smoke...?” It probably implies that she was surrounded by the smoke of fragrant incense. Like a queen, the woman also had soldiers around

her to protect and honor her. The woman was carried in luxury to the man, who waited for her in Jerusalem. He was compared to the greatest of kings. This hyperbole may come from a marriage custom where the bride and groom wore royal crowns on their wedding day.

3:11

It is recommended that you imagine 3:11 in the following way: The man was waiting in Jerusalem for his bride to arrive in the royal wedding procession. She was coming in a luxurious carriage, which was surrounded by many armed guards. The young women of Jerusalem were called to come and join the king and participate in the wedding celebration.

3:11a

Come out, O daughters of Zion,

- Come outside, women of Zion,
- Women of Zion, come out

Come out, O daughters of Zion: Here an unknown person, possibly the author, spoke to the women of Zion. In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of phrases in 3:11a. For example:

Women of Zion, come... (GNT)

Young women of Zion, come out (GW)

Come out: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Come out means “go out” or “come out.” In many languages the choice of verb depends on the location of the speaker. In this verse, the author did not reveal the speaker’s location. However, he invites the young women to be outside where the wedding celebration will happen. Some ways to translate this invitation are:

come (CEV)

go out (NCV)

Translate the invitation in a clear way in your language.

daughters of Zion: The phrase, daughters of Zion, has the same meaning as daughters of Jerusalem in 3:10. Both phrases refer to the same group of young women. Zion is the name of a specific part of Jerusalem where the temple and royal palace were located. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

You women who live on Zion’s mountain

You women in Zion

3:11b

and gaze at King Solomon, wearing the crown

- and see King Solomon wearing the crown
- and behold on King Solomon wearing the wedding wreath

and gaze at King Solomon: In Hebrew this clause is more literally, “and see the king Solomon.” In this context the phrase King Solomon refers to the man who is about to be married. Some other ways to translate this invitation :

Go out and behold “King Solomon.”

Come gaze at the groom, as splendid as King Solomon!

In some languages there is a figure of speech to describe the way someone gazes at a beautiful or unusual sight. For example:

feast your eyes on King Solomon

drink in the glory/splendor of this “King Solomon”

King Solomon: Here King Solomon is a symbol of royal majesty. The author implied that the man on his wedding day was as majestic and splendid as King Solomon. King Solomon himself is not a character in the story.

3:11c

his mother bestowed

- that his mother gave him
- that his mother placed on his head

3:11d

on the day of his wedding—

- on his wedding day,
- on the day when he was married,
- on the day when he married his bride.

3:11b–d

wearing the crown his mother bestowed on the day of his wedding: There are two ways to interpret the custom of crowning that is mentioned here:

1. It was a wedding custom. The mother of the groom put a wreath made of vines or flowers on her son’s head to honor him at his wedding.
2. It was a custom at the ceremony when a new king began to reign. He was crowned with an expensive

royal crown, which was often made of gold and adorned with precious jewels.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The wedding is mentioned, not the crowning of a king. See 1 Kings 1:32–48 for an account of Solomon's coronation as king. For a detailed description of coronations see de Vaux, pages 102–107. This fits the context of the Song. In the Song, Solomon is not an actor. He is a symbol of power and splendor.

the crown...bestowed: The crown in this context was probably a wreath that was woven of flowers and greenery. It was a symbol that the man to be married is powerful and majestic like a king. Some scholars mention that this feeling of majesty is common for a man when he marries the woman he loves. The verb that the BSB translates as bestowed means “put a crown on his head.” Other ways to translate the action here are:

Wearing the crown that his mother gave him... (NJPS)

wearing the crown that his mother placed on his head... (GNT)

with the crown with which his mother crowned him (RSV)

In some languages it may be helpful to include a footnote to explain the custom of wearing a wedding crown or wreath. For example:

In that culture it was customary for a man's mother to put a crown or wreath on his head to honor him at his wedding.

Some other ways to translate the word crown in this context are:

crown/wreath for the wedding

the decorated wedding hat

his mother bestowed on the day of his wedding: This phrase refers to a wedding custom in that culture. The mother put a crown or wreath on her son's head to honor him at his wedding. In some cultures men do not wear crowns or wreaths, so that custom may imply a wrong meaning. Some other options for translation are:

- Refer to a gift that a mother gives a son at his wedding. For example:

with the special gift/clothing that his mother gave him to honor him on his marriage

- Use a more general expression. For example:

how his mother honored him on his wedding day.

on the day of his wedding: This is the only verse in the Song of Songs where the word wedding occurs. Because the word wedding is not mentioned anywhere else in the Song, some scholars doubt that this passage is really about a wedding. However, the whole section (3:6–5:1) should probably be understood as the wedding celebration. In 3:6–11 the text implies in several ways that it describes a wedding procession. Then in chapters 4–5 the man often referred to the woman as “my bride” (4:8, 9, 10, 11, 12; 5:1). Some scholars classify this as an “epithalamium,” a special wedding poem that was recited or sung at weddings.

Cultures have different wedding customs. In some cultures there is more than one public ceremony that a couple can consider as their wedding. In other cultures there is no public ceremony when a couple marries. If that is true in your culture, you may need to use a descriptive phrase. For example:

on the day when they celebrated/began their marriage

on their wedding day

on the day when they married

3:11e the day of his heart's rejoicing.

- on the day when his heart rejoiced.
- That was the day when his joy was complete.

the day of his heart's rejoicing: This phrase is parallel to 3:11d. Both 3:11d and 3:11e refer to the same day and event, but the phrase here in 3:11e adds a comment about the groom's joy on that day (his wedding day). In some languages it is more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

On that day he was filled with joy.

That was the happiest day of his life.

his heart's rejoicing: The phrase his heart's rejoicing is an idiom that describes great joy. The phrase his heart's rejoicing emphasizes that the man's joy was strong and fervent. This is the only reference to rejoicing in the Song, but it is important because it comes at a climax in the book. It indicates that the man was happy and excited that he was marrying his beloved.

The bridal procession arrived! The author implied that the bride was beautiful and mysterious. Until she arrived, she was veiled by the curtains of the palanquin. When she arrived, the man was excited and joyful, and he showed that joy as he described her in chapter 4. In some languages there may be a figure of speech to describe this joy. For example:

the day when his joy overflowed

Some other ways to translate his heart's rejoicing are:

his...joyful delight (GW)

his most joyous day (NLT)

Describe his joy in a natural way in your language.

General Comment on 3:6–11

The author used hyperbole as he described the wedding procession in 3:6–11. Solomon himself was mentioned as part of the royal imagery, but he was not actually a part of the celebration. These verses are a “wedding song” that describes the joy that the bride and groom felt on their wedding day. That day was their special day when they were as happy as a king and queen.

Song of Solomon 4:1

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple's wedding day. The section has several parts:

3:6–11 The man and woman came to their wedding in a grand procession

4:1–15 The man described his beautiful bride

4:16–5:1 The man and woman consummated their marriage

Paragraph 4:1–7 The man told his bride how beautiful she is

In 4:1–7 the man used figures of speech to tell his bride how beautiful and majestic she was. Bergant (page 42) explains the two aspects of the description in this way: “It is a descriptive song that uses metaphors and similes both representationally (highlighting physical similarity) and presentationally (eliciting an emotional response).” This type of physical description of one's beloved is called a “wasf” (an Arabic word). It was a common type of poetry in the ancient Near East. Such figures of speech were common in the love poetry of nearby cultures. The man also describes his bride in 6:4–10 and 7:1–9. In one example (5:10–16) the woman describes the man. He first praised her eyes and hair, then he praised her mouth, lips, and teeth. He described her temples and neck and then her breasts. Paragraph 4:1–7 begins and ends with similar statements that summarize her beauty:

:1 How beautiful you are, my darling—

how very beautiful!

:7 You are altogether beautiful, my darling;

there is no flaw in you.

Cultures have different ideas about what is beautiful. In some cultures the figures of speech that the man used to describe the woman may seem strange or insulting, but in his culture, they were powerful ways to praise her. Sometimes they described the man's feelings about her instead of describing her appearance. For example, in 4:4 the man compared the woman's neck (or her necklaces) to the tower of King David. Her neck did not look like the tower, but to him she seemed as majestic as that tower where warriors' shields hung to represent their power.

Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song

In 4:1–7 the man often referred to the woman's body. In most cultures certain parts of the body are “private” or “sexual,” and those parts should not be uncovered in public. In some cultures, women must be covered

from the waist to the ankles. In some cultures certain references may embarrass people who read or hear them. It may not be modest to mention a woman's breasts or her belly or navel (as in some verses of the Song). Other cultures have different standards. Scholars are not sure about the specific standards in Israel when the Song was written, but the Song does not violate the standards of modesty in the OT. Two facts about the Song may help to indicate the standards of modesty in Israel's culture in OT times:

1. The Song refers to parts of the female body more than 40 times, but only three of these mention areas below the waist. Two of these references are to the feet, which were usually uncovered. The other is to "rounded thighs" in 7:1. It probably refers to the general shape of the thighs, which may be obvious even when a woman is fully clothed. This may imply that the area below the waist was the "private" area, which must be covered in public.
2. In 8:8–10 both the woman and her brothers spoke casually about her breasts. This probably indicates that in that culture a woman did not always cover her breasts. For example, it was common to breast-feed babies openly (as in 8:1 and other OT verses).

These two facts imply that the author described the woman's body in a more modest way than some scholars assume. When the man described the woman's beauty (as in 4:1–7 and 7:1–9), he did it in a proper way. He did not describe "private sexual" parts. In some languages it may be helpful to include a footnote to explain that cultures have different standards of what is proper, decent, and respectful. Translate in a way that does not violate your culture's standards.

4:1a–c

4:1a–b and the first part of 4:1c are identical to 1:15a–b. The Notes for the two verses are not exactly the same because the context is different. In 4:1 the context is the couple's wedding day. However, you should translate the similarities in the two verses in the same way (or a very similar way).

4:1a

How beautiful you are, my darling—

- How beautiful you are, my love, (NRSV)
- My darling, you are so beautiful,

4:1b

how very beautiful!

- so very beautiful!
- too beautiful to describe.

4:1a–b

How beautiful you are, my darling—how very beautiful!: These phrases also occurred in 1:15. You may

translate them as you did there. See also CEV, NASB, NCV, NJB, and GNT. Notice that the phrases here in 4:1a–b are repeated in 4:7 to form an inclusio, which indicates the end of Paragraph 4:1–7.

my darling: See the Notes on 1:9a–b for a discussion of the phrase my darling. You should translate it as you did there and in 1:15. In some languages a direct address like this comes first in the sentence. For example:

My darling, how beautiful you are...

4:1c

Your eyes are like doves behind your veil.

- Your eyes are like doves hidden behind your veil.
- Your lovely eyes are like shy/gentle birds.

Your eyes are like doves: The phrase Your eyes are like doves is a simile. The man compares the woman's eyes to a small bird called a "dove." The man did not mean that her eyes looked like doves. He meant that her eyes had a characteristic that reminded him of doves.

Scholars are uncertain about the exact meaning of this simile. Doves are gentle birds, so the simile probably implies that the woman's eyes revealed that she was gentle like a dove. In the context of 4:1a–b it also implies that her eyes were beautiful. Doves probably symbolize love here.

See 1:15c (which has the identical simile) for a more detailed discussion. You should translate this simile in the same way in both verses. In some languages it may be necessary to make the meaning explicit. For example:

Your lovely eyes show that you are as gentle as a dove

doves: For more information about doves, see the note on 1:15c.

behind your veil: Here in 4:1c the author adds the phrase behind your veil, which was not part of the comparison in 1:15. A veil was a piece of fabric that covered part of the head. In this verse, the author implied that the veil covered the woman's face.

Probably the veil was partly transparent so that the man could see her eyes through the fabric. Other scholars say that the veil may have covered only the lower part of her face so that her eyes were visible above the veil. It is uncertain whether the veil symbolizes the woman's modesty or if the veil serves to

further enhance her mysterious beauty. Perhaps both are true.

Some other ways to translate behind your veil are:

as you look through your veil (CEV)

inside the cloth that covers your face

4:1d-e

Your hair is like a flock of goats streaming down Mount Gilead: In 4:1d-e the author describes the way the woman's hair looks as it moves. It moves in a fascinating way that is constantly changing. He compares it to the way a big group of goats move down mountain slopes in Gilead. Their movements are delightful to watch as they come down the mountain together. A similar simile is found in 6:5.

In many cultures people do not compare a woman's hair to the movement of goats. If this is true in your language, you may need to make the similarity more explicit. For example:

Your hair dances like a flock of goats bounding down the hills of Gilead. (GNT)

Your hair is like a flock of goats streaming down Mount Gilead. (NCV)

Your dark/black hair moves like a flock of dark/black goats as they leap down the slopes of Gilead.

For more information, see the note on streaming down Mount Gilead in this part of the verse.

4:1d

Your hair is like a flock of goats

- Your hair looks like a flock of goats,
- Your wavy hair is like a big group of black goats,

flock of goats: The phrase flock of goats refers here to a group of goats that are seen from a distance. The individual goats are not in focus. The author compared the woman's hair to a flock of goats moving down a mountain to imply that her hair was beautiful as it moved.

In some cultures, people do not think of goats as beautiful or graceful. They may think of them as ugly or even associated with evil customs. If that is true in your culture, you may use a more general term. For example:

like flocks/groups of animals dancing down the slopes of Gilead

4:1e

streaming down Mount Gilead.

- as it moves/flows down the slopes of Gilead.
- surging down from Gilead heights.

streaming down: Here the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as streaming describes the way the goats move, or how they look as they go down the mountain slopes and hillsides in Gilead. Some other ways to describe this movement are:

flowing/streaming down

bounding/dancing down

Use a poetic way in your language to describe their movement.

Mount Gilead: The name Gilead probably refers here to a plateau region on the east side of the Jordan River. There was also a mountain called "Gilead" on the western side of the Jordan River. That region has many cliffs and mountain slopes. It probably does not refer to a single mountain. However, scholars and English versions differ on this issue. In this context, you may translate the word Mount as either singular or plural, whichever is most natural in your language. Scholars disagree on this issue. There are two main views: (1) It refers generally to the mountainous region of Gilead, possibly where the land slopes down to the Jordan River valley. For example, the ESV has, "surging down the slopes of Gilead." Versions which follow this view are CEV, ESV, JB, NAB, NLT, RSV, GNT, and NIV11. (2) It refers to a specific mountain. For example, the NIV has, "descending from Mount Gilead." Versions which follow this view are BSB, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, and REB. In 6:5 the author used a similar expression but without the word "mountain." The NIV translates it as "descending from Gilead." Also, in 4:1 the expression lacks the article and so probably means "mountainous Gilead." A specific mountain does not seem to be in focus in either verse. For example:

the slopes of Gilead (RSV)

Song of Solomon 4:2

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
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In this section the author describes the couple's wedding day. The section has several parts:

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Her neck did not look like the tower, but to him she seemed as majestic as that tower where warriors' shields hung to represent their power.

Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song

In 4:1-7 the man often referred to the woman's body. In most cultures certain parts of the body are "private" or "sexual," and those parts should not be uncovered in public. In some cultures, women must be covered from the waist to the ankles. In some cultures certain references may embarrass people who read or hear them. It may not be modest to mention a woman's breasts or her belly or navel (as in some verses of the Song). Other cultures have different standards. Scholars are not sure about the specific standards in Israel when the Song was written, but the Song does not violate the standards of modesty in the OT. Two facts about the Song may help to indicate the standards of modesty in Israel's culture in OT times:

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These two facts imply that the author described the woman's body in a more modest way than some scholars assume. When the man described the woman's beauty (as in 4:1-7 and 7:1-9), he did it in a proper way. He did not describe "private sexual" parts. In some languages it may be helpful to include a footnote to explain that cultures have different standards of what is proper, decent, and respectful. Translate in a way that does not violate your culture's standards.

4:2

In this verse there is a visual contrast with 4:1. In 4:1 a flock of black goats are descending the mountains. In 4:2 there is a flock of white sheep that have just been washed. There are some interpretation issues in 4:2, but the main point is fairly clear: The man described the woman's beautiful teeth. They were white, and none were missing. Her white teeth were striking in their contrast to her black hair.

This verse is repeated in almost identical form in 6:6a–b.

4:2a

Your teeth are like a flock of newly shorn sheep

- Your teeth are like female sheep after their dirty wool is removed
- Your teeth are as white as a flock of sheep after someone cuts off their old wool/hair

Your teeth are like a flock of newly shorn sheep: In this clause the man praised the woman by comparing her teeth to a flock of newly shorn sheep. The comparison means that her teeth were white and smooth, like a group of sheep when their wool has just been cut off (shorn). (Sheep in Palestine were usually white.) The woman's white teeth also imply that she was young, since teeth become more yellow as a person ages.

In some languages it is necessary to make this comparison more explicit. For example:

Your teeth are as white as sheep that have just been shorn and washed. (GNT)

Your teeth are white like newly sheared sheep just coming from their bath. (NCV)

teeth...like a flock of newly shorn sheep: In this phrase the author focuses on all of the woman's teeth together. They are like a group (flock) of sheep, not like only one sheep. In some languages the plural form of the word sheep already implies a group of sheep, so a word like flock may not be needed.

newly shorn sheep: Scholars disagree about whether the phrase shorn sheep implies that the sheep had already been shorn or were about to be shorn:

1. The sheep were already shorn. For example:

Your teeth are like a flock of sheep just shorn... (NIV) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT, RSV, GNT)

1. The sheep were not yet shorn. For example:

a flock of sheep to be shorn... (NJB) (GW, NAB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This seems to be the most likely interpretation and most versions follow it.

4:2b

coming up from the washing;

- and they have just been washed.
- and bathes them in the stream/river.

coming up from the washing: The phrase coming up from the washing modifies the phrase “flock of newly shorn sheep” in 4:2a. After the wool was cut off the sheep (they were “shorn”), the sheep were washed, possibly in a stream. Then the sheep were clean and white. The woman's teeth also looked clean and white like those freshly washed sheep.

The point of the simile in 4:2a–b is that the woman's teeth were very white, which implies that they looked beautiful to the man. Here is another way to make this meaning clear:

Your teeth are as white as sheep, recently shorn and freshly washed. (NLT)

4:2c

each has its twin,

- Your teeth are like twin lambs. Each tooth has its matching one,
- Each of your teeth has its twin,

4:2d

and not one of them is lost.

- and no single one is missing.
- they are all perfectly matched. (GNT)

4:2c–d

each has its twin, and not one of them is lost: The phrase each has its twin, and not one of them is lost is closely connected to the simile in 4:2a–b. However, it is a different simile, which compares the woman's teeth to twin lambs. Exum makes the point that first the woman's teeth are identified with the ewes that come up from the wash, but then the twin lambs take over the image and the teeth are now associated with the second part of the simile. She says: “As appealing as it may be to translate the second couplet as “all of them in pairs, none bereft of its twin,” and take the phrase as a reference to the ewes, this does not seem to be the picture that lies behind the metaphor. More likely the poet has in mind two baby lambs, “twins,” lagging behind their mother...In many of the man's metaphoric descriptions of his lover, the image tends to overshadow its referent in an effort to create a total picture and that is what appears to happen here. In the second couplet, the image of twinning takes over, while the referent (“your teeth”) lags behind. First the teeth are identified with ewes, but once the ewes are said to have twins, then the teeth are identified with

the twins and not the ewes with their twins (in which case the woman would have too many teeth).” (pages 162–163)

The phrase each has its refers to the ewes in 4:2a–b. Here in 4:2c–d the author indicates that each tooth on one side of the woman’s mouth had a tooth just like it (a twin) on the other side. None of the teeth has lost its matching tooth on the other side. In the author’s lifetime it was probably unusual for an adult to have a complete set of teeth like that. Another way to translate this meaning is:

they match perfectly, not one is missing. (CEV)

Song of Solomon 4:3

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple’s wedding day. The section has several parts:

3:6–11 The man and woman came to their wedding in a grand procession

4:1–15 The man described his beautiful bride

4:16–5:1 The man and woman consummated their marriage

Paragraph 4:1–7 The man told his bride how beautiful she is

In 4:1–7 the man used figures of speech to tell his bride how beautiful and majestic she was. Bergant (page 42) explains the two aspects of the description in this way: “It is a descriptive song that uses metaphors and similes both representationally (highlighting physical similarity) and presentationally (eliciting an emotional response).” This type of physical description of one’s beloved is called a “wasf” (an Arabic word). It was a common type of poetry in the ancient Near East. Such figures of speech were common in the love poetry of nearby cultures. The man also describes his bride in 6:4–10 and 7:1–9. In one example (5:10–16) the woman describes the man. He first praised her eyes and hair, then he praised her mouth, lips, and teeth.

He described her temples and neck and then her breasts. Paragraph 4:1–7 begins and ends with similar statements that summarize her beauty:

:1 How beautiful you are, my darling—

how very beautiful!

:7 You are altogether beautiful, my darling;

there is no flaw in you.

Cultures have different ideas about what is beautiful. In some cultures the figures of speech that the man used to describe the woman may seem strange or insulting, but in his culture, they were powerful ways to praise her. Sometimes they described the man’s feelings about her instead of describing her appearance. For example, in 4:4 the man compared the woman’s neck (or her necklaces) to the tower of King David. Her neck did not look like the tower, but to him she seemed as majestic as that tower where warriors’ shields hung to represent their power.

Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song

In 4:1–7 the man often referred to the woman’s body. In most cultures certain parts of the body are “private” or “sexual,” and those parts should not be uncovered in public. In some cultures, women must be covered from the waist to the ankles. In some cultures certain references may embarrass people who read or hear them. It may not be modest to mention a woman’s breasts or her belly or navel (as in some verses of the Song). Other cultures have different standards. Scholars are not sure about the specific standards in Israel when the Song was written, but the Song does not violate the standards of modesty in the OT. Two facts about the Song may help to indicate the standards of modesty in Israel’s culture in OT times:

1. The Song refers to parts of the female body more than 40 times, but only three of these mention areas below the waist. Two of these references are to the feet, which were usually uncovered. The other is to “rounded thighs” in 7:1. It probably refers to the general shape of the thighs, which may be obvious even when a woman is fully clothed. This may imply that the area below the waist was the “private” area, which must be covered in public.
2. In 8:8–10 both the woman and her brothers spoke casually about her breasts. This probably indicates that in that culture a woman did not always cover

her breasts. For example, it was common to breast-feed babies openly (as in 8:1 and other OT verses).

These two facts imply that the author described the woman's body in a more modest way than some scholars assume. When the man described the woman's beauty (as in 4:1–7 and 7:1–9), he did it in a proper way. He did not describe “private sexual” parts. In some languages it may be helpful to include a footnote to explain that cultures have different standards of what is proper, decent, and respectful. Translate in a way that does not violate your culture's standards.

4:3a

Your lips are like a scarlet ribbon,

- Your lips are like a red ribbon,
- Your lips attract/delight me with their lovely color.

Your lips are like a scarlet ribbon: Here the author compares the woman's lips to a scarlet ribbon. The word scarlet refers to a bright red color. In ancient Palestine red lips were considered beautiful, so the woman probably put something on her lips to make them a bright red color. One suggestion is that she used juice made from the nests of a certain insect.

In some cultures people do not consider red lips to be beautiful, or red lips may imply something bad about a woman. If that is true in your language, you may translate in a more general way. For example:

Your lips are a glorious color.

Your lips are beautiful.

Your lips shine.

scarlet thread: scarlet ribbon: The phrase scarlet ribbon probably emphasizes the color scarlet, which is bright red. The phrase does not imply that the woman's lips were thin like some ribbon may be. In your translation you may need to compare her lips to something thick. For example:

Your lips are as beautiful as fine scarlet cord

4:3b

and your mouth is lovely.

- and your mouth is beautiful.
- Oh, how beautiful they are!

and your mouth is lovely: The phrase and your mouth is lovely is parallel to 4:3a, and it probably has a similar meaning. However, scholars interpret the Hebrew

word that the BSB translates as mouth in different ways here:

1. It means “mouth.” For example:

your mouth is lovely. (NIV) (BSB, CEV, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, REB, RSV)

1. It means “words” or “speech.” For example:

and your words enchanting. (NJB) (KJV, NEB, NJB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), as most English versions do. The Hebrew word can have either meaning, but in this context the man described the woman's beauty. It seems unlikely that he suddenly changed to describing what she said. However, in Hebrew the word for “lips” can also mean “language” (Genesis 11:1, 6, 7). That meaning may be implied here also.

4:3c

Your brow behind your veil is like a slice of pomegranate.

- Your cheeks behind your veil are like pomegranate halves.
- Your cheeks under your veil fascinate/draw me like two halves of a pomegranate.

Your brow behind your veil is like a slice of pomegranate:

This clause is a simile. The author does not indicate how the woman's brow...is like a slice of pomegranate behind her veil. There are at least two ways to interpret the simile:

1. It indicates that her skin has a reddish color like a pomegranate's skin. For example:

Your cheeks are like rosy pomegranates behind your veil. (NLT) (GNT, CEV, NLT)

1. It indicates that the pattern of light shining through the threads in the girl's veil make her cheeks look like the inside of the pomegranate with its white membranes and red seeds.

Most English versions do not indicate how the girl's cheeks are like a pomegranate. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is probably more likely that the woman's skin had a healthy reddish color and was smooth like the outside reddish skin of the pomegranate. The rough inside texture seems less attractive.

Some ways to translate this meaning are:

- Translate the metaphor without indicating its meaning. For example:

Your cheeks behind your veil are like slices of a pomegranate.

- Translate the metaphor and indicate its meaning. For example:

Your cheeks are like rosy pomegranates behind your veil. (NLT)

Your cheeks behind your veil are like pomegranate halves—lovely and delicious. (NLT96)

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

behind your veil are hidden beautiful rosy cheeks. (CEV)

Your brow: Here the man compared the woman's brow to a slice of a pomegranate. There are different ways to interpret the phrase Your brow here:

1. It refers to the woman's "cheeks" (the sides of her face below her eyes). For example:

Your cheeks are like halves of a pomegranate... (ESV) (CEV, ESV, NAB, NCV, NJB, NLT, RSV, GNT)

1. It refers to the woman's temples The word "temple" here refers to the region on each side of the head in front of the ear and above the cheek bone. or forehead/brow (the sides of her face beside her eyebrows and above them). For example:

Your temples behind your veil are like the halves of a pomegranate. (NIV) (BSB, GW, NASB, NIV, NET, KJV, NJPS) The REB translates this as "parted lips." No other versions consulted followed this interpretation.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), but interpretation (2) is also acceptable. The literal meaning of the Hebrew word seems closest to "temple." However, many scholars believe that this word could also include the cheeks. Languages use different words to refer to different parts of a person's face. Use a natural description in your language.

Song of Solomon 4:4

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple's wedding day. The section has several parts:

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In 4:1–7 the man used figures of speech to tell his bride how beautiful and majestic she was. Bergant (page 42) explains the two aspects of the description in this way: "It is a descriptive song that uses metaphors and similes both representationally (highlighting physical similarity) and presentationally (eliciting an emotional response)." This type of physical description of one's beloved is called a "wasf" (an Arabic word). It was a common type of poetry in the ancient Near East. Such figures of speech were common in the love poetry of nearby cultures. The man also describes his bride in 6:4–10 and 7:1–9. In one example (5:10–16) the woman describes the man. He first praised her eyes and hair, then he praised her mouth, lips, and teeth. He described her temples and neck and then her breasts. Paragraph 4:1–7 begins and ends with similar statements that summarize her beauty:

:1 How beautiful you are, my darling—

how very beautiful!

:7 You are altogether beautiful, my darling;

there is no flaw in you.

Cultures have different ideas about what is beautiful. In some cultures the figures of speech that the man

used to describe the woman may seem strange or insulting, but in his culture, they were powerful ways to praise her. Sometimes they described the man's feelings about her instead of describing her appearance. For example, in 4:4 the man compared the woman's neck (or her necklaces) to the tower of King David. Her neck did not look like the tower, but to him she seemed as majestic as that tower where warriors' shields hung to represent their power.

Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song

In 4:1-7 the man often referred to the woman's body. In most cultures certain parts of the body are "private" or "sexual," and those parts should not be uncovered in public. In some cultures, women must be covered from the waist to the ankles. In some cultures certain references may embarrass people who read or hear them. It may not be modest to mention a woman's breasts or her belly or navel (as in some verses of the Song). Other cultures have different standards. Scholars are not sure about the specific standards in Israel when the Song was written, but the Song does not violate the standards of modesty in the OT. Two facts about the Song may help to indicate the standards of modesty in Israel's culture in OT times:

1. The Song refers to parts of the female body more than 40 times, but only three of these mention areas below the waist. Two of these references are to the feet, which were usually uncovered. The other is to "rounded thighs" in 7:1. It probably refers to the general shape of the thighs, which may be obvious even when a woman is fully clothed. This may imply that the area below the waist was the "private" area, which must be covered in public.
2. In 8:8-10 both the woman and her brothers spoke casually about her breasts. This probably indicates that in that culture a woman did not always cover her breasts. For example, it was common to breast-feed babies openly (as in 8:1 and other OT verses).

These two facts imply that the author described the woman's body in a more modest way than some scholars assume. When the man described the woman's beauty (as in 4:1-7 and 7:1-9), he did it in a proper way. He did not describe "private sexual" parts. In some languages it may be helpful to include a footnote to explain that cultures have different standards of what is proper, decent, and respectful. Translate in a way that does not violate your culture's standards.

4:4

In 4:4 the man used a simile that has two parts. He began by comparing the woman's neck to the tower

of David (4:4a-b). Then he compared her jewelry to shields, which were hanging on the tower (4:4c-d).

4:4a

Your neck is like the tower of David,

- Your neck is like David's tower,
- Your neck is majestic like the tower of David,

4:4b

built with rows of stones;

- built with great care.
- so beautifully designed.

4:4a-b

Your neck is like the tower of David, built with rows of stones: Here the man compared the woman's neck to the tower of David. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as rows of stones seems to describe the way that the tower was built, but the meaning of the Hebrew word is unknown. The Hebrew word consists of the prefixed preposition *le* translated as with plus the unknown root word translated rows of stones. It occurs only here in the OT. There are at least three ways to interpret it:

1. It means that woman's neck is similar in some way to the impressive way that the tower of David was designed and constructed. For example:

Your neck is like David's beautifully-designed tower. (GW) (CEV, GW, NIV, NLT, GNT)

1. It means "built in rows." This may refer to the woman's necklaces as being like rows of shields (4:4c-d) or like the way the tower was built with rows of stones. (These rows are called "courses" in some English versions.) For example:

Your neck is like the tower of David, built in courses... (NRSV) (BSB, ESV, NCV, NET, NJB, NRSV, REB, NIV)

1. It describes the function of the tower, either as a storage place for weapons or as a defensive structure. For example:

Your neck is like the tower of David, built for an arsenal... (RSV) (NJPS, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The woman's beautiful neck and necklaces were like the tower of David, which was tall, majestic, and beautiful. The shields that hung from it were also beautiful. They were probably decorated with gold and

jewels that shone in the sun like the woman's necklaces described in 4:4c-d. At first glance, it appears by the ending on this word *le-talpiyyot*, a plural suffix -ot, that this is a plural noun. However, as Bloch and Bloch point out (pages 170-172), there is a class of words that have a plural marker but that function adverbially. They point out that in this context with the word "to build" it would have been more common to use the preposition *be* rather than *le*. Also, it is very common in Hebrew constructions using "to build" plus an adverbial to use the preposition *le* attached to the adverb. This explanation does not pinpoint the exact meaning of *le-talpiyyot*, but it does narrow it down in context to some quality of beauty that both the tower and her neck have in common. A generic sort of quality such as "beautifully," "masterfully," or "elegantly" seems as good an option as any. Such a description would function in a similar manner to the description of her thighs in 7:1, "the work of a master hand."

Because the BSB does not follow interpretation (1), the Notes uses the NIV as the source text for the Notes and Display of 4:4a-b.

(NIV) Your neck is like the tower of David, built with elegance: In this comparison the author indicates that the woman's neck was beautiful and elegant. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

Your neck is more graceful than the tower of David. (CEV)

Your neck is as beautiful as the tower of David (NLT)

(NIV) the tower of David: The phrase tower of David refers here to one of the towers that King David caused to be built. It does not refer to the tower near Jerusalem that is known today as the "tower of David." That tower was built a long time after the Song of Songs was written. The tower in this verse refers to an older tower. Scholars do not have any information about this tower except what is said here in the Song, and the Bible does not refer to it anywhere else.

The Song implies that the tower was large, impressive, and beautiful. Probably David did not actually build it himself. He provided the money and instructions for it to be built. Some other ways to translate the phrase the tower of David are:

the tower that David built

the tower which David caused to be built

tower: A tower in ancient Israel was a building that was much taller (and often not as wide) as the buildings around it. Most towers were made of stone, but some of the towers that King David built were made of white marble. Marble is a beautiful, smooth, expensive stone. It is also hard and durable.

A tower was usually used to watch for signs that enemies were coming to attack. It was also a place that was hard for enemies to enter, so it protected the soldiers and other people during battle. In some languages it may be helpful to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

watchtower

tall building where men guarded the city

(NIV) built with elegance: The meaning of the Hebrew word that the NIV translates as built with elegance is unknown. However, the context indicates that the tower was beautiful and well-built. Another way to translate this meaning is:

beautifully designed (GW)

4:4c
on it hang a thousand shields,

- A thousand small shields hang on the tower.
- Costly necklaces decorate it as the tower is decorated with many costly shields

4:4d
all of them shields of warriors.

- Each of them is a warrior's shield.
- that belonged to famous warriors.

4:4c-d

In 4:4c-d the author continued to compare the woman's neck to the watchtower. Here he compared the jewelry on her neck to the shields that hung from the tower. These shields were impressive and beautiful. They were probably decorated with gold and jewels to make them shine in the sun. The woman's jewelry was also impressive and beautiful. Translate in a way that communicates that picture.

on it hang a thousand shields, all of them shields of warriors: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as shields refers to small round shields that soldiers (warriors) carried in battle. The phrase on it hang a thousand shields indicates that a thousand of these

shields were hanging from the tower. The text indicates that the woman's necklaces or ornaments and these shields were similar to each other in some way.

Some other way to translate the whole comparison are:

Your neck is like the tower of David, round and smooth, with a necklace like a thousand shields hung around it. (GNT)

Your neck is as beautiful as the tower of David, jeweled with the shields of a thousand heroes. (NLT)

all of them shields of warriors: The phrase all of them shields of warriors is parallel to a thousand shields. It repeats the idea of shields and adds the information that they were warriors' shields. It was common to hang shields on walls for decoration. They were considered beautiful ornaments. For example, Ezekiel 27:11 says, "Men of Arvad and Helech manned your walls all around, and the men of Gammad were in your towers. They hung their shields around your walls; they perfected your beauty." Another reference to ornamental shields is found in 1 Maccabees 4:57.

The author probably focused here on the beauty of the ornamental shields that he compared to the beauty of the woman's jewelry and to her own beauty. The magnificence of the tower with military shields suggests that the woman was like a beautiful queen.

See the preceding note for examples of how to translate this comparison.

Song of Solomon 4:5

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
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In this section the author describes the couple's wedding day. The section has several parts:

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how very beautiful!

:7 You are altogether beautiful, my darling;

there is no flaw in you.

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Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song

In 4:1–7 the man often referred to the woman's body. In most cultures certain parts of the body are "private" or "sexual," and those parts should not be uncovered in public. In some cultures, women must be covered from the waist to the ankles. In some cultures certain references may embarrass people who read or hear

them. It may not be modest to mention a woman's breasts or her belly or navel (as in some verses of the Song). Other cultures have different standards. Scholars are not sure about the specific standards in Israel when the Song was written, but the Song does not violate the standards of modesty in the OT. Two facts about the Song may help to indicate the standards of modesty in Israel's culture in OT times:

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2. In 8:8-10 both the woman and her brothers spoke casually about her breasts. This probably indicates that in that culture a woman did not always cover her breasts. For example, it was common to breast-feed babies openly (as in 8:1 and other OT verses).

These two facts imply that the author described the woman's body in a more modest way than some scholars assume. When the man described the woman's beauty (as in 4:1-7 and 7:1-9), he did it in a proper way. He did not describe "private sexual" parts. In some languages it may be helpful to include a footnote to explain that cultures have different standards of what is proper, decent, and respectful. Translate in a way that does not violate your culture's standards.

4:5b twins of a gazelle

- They are like twins of a gazelle
- They are as beautiful and delicate as twin gazelles

4:5

In 4:5 the man compared the woman's breasts to two gazelles grazing among lilies. In some cultures it may not be appropriate to describe a woman's breasts openly, but in the author's culture it was an acceptable and common part of love poetry. For more information, see the comments on "Respectable speech and actions in the Song" in the introduction to 4:1-7.

Your breasts are like two fawns, twins of a gazelle grazing among the lilies: In this phrase the man praised the woman. He implied that he felt strong love for her as he looked at her. Her breasts made him feel as happy as if he were in a beautiful place where fawns grazed among sweet-smelling lilies. Translate in a beautiful, poetic way that will express the feelings of the man as he spoke to the woman.

Some ways to do this in English are:

Your breasts remind me of twin fawns of a gazelle grazing in a field of lilies.

When I see your breasts, I think of young gazelle twins feeding on sweet-smelling lilies.

It is likely that in this statement, the man described some characteristics of the woman that the gazelles and lilies suggested. He described how she affected him, rather than what she looked like. In Bergant's terms, the focus in this verse seems to be on the presentational (how the man feels about her) rather than on the representational (descriptive) function of the simile. (p. 42). However, the figure actually begins on a physical note with "twins," but simultaneously the physical similarity factor diffuses into the less tangible qualities of the woman herself symbolized by fawns. So there may be a sort of representational-to-presentational dynamic going on here, from surface appearance to deeper values or feelings.

4:5a

Your breasts are like two fawns,

- Your breasts are like two young deer.
- Your breasts remind me of fawns.

Your breasts are like two fawns, twins of a gazelle:

In this phrase the man compared the woman's breasts to two young gazelles (fawns). He describes her breasts as being like twins born to the same mother. This figure of speech implies that her breasts are identical, just as twin fawns are identical. Another way to translate this comparison is:

Your two breasts are like young twins of a gazelle

Your breasts: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as breasts is literally, "your two breasts." It's possible the Hebrew includes the word two because it begins with the same sound as the word for breasts. In many languages the word two is not needed here, as in the BSB.

like two fawns, twins: The word, twins, implies that the woman's breasts are exactly alike, but the text does not explicitly say how they are like fawns. The fawns that the man referred to here are young gazelles. In Israel people considered them to be graceful, gentle, beautiful, shy, and quick. It is uncertain which specific quality the author referred to here, but it is clear that the woman's breasts were beautiful and

pleasing to the man. Consider how to communicate this meaning in a poetic way.

In some languages it may seem insulting to compare the woman's breasts to fawns, or it may imply a wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, you may be able to use a more general description. Since the man described his feelings about her breasts, it may be helpful to indicate that he considered them to be beautiful. For example:

Your breasts are as lovely as two beautiful twin fawns

4:5c grazing among the lilies.

- that graze among lilies.
- that feed in fields of flowers.

grazing among the lilies: The phrase grazing among the lilies describes the place where the fawns were feeding. It also implies that the man had strong loving feelings as he looked at the woman. He felt happy when he was with her. Here the beautiful fawns among the lilies represent the woman's breasts and the woman herself.

Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

that feed in the midst of lilies.

that eat where lily flowers grow.

lilies: lilies smell sweet, and they may be associated with romance. The lilies are part of the description of the woman's breasts. The text may imply that her breasts were like lilies because they were perfumed.

Song of Solomon 4:6

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple's wedding day. The section has several parts:

3:6–11 The man and woman came to their wedding in a grand procession

4:1–15 The man described his beautiful bride

4:16–5:1 The man and woman consummated their marriage

Paragraph 4:1–7 The man told his bride how beautiful she is

In 4:1–7 the man used figures of speech to tell his bride how beautiful and majestic she was. Bergant (page 42) explains the two aspects of the description in this way: "It is a descriptive song that uses metaphors and similes both representationally (highlighting physical similarity) and presentationally (eliciting an emotional response)." This type of physical description of one's beloved is called a "wasf" (an Arabic word). It was a common type of poetry in the ancient Near East. Such figures of speech were common in the love poetry of nearby cultures. The man also describes his bride in 6:4–10 and 7:1–9. In one example (5:10–16) the woman describes the man. He first praised her eyes and hair, then he praised her mouth, lips, and teeth. He described her temples and neck and then her breasts. Paragraph 4:1–7 begins and ends with similar statements that summarize her beauty:

:1 How beautiful you are, my darling—

how very beautiful!

:7 You are altogether beautiful, my darling;

there is no flaw in you.

Cultures have different ideas about what is beautiful. In some cultures the figures of speech that the man used to describe the woman may seem strange or insulting, but in his culture, they were powerful ways to praise her. Sometimes they described the man's feelings about her instead of describing her appearance. For example, in 4:4 the man compared the woman's neck (or her necklaces) to the tower of King David. Her neck did not look like the tower, but to him she seemed as majestic as that tower where warriors' shields hung to represent their power.

Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song

In 4:1–7 the man often referred to the woman's body. In most cultures certain parts of the body are "private" or "sexual," and those parts should not be uncovered in public. In some cultures, women must be covered

from the waist to the ankles. In some cultures certain references may embarrass people who read or hear them. It may not be modest to mention a woman's breasts or her belly or navel (as in some verses of the Song). Other cultures have different standards. Scholars are not sure about the specific standards in Israel when the Song was written, but the Song does not violate the standards of modesty in the OT. Two facts about the Song may help to indicate the standards of modesty in Israel's culture in OT times:

1. The Song refers to parts of the female body more than 40 times, but only three of these mention areas below the waist. Two of these references are to the feet, which were usually uncovered. The other is to "rounded thighs" in 7:1. It probably refers to the general shape of the thighs, which may be obvious even when a woman is fully clothed. This may imply that the area below the waist was the "private" area, which must be covered in public.
2. In 8:8–10 both the woman and her brothers spoke casually about her breasts. This probably indicates that in that culture a woman did not always cover her breasts. For example, it was common to breast-feed babies openly (as in 8:1 and other OT verses).

These two facts imply that the author described the woman's body in a more modest way than some scholars assume. When the man described the woman's beauty (as in 4:1–7 and 7:1–9), he did it in a proper way. He did not describe "private sexual" parts. In some languages it may be helpful to include a footnote to explain that cultures have different standards of what is proper, decent, and respectful. Translate in a way that does not violate your culture's standards.

4:6

Verse 6 clearly refers back to 2:17. In 2:17, the woman spoke to the man. Here in 4:6, the man speaks to the woman. He repeats what she said about the time of day and mountains in 2:17, but he changes it slightly to express his desire for her.

4:6a

Before the day breaks

- When the evening breeze blows
- When the cool evening breeze arises

4:6b

and the shadows flee,

- and the shadows lengthen,
- and the shadows begin to disappear,

4:6a–b

In 4:6a–b the author repeats exactly what he said in 2:17a–b. See the discussion under 2:17a–b. As in 2:17, the phrase "the day breaks" probably refers to the cool

breezes that often come in the late afternoon in that region. The phrase "shadows flee" probably refers to the disappearing of shadows at the end of day. So both 2:17a–b and 4:6a–b refer to late afternoon or evening. You should translate these two passages in the same way.

Before the day breaks and the shadows flee: The Hebrew word 'ad. that the BSB translates as Before can be translated in different ways depending on the context. In 2:17a–b, the Notes suggested the translation "until" because the man and woman were together. Here in 4:6 the man wanted to hurry and go to her (4:6c), so it may be more natural to translate the Hebrew word in a different way like "when" or "as soon as." For example:

As soon as the evening breeze cools the day and the shadows disappear, I will hurry...

When the day brings a cool breeze and the shadows flee, I will go... (GW)

4:6c

I will make my way to the mountain of myrrh

- I will hurry to the mountain that is scented with myrrh,
- I will go to my darling, who is as delightful to me as mountains of myrrh

4:6d

and to the hill of frankincense.

- to the hill that smells like frankincense.
- and frankincense.

4:6c–d

I will make my way to the mountain of myrrh and to the hill of frankincense: The phrase I will make my way means "I will go" or "I will hurry." In this statement the man indicated that he was eager to be with his bride. He wanted to hurry to her.

The phrases the mountain of myrrh and the hill of frankincense are parallel metaphors. They probably refer to either the woman herself (including her body, as in 3:6c) or specifically to her breasts (mentioned in 4:5). Both options (1) and (2) allude to anticipated intimate relations of the man with the woman. But it is recommended that you follow option (1) for the following reasons: (a) The metaphor probably alludes to 3:6 where the woman (not just her breasts) is "scented with myrrh and frankincense." (b) Although the metaphor has two lines with similar items—"mountain of myrrh" and "hill of frankincense"—such parallelism may imply intensification or subtle differences rather than perfect synonymy. Here a sug-

gestion that her breasts were slightly different sizes and perfumed differently may contradict the idea of “twin” (4:5a), which suggests that her breasts were the same. It also seems to undermine 4:7b that says “in you there is no flaw.”(c) The metaphor may point ahead to the list of fragrances in 4:14 where myrrh and frankincense are two of the many spices mentioned to describe the woman. In 4:12–14 the fragrances refer in a general way to the woman, who is compared to a fragrant garden.(d) In 4:5a, the Notes suggest that the point of similarity with the “fawns” refers to some personal qualities of the woman, and not literally to her breasts. 4:6 continues the more general reference to the woman, not to specific body parts. The next verse will also describe her beauty in a general way (“you are altogether beautiful...”). She was like mountains that were covered with sweet-smelling myrrh and frankincense. By saying this, the man was using a delicate way to express his desire to have intimate relations with her.

Some ways to translate this statement are:

- Keep the metaphor of sweet-smelling spices. For example:

I will hurry to the sweet-smelling mountains of myrrh and frankincense.

I will go to enjoy the fragrant hills.

- Use a simile. For example:

I will hurry to my love who is as sweet-smelling/ delightful as the best perfume.

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

I will hurry to my sweet-smelling bride.

Translate the figures of speech in a natural way in your language.

myrrh: myrrh was an expensive imported perfume that is not native to Israel. For more information, see the note on 3:6c. You should probably translate myrrh in the same way here.

frankincense: frankincense is a kind of fragrant incense that is not native to Israel. For more information, see the note on frankincense in 3:6c. You should probably translate frankincense in the same way here.

Song of Solomon 4:7

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple’s wedding day. The section has several parts:

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Paragraph 4:1–7 The man told his bride how beautiful she is

In 4:1–7 the man used figures of speech to tell his bride how beautiful and majestic she was. Bergant (page 42) explains the two aspects of the description in this way: “It is a descriptive song that uses metaphors and similes both representationally (highlighting physical similarity) and presentationally (eliciting an emotional response).” This type of physical description of one’s beloved is called a “wasf” (an Arabic word). It was a common type of poetry in the ancient Near East. Such figures of speech were common in the love poetry of nearby cultures. The man also describes his bride in 6:4–10 and 7:1–9. In one example (5:10–16) the woman describes the man. He first praised her eyes and hair, then he praised her mouth, lips, and teeth. He described her temples and neck and then her breasts. Paragraph 4:1–7 begins and ends with similar statements that summarize her beauty:

:1 How beautiful you are, my darling—

how very beautiful!

:7 You are altogether beautiful, my darling;

there is no flaw in you.

Cultures have different ideas about what is beautiful. In some cultures the figures of speech that the man

used to describe the woman may seem strange or insulting, but in his culture, they were powerful ways to praise her. Sometimes they described the man's feelings about her instead of describing her appearance. For example, in 4:4 the man compared the woman's neck (or her necklaces) to the tower of King David. Her neck did not look like the tower, but to him she seemed as majestic as that tower where warriors' shields hung to represent their power.

Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song

In 4:1-7 the man often referred to the woman's body. In most cultures certain parts of the body are "private" or "sexual," and those parts should not be uncovered in public. In some cultures, women must be covered from the waist to the ankles. In some cultures certain references may embarrass people who read or hear them. It may not be modest to mention a woman's breasts or her belly or navel (as in some verses of the Song). Other cultures have different standards. Scholars are not sure about the specific standards in Israel when the Song was written, but the Song does not violate the standards of modesty in the OT. Two facts about the Song may help to indicate the standards of modesty in Israel's culture in OT times:

1. The Song refers to parts of the female body more than 40 times, but only three of these mention areas below the waist. Two of these references are to the feet, which were usually uncovered. The other is to "rounded thighs" in 7:1. It probably refers to the general shape of the thighs, which may be obvious even when a woman is fully clothed. This may imply that the area below the waist was the "private" area, which must be covered in public.
2. In 8:8-10 both the woman and her brothers spoke casually about her breasts. This probably indicates that in that culture a woman did not always cover her breasts. For example, it was common to breast-feed babies openly (as in 8:1 and other OT verses).

These two facts imply that the author described the woman's body in a more modest way than some scholars assume. When the man described the woman's beauty (as in 4:1-7 and 7:1-9), he did it in a proper way. He did not describe "private sexual" parts. In some languages it may be helpful to include a footnote to explain that cultures have different standards of what is proper, decent, and respectful. Translate in a way that does not violate your culture's standards.

4:7

This verse is similar to 4:1, and it ends the inclusio, which began there. In 4:1 the man said in a general but emphatic way, "You are beautiful." In 4:7, he elaborated

on "you are beautiful" by saying "You are altogether beautiful" and "in you there is no flaw."

After the man described her in 4:1-6, he concluded that she was perfect. The two lines, 4:7a and 4:7b, have a similar meaning, but 4:7b intensifies 4:7a by adding "no flaw."

4:7a

You are altogether beautiful, my darling;

- You are altogether beautiful, my beloved.
- My darling, you are lovely in every way, (CEV)

You are altogether beautiful, my darling: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as You are altogether beautiful is more literally, "all of you is beautiful." It indicates that the man considered the woman to be beautiful in every way. He probably referred specifically to physical beauty here. He implied that all of the woman's physical characteristics were beautiful. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Every part of you is fair, my darling... (NJPS)

This phrase summarizes the woman's beautiful features, which the man described specifically in 4:1-6. It may also imply good character qualities. For example, in 4:1 the phrase your eyes are like doves may refer to the woman's gentleness or modesty. In 4:4, her neck being like a tower may imply noble character. In 4:5 the comparison of her breasts to fawns may imply "innocence" or "life-giving energy." There is uncertainty about the meaning of much of the imagery. But there seems to be more going on than mere physical description. Again, this draws on Dianne Bergant's distinction between the representational (physical description) and presentational (less tangible descriptions that focus on the emotional aspects and character qualities). Commentators prior to the 20th century tended to see much more description of the woman's character than present day commentators who see mostly the physical. But both are likely involved.

beautiful: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as beautiful in this verse is the same word that it translates as "beautiful" in 4:1. *yaphah*. It is helpful to translate this word in the same way in both 4:1 and 4:7 to make it clear that these verses are an inclusio. They indicate the beginning and end of a unit in the Song.

my darling: The phrase my darling also occurs in 4:1, and you may translate it in the same way here. See the note on 4:1a-b.

4:7b**in you there is no flaw.**

- There is nothing imperfect about you.
- you are perfect!

in you there is no flaw: The phrase in you there is no flaw has a similar meaning to 4:7a, but it is stated in a negative way. It indicates that the woman was completely beautiful, and each of her features was beautiful. There was nothing about her that was not lovely, and none of her features reduced her beauty. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

There is no blemish/fault in you.

beautiful without a flaw. (REB)

beautiful in every way. (NLT)

General Comment on 4:7

The two clauses in this verse are parallel and have almost the same meaning. The repetition of the meaning makes it more emphatic. It indicates that the woman is wonderful in every way. Some ways to translate this meaning are:

- Use two statements with the same meaning. For example:

How beautiful you are, my love; how perfect you are! (GNT)

- Use one emphatic statement. For example:

My darling, you are lovely in every way. (CEV)

Song of Solomon 4:8**Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her**

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple's wedding day. The section has several parts:

3:6–11 The man and woman came to their wedding in a grand procession

4:1–15 The man described his beautiful bride

4:16–5:1 The man and woman consummated their marriage

Paragraph 4:8–15 The man called his bride from Lebanon; and compared her to a private garden

In these lines the man continued to use figurative language to praise his bride (4:8–15). First, he spoke to her as if he and she were in Lebanon. Lebanon is a region north of Israel. It is far from Jerusalem (Zion), where they celebrated their wedding. In Lebanon the rugged mountains and wild animals make it dangerous for people to travel. The man calling the woman from Lebanon symbolizes that he thought the woman was wonderful and mysterious (like Lebanon), but perhaps she was reluctant to fully surrender herself to him. She seemed beyond his reach, as though she was up in the mountains, guarded by wild animals. Because he loved her, he was gentle as he wooed her, preparing her to surrender herself to him.

As you translate these lines, it is important to remember that the author used figurative language. The woman was not actually in Lebanon, and the man did not refer to a real journey from there. The garden descriptions in 4:12–15 are also figurative. They do not describe an actual garden.

Several poetic themes help to unify 4:8–15 and 4:16–5:1:

1. Lebanon (4:8, 11, 15): In the OT, Lebanon is often portrayed as a remote, beautiful, and fragrant place with mountains and cedar forests. (For example, see Psalm 72:16; Isaiah 35:2; 60:13; and Hosea 14:5–7.)
2. fragrances (4:10–11, 13–14, 16, 5:1, and maybe implied in 4:8) Lebanon was especially known for its fragrant cedar trees. So fragrance is probably implied in 4:8.
3. tastes (4:10–11, 13–14, 16, 5:1)
4. the garden metaphor (especially in focus in 4:12–5:1)

The context of 4:8–5:1, as well as 3:6–4:7, is probably the day of the couple's wedding. In 5:1, the women of Jerusalem encouraged them to consummate their love as husband and wife.

4:8–11

In 4:8–11 the man used figurative language to invite the woman to come and be intimate with him. He spoke as if she were in far-away Lebanon. This figure of speech is similar to the one in 2:14, where he spoke of her being like a dove hidden high on rocky cliffs. She was not on literal cliffs, and here in 4:8–11 she

was not literally on the tops of mountains in Lebanon. The figurative language may suggest that the man perceived the woman as being reluctant to fully surrender herself to him. The love that the man expressed here in 4:8–11 is more intense than in 2:14. He wanted to have marital relations with his new bride.

4:8a

Come with me from Lebanon, my bride,

- Come with me from the Lebanon Mountains, my bride. (GNT)
- My bride, come from the Lebanon mountains with me.

4:8a–b

There is a textual issue in this part of the verse. One Hebrew text has 'ittiy which means "with me." An alternate Hebrew text, which some versions follow, has a word that means "come." Since the word "come" is repeated later in the verse, the overall meaning of the verse is the same in both texts. But the two textual variations have the same general meaning. The text that the Notes follows is literally, "With me from Lebanon, bride, with me from Lebanon come." In some languages, it is more natural to begin the sentence with the verb "come," as in the BSB, or with the word "bride." For example:

Come with me from Lebanon, my bride....

My bride, come from Lebanon with me....

Come with me from Lebanon, my bride: Here the man used a figurative way to tell his bride that he wanted her to be with him. He wanted the two of them to begin to experience the joys of physical love in their marriage.

The phrase Come with me is figurative. He and she were not actually in Lebanon, so he did not mean that he literally wanted her to leave Lebanon with him.

Some other ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Use a simile or other comparison. It is helpful if the comparison implies marital relations between the man and his bride. For example:

My bride, come with me, as if we were coming from the remote Lebanon mountains.

- Use a comparison and make the meaning more explicit. For example:

My bride, come and be secure with me, as if we are descending Lebanon's rugged mountains, coming down from Lebanon.

Translate the meaning in a poetic way in your language.

from Lebanon: Lebanon was a mountainous region north of Israel. It was a beautiful place, but it was also rugged and dangerous. It was far from Jerusalem, and the man implied that in a figurative way, the woman, though wonderful and beautiful like Lebanon, seemed far away from him like Lebanon. Her distance from him is a poetic way that may imply that she was reluctant to fully surrender herself to him. He also may have seen her as beyond his reach, like a beautiful queen.

Such figurative themes are common throughout the Song. For example, see 2:14; 3:6–11; 5:2–7; and 6:10.

my bride: The Hebrew word that is translated as bride is used to refer to a woman during the time right before she marries, as she marries, and for some time after the marriage. The phrase my bride is one word in Hebrew—simply bride. It is used only in 4:8–5:1, where it is used five times. It is appropriate for that section of the Song, which focuses on the wedding celebration and the days immediately after it. The technical term used by many commentators is epithalamium, a poem celebrating a marriage.

In 4:8–5:1 the man seemed to use the word bride to show his delight that the woman was now his wife. There is disagreement among scholars about the meaning of my bride. My bride occurs twice in 4:9–10 along with the parallel, my sister. In that context, my sister is a term of affection and does not mean that she is literally his sister. So, some scholars think that bride in this context also is only a term of affection, and that it does not imply a marriage. However, every English version consulted by the Notes uses the term "bride." The Notes take the view that the whole context from 3:6–5:1 is about a marriage, so references to bride should be taken literally. It is not used anywhere else in the Song. Use an appropriate way in your language for a husband to speak to his new wife. For example:

beloved wife

you the one I married

4:8b

come with me from Lebanon!

- Accompany me from the Lebanon mountains.

- Come from Lebanon to be with me.

come with me from Lebanon: Here the clause in 4:8a is repeated to add emphasis to what the man said to his bride. It emphasizes that he greatly desired to be with the woman he loved. In some languages it may not be natural to repeat this phrase or to repeat it in exactly the same words. It may be necessary to use a different way to indicate that the man was emphasizing what he just said. For example:

yes, please come with me from there!

come, let's descend those peaks!

4:8c

Descend from the peak of Amana,

- Descend from the summit of Amana,
- Come down from Amana mountain,

4:8d

from the summits of Senir and Hermon,

- and from the summits of Senir and Hermon.
- come down to me from Mount Senir and Mount Hermon.

4:8c–f

Descend from the peak of Amana, from the summits of Senir and Hermon, from the dens of the lions, from the mountains of the leopards: In 4:8c–f the man continued to invite the woman to come with him. In some languages his command to the woman to “descend” may wrongly imply that he wanted her to come down those peaks alone. Translate in a way that implies that the man will descend the peaks with her. For example:

You will travel with me from the peak of Mount Amana, from the mountain peaks in Senir and Hermon, from the lairs of lions, from the mountains of leopards. (GW)

We will come down from the top of Mount Amana. We will descend from the tops of Mount Senir and Mount Hermon, where lions and leopards live/roam.

Let's go down from the tops of Amana, Senir, and Hermon mountains, where lions and leopards have their homes.

from the summits of Senir and Hermon: In 4:8c–d the author gave the names of three peaks in the Lebanon

mountains—“Amana,” Senir, and Hermon. Two English versions (KJV and NJB) follow the interpretation that the text refers to looking down from the peaks. For example, the KJV has, “look from the top of Amana, from the top of Shenir and Hermon.” Some scholars believe that the names Senir and Hermon refer to the same peak. Mount Senir may be the Amorite name for Mount Hermon. Another possibility is that Senir refers to the whole Lebanon range while Hermon is a specific mountain in that range. However, you should include all three names in your translation.

General Comment on 4:8c–d

The list of three mountain peaks in 4:8c–d seems to imply that the woman was on several mountain peaks. But she was not actually in the Lebanon mountains or on top of any mountain peak. The author used a figurative way to describe her as remote and mysterious. The two lines, 4:8c–d, are parallel and have the same meaning. The man figuratively encouraged the woman to come and be intimate with him.

4:8e

from the dens of the lions,

- Come from the lions' lairs,
- Descend from where the lions

4:8f

from the mountains of the leopards.

- from the mountain haunts of leopards.
- and leopards live.

4:8e–f

from the dens of the lions, from the mountains of the leopards: The lines of 4:8e and 4:8f are parallel to 4:8c and 4:8d. In 4:8e–f, the man continued to speak to his bride in a figurative way about their love. He invited her to come share in the security and joys of married love.

Some other ways to translate 4:8e–f are:

where the lions and leopards live. (GNT)

where the lions have their dens and leopards live among the hills. (NLT)

dangers lurk/hide there like lions and leopards lurk/hide to catch their prey.

from the dens of the lions: The phrase dens of the lions refers to the homes of lions where they take care of their young cubs. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

homes of lions

places where the lions live

from the mountains of the leopards: The phrase from the mountains of the leopards refers to the mountains where leopards live. Another way to translate this phrase is:

from the mountains where the leopards live/roam

Song of Solomon 4:9

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

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2. There is a change of speaker.
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3. tastes (4:10–11, 13–14, 16, 5:1)
4. the garden metaphor (especially in focus in 4:12–5:1)

The context of 4:8–5:1, as well as 3:6–4:7, is probably the day of the couple's wedding. In 5:1, the women of Jerusalem encouraged them to consummate their love as husband and wife.

4:9a

You have captured my heart, my sister, my bride;

- You have captured my heart, my treasure, my bride. (NLT)
- My bride, you have overcome/thrilled me. You are my dear one,

You have captured my heart: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as captured my heart is more literally “you heart-ed me” (the word “heart” is used as a verb). The word can have different meanings in different contexts. Here it describes a person who is overcome by strong feelings of love. It may imply that the man felt physically weak when he looked at the woman because of the intense love and excitement he felt.

Languages have different ways to describe a lover who feels overcome by his feelings for his beloved. Consider whether your language has an idiom or figure of speech to describe this. Some other ways to translate 4:9 are:

I am helpless to stop feeling this love for you.
When you look at me for one moment or if I see
one bead from your necklace, I feel overcome with love.

When you glance at me, I feel weak with feelings
of love. I am overcome with love just by seeing
one of your necklaces.

In many languages there are idioms to describe this feeling. It combines both helplessness and pleasure. The woman also described that type of feeling in 2:5c where she said, I am sick with love. Her love was so strong that she could describe it as a type of pleasurable “sickness.”

my sister: The term my sister is used in a figurative way here to express affection. The woman was not literally his sister or other relative, but she was as dear to him as a sister. This type of figurative usage was common in the man’s culture at that time. In some languages it gives a wrong meaning for the man to call the woman his sister. If that is true in your language, some options for translation are:

- Substitute a different term for sister. For example:

my treasure (NLT)

my very own (CEV)

my love

- Use a simile. For example:

My bride, you are as dear to me as a sister.

- Use only the term my bride and add an expression of affection. For example:

My beloved bride

In some languages it may be necessary to put the phrase “my sister, my bride” at the beginning of 4:10. For example:

My sister, my bride, how wonderful is your love!

my bride: For a discussion of my bride, see 4:8a–b.

4:9b you have stolen my heart

- You have captivated my heart (ESV)
- and you so easily overcome/thrill me

you have stolen my heart: This phrase in 4:9b exactly repeats the phrase from 4:9a. The repetition adds emphasis, as 4:8b adds emphasis to 4:8a. It emphasizes that the woman has caused the man to be overcome by strong feelings of love. For more information, see the note on 4:8a–b. You could use these two phrases in the

same way, or emphasize this meaning in a natural way in your language. For example:

you truly have captured my heart

4:9c with one glance of your eyes,

- with a single glance from your eyes, (GW)
- just by looking at me once.

**4:9c–d
with one glance of your eyes, with one jewel of your neck:** In Hebrew the phrase with one glance of your eyes is literally “with one from your eyes.” It probably refers to when the woman looked briefly at him. Even when the woman looked at him only for a moment, he felt intense love. This implies that a longer gaze could totally overpower him. The Song has already mentioned the beauty of the woman’s dove-like eyes (1:15 and 4:1). For translation examples, see the note on 4:9a.

4:9d with one jewel of your neck.

- by a single bead of your necklace. (NLT96)
- You delight/thrill me when I see just the single jewel around your neck.

with one jewel of your neck: This phrase means that the woman wears a jewel on her neck, in the form of jewelry like a necklace or pendant. This phrase adds information to the phrase “You have captured my heart.” In some languages it is natural to repeat the phrase here. For example:

with one jewel of your neck, you have captured my heart.

There is a figure of speech here that intensifies the impact (as in 4:9c–d). It implies that if just one jewel on her neck was enough to ravish his heart, seeing all of her beauty totally overpowered him.

one jewel of your neck: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as jewel is singular. This singular form occurs only here in the OT. (The plural form occurs in two other verses in the OT and refers to objects that hang around a person’s neck.) Most English versions translate the meaning “one jewel/bead.” For example:

a single bead of your necklace (NLT96)

However, if necklaces with more than one strand are common in your culture, then “one strand” is also acceptable.

Song of Solomon 4:10

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple’s wedding day. The section has several parts:

3:6–11 The man and woman came to their wedding in a grand procession

4:1–15 The man described his beautiful bride

4:16–5:1 The man and woman consummated their marriage

Paragraph 4:8–15 The man called his bride from Lebanon; and compared her to a private garden

In these lines the man continued to use figurative language to praise his bride (4:8–15). First, he spoke to her as if he and she were in Lebanon. Lebanon is a region north of Israel. It is far from Jerusalem (Zion), where they celebrated their wedding. In Lebanon the rugged mountains and wild animals make it dangerous for people to travel. The man calling the woman from Lebanon symbolizes that he thought the woman was wonderful and mysterious (like Lebanon), but perhaps she was reluctant to fully surrender herself to him. She seemed beyond his reach, as though she was up in the mountains, guarded by wild animals. Because he loved her, he was gentle as he wooed her, preparing her to surrender herself to him.

As you translate these lines, it is important to remember that the author used figurative language. The woman was not actually in Lebanon, and the man did not refer to a real journey from there. The garden descriptions in 4:12–15 are also figurative. They do not describe an actual garden.

Several poetic themes help to unify 4:8–15 and 4:16–5:1:

1. Lebanon (4:8, 11, 15): In the OT, Lebanon is often portrayed as a remote, beautiful, and fragrant place with mountains and cedar forests. (For example,

see Psalm 72:16; Isaiah 35:2; 60:13; and Hosea 14:5–7.)

2. fragrances (4:10–11, 13–14, 16, 5:1, and maybe implied in 4:8) Lebanon was especially known for its fragrant cedar trees. So fragrance is probably implied in 4:8.

3. tastes (4:10–11, 13–14, 16, 5:1)

4. the garden metaphor (especially in focus in 4:12–5:1)

The context of 4:8–5:1, as well as 3:6–4:7, is probably the day of the couple’s wedding. In 5:1, the women of Jerusalem encouraged them to consummate their love as husband and wife.

4:10a

How delightful is your love, my sister, my bride!

- Your love is wonderful, my sister, my bride!
- My treasure, my bride, your love is so delightful!

How delightful is your love: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as How delightful is your love is an exclamation. The man told his bride that her love gave him great pleasure. Some other ways to translate the exclamation are:

Your love delights me (GNT)

How beautiful are your expressions of love (GW)

Your love causes me to feel happy

Translate it in a way that fits this context in your language.

delightful is your love: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as love is plural. It probably refers to physical ways that the woman showed her love to him. These ways include actions like kissing and touching. The word delightful is often translated as “sweet” or “beautiful.” It indicates that the ways she showed her love were wonderful and delightful to the man. They gave him much pleasure.

your love: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as your love The word in the Hebrew text means “love” which is followed by the BSB and most other versions. However, the NEB and REB have the word “breasts” which is based on the Greek Septuagint translation. The issue here is that originally, the writers of the Hebrew OT did not write vowels. The consonants are the same for “love” and “breasts” (ddyk), but the unwritten vowels were different. The translators of the Greek OT interpreted ddyk and its implied vowels as mastoi sou “your breasts.” The Masoretic text, which most English versions follow here, interpret the word

as “your love.” It is recommended that you follow the better Hebrew textual reading, love, as in the BSB. It is also used in 1:2. See the note on 1:2b for more information.

my sister, my bride: This phrase was also used in 4:9. For information on how to translate the phrase my sister, see the notes on 4:9a. For information on how to translate my bride, see the notes on 4:8a–b.

In some languages it may be necessary to put the phrase my sister, my bride at the beginning of 4:10. For example:

My sister, my bride, how wonderful is your love!

For a discussion of my sister, see the note on 4:9a. For a discussion of my bride, see the note on 4:8a–b.

4:10b

Your love is much better than wine,

- It is so much more delightful than wine.
- Your love is more intoxicating than wine.

Your love is much better than wine: What the man said here is similar to what the woman said to him in 1:2b. You should translate the two verses in a similar way. The Hebrew identifies 4:10b–c as an exclamation. Other ways to translate the exclamation are:

Your love is sweeter than wine (CEV)

how much better is your love than wine (RSV)

Refer to how you translated the similar expression in 1:2b and translate in a similar way.

Your love: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Your love. The word in the Hebrew text means “love” which is followed by the BSB and most other versions. However, the NEB and REB have the word “breasts” which is based on the Greek Septuagint translation. The issue here is that originally, the writers of the Hebrew OT did not write vowels. The consonants are the same for “love” and “breasts” (ddyk), but the unwritten vowels were different. The translators of the Greek OT interpreted ddyk and its implied vowels as mastoi sou “your breasts.” The Masoretic text, which most English versions follow here, interpret the word as “your love.” It is recommended that you follow the better Hebrew textual reading, love, as in the BSB. It is also used in 1:2. See the note on 1:2b for more information.

wine: The word wine refers here to a fermented drink made from grapes. It was a common beverage among the Hebrew people and was often used in celebrations. You should translate it as you did in 1:2b.

4:10c

and the fragrance of your perfume than all spices.

- The fragrance of your perfume is much better than any spice!
- The scent of perfume from your body is better than any other perfume!

and the fragrance of your perfume than all spices:

Here the phrase the fragrance of your perfume refers to the perfumed oil that the woman rubbed on her body to make her smell sweet. The man also wore perfumed oils. In 1:3a the woman told the man that his oils were fragrant. Here the man praised her oils even more. He said that they smelled better than any spice.

Some other ways to translate this comparison are:

Your perfume smells better than any spice. (NCV)

Your perfumed oil is more fragrant than the best of spices.

perfume: In the ancient Near East olive oil was used as a base for making perfume and cologne. Expensive fragrances were added to the oils. Some of these fragrances were made from costly foreign spices, and both men and women used them. Use appropriate words in your language to describe fragrances that men and women put on their bodies to make them smell good.

General Comment on 4:10b–c

The comparisons in 4:10b and 4:10c are parallel. Both comparisons say that something is better than something else. It is common in Hebrew poetry that part of the comparison is implied in the second parallel line, so it is not stated explicitly. The implied words in the example below are in brackets:

Your love is much better than wine,

and the fragrance of your perfume is much better than all spices!

Translate the comparison in a natural way in your language.

Song of Solomon 4:11

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple's wedding day. The section has several parts:

3:6–11 The man and woman came to their wedding in a grand procession

4:1–15 The man described his beautiful bride

4:16–5:1 The man and woman consummated their marriage

Paragraph 4:8–15 The man called his bride from Lebanon; and compared her to a private garden

In these lines the man continued to use figurative language to praise his bride (4:8–15). First, he spoke to her as if he and she were in Lebanon. Lebanon is a region north of Israel. It is far from Jerusalem (Zion), where they celebrated their wedding. In Lebanon the rugged mountains and wild animals make it dangerous for people to travel. The man calling the woman from Lebanon symbolizes that he thought the woman was wonderful and mysterious (like Lebanon), but perhaps she was reluctant to fully surrender herself to him. She seemed beyond his reach, as though she was up in the mountains, guarded by wild animals. Because he loved her, he was gentle as he wooed her, preparing her to surrender herself to him.

As you translate these lines, it is important to remember that the author used figurative language. The woman was not actually in Lebanon, and the man did not refer to a real journey from there. The garden descriptions in 4:12–15 are also figurative. They do not describe an actual garden.

Several poetic themes help to unify 4:8–15 and 4:16–5:1:

1. Lebanon (4:8, 11, 15): In the OT, Lebanon is often portrayed as a remote, beautiful, and fragrant place with mountains and cedar forests. (For example, see Psalm 72:16; Isaiah 35:2; 60:13; and Hosea 14:5–7.)
2. fragrances (4:10–11, 13–14, 16, 5:1, and maybe implied in 4:8) Lebanon was especially known for its fra-

grant cedar trees. So fragrance is probably implied in 4:8.

3. tastes (4:10–11, 13–14, 16, 5:1)
4. the garden metaphor (especially in focus in 4:12–5:1)

The context of 4:8–5:1, as well as 3:6–4:7, is probably the day of the couple's wedding. In 5:1, the women of Jerusalem encouraged them to consummate their love as husband and wife.

4:11a

Your lips, my bride, drip sweetness like the honeycomb;

- Your lips are as sweet as wild honey, my bride.
- My bride, your kisses are like honey.

Your lips, my bride, drip sweetness like the honeycomb:

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as drip has several meanings. Here it means “to drip” or “to drop.” Literally, it indicates that sweet nectar dripped from the bride's lips. Figuratively, it indicates that the bride's kisses were very sweet. Some other ways to translate the meaning are:

Your lips are as sweet as nectar, my bride. (NLT)

The taste of honey is on your lips, my darling; (GNT)

Your lips, my bride, drip sweetness: The phrase Your lips...drip sweetness is a metaphor that describes how “sweet” the bride's kisses are. Some scholars interpret 4:11a–b as referring to the bride's sweet words. Pope (page 484) says, “...the preferred reference is to friendly and sweet conversation. This seems plausible in the light of Proverbs 5:3 and the use of the verb... elsewhere for speech.” However, the context focuses on sensory experience. The man meant that her kisses gave him great pleasure. Some ways to translate the metaphor are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

My bride, your lips drip honey (NCV)

Your lips are a honeycomb (CEV)

- Use a simile. For example:

Your lips, my bride, are as sweet as honey. (NLT96)

Your lips taste like honey

- Translate the meaning without a figure of speech. For example:

Your lips/kisses are wonderfully sweet.

Your lips: The phrase Your lips is probably a figure of speech that uses lips to represent kisses. Some ways to translate this figure of speech are:

When I kiss you

Your lips/kisses

my bride: For information on how to translate my bride, see the notes on 4:8a–b.

drip sweetness: The words drip sweetness are a figure of speech. Since the woman’s “lips” refer figuratively to kisses here, the phrase drip sweetness indicates that the woman’s kisses gave the man great pleasure

sweetness: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sweetness refers specifically to “honey” or to a “honeycomb.” It does not refer to the nectar of flowers. However, if honey is unknown in your area, you may use a word that refers to the nectar of flowers.

4:11b

honey and milk are under your tongue,

- There is a sweetness of honey and milk under your tongue.
- Your kisses/mouth tastes like the sweetest honey and the richest/creamiest milk.

This part of the verse is parallel to 4:11a and has a similar meaning.

honey and milk are under your tongue: The phrase honey and milk are under your tongue is a metaphor. It indicates that the woman’s mouth was delightful. As with “lips” in 4:11a, the phrase under your tongue refers to the sweetness and pleasure that the woman’s kisses gave the man. It probably does not refer to her sweet speech, and it does not indicate that she was literally holding honey and milk in her mouth.

Honey and milk were luxury items. Here they imply that the woman’s love was an experience of luxurious delight.

Some ways to translate the metaphor are:

- Use a metaphor. For example:

Your tongue is milk and honey for me. (GNT)

- Use a simile. For example:

Your mouth is as delightful as milk and honey.

Your tongue is like milk and honey.

- Translate the meaning more directly. For example:

Your mouth is full of delights.

Translate the meaning in a natural way in your language.

honey and milk: In other parts of the OT the phrase “milk and honey” was used to describe the land of Israel as a fruitful place with abundant food. Here in the Song the word order is changed to honey and milk. These terms were also used in other love poetry of the Near East to express the joy and beauty of love. See the preceding note for translation examples.

honey: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as honey is a general word that refers to sweet substances. These substances can be added to food to make it sweeter. These sweeteners include bees’ honey from honeycombs as well as date or grape syrups. Use an appropriate word in your language.

4:11c

and the fragrance of your garments is like the aroma of Lebanon.

- The scent of your clothing is like the pleasing scents of Lebanon.
- Your clothes smell like the sweet fragrance of Lebanon.

the fragrance of your garments is like the aroma of Lebanon: Here the man compared the fragrance of the woman’s clothing to the pleasant scent of the region of Lebanon. Lebanon was famous for its cedar trees, so some scholars think the fragrance refers to the fragrance of the cedar trees. Others think that it refers more generally to the many pleasing scents of Lebanon.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a general way in your language to refer to a pleasant smell. For example:

Your clothes smell sweet/good like the region of Lebanon.

- Use a more specific comparison that refers to the mountains or cedars of Lebanon. For example:

Your clothes smell like the cedars of Lebanon.
(NCV)

The scent of your clothing is like that of the mountains and the cedars of Lebanon.

Choose a comparison that is pleasing in your language.

Lebanon: The land of Lebanon represented what was beautiful and fragrant. It was especially famous for its fragrant cedar trees. Refer to the notes on Lebanon in 4:8a-b and 4:8b for more information. It is important to notice the fragrance theme that is prominent throughout the Song.

garments: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as garments refers in general to clothing. It is good to use a general term in your language. For example:

clothing

clothes

like the aroma of Lebanon: The region of Lebanon is mentioned several times in 4:8-15. It forms a poetic Lebanon theme that helps give unity to lines 4:8-15. Here in 4:11 it forms an inclusio with 4:8, where the man said to the woman, "Come with me from Lebanon." In 4:11, the man implied that the woman figuratively came from Lebanon, and she still smelled like that wonderful place.

Song of Solomon 4:12

Section 3:6-5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1-5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple's wedding day. The section has several parts:

3:6-11 The man and woman came to their wedding in a grand procession

4:1-15 The man described his beautiful bride

4:16-5:1 The man and woman consummated their marriage

Paragraph 4:8-15 The man called his bride from Lebanon; and compared her to a private garden

In these lines the man continued to use figurative language to praise his bride (4:8-15). First, he spoke to her as if he and she were in Lebanon. Lebanon is a region north of Israel. It is far from Jerusalem (Zion), where they celebrated their wedding. In Lebanon the rugged mountains and wild animals make it dangerous for people to travel. The man calling the woman from Lebanon symbolizes that he thought the woman was wonderful and mysterious (like Lebanon), but perhaps she was reluctant to fully surrender herself to him. She seemed beyond his reach, as though she was up in the mountains, guarded by wild animals. Because he loved her, he was gentle as he wooed her, preparing her to surrender herself to him.

As you translate these lines, it is important to remember that the author used figurative language. The woman was not actually in Lebanon, and the man did not refer to a real journey from there. The garden descriptions in 4:12-15 are also figurative. They do not describe an actual garden.

Several poetic themes help to unify 4:8-15 and 4:16-5:1:

1. Lebanon (4:8, 11, 15): In the OT, Lebanon is often portrayed as a remote, beautiful, and fragrant place with mountains and cedar forests. (For example, see Psalm 72:16; Isaiah 35:2; 60:13; and Hosea 14:5-7.)
2. fragrances (4:10-11, 13-14, 16, 5:1, and maybe implied in 4:8) Lebanon was especially known for its fragrant cedar trees. So fragrance is probably implied in 4:8.
3. tastes (4:10-11, 13-14, 16, 5:1)
4. the garden metaphor (especially in focus in 4:12-5:1)

The context of 4:8-5:1, as well as 3:6-4:7, is probably the day of the couple's wedding. In 5:1, the women of Jerusalem encouraged them to consummate their love as husband and wife.

4:12-15

In 4:12-15 the man described the woman as an ideal garden with abundant water. The description uses hyperbole, since no real garden in ancient Israel had such a variety of plants growing together in one place. When the author describes the garden, he probably implies the effect that the woman herself had on the man. The author probably does not refer here to the effects of specific body parts related to sexual intimacy.

The author related these verses to the previous ones by using common themes and words. In 4:12 he repeated the phrase, my sister, my bride, that was used twice in the preceding verses. He also continued to speak of fragrances, and he concluded 4:15 with the Lebanon theme.

4:12a

My sister, my bride, you are a garden locked up,

- My sister, my bride, you are a locked garden,
- You are like a private garden, my beloved bride.

In 4:12 the man continued his theme of the woman being hard to reach, which he described in 4:8. But here the man used the metaphors of a “locked garden” and a “sealed fountain” to describe her.

My sister, my bride, you are a garden locked up:

Here the man described the woman with the metaphor of a beautiful garden that is locked up. No one was able to enter and come to her. Some scholars think that her beloved already came to her and had sexual relations with her. However, it is more likely that she was still a virgin. As in 2:14 and 4:8, the man again gently encouraged her to give herself totally to him. In 4:16 she will respond and invite him to “enter her garden” to be intimate with her.

In some languages it is more natural to change the order of the words in this sentence. For example:

My bride, my sister is a garden that is locked.

This statement is a metaphor. Other ways to translate the metaphor are:

- Use a simile. For example:

My sister, my bride, you are like a garden that is locked.

- Use a simile and indicate the implied meaning. For example:

My sister, my bride, you are as private as a locked garden.

My sister, my bride: The phrases My sister and my bride are parallel terms that the man used to express affection to his bride. The word bride also implies a marriage celebration. For a more detailed discussion of My sister, my bride, see the note on this phrase in 4:10a.

garden: In the land where the man and woman lived, The setting of the Song of Songs was somewhere in the Ancient Near East. A garden was like a park that had trees and flowers. The man did not refer here to a small garden with a few vegetables. The type of garden to which the man compared his bride was unusually beautiful. The trees in the garden were filled with delicious fruit, and its flowers included fragrant herbs. It was an imaginary garden, where everything was ideal. Use an appropriate word in your language for such a garden.

In 4:12 the man referred to the woman as if he were talking about her to others. But in 4:13 it is clear that he spoke directly to her when he said “your shoots.” In many languages it is more natural to indicate in both verses that the man spoke directly to her. For example:

You are a garden locked up, my sister, my bride...

4:12b

a spring enclosed,

- you are a locked spring,
- You are like an enclosed pool.

4:12c

a fountain sealed.

- you are a sealed fountain.
- You are like a spring that is protected with a seal/lock.

4:12b-c

a spring enclosed, a fountain sealed: The phrases a spring enclosed and a fountain sealed have similar meanings. Literally, they indicate that no one but the owner of the spring or fountain can take any of its water. Figuratively, they indicate that the woman was private. No one could come to her without permission. She was the source of refreshment for the man, and he was the only one who had a right to enjoy lovemaking with her.

In some languages it may be more natural to translate the figure of speech about the private spring and fountain only once. For example:

You are like a spring that is only for me.

a spring enclosed: There is a textual issue here with the word that the BSB translates as spring: The RSV follows an alternate textual reading gan “garden” which is found in some ancient versions (Septuagint, Syriac, and Vulgate). The Masoretic Hebrew text has gal “spring.” It is possible that there was a copyist’s

error since the words *gan* and *gal* look similar in Hebrew.

1. The Hebrew text has the word *gal*, which means “spring” or “pool.” For example:

you are a spring enclosed... (NIV) (BSB^c ESV, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT)

1. Other ancient versions have a word that means “garden.” For example:

a walled garden... (GNT) (RSV, CEV, GW, NAB, NASB, REB, GNT)

The decision about which text to follow is difficult, since either approach makes sense in the context. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), which follows the Hebrew text. It fits both the sounds of the poetry and its meaning especially well. There are two reasons that the Hebrew text seems correct: 1) The sounds of *gal na'ul* “a pool/fountain locked” links it with the sounds of the previous *gan na'ul* “a garden locked,” and 2) the meaning of *gal* “pool/fountain” links it with the word “spring” which follows. So both the poetic assonance and semantic cohesion is strengthened when following option (1).

Song of Solomon 4:13

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
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In these lines the man continued to use figurative language to praise his bride (4:8–15). First, he spoke to her as if he and she were in Lebanon. Lebanon is a region north of Israel. It is far from Jerusalem (Zion), where they celebrated their wedding. In Lebanon the rugged mountains and wild animals make it dangerous for people to travel. The man calling the woman from Lebanon symbolizes that he thought the woman was wonderful and mysterious (like Lebanon), but perhaps she was reluctant to fully surrender herself to him. She seemed beyond his reach, as though she was up in the mountains, guarded by wild animals. Because he loved her, he was gentle as he wooed her, preparing her to surrender herself to him.

As you translate these lines, it is important to remember that the author used figurative language. The woman was not actually in Lebanon, and the man did not refer to a real journey from there. The garden descriptions in 4:12–15 are also figurative. They do not describe an actual garden.

Several poetic themes help to unify 4:8–15 and 4:16–5:1:

1. Lebanon (4:8, 11, 15): In the OT, Lebanon is often portrayed as a remote, beautiful, and fragrant place with mountains and cedar forests. (For example, see Psalm 72:16; Isaiah 35:2; 60:13; and Hosea 14:5–7.)
2. fragrances (4:10–11, 13–14, 16, 5:1, and maybe implied in 4:8) Lebanon was especially known for its fragrant cedar trees. So fragrance is probably implied in 4:8.
3. tastes (4:10–11, 13–14, 16, 5:1)
4. the garden metaphor (especially in focus in 4:12–5:1)

The context of 4:8–5:1, as well as 3:6–4:7, is probably the day of the couple’s wedding. In 5:1, the women of Jerusalem encouraged them to consummate their love as husband and wife.

4:13a

Your branches are an orchard of pomegranates

- Your limbs are like an orchard of pomegranates (NCV)
- You are like a garden/grove that has pomegranate trees/bushes

Your branches are an orchard: Here the author again compares the woman to a garden. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *Your branches* occurs only here in the OT, and its meaning is uncertain. It seems to refer in general to what comes out from something else, like the shoots of plants, the streams of a river. For a brief discussion of this meaning, see Bloch

and Bloch, page 177. or the legs and arms of a person. Because of its general meaning, it must be translated in different ways in different contexts.

The phrase Your branches are an orchard is a metaphor. Some other ways to translate it in this context are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

You are paradise that produces... (GW)

- Use a simile. For example:

You are like a private garden (NLT96)

When you translate this metaphor, be careful that what it communicates is beautiful, and not ugly, humorous, or shocking. It should imply that the woman was refreshing and lovely like a garden. In some languages it may be more natural to speak of the woman herself instead of using the metaphor of branches. For example:

You are like a lovely orchard (NLT96)

You are paradise that produces pomegranates (GW)

an orchard: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as orchard also means “paradise.” The word in the Hebrew text is actually a Persian loan word meaning “park” or “paradise.” It was transliterated into Greek and also passed into English as a transliteration. and some versions translate it this way. orchard or “paradise” is parallel to “garden” in 4:12a.

of pomegranates: The word pomegranates refers to the fruit that grows on small bush-like trees that are also called “pomegranate trees.” The pomegranate fruit is smooth and red on the outside. Inside, its seeds are surrounded with a jelly-like pulp. Its juice is sweet and refreshing and was sometimes made into syrup or wine. The pomegranate fruit symbolized beauty. For more information and a picture of the fruit, see the note on 4:3c.

4:13b with the choicest of fruits,

- along with the all the best fruits,
- and all kinds of delicious fruit.

with the choicest of fruits: The phrase with the choicest of fruits introduces a list of the finest fruits

and spices. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as with is used several times in the list to introduce another fruit or spice.

In some languages (as in English), a connector like with may be confusing here. It may wrongly imply that pomegranate trees produce many kinds of fruit besides pomegranates. However, the meaning here is “along with” or simply “and.” Other ways to translate the connection between 4:13a and 4:13b are:

pomegranates along with many other choicest fruits...

pomegranates and the best fruits (GW)

For the list in 4:13–14 use natural connectors in your language.

the choicest of fruits: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as fruits is a general word for fruit. The phrase the choicest of fruits indicates a variety of the best and most delicious kinds of fruit. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

the best/finest fruits

rare spices (NLT)

as well as many other wonderful fruits

4:13c with henna and nard,

- and henna along with nard,
- Your charms are like fragrant henna shrubs and nard spice bushes,

In 14:13c the list of orchard plants continues.

with henna and nard: The phrase henna and nard refers to two plants that smell sweet. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

henna bushes and nard plants

henna and nard

henna: The word henna refers to a shrub (bush) with very fragrant flowers.

nard: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as nard is a plant used to produce an oil which has a sweet spicy fragrance. This plant is often called “spikenard.”

It grows in the Himalaya mountains, far from Israel, and it was expensive for people in Israel to buy. If people are not familiar with nard in your area, it is helpful to indicate what it is, or to use a general word or phrase. For example:

nard plants

nard spice bushes

sweet-smelling spice bushes

This word also occurred in 1:12b, where the Notes recommended that translators refer to the plant in a more general way. For more information, see the note there.

Song of Solomon 4:14

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple's wedding day. The section has several parts:

3:6–11 The man and woman came to their wedding in a grand procession

4:1–15 The man described his beautiful bride

4:16–5:1 The man and woman consummated their marriage

Paragraph 4:8–15 The man called his bride from Lebanon; and compared her to a private garden

In these lines the man continued to use figurative language to praise his bride (4:8–15). First, he spoke to her as if he and she were in Lebanon. Lebanon is a region north of Israel. It is far from Jerusalem (Zion), where they celebrated their wedding. In Lebanon the rugged mountains and wild animals make it dangerous for people to travel. The man calling the woman from Lebanon symbolizes that he thought the woman was wonderful and mysterious (like Lebanon), but perhaps she was reluctant to fully surrender herself to him. She seemed beyond his reach, as though she was up

in the mountains, guarded by wild animals. Because he loved her, he was gentle as he wooed her, preparing her to surrender herself to him.

As you translate these lines, it is important to remember that the author used figurative language. The woman was not actually in Lebanon, and the man did not refer to a real journey from there. The garden descriptions in 4:12–15 are also figurative. They do not describe an actual garden.

Several poetic themes help to unify 4:8–15 and 4:16–5:1:

1. Lebanon (4:8, 11, 15): In the OT, Lebanon is often portrayed as a remote, beautiful, and fragrant place with mountains and cedar forests. (For example, see Psalm 72:16; Isaiah 35:2; 60:13; and Hosea 14:5–7.)
2. fragrances (4:10–11, 13–14, 16, 5:1, and maybe implied in 4:8) Lebanon was especially known for its fragrant cedar trees. So fragrance is probably implied in 4:8.
3. tastes (4:10–11, 13–14, 16, 5:1)
4. the garden metaphor (especially in focus in 4:12–5:1)

The context of 4:8–5:1, as well as 3:6–4:7, is probably the day of the couple's wedding. In 5:1, the women of Jerusalem encouraged them to consummate their love as husband and wife.

4:14a with nard and saffron,

- both nard and saffron.
- even those rare nard bushes and saffron flowers.

In 4:14 the man continued to list plants that were found in the beautiful garden that he described. He used the plants in a figurative way to describe his bride.

with nard: The oil of the nard plant is expensive for people in Israel and the Near East. The author repeats nard here (from 4:13) for emphasis. Consider how to emphasize it in a natural way in your language. For example:

even nard plants

the expensive nard spice

In some languages it is helpful to have another introduction to the comparisons. For example:

Yes, in the garden are precious nard plants.

and saffron: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as saffron is a type of crocus with purple flowers. It was used to produce an oil with a sweet floral fragrance. In some languages it is helpful to indicate what saffron refers to. For example:

saffron flowers

beautiful saffron flowers

4:14b

with calamus and cinnamon,

- There are both calamus and cinnamon,
- Your garden has calamus plants, cinnamon trees,

The list of orchard plants continues in this part of the verse.

with calamus: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as calamus probably refers to a type of sweet cane. It produces an oil that has a spicy fragrance. Some other ways to translate calamus here are:

calamus plants

sweet cane plants

calamus canes that produce fragrant oil

and cinnamon: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as cinnamon refers to the small tree called “cinnamon.” The bark of the cinnamon tree is used to make a fragrant spice. In the Bible this spice was used to make anointing oil.

Some other ways to translate cinnamon here are:

cinnamon trees

cinnamon spice trees

4:14c

with every kind of frankincense tree, with myrrh and aloes,

- along with other trees: frankincense, myrrh and aloe trees,
- and other trees such as frankincense, sweet-smelling myrrh trees and aloe trees.

with every kind of frankincense tree, with myrrh and aloes: The phrase every kind of introduces a list of other spice trees, frankincense, myrrh and aloes,

in addition to the cinnamon tree that was just mentioned in 4:14b.

frankincense: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as frankincense also occurred in 3:6c. For more information, see the note there. You should translate it in the same way in both verses.

myrrh: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as myrrh also occurred in 3:6c. For more information, see the note there. You should translate it in the same way in both verses.

aloes: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as aloes refers here to a type of fragrant resin that is sometimes found inside certain trees of east India. The resin develops because of an infection in the tree, which causes the resin to grow inside the tree. The aloes resin is rare and valuable. Other ways to translate aloes here are:

aloes wood

aloes resin

fragrant resin called aloes

4:14d

with all the finest spices.

- along with all the most fragrant spices.
- It also has all the other finest spices.

with all the finest spices: The phrase with all the finest spices indicates that there are many other fragrant spices. It implies that the man could list them all as being in the “garden” to which he compared the woman. She was as wonderful as all those spices. The spices are so many that he cannot list them all specifically.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

along with all the other best/finest spices

and every other lovely spice. (NLT)

General Comment on 4:13–14

In these two verses the man compared the woman to a garden that was extravagant. Many of the plants were rare and valuable. Some of them were not native to Palestine, where the man and woman lived. It had the most wonderful fragrant plants that a person can imagine. This description of the fantasy garden is

a hyperbole. It implies that the man considered his beloved to be full of wonderful delights.

Song of Solomon 4:15

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
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4. the garden metaphor (especially in focus in 4:12–5:1)

The context of 4:8–5:1, as well as 3:6–4:7, is probably the day of the couple's wedding. In 5:1, the women of Jerusalem encouraged them to consummate their love as husband and wife.

4:15

In 4:15 the man stopped describing the wonderful plants of the garden (4:13–14). He began to describe the spring inside the garden that gave it water.

4:15a–b

You are a garden spring, a well of fresh water: The phrases a garden spring and a well of fresh water use two different metaphors to express the same meaning. Both phrases describe an abundant source of fresh water that flows out and waters the garden to help the fruits and spices mentioned in 4:13–14 to grow. The water is a metaphor to describe the woman as a source of joy and life.

4:15a

You are a garden spring,

- You are a garden fountain,
- You are like a garden fountain

a garden spring: In this verse the man continued to speak to the woman. He compared her to a fountain (or spring) in a garden. In some languages it is necessary to make this comparison explicit, as many English versions do. For example:

You are like a garden fountain (NCV)

In Hebrew the word garden is plural, and the phrase a garden spring is literally “a fountain of gardens.” This phrase is a figure of speech to emphasize that the fountain produces abundant water. Another way to translate that meaning is:

You are like many springs that make the garden moist.

spring: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as spring refers to water that flows out from an opening in the ground. This type of spring is often called a “fountain” in English (as in the RSV). A spring produces a constant flow of fresh water. This is in contrast to

a well where the water stays in one place and can become stagnant. Use a word in your language that refers to a natural spring, not a man-made fountain.

4:15b

a well of fresh water

- you are a spring of fresh water,
- and like a spring of running water,

a well of fresh water: As in 4:15a, the man continued to speak to the woman. He indicated that she was like a well of fresh water. In an ordinary well, the water does not flow or move, so the water can become dirty and stagnant. The woman is like an unusual well that produces flowing (fresh) water.

The phrase fresh water indicates that the water continues to flow inside the well, as if it were in a stream. It contrasts with water in an ordinary well that does not move or flow. Some scholars suggest that the source of the well is a spring, which causes the water in the well to keep moving.

Some ways to translate a well of fresh water are:

a well of living water (RSV)

a well that has flowing water

a spring of pure water

4:15c

flowing down from Lebanon.

- that becomes streams flowing down Lebanon.
- flowing from the Lebanon mountains.

flowing down from Lebanon: Here the man compared the woman to streams that flow from Lebanon. The author implies that the Lebanon mountains are the source of the best fresh water. (Those mountains were also the source of wonderful fragrances in 4:11c.) Some ways to translate the comparison are:

You are like a refreshing stream that flows from Lebanon.

and streams flowing from Lebanon. (NASB)

flowing: The word flowing has a similar meaning to “spring” in 4:15a and the well “of fresh water” in 4:15b. The phrase describes this water as being like water that comes down from the Lebanon mountains. It is clear, fresh and flowing.

from Lebanon: Here Lebanon is the source of flowing streams of water. In 4:11 Lebanon was the source of wonderful fragrances.

In 4:8 the man implied that the Lebanon mountains isolated the woman from him. Here the metaphor of the Lebanon mountains changes. The man describes the flowing streams from the Lebanon mountains as a source of life and joy. The reference to Lebanon in 4:8a–b and 4:15 form an inclusio.

Other ways to translate from Lebanon here are:

from the Lebanon Mountains. (GNT)

down the mountains in Lebanon.

Song of Solomon 4:16

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

1. The scene changes from a nighttime dream to a public daytime event.
2. There is a change of speaker.
3. The search theme in the preceding verses changes to a wedding theme in this section.
4. The mood changes from anxious searching to joyful celebration.

In this section the author describes the couple’s wedding day. The section has several parts:

3:6–11 The man and woman came to their wedding in a grand procession

4:1–15 The man described his beautiful bride

4:16–5:1 The man and woman consummated their marriage

Paragraph 4:16–5:1 The man and woman united in marriage

These two verses (4:16 and 5:1) can be considered the climax of the Song. In 4:16 the woman spoke for the first time since 3:5. She responded to the man’s praise in 4:1–15, and she indirectly invited him to enter the “garden.” Here the garden is a poetic way for the woman to refer to herself. The woman invited the man to come “into her garden,” and in 5:1 he did come in.

In Hebrew the word used for “awake” in 4:16 is the same word that was used in 2:7c–d. There the woman told the other women not to stir up nor awaken love until the right time. In 4:16–5:1 the time became right

for love to awaken. The man and woman were married, and it was time to fulfill their desires for each other.

4:16a

Awake, O north wind,

- North wind, wake up!
- The north wind

4:16b

and come, O south wind.

- South wind, come!
- and the south wind must both start gently blowing!

4:16a–c

Awake, O north wind, and come, O south wind.

Breathe on my garden: Here the woman replied to the man indirectly by calling to the wind. She used a figurative way to invite him to be intimate with her. When she told the winds to blow on the locked garden, she indicated that she was opening the garden so the man could enter and enjoy its fruits. The garden represents the woman herself. She called the winds to blow so that her fragrance would reach the man and make him want to come to her.

In this verse the woman speaks directly to the north and south winds. In some languages speaking to the wind may imply a wrong meaning or it may not be natural. If that is true in your language, you may translate the meaning indirectly. For example:

How I wish the north and south winds would blow!
I wish they would come and blow on my garden!

Let the north wind blow, the south wind too! Let
them spread the aroma of my garden (CEV)

In some languages it may be helpful to make the figurative meaning more explicit. For example:

The north and south winds should arise and blow
to spread the fragrances of my garden to my
beloved!

Awake...come: The woman calls to the winds to Awake and come. In some languages, there may be a more natural way to speak about the wind rising. Use a natural way in your language. For example:

O winds, be stirred, start blowing/breathing...

The winds should rise and fly/come

north wind...south wind: Scholars are not sure why the author mentioned the directions north and south to describe the winds. The words north and south may represent winds from all directions, or it may be a poetic way to talk about wind here. Use a natural way in your language to speak about the wind. Other ways to translate these winds in this context are:

O north wind, rise and blow!

O south wind, come!

O winds, come from all directions,

come and blow!

4:16c–d

Breathe on my garden and spread the fragrance of its spices:

Here the woman called on the wind to blow on her garden so that its fragrance would spread. She specifically wanted her beloved (4:16e–f) to smell the sweet odors and come to her. So 4:16d is the purpose for the action in 4:16c. Some other ways to translate the action and purpose are:

- Use a purpose connector. For example:

Blow on my garden so that its fragrant spices may
send out their sweet smell. (NET)

- Translate the clauses as separate actions. For example:

blow on my garden; fill the air with fragrance.
(GNT)

Translate the actions in a natural way in your language.

4:16c

Breathe on my garden

- Blow across my garden
- They must breathe on my garden,

Breathe on my garden: The phrase Breathe on my garden indicates that the woman wanted the wind to blow on her garden so that the good odors of the fruits and flowers there will spread. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

Waft over my garden!

Blow on/over my garden!

my garden: In 4:12 the man compared the woman to a garden. Here the woman used the phrase my garden in a figurative way to speak about herself. The fragrant garden represents the woman. Before 4:16 she was like a locked garden because she had not yet “opened” her body to anyone. In 4:16e, she will speak of herself as “his garden,” which will be a major change for them.

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate more explicitly that the woman compared herself to a garden here. For example:

I am like a garden that needs the wind to blow across it

4:16d and spread the fragrance of its spices.

- and spread its fragrance.
- so that its fragrant spices may send out their sweet smell. (NET)

spread the fragrance of its spices: In this clause the woman continued to speak to the winds. She implied that the winds should spread the fragrances of her garden. The next clauses (4:16e-f) show that she wanted those odors to reach the man who was outside the garden. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and spread its fragrance all around (NLT)

so that my beloved will smell its sweet odors

spread: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as spread means “to flow.” The woman wanted the odor of the perfume to flow through the air. The context implies that she wanted it to reach her beloved. She hoped that the odor would attract him to come to her.

the fragrance of its spices: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the fragrance of its spices is literally “its spices” or “its perfumes.” The ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NJPS, and REB translate literally in this way. However, the author refers to the sweet odor of the spices. In many languages it is clearer to refer directly to the fragrance (BSB) or “sweet smell.” It is the odor of the spices and not the spices themselves that the woman wanted the wind to spread. The garden’s fragrance represents the woman’s perfume or her sweet odor in general.

4:16e

Let my beloved come into his garden

- It is time for my love to come to his garden
- My beloved, come now and enter your garden.

Let my beloved come into his garden: Here the woman shifted from speaking to the wind (4:16a-d) to speaking to her beloved. She used an indirect way to tell him that she desired his love. In some languages this indirect request may not be clear or it may imply a wrong meaning. If that is true in your language, you may communicate the meaning more directly. For example:

Come into your garden, my love (NLT)

My love, I am your garden. Come in

Let...come: The verb Let...come is a request. The woman used it to invite the man into her garden. The garden is a symbol for the woman herself, so the request implies that she wanted the man to show his love for her. Translate this desire in a natural way in your language. See the examples in the preceding note.

his garden: The words “my garden” (4:16c) and his garden (4:16e) both refer to the woman. They do not refer to two different gardens. Here the woman changed from referring to herself (or her body) as “my garden,” to saying that she was his garden. This change shows that the woman agreed to be united with the man in the sexual union that a husband and wife share. This shift from “my garden” to his garden implies that they were now husband and wife.

4:16f

and taste its choicest fruits.

- and eat some of its delicious fruits.
- Taste its best fruits.

and taste its choicest fruits: In this part of the verse the woman continued her indirect request for the man to unite with her in marital relations. She offered her husband the freedom to eat the best fruits of her garden. This offer is a metaphor and a euphemism. It means that she invited her husband to enjoy her as they had sexual relations together. Use an appropriate way for a modest woman to invite her husband to make love to her.

Some other ways to do this in English are:

enjoy my best fruits

share the pleasure of the finest fruit of my love

In some languages it may be helpful to include a footnote in your translation. For example:

The woman here invites the man to have marital relations with her.

taste: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as taste is used here as a euphemism to refer to enjoying making love.

its choicest fruits: A similar phrase to its choicest fruits also occurred in 4:13b. There the man described the woman as a garden and mentioned her “choicest fruits.” So here in 4:16 she quoted the man and invited him to come and eat those fruits. The phrase choicest fruits figuratively refers to the woman’s sensual charms and her lovemaking. Some other ways to translate it are:

its greatest pleasures

its sweet delights

Song of Solomon 5:1

Section 3:6–5:1: The man and woman married and the man praised her

In 3:6 a new section begins. The author indicates this by several obvious changes from (3:1–5):

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These two verses (4:16 and 5:1) can be considered the climax of the Song. In 4:16 the woman spoke for the first time since 3:5. She responded to the man’s praise in 4:1–15, and she indirectly invited him to enter the

“garden.” Here the garden is a poetic way for the woman to refer to herself. The woman invited the man to come “into her garden,” and in 5:1 he did come in.

In Hebrew the word used for “awake” in 4:16 is the same word that was used in 2:7c–d. There the woman told the other women not to stir up nor awaken love until the right time. In 4:16–5:1 the time became right for love to awaken. The man and woman were married, and it was time to fulfill their desires for each other.

5:1

A new chapter begins here, but the original Hebrew text did not indicate chapter breaks. In the final verse of chapter 4, the woman spoke to the man, and in 5:1 he responded. Because of that, it is more natural to include 5:1 in the same section as 4:16. It is recommended that you not begin a new section until the beginning of 5:2.

5:1a–d

In 5:1a–d the man gladlyThe BSB and many other versions fail to fully capture the excitement on the man’s part. In those versions he seemed to respond in a plain, unemotional way that is almost anticlimactic. But in Hebrew there are several indicators that the man was probably expressing himself with deep emotion:1) The heavy use of 1st person possessive forms contrasts sharply with the previously locked garden.2) The perfective aspect probably functions in an emphatic way, suggesting complete satisfaction or fulfillment.3) The emotional force of the metaphors adds strong impact to the verse.The man’s emotion in this verse is probably at least as intense as when he was describing the woman in 4:1–15. This is, after all, the climax of his longings. He accepted the woman’s invitation to enter her garden. He referred back to the way he described her and the garden in 4:9–15. At that time, the woman was like a locked garden that the man could not enter. But here in 5:1 he said “my” eight times. He implied that now the woman was his wife, and he was free to enjoy the sensual pleasures that she offered him. The garden with its fruit and spices symbolizes the woman.

I have come...I have gathered...I have eaten...I have drunk:

There are several ways to translate the Hebrew form of the verbs come, gathered, eaten, and drunk.All four Hebrew verbs in 5:1a–d are in the perfect aspect. This form does not indicate whether the actions are past, present or future.In terms of time, the Hebrew text does not focus on time nor does it indicate time of action. Rather it focuses on the event itself; on its beginning, as well as the assured continuation, of this whole and fulfilling event. There is no time indicated by the perfective aspect marker. Here the verbs prob-

ably refer to what the man was about to do. He implied that he will now have sexual relations with his wife to complete their marriage. This sense is in keeping with the semantic nature of the verbal metaphors that deal ultimately with emotional or romantic satisfaction. The nuanced significance of the perfective marker relies on contextual (including semantic) factors. Several other facts support it: (a) In 5:1e–f the wedding guests blessed the man and woman, saying: “Eat, O friends, and drink deeply.” This blessing implies that the couple will soon enjoy sexual union, but they have not yet experienced it. (b) The guests were at the wedding when they blessed the man and woman. They used commands to tell the couple to begin to freely enjoy sexual love. Past tense forms do not fit the context or the moral standards of the OT. (c) The present tense verbs do not imply that the couple began to have sexual relations at the moment when the guests blessed them. After the blessing, the couple went to a private place for their sexual union. This interpretation fits well with 5:1e–f, where their wedding guests told them to “eat...and drink deeply.”

Some other ways to translate these verbs are:

I am here in my garden...I gather my myrrh...and eat my honeycomb with my honey. I drink my wine with my milk. (NLT96)

I have entered my garden...I am gathering my spices and myrrh; I am eating my honey and honeycomb; I am drinking my wine and milk. (GNT)

5:1a

I have come to my garden, my sister, my bride;

- My dear one, my bride, I am here in my garden.
- My bride, I have come to you. You are my own garden!

I have come to my garden, my sister, my bride: Here the man responded to the woman’s invitation in 4:16. It is the fourth time that he used the phrase my sister, my bride to refer to the woman. The first time is in 4:9a. You should translate the phrase in the same way here. In many languages it is more natural to begin the verse with this phrase. For example:

My bride, my very own, I come to my garden. (CEV)

Notice that the CEV used the phrase “my very own” instead of my sister, since the woman was not literally his sister. The CEV also put the phrase “My bride”

first. Use a natural way in your language for a man to address the woman he loves and has just married.

I have come to my garden: The phrase I have come indicates here that the man accepted the woman’s invitation in 4:16. She already opened her locked garden to him, and now he entered. The garden represents the woman herself. When the man said I have come, he accepted her invitation to be intimate with her. In some languages it is necessary to make this meaning more explicit. For example:

I have come to you, my private garden

you are like my own garden, and I have come in

my garden: Here there is a contrast with the way the man used the word garden in 4:12–15. In 4:12 he spoke of the woman as “a locked garden.” He implied that he still could not enter it. Here in 5:1 he spoke of her as my garden. In some languages it may be helpful to indicate that he spoke about the woman as his garden. See the preceding note for examples.

5:1b–d

I have gathered my myrrh with my spice. I have eaten my honeycomb with my honey; I have drunk my wine with my milk:

These three clauses use figurative ways to describe the sexual union that the man had with the woman. The man compared it to enjoying the delights of a garden. Scholars differ about when the man and woman had this sexual union. The man implied that they united in this way as he spoke in 5:1b–d. However, it probably happened very soon after he spoke. Some languages are tense-priority languages while others are aspect-priority. This can cause difficulties when translating from one type of language to another. Hebrew, for example, is aspect-priority, while English is tense-priority.

In some languages present tense may not be natural for these actions, since they did not happen at exactly the same time as the man spoke. If that is true in your language, it may be more natural to refer to the man’s intention to do the actions instead of referring to the actions themselves. For example:

I have come to my garden, my sister, my bride, to gather my myrrh with my spice, to eat my honeycomb with my honey, to drink my wine with my milk.

I have gathered my myrrh...spice: The phrase I have gathered my myrrh and spice refers literally to har-

vesting some of the resin of the myrrh tree and the spice tree. To harvest these resins, a person must cut into the trees. Then a sticky substance called “resin” will gradually come out. These resins are sweet-smelling spices that are used to make ointments and perfumes. The spice tree is the same tree as the frankincense tree from 4:14c. However, in this context the phrase has a figurative meaning. The man used the gathering of myrrh and spice as a figure of speech to refer to enjoying the love of his bride.

In some languages a literal translation may give a wrong meaning. Some other ways to translate the figure of speech are:

- Use a more general figure of speech that refers to enjoying a garden. For example:

I come to my garden and enjoy its spices. (CEV)

- Use a simile. For example:

I come to my love and delight in her like a man enjoying the sweetest spices.

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

I delight in the sweet kisses/charms of my love.

5:1b

I have gathered my myrrh with my spice.

- I am ready to gather my myrrh and my spice,
- I will enjoy all the delights you give, as if I were gathering the sweetest/best spices,

with my spice: The words with my spice refers back to the frankincense in 4:14c. The spices were locked up in the garden, but now they are his to enjoy. The spice probably refers to the fragrance of the woman’s perfume.

5:1c

I have eaten my honeycomb with my honey;

- I have come to eat my honeycomb and my honey,
- and eating my honey with its honeycomb,

I have eaten my honeycomb with my honey: This is the second of the three clauses that describe the man partaking of the garden’s delights. The phrase I have eaten my honeycomb with my honey is a metaphor. It refers back to 4:11a–b where honey symbolized the woman’s sweet kisses. So here it probably refers specifically to her sensual kisses and more generally

to their lovemaking. The word my indicates that her kisses and her lovemaking are now his to enjoy.

As in 5:1b, there are several ways to translate this metaphor, and you can translate it in a similar way as you translated it there. For example:

I have enjoyed your charms like a man eating his honeycomb with its honey.

Loving you is as sweet as eating honey with the honeycomb.

Your kisses are as sweet to me as honey and the honeycomb.

I have eaten: The man said I have eaten to respond to what the woman said in 4:16f. She invited him to come to her garden and “eat its choicest fruits.”

5:1d

I have drunk my wine with my milk.

- I have come to drink my wine and my milk.
- and drinking my wine and milk.

I have drunk my wine with my milk: Here the man used a third clause to describe how he enjoyed the garden’s delights. It is a figurative way to speak about enjoying the woman’s charms. You should continue to use the same tense of the verb have drunk as you used for the verbs “have gathered” and “have eaten” in 5:1b and 5:1c.

As in 5:1b and 5:1c, there are several ways to translate this metaphor. It is probably good to translate it in a similar way as you translated the metaphors there. Some ways to translate it are:

I have drunk in the charms of my loved-one like someone drinking the best wine and milk.

My love nourishes me like the best milk and wine.

my wine with my milk: wine was mentioned in 4:10 and milk in 4:11. The man used drinking wine and milk in a figurative way. He described how he felt when he and the woman showed their love to each other. That is, when they expressed their love for each other through sexual relations. He felt joyful and refreshed as if he were drinking wine and milk. In the Song wine is a symbol of love (see, for example, 1:2 and 4:10). The word my indicates that now the woman’s lovemaking belonged to the man to enjoy.

5:1e–f

At the end of 5:1d the man finished speaking. The author did not indicate explicitly who spoke in 5:1e–f and to whom they spoke. Some English versions indicate the speakers in the margin or in footnotes, and some versions do not identify the speakers. The main views about the speakers and who they spoke to here are:

1. A group of wedding guests (probably the Jerusalem women or other friends) spoke to the couple. For example:

Their Friends Speak (CEV)

Young Women of Jerusalem (NLT) (BSB, CEV, ESV, NAB, NCV, NIV, NLT, NRSV, GNT)

1. The author of the Song spoke to the couple. For example:

The Poet to the Couple (NET) (NET, NJB)

1. The man (groom) spoke to the wedding guests. The versions that follow this view generally indicate it without a heading. For example:

Eat, my friends! (GW) (GW, NASB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with the majority of English versions. Option 2 is also a valid option. Option 3 is not recommended. It seems to imply that the groom invited the wedding guests to participate in lovemaking. An invitation to an orgy hardly seems likely here! Some commentators and versions identify these guests specifically as the Jerusalem women. Others suggest friends or other guests. It is likely that the women of Jerusalem were the speakers, since they spoke to the woman in other parts of the Song (for example, in 1:5; 2:7; 3:5; 3:11; 5:8–16; and 6:1–3).

5:1e**Eat, O friends, and drink;**

- Friends, drink and eat!
- Now, you^(plur) lovers, enjoy

Eat, O friends, and drink: Here the wedding guests encouraged the newly married couple to eat and drink to celebrate their marriage. The words Eat and drink have the same meaning as in 5:1b–d. The verbs are a tactful way to say, “enjoy sexual relations with each other.” The guests encouraged the couple to enjoy

their love-making. Translate this meaning in an appropriate way for your culture.

In some languages it is more natural to put the direct address to the couple in a different place in the sentence. For example:

Friends, eat and drink...

Eat, lovers, and drink (GNT)

O friends: The word friends refers here to the newly married couple, and you should make that clear in a natural way in your language. The word O is not in the Hebrew text, but some English versions add it to indicate that the wedding guests spoke directly to the bride and groom and called them friends.

5:1f**drink freely, O beloved.**

- Love each other with joy like people drinking their favorite wine!
- loving each other and be completely satisfied!

drink freely, O beloved: The meaning of 5:1f is similar to the meaning of 5:1e, and the author repeats the meaning to emphasize it. However, in this context there are two different ways to interpret the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as beloved. In other verses of the Song and in other books of the OT, this plural form of the word means “love, expressions of affection.” There are two ways to interpret it here:

1. The word means “love” or “lovemaking.” For example:

Drink deep of love! (NJPS) (NRSV, CEV, ESV, GW, NAB, NIV, NJPS, NLT, REB, GNT)

1. The word means “lovers.” For example:

...drink your fill, O lovers. (NIV) (BSB, RSV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions. A similar example with the plural form of “love” occurs in Proverbs 7:18, which the BSB translates as “Come, let us take our fill of love till morning.” Ezekiel 16:8 and 23:17 also have clear examples of “love” used with this meaning of love-making. In Song 1:2, 1:4, 4:10, and 7:12 the BSB also translates it as “love” rather than “lovers.”

Since the BSB follows interpretation (2) here, the Display will use the NIV as the source line for 5:1f.

(NIV) drink your fill of love: This phrase is a figure of speech. It indicates that the bride and groom should delight in making fervent love with each other. Some ways to translate the figure are:

- Translate the figure of speech directly (drinking love). For example:

Yes, drink deeply of your love! (NLT)

Drink deep of love! (NJPS)

- Use a figure of speech that has the same meaning in your language. For example:

make love with each other to your heart's content

- Translate the meaning directly. For example:

love each other freely

delight yourselves in loving each other

Some English versions translate the idea of being “drunk” with love (for example, GW and NRSV). However, such a comparison may cause problems, since the point of comparison is not clear. Because of that, it may cause people to misunderstand the verse, especially in cultures where drinking too much wine has damaged people’s lives.

(NIV) love: The word love can also be translated as “lovemaking” in this context. For more information, see the note on “your love” in 1:2b. It is also helpful to read the note there on “your love is better than wine.”

General Comment on 5:1

When the wedding guests told the man and woman to “drink freely of love (NIV),” it was their blessing on their sexual relationship as husband and wife. This verse (5:1) is a climax to this section and to the book. There is another type of climax in 8:6-7.

Remember that the language in 4:1-5:1 describes the feelings of love and lovemaking in beautiful and delicate ways. The author describes romantic love in a powerful way, but he does not use vulgar words or phrases that would make modest people feel ashamed. Kinlaw (page 1230) says: “The language used here of love’s consummation is classic in its chasteness, a character possible only through the use of

symbolic language. The beauty of expression fits the holiest of all human relationships. Metaphor plays the same role here as the veil in the temple. Sinful man needs such to protect the mystery.” It is important for translators also to find artistic ways to communicate the beauty of the Song and to use modest language that is appropriate for the cultural context.

Song of Solomon 5:2

Section 5:2-6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2-7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10-16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2-3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2-7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2-7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
2. Section 3:6-5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman. Does Section 5:2-6:3 tell about a time after they married? Although 3:6-5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman, 5:2-6:3 may not refer to a time after the wedding. It may describe something they experienced more than once. In other sections also, the man and woman were apart at the beginning but together at the end (as in 1:2-2:7). If 5:2-6:3 refers to a time before their wedding, some scholars view the whole book, Song of Songs, as a large chiasm. (For example, Dorsey suggests *abdc b'a'*, (1999, p.200.)) So, the section, 3:6-5:1 is the central and climactic part of the chiasm, and what comes before and after are related to the center, not chronologically but thematically. So, the material both before and after, may be pointing to the grand central climax, the wedding. What follows the wedding, 5:2-8:14, may actually repeat much of the material in 1:2-3:5. Again, this is more of a cyclical rather than chronological way of

understanding the book. It describes the woman's hopes and fears as she imagined her future with the man (as in 3:1-4). The dream might indicate that she feared that he had stopped loving her, but at the end of 6:2-3, she realized that he continued to love her faithfully. Some scholars believe that this section follows chronologically after the wedding. Some of these scholars interpret it as describing a time of conflict for the newly married couple. But the theme of marital conflict does not seem to fit the overall message or tone of the Song.

3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see "Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song" in POEM 4:1-7.)

Paragraph 5:2-8 The woman spoke to the women of Jerusalem

There are different ways to interpret what the woman said in 5:2-8:

1. She told about something that she dreamed or imagined. She described her feelings for the man in a poetic way.
2. She told what happened when the man actually came to her. She was sleeping, but she woke up when she heard him knocking on her door.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The verses probably describe something that the woman dreamed or imagined, since some of the descriptions seem unreal or dreamlike. They are a poetic way to express the woman's feelings for the man.

Does 5:2-8 describe sexual relations between the woman and man?

There are two views about whether 5:2-8 implies that they had sexual relations:

1. The verses indicate romantic feelings, but they do not describe sexual relations between the man and woman. He stood outside her house knocking, but she was already in bed. She delayed in opening her door, and he left before she opened it.
2. The verses have a double meaning. For example, in 5:4 they interpret the man's "hand" and the door "latch" (literally "hole" in Hebrew) as referring to male and female sexual organs. Pope and some other modern commentators follow this view. The man was outside the room knocking on the door. He was also outside the woman's body, wanting to enter and have sexual relations with her.

It is recommended that you follow option (1), which is followed by many reliable commentaries. See, for example, Assis, Barbiero, Bloch and Bloch, Davidson, Delitzsch, Elliott, Estes, Fox, Ginsburg, Gordis, Hess, Mitchell, and Murphy. Michael Fox argues that this view spoils the true romantic impact and beauty of the book (Fox, pages 144-145). The text indicates that the man did not come inside the woman's house, but he left before she could open the door.

Common themes

This section has similar themes (motifs) that were part of earlier sections. You should translate such themes in a similar way throughout the book. This helps readers understand the unity of the Song. For example, as in 3:1-4, also here in 5:2-8, the author told about the woman having a dream and searching for her beloved in the town at night. Also, in 2:8-14, the young man stood outside the woman's house, but she was inside behind a locked door. This theme of the woman being hard to reach is also found in 2:9; 2:14; 4:8; and 4:12.

5:2a

I sleep, but my heart is awake.

- While I slept, I began to dream.
- One night as I was asleep in bed, I started to dream.

I sleep, but my heart is awake: The phrase I sleep, but my heart is awake probably indicates that as the woman slept, she had a dream. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

I was sleeping, and I began to dream.

As I slept, I dreamed.

In some languages there may be an idiom that indicates that a person is dreaming. For example:

I slept but my mind was alert.

Use a natural way in your language to refer to dreaming.

heart: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as heart is used in many idioms in Hebrew. Here it refers to the part of the woman that was aware of what happened around her. In some languages it is not necessary to use a part of the body to describe being aware. For example:

I slept but I was still alert.

5:2b–e

In 5:2b–e the man came to the woman’s house at night and knocked on the door. He asked her to open it and to let him come in. The text does not indicate whether the man had a specific reason to visit her, but he was respectful and spoke in a loving way. He stood outside her house in the damp night air. She did not want to get out of bed, so she said that she was ready to sleep. But he continued to knock, because he wanted to be with her. Her hesitation to let him in may imply that she feared to risk the pain or difficulties that such love might cause. Some commentators think that the man’s comments are a “tease” and that the woman responded in like manner with a “tease.” Then, perhaps because he misunderstood her intent, he left before she could get to the door.

5:2b**A sound! My beloved is knocking:**

- Listen!^(plur) My beloved is knocking at the door
- Then I heard a sound! It was the one I love calling out at the door of my room/house.

A sound! My beloved is knocking: When the woman told her dream to the women of Jerusalem, she spoke as if she were still in her dream. The phrase A sound! My beloved is knocking is more literally, “sound/voice of my lover knocking.” The woman spoke as if she still heard the man knocking and calling to her.

In some languages it is more natural to speak of the dream as happening in the past. For example:

I heard my lover knocking and calling (NLT)

The one I love was at the door, knocking and saying (CEV)

A sound! My beloved: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as A sound! My beloved means either “voice of my beloved” or “sound of my beloved.” In this context it can refer to both the sound of his knocking and his voice.

My beloved: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as My beloved first occurred in 1:13a. It is the most common way that the woman used to refer to the man in the Song. It is good to translate it in the same way throughout the book. For more information, see the note on 1:13a–b.

is knocking: The word knocking does not specify where the young man knocked. He may have knocked at the door or window of a house. In 2:9 he was outside

her window, but here in 5:2 he probably knocked on a door of the house.

In some cultures when a person comes to visit, he calls to the people in the house or makes another sound (like clapping his hands). It is not the custom to knock on their door. Use a natural way in your language for the woman to describe how the man tried to get her attention. For example:

I hear my beloved calling to me

I hear my love knocking... (NJB)

I hear my beloved knocking/clapping on/at the door/window and calling to me...

5:2c–e

In 5:2c–e the woman quoted what the man said to her. In some languages it may be necessary to use a word or phrase to introduce the quote, for example:

He said to me

5:2c**“Open to me, my sister, my darling, my dove, my flawless one.**

- and saying, “My dear one, you are my love. You are my dove, my perfect one. Please let me in.
- He said to me, “My treasure, you are the one I love. You are as gentle/lovely as a dove. You are perfect! Come open the door for me.

Open to me, my sister, my darling, my dove, my

flawless one: Here the man used four loving names as he called to the woman. He wanted to persuade her to open the door for him. In some languages it is more natural to begin the sentence with these loving names. For example:

My sister! My darling! My dove! My flawless one!
Please open the door to me.

The man used these loving names to call out to the woman through her door. In some languages it is not natural to use four names one after another like this. It may be more natural to translate the meaning of the names as one or more sentences. For example:

You are as precious to me as a sister, my darling.
You are as gentle and beautiful as a dove—you are flawless!

Open to me: The phrase Open to me implies that the man wanted the woman to open the door for him to come in and be with her. He was making a polite request. He did not imply that it was an order that she must obey. The request may also imply a romantic sense that the man wanted her to open herself to him as her beloved. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

please let me come in

open the door for me

my sister, my darling, my dove, my flawless one:

Here the man used several loving names to call his beloved and encourage her to open the door for him. The author used three of these names earlier in the book. For a discussion of the phrase my sister, see the note on 4:9a. For a discussion of my darling, see the note on 1:9a–b. For more information on the phrase my dove, see the note in 2:14a–b.

my darling: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as my darling was also used in 1:9. Translate it as you did there.

my dove: The term my dove is another loving name that the man used for the woman. It indicates that the woman was as beautiful and gentle as a dove. A dove is often used as a symbol for love. For more information and a picture of a dove, see the note on 2:14a–b. Translate dove in the same way as you did there.

my flawless one: The meaning of the phrase my flawless one is similar to the phrase in 4:7 that says, “You are altogether beautiful, my darling; in you there is no flaw.” It probably implies that the woman was physically beautiful and also morally good. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

You are perfect!

You have no faults!

5:2d–e

My head is drenched with dew, my hair with the dampness of the night: Here the man told the woman a reason why she should let him into the house. The clauses in 5:2d and 5:2e have the same meaning. They indicate that the man’s hair was wet with the heavy mist that was in the air. In the country where they lived, heavy dew often fell at night. People who were outside got wet hair and probably felt cold.

Some ways to translate the clauses in 5:2d and 5:2e are:

- Translate them in two slightly different ways. For example:

^{2d}My hair is very wet ^{2e}because of the heavy dew that is falling tonight.

- Translate the meaning only once. For example:

My head is drenched with evening dew. (CEV)

Translate the meaning in a natural way in your language.

5:2d

My head is drenched with dew,

- My head is wet from the mist in the air.
- My head is covered with the dew that is falling,

head: Here the word head probably refers to the man’s hair.

5:2e

my hair with the dampness of the night.”

- My hair is full of the nighttime dewdrops.”
- and my hair is already wet with the cold dampness of the night.”

my hair with the dampness of the night: The clause my hair with the dampness of the night has implied information. The implied phrase is indicated in the following example:

My hair is wet from the dampness of the night.

The phrase “is wet” is implied. In some languages it is more natural to make this information explicit. For example:

The mist in the evening air makes my hair very wet.

My hair is damp from the mist that is falling tonight.

my hair: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as hair is only used twice in the OT—here and in 5:11. It is probably used to make the poetry more interesting in Hebrew.

the dampness of the night: The phrase the dampness of the night is a poetic way to refer to dew or mist in the evening air.

Song of Solomon 5:3

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2–7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2–7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
2. Section 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman. Does Section 5:2–6:3 tell about a time after they married? Although 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman, 5:2–6:3 may not refer to a time after the wedding. It may describe something they experienced more than once. In other sections also, the man and woman were apart at the beginning but together at the end (as in 1:2–2:7). If 5:2–6:3 refers to a time before their wedding, Some scholars view the whole book, Song of Songs, as a large chiasm. (For example, Dorsey suggests *abcdc'b'a'*, (1999, p.200.)) So, the section, 3:6–5:1 is the central and climactic part of the chiasm, and what comes before and after are related to the center, not chronologically but thematically. So, the material both before and after, may be pointing to the grand central climax, the wedding. What follows the wedding, 5:2–8:14, may actually repeat much of the material in 1:2–3:5. Again, this is more of a cyclical rather than chronological way of understanding the book. it describes the woman's hopes and fears as she imagined her future with the man (as in 3:1–4). The dream might indicate that she feared that he had stopped loving her, but at

the end of 6:2–3, she realized that he continued to love her faithfully. Some scholars believe that this section follows chronologically after the wedding. Some of these scholars interpret it as describing a time of conflict for the newly married couple. But the theme of marital conflict does not seem to fit the overall message or tone of the Song.

3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see “Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song” in POEM 4:1–7.)

Paragraph 5:2–8 The woman spoke to the women of Jerusalem

There are different ways to interpret what the woman said in 5:2–8:

1. She told about something that she dreamed or imagined. She described her feelings for the man in a poetic way.
2. She told what happened when the man actually came to her. She was sleeping, but she woke up when she heard him knocking on her door.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The verses probably describe something that the woman dreamed or imagined, since some of the descriptions seem unreal or dreamlike. They are a poetic way to express the woman's feelings for the man.

Does 5:2–8 describe sexual relations between the woman and man?

There are two views about whether 5:2–8 implies that they had sexual relations:

1. The verses indicate romantic feelings, but they do not describe sexual relations between the man and woman. He stood outside her house knocking, but she was already in bed. She delayed in opening her door, and he left before she opened it.
2. The verses have a double meaning. For example, in 5:4 they interpret the man's “hand” and the door “latch” (literally “hole” in Hebrew) as referring to male and female sexual organs. Pope and some other modern commentators follow this view. The man was outside the room knocking on the door. He was also outside the woman's body, wanting to enter and have sexual relations with her.

It is recommended that you follow option (1), which is followed by many reliable commentaries. See, for example, Assis, Barbiero, Bloch and Bloch, Davidson,

Delitzsch, Elliott, Estes, Fox, Ginsburg, Gordis, Hess, Mitchell, and Murphy. Michael Fox argues that this view spoils the true romantic impact and beauty of the book (Fox, pages 144-145). The text indicates that the man did not come inside the woman's house, but he left before she could open the door.

Common themes

This section has similar themes (motifs) that were part of earlier sections. You should translate such themes in a similar way throughout the book. This helps readers understand the unity of the Song. For example, as in 3:1-4, also here in 5:2-8, the author told about the woman having a dream and searching for her beloved in the town at night. Also, in 2:8-14, the young man stood outside the woman's house, but she was inside behind a locked door. This theme of the woman being hard to reach is also found in 2:9; 2:14; 4:8; and 4:12.

5:3

There are two views about the woman's words in 5:3:

1. The words tell what the woman thought when the man came to her. She later told her thoughts to the Jerusalem women. She did not say the words directly to the man. For example:

I had taken off my robe...I had bathed my feet...
(NJPS) (BSB, CEV, ESV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJPS, RSV)

1. She said the words directly to the man when he asked her to open the door (5:2c-e). Later she told the Jerusalem women what she said. For example:

But I responded, "I have taken off my robe..." (NLT)
(NET, NJB, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with more English versions. Some of these versions use present tense for the woman's words, but they do not use quotation marks, implying that she did not speak them to the man. The GNT is ambiguous because it uses no quotation marks for either the man's or the woman's words.

5:3a-d

There are two similar parts in 5:3 (5:3a-b is similar to 5:3c-d). Each part has a statement and a rhetorical question:

^{3a}I have taken off my robe—

^{3b}must I put it back on?

^{3c}I have washed my feet—

^{3d}must I soil them again?

The two parts have similar meanings. The woman implied that she prepared herself for sleeping and got into bed before the man came. In 5:3a-b she said that she already undressed so she did not want to dress again. In 5:3c-d she said that she already washed her feet, so she did not want to make them dirty again. The author repeats these similar meanings to emphasize them.

Some other ways to translate 5:3a-b and 5:3c-d are:

- Translate 5:3a-b and 5:3c-d as similar statements. For example:

I had already taken off my robe,

and I did not want to put it on again.

I had already washed my feet,

and I did not want to soil them again.

- Combine the actions in 5:3a-b and 5:3c-d as one explanation. For example:

I had already taken off my robe and washed my feet, and/so I did not want to put my robe on again and soil my feet!

- Combine 5:3a-b as one statement and 5:3c-d as one question. For example:

But I had already undressed and bathed my feet.
Should I dress again and get my feet dirty? (CEV)

Translate these parallel parts of the verse in an emphatic way in your language.

5:3a

I have taken off my robe—

- When I heard him, I thought, "I already removed my robe/clothes.
- But I was already undressed for bed,

I have taken off my robe: Here the woman explained to the other women the reason that she did not want to get up to open the door for the man. She explained that when the man arrived, she had already removed her clothes and was ready to sleep. The phrase I have

taken off my robe is not something that she said to the man. Some other ways to translate this explanation are:

But I was already undressed

I had put off my garment (RSV)

taken off my robe: The phrase that the BSB translates as taken off my robe refers to removing the robe that a person (either male or female) normally wore under other clothes. It was customary to remove this robe when getting into bed to sleep. Use a natural way in your language to refer to removing clothes to prepare to sleep.

5:3b

must I put it back on?

- Should I put it/them on again?
- and I did not want to dress again.

must I put it back on?: The clause must I put it back on is a rhetorical question. It implies that the woman did not want to put her clothes on again after taking them off to get into bed. She thought that it was too much effort for her to do that. Some other ways to translate this rhetorical question are:

- Use a rhetorical question that implies that meaning in your language. For example:

why should I get dressed again? (GNT)

must I put it on again? (REB)

- Use a statement. For example:

I have taken off my garment, and I do not want to put it on again.

Translate the meaning in a natural way in your language.

5:3c

I have washed my feet—

- I already washed my feet.
- My feet were clean, ready for bed,

I have washed my feet: Here the woman indicated that she already washed her feet to get into bed. It was common for people to wash their feet even if they did not bathe the rest of their bodies. People commonly went barefoot or wore open sandals, so

their feet got dirty from the dust. Another way to translate 5:3c is:

I had already bathed my feet.

5:3d

must I soil them again?

- Should I get them dirty again?”
- and I did not want to get them dirty again.

must I soil them again: The rhetorical question must I soil them again implies that the woman did not want to get her feet dirty. It does not imply that she was not able to get them dirty. Another way to translate the rhetorical question is:

I did not want to make them dirty again.

General Comment on 5:3

In this verse, the woman was already in bed. She had already washed her feet and removed her garment to get ready to sleep. She was not prepared for the man's visit, and she was surprised that he came. (The General Comment on 5:5 about myrrh gives more information about preparing for sleep in that culture.)

Song of Solomon 5:4

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2–7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2–7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.

2. Section 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman. Does Section 5:2–6:3 tell about a time after they married? Although 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman, 5:2–6:3 may not refer to a time after the wedding. It may describe something they experienced more than once. In other sections also, the man and woman were apart at the beginning but together at the end (as in 1:2–2:7). If 5:2–6:3 refers to a time before their wedding, Some scholars view the whole book, Song of Songs, as a large chiasm. (For example, Dorsey suggests *abdc'b'a'*, (1999, p.200.)) So, the section, 3:6–5:1 is the central and climactic part of the chiasm, and what comes before and after are related to the center, not chronologically but thematically. So, the material both before and after, may be pointing to the grand central climax, the wedding. What follows the wedding, 5:2–8:14, may actually repeat much of the material in 1:2–3:5. Again, this is more of a cyclical rather than chronological way of understanding the book. It describes the woman's hopes and fears as she imagined her future with the man (as in 3:1–4). The dream might indicate that she feared that he had stopped loving her, but at the end of 6:2–3, she realized that he continued to love her faithfully. Some scholars believe that this section follows chronologically after the wedding. Some of these scholars interpret it as describing a time of conflict for the newly married couple. But the theme of marital conflict does not seem to fit the overall message or tone of the Song.
3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see "Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song" in POEM 4:1–7.)

Paragraph 5:2–8 The woman spoke to the women of Jerusalem

There are different ways to interpret what the woman said in 5:2–8:

1. She told about something that she dreamed or imagined. She described her feelings for the man in a poetic way.
2. She told what happened when the man actually came to her. She was sleeping, but she woke up when she heard him knocking on her door.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The verses probably describe something that the woman dreamed or imagined, since some of the de-

scriptions seem unreal or dreamlike. They are a poetic way to express the woman's feelings for the man.

Does 5:2–8 describe sexual relations between the woman and man?

There are two views about whether 5:2–8 implies that they had sexual relations:

1. The verses indicate romantic feelings, but they do not describe sexual relations between the man and woman. He stood outside her house knocking, but she was already in bed. She delayed in opening her door, and he left before she opened it.
2. The verses have a double meaning. For example, in 5:4 they interpret the man's "hand" and the door "latch" (literally "hole" in Hebrew) as referring to male and female sexual organs. Pope and some other modern commentators follow this view. The man was outside the room knocking on the door. He was also outside the woman's body, wanting to enter and have sexual relations with her.

It is recommended that you follow option (1), which is followed by many reliable commentaries. See, for example, Assis, Barbiero, Bloch and Bloch, Davidson, Delitzsch, Elliott, Estes, Fox, Ginsburg, Gordis, Hess, Mitchell, and Murphy. Michael Fox argues that this view spoils the true romantic impact and beauty of the book (Fox, pages 144–145). The text indicates that the man did not come inside the woman's house, but he left before she could open the door.

Common themes

This section has similar themes (motifs) that were part of earlier sections. You should translate such themes in a similar way throughout the book. This helps readers understand the unity of the Song. For example, as in 3:1–4, also here in 5:2–8, the author told about the woman having a dream and searching for her beloved in the town at night. Also, in 2:8–14, the young man stood outside the woman's house, but she was inside behind a locked door. This theme of the woman being hard to reach is also found in 2:9; 2:14; 4:8; and 4:12.

5:4a

My beloved put his hand to the latch;

- My beloved put his hand through the opening in the door,
- Then my love's hand reached in through a hole in the door, trying to open it,

My beloved put his hand to the latch: In this clause the woman implied that she could hear the man put his hand into the latch to try to open the door. The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as put his hand

to means “to stretch out his hand.” But here in 5:4 it is used with a Hebrew word. The preposition *min* (often translated “from”) is used here, which probably indicates that he put his hand through (something). (For more details, see the next note on the word latch.)

Some ways to translate the clause are:

- Imply that the man put his hand through an opening. For example:

My love thrust his hand through the hole in the door... (NJB)

Then my darling’s hand reached to open the latch... (CEV)

- Use a phrase with a more general meaning. For example:

My lover tried to unlatch the door (NLT)

The one I love tried to use his hand to open the door.

latch: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as latch is literally “hole.” It implies that there was an opening in the door. A person could reach through it to open the door. The GW calls this opening a “keyhole.” However, it was larger than many modern keyholes, since a person could put his hand through it.

5:4b

my heart pounded for him.

- and then I was filled/overcome with desire for him.
- and I became excited by my love for him.

my heart pounded for him: This phrase is a figure of speech. It tells the woman’s response when she heard the man trying to open the door (5:4a). She longed for his love, and she urgently wanted to be with him. The phrase may also imply that her sexual desires were aroused.

In some languages people do not talk about the heart when they refer to romantic feelings. Languages have different ways to refer to such feelings, and some languages use a figure of speech. It is important to use a natural way in your language. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

I longed for him.

I was filled with desire for him.

my inmost being yearned for him (NRSV)

I was thrilled that he was near (GNT)

Song of Solomon 5:5

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2–7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2–7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
2. Section 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman. Does Section 5:2–6:3 tell about a time after they married? Although 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman, 5:2–6:3 may not refer to a time after the wedding. It may describe something they experienced more than once. In other sections also, the man and woman were apart at the beginning but together at the end (as in 1:2–2:7). If 5:2–6:3 refers to a time before their wedding, some scholars view the whole book, Song of Songs, as a large chiasm. (For example, Dorsey suggests *abdc b’a’*, (1999, p.200.)) So, the section, 3:6–5:1 is the central and climactic part of the chiasm, and what comes before and after are related to the center, not chronologically but thematically. So, the material both before and after, may be pointing to the grand central climax, the wedding. What follows the wedding, 5:2–8:14, may actually repeat much of the material in 1:2–3:5. Again, this is more of a cyclical rather than chronological way of understanding the book. It describes the woman’s hopes and fears as she imagined her future with the man (as in 3:1–4). The dream might indicate that she feared that he had stopped loving her, but at

the end of 6:2-3, she realized that he continued to love her faithfully. Some scholars believe that this section follows chronologically after the wedding. Some of these scholars interpret it as describing a time of conflict for the newly married couple. But the theme of marital conflict does not seem to fit the overall message or tone of the Song.

3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see “Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song” in POEM 4:1-7.)

Paragraph 5:2-8 The woman spoke to the women of Jerusalem

There are different ways to interpret what the woman said in 5:2-8:

1. She told about something that she dreamed or imagined. She described her feelings for the man in a poetic way.
2. She told what happened when the man actually came to her. She was sleeping, but she woke up when she heard him knocking on her door.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The verses probably describe something that the woman dreamed or imagined, since some of the descriptions seem unreal or dreamlike. They are a poetic way to express the woman's feelings for the man.

Does 5:2-8 describe sexual relations between the woman and man?

There are two views about whether 5:2-8 implies that they had sexual relations:

1. The verses indicate romantic feelings, but they do not describe sexual relations between the man and woman. He stood outside her house knocking, but she was already in bed. She delayed in opening her door, and he left before she opened it.
2. The verses have a double meaning. For example, in 5:4 they interpret the man's “hand” and the door “latch” (literally “hole” in Hebrew) as referring to male and female sexual organs. Pope and some other modern commentators follow this view. The man was outside the room knocking on the door. He was also outside the woman's body, wanting to enter and have sexual relations with her.

It is recommended that you follow option (1), which is followed by many reliable commentaries. See, for example, Assis, Barbiero, Bloch and Bloch, Davidson,

Delitzsch, Elliott, Estes, Fox, Ginsburg, Gordis, Hess, Mitchell, and Murphy. Michael Fox argues that this view spoils the true romantic impact and beauty of the book (Fox, pages 144-145). The text indicates that the man did not come inside the woman's house, but he left before she could open the door.

Common themes

This section has similar themes (motifs) that were part of earlier sections. You should translate such themes in a similar way throughout the book. This helps readers understand the unity of the Song. For example, as in 3:1-4, also here in 5:2-8, the author told about the woman having a dream and searching for her beloved in the town at night. Also, in 2:8-14, the young man stood outside the woman's house, but she was inside behind a locked door. This theme of the woman being hard to reach is also found in 2:9; 2:14; 4:8; and 4:12.

5:5a

I rose up to open for my beloved.

- I got up to open the door for my beloved.
- I rose from bed to let my love come in,

I rose up to open for my beloved: Here the woman left her bed to open (the door) for her beloved to come in. She had become eager to see him, so she was willing to put on her robe again, as she mentioned in 5:3. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I got up to open the door for my love.

I quickly left my bed and went to open up to my beloved.

5:5b

My hands dripped with myrrh,

- My hands were covered with myrrh, (GNT)
- and perfume dripped from my hands.

5:5b-c

My hands dripped with myrrh, my fingers with flowing myrrh: In 5:5b and 5:5c the meaning is repeated to emphasize it. Both clauses indicate that liquid myrrh dripped from the woman's hands (and fingers). The text may imply that when the woman got up, she quickly poured myrrh on her hands, and some of the myrrh dripped from them. This is a hyperbole. It probably indicates that she was now eager to please the man.

Some other ways to translate the parallel clauses are:

- Translate the meaning twice in slightly different ways. For example:

^{5b}myrrh perfume covered my fingers ^{5c}and dripped from my hands

- Combine 5:5b and 5:5c and translate the meaning only once. For example:

my hands were dripping with myrrh perfume

Translate the meaning in a natural way in your language.

hands...fingers: The words hands and fingers have the same meaning here. The author repeated the meaning to add poetic interest and emphasis. He did not imply any difference in meaning.

myrrh: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as myrrh occurs twice in this verse. Both times it refers to the liquid form of the myrrh perfume. This word also occurred in 1:13, 3:6, 4:6, and 4:14. (In 1:13a–b and 4:6 the myrrh was probably in solid form.)

Here the word myrrh in 5:5b and the phrase “flowing myrrh” in 5:5c refer to the same substance. In this context myrrh can also be translated generally as “perfume.” In the dream that the woman described, myrrh probably symbolizes her loving desire for the man.

For more information about myrrh, see the note on 3:6c.

5:5c

my fingers with flowing myrrh

- and my fingers dripped with flowing myrrh,
- Costly perfume covered my fingers

my fingers with flowing myrrh: There is an ellipsis in 5:5c, and the word “dripped” is implied. In many languages translators need to supply this implied verb. For example:

my fingers dripped with flowing myrrh.

The myrrh dripped or flowed from her hands and fingers onto the handles of the bolt (5:5d). Some other ways to translate the phrase in 5:5c are:

my fingers were wet with myrrh

My fingers dripped with lovely myrrh (NLT)

flowing myrrh: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as flowing myrrh and the parallel “dripped” myrrh in 5:5b probably refer to the same type of myrrh. For more information about myrrh, see the note on myrrh in 3:6c.

5:5d

on the handles of the bolt.

- when I touched the door latch/bar.
- as I grasped the handle of the door. (GNT)

on the handles of the bolt: The phrase, handles of the bolt, refers to the object that was used to bolt (lock) the door. This bolt was often a metal or wooden bar. It was fastened to the door with a lock. Some commentators think the handles of the bolt is a sexual euphemism. The Notes considers this interpretation to be unlikely, and it is also difficult to fit with the other details of the verse. For these reasons, the Notes does not recommend it. For further discussion on the general issue of whether this passage describes a sexual encounter, refer to the introduction of Section 5:2–8. Some other ways to translate 5:5c are:

- Use a specific phrase that is natural in your language. For example:

the handle of the door (GNT)

the latch handles

- Use a more general phrase that does not refer specifically to the lock. For example:

to open the door (CEV)

as I pulled back the bolt (NLT)

Use a natural phrase in your language to refer to a lock or whatever is natural in your culture to lock or bar a door.

General Comment on 5:5

The Notes suggest that the dripping myrrh on the woman’s hands is hyperbole. It is probably not literal but a symbol for feelings of love. This symbolic myrrh emphasizes that the woman had strong feelings of love for the man.

Song of Solomon 5:6

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2–7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2–7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
2. Section 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman. Does Section 5:2–6:3 tell about a time after they married? Although 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman, 5:2–6:3 may not refer to a time after the wedding. It may describe something they experienced more than once. In other sections also, the man and woman were apart at the beginning but together at the end (as in 1:2–2:7). If 5:2–6:3 refers to a time before their wedding, Some scholars view the whole book, Song of Songs, as a large chiasm. (For example, Dorsey suggests *abcdc'b'a'*, (1999, p.200.)) So, the section, 3:6–5:1 is the central and climactic part of the chiasm, and what comes before and after are related to the center, not chronologically but thematically. So, the material both before and after, may be pointing to the grand central climax, the wedding. What follows the wedding, 5:2–8:14, may actually repeat much of the material in 1:2–3:5. Again, this is more of a cyclical rather than chronological way of understanding the book. it describes the woman's hopes and fears as she imagined her future with the man (as in 3:1–4). The dream might indicate that she feared that he had stopped loving her, but at the end of 6:2–3, she realized that he continued to love her faithfully. Some scholars believe that this section follows chronologically after the wedding. Some of these scholars interpret it as describing a

time of conflict for the newly married couple. But the theme of marital conflict does not seem to fit the overall message or tone of the Song.

3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see “Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song” in POEM 4:1–7.)

Paragraph 5:2–8 The woman spoke to the women of Jerusalem

There are different ways to interpret what the woman said in 5:2–8:

1. She told about something that she dreamed or imagined. She described her feelings for the man in a poetic way.
2. She told what happened when the man actually came to her. She was sleeping, but she woke up when she heard him knocking on her door.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The verses probably describe something that the woman dreamed or imagined, since some of the descriptions seem unreal or dreamlike. They are a poetic way to express the woman's feelings for the man.

Does 5:2–8 describe sexual relations between the woman and man?

There are two views about whether 5:2–8 implies that they had sexual relations:

1. The verses indicate romantic feelings, but they do not describe sexual relations between the man and woman. He stood outside her house knocking, but she was already in bed. She delayed in opening her door, and he left before she opened it.
2. The verses have a double meaning. For example, in 5:4 they interpret the man's “hand” and the door “latch” (literally “hole” in Hebrew) as referring to male and female sexual organs. Pope and some other modern commentators follow this view. The man was outside the room knocking on the door. He was also outside the woman's body, wanting to enter and have sexual relations with her.

It is recommended that you follow option (1), which is followed by many reliable commentaries. See, for example, Assis, Barbiero, Bloch and Bloch, Davidson, Delitzsch, Elliott, Estes, Fox, Ginsburg, Gordis, Hess, Mitchell, and Murphy. Michael Fox argues that this view spoils the true romantic impact and beauty of the book (Fox, pages 144–145). The text indicates that

the man did not come inside the woman's house, but he left before she could open the door.

Common themes

This section has similar themes (motifs) that were part of earlier sections. You should translate such themes in a similar way throughout the book. This helps readers understand the unity of the Song. For example, as in 3:1–4, also here in 5:2–8, the author told about the woman having a dream and searching for her beloved in the town at night. Also, in 2:8–14, the young man stood outside the woman's house, but she was inside behind a locked door. This theme of the woman being hard to reach is also found in 2:9; 2:14; 4:8; and 4:12.

5:6a

I opened for my beloved,

- I opened the door for my beloved,
- I opened to let my love come in.

I opened for my beloved: In this context the phrase I opened for my beloved probably indicates that the woman opened the door for the man to enter her room. It may also imply that she opened herself to welcome him. Some other ways to translate the clause are:

I opened the door for my lover (NCV)

I opened the door for the one I love to enter

I opened to/for my beloved

5:6b

but he had turned and gone.

- but my beloved had turned away and was gone. (RSV)
- But my love had gone. He was not there!

but he had turned and gone: This clause tells what the woman realized when she opened the door. She saw that her beloved was not there. The text implies that he went away after the woman hesitated to open the door. He was gone when she finally opened the door.

Some other ways to translate the clause are:

but my beloved had turned away. He was gone! (GW)

but my beloved had left; he was not there!

had turned and gone: The phrase had turned and gone indicates that the man left, and he was gone by the time the woman came to the door. In some languages it may be natural to use only one verb. For example:

but he was gone! (NLT)

5:6c

My heart sank at his departure.

- I almost fainted/died when he left me.
- When he went away, I was desperately disappointed.

My heart sank at his departure: Scholars differ about what caused the woman's heart to sink. There is a textual issue concerning the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as at his departure. This difference is based on a textual issue that involves the Hebrew writing system, which did not originally indicate all the vowel sounds. Symbols for these sounds were supplied many years after the text was written. Scholars have two different proposals for the vowels that should be supplied here. The difference of one vowel changes the meaning of the word.

1. The word means "when he left." For example:

My heart sank at his departure... (NIV) (BSB, GW, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB)

1. The word means "when he spoke." For example:

My soul failed me when he spoke... (ESV) (RSV, CEV, ESV, NASB, NCV, NJPS, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The meaning "when he left" makes better sense in this context. The woman wanted the man. In 5:6c–d she searched desperately for him. She had no reason to say "my soul failed me when he spoke," as in interpretation (2). He spoke only to ask her to open the door (5:2), which should not distress her. She was distressed because he left, and she feared that he might stop loving her.

My heart sank: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as My heart sank is more literally "my-soul/breath went-out." This phrase is a figure of speech to indicate that the woman felt distressed and desperate. She feared that the man had left her, and that he might not return. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

When he left, I felt terrible distress

I was very lonely when he left

In some languages there is a figure of speech to translate this meaning. For example:

I fell into despair when he departed. (NET)

Notice also that the BSB uses the figure of speech “my heart sank.” Use a natural way in your language to describe this feeling.

5:6d–5:7b

What the woman said in 5:6d–5:7b uses the theme of searching that occurs often in the Song. Her statements here repeat statements in 3:1b and 3:3a–b. In chapter 3 and here in chapter 5 the woman searched for the man. She described her search in similar ways in both chapters. Try to keep these similarities in your own translation.

5:6d

I sought him, but did not find him.

- I looked for him, but I could not find him.
- I went out to try to find/see him, but I did not find/see him anywhere.

I sought him, but did not find him: The phrase I sought him, but did not find him is the same as the phrase in 3:1b. Here it indicates that the woman left her house and went to search for the man in the streets of the town. She searched for him because she loved him and longed to be with him. She was distressed until she could see him again, but when she looked for him, she could not see him anywhere.

You should translate the phrase in the same way or a similar way as you did in 3:1b. Some ways to translate it are:

I searched for him but could not find him anywhere (NLT)

I looked for him but did not find him (NET)

I went around trying to find him, but I did not see him anywhere.

but did not find him: The woman could not find the man when she searched for him, so she felt sadder and even more afraid. The author emphasized her sorrow to cause readers to sympathize with her and to want her to be happy again.

Use a natural way in your language to translate this emphasis. In some languages a word like “find” may imply that a person accidentally discovered something that he was not searching for. That meaning does not fit this context. If that is true in your language, you should translate in a different way. For example:

but I did not see him anywhere.

5:6e

I called, but he did not answer.

- I called to him, but he did not reply.
- I said, “My love, where are you?” but I could not hear him answer me.

I called, but he did not answer: Here the woman called to the man because she hoped that he would hear her and respond to her. However, he did not hear her, so he did not respond. In some languages it may be helpful to use a direct quote and include the implied words that she said to call him. For example:

She called to him, “My beloved, where are you?” but she did not hear him answer.

Song of Solomon 5:7

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2–7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2–7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
2. Section 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman. Does Section 5:2–6:3 tell about a time after they married? Although 3:6–5:1 told about the

wedding of the man and woman, 5:2-6:3 may not refer to a time after the wedding. It may describe something they experienced more than once. In other sections also, the man and woman were apart at the beginning but together at the end (as in 1:2-2:7). If 5:2-6:3 refers to a time before their wedding, Some scholars view the whole book, Song of Songs, as a large chiasm. (For example, Dorsey suggests *abdc'b'a'*, (1999, p.200.)) So, the section, 3:6-5:1 is the central and climactic part of the chiasm, and what comes before and after are related to the center, not chronologically but thematically. So, the material both before and after, may be pointing to the grand central climax, the wedding. What follows the wedding, 5:2-8:14, may actually repeat much of the material in 1:2-3:5. Again, this is more of a cyclical rather than chronological way of understanding the book. It describes the woman's hopes and fears as she imagined her future with the man (as in 3:1-4). The dream might indicate that she feared that he had stopped loving her, but at the end of 6:2-3, she realized that he continued to love her faithfully. Some scholars believe that this section follows chronologically after the wedding. Some of these scholars interpret it as describing a time of conflict for the newly married couple. But the theme of marital conflict does not seem to fit the overall message or tone of the Song.

3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see "Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song" in POEM 4:1-7.)

Paragraph 5:2-8 The woman spoke to the women of Jerusalem

There are different ways to interpret what the woman said in 5:2-8:

1. She told about something that she dreamed or imagined. She described her feelings for the man in a poetic way.
2. She told what happened when the man actually came to her. She was sleeping, but she woke up when she heard him knocking on her door.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The verses probably describe something that the woman dreamed or imagined, since some of the descriptions seem unreal or dreamlike. They are a poetic way to express the woman's feelings for the man.

Does 5:2-8 describe sexual relations between the woman and man?

There are two views about whether 5:2-8 implies that they had sexual relations:

1. The verses indicate romantic feelings, but they do not describe sexual relations between the man and woman. He stood outside her house knocking, but she was already in bed. She delayed in opening her door, and he left before she opened it.
2. The verses have a double meaning. For example, in 5:4 they interpret the man's "hand" and the door "latch" (literally "hole" in Hebrew) as referring to male and female sexual organs. Pope and some other modern commentators follow this view. The man was outside the room knocking on the door. He was also outside the woman's body, wanting to enter and have sexual relations with her.

It is recommended that you follow option (1), which is followed by many reliable commentaries. See, for example, Assis, Barbiero, Bloch and Bloch, Davidson, Delitzsch, Elliott, Estes, Fox, Ginsburg, Gordis, Hess, Mitchell, and Murphy. Michael Fox argues that this view spoils the true romantic impact and beauty of the book (Fox, pages 144-145). The text indicates that the man did not come inside the woman's house, but he left before she could open the door.

Common themes

This section has similar themes (motifs) that were part of earlier sections. You should translate such themes in a similar way throughout the book. This helps readers understand the unity of the Song. For example, as in 3:1-4, also here in 5:2-8, the author told about the woman having a dream and searching for her beloved in the town at night. Also, in 2:8-14, the young man stood outside the woman's house, but she was inside behind a locked door. This theme of the woman being hard to reach is also found in 2:9; 2:14; 4:8; and 4:12.

5:7a

I encountered the watchmen

- The city guards found me,
- The sentinels saw me

5:7b

on their rounds of the city.

- while they patrolled the city.
- while they were walking around to check that the city was safe/secure.

5:7a-b

Here in 5:7a-b the author repeated the words in 3:3a-b exactly. It is good to translate them in the same way in

both places. The notes here in 5:7a–b are the same as the notes for 3:3a–b except for some minor changes.

I encountered the watchmen on their rounds of the city: The text indicates that as the woman searched for her beloved around the town at night, the watchmen saw her. The text does not imply that they were searching for her. One way to translate this meaning is:

^{7b}As the people who guard the town walked through it, ^{7a}they saw me.

Notice that this example changes the order of 5:7a and 5:7b. Use a natural order in your language.

watchmen: The watchmen were men who guarded the city. They walked in it at night to ensure that people were safe from dangers. It is uncertain what symbolic meaning the author wanted to imply by the word watchmen here. In this verse they treated the woman differently from the way they treated her in 3:3. In 3:3 they were polite, but here they treated her roughly and hurt her.

In some languages it may be helpful to introduce the watchmen as you did in 3:3. For example:

There were some watchmen who guarded the city.
They saw me as they walked through the streets.

The city guards were walking through the streets,
and they met/saw me.

However, in other languages, it may not be necessary to introduce the watchmen again, if they were introduced in 3:3a–b.

5:7c

They beat me and bruised me;

- They beat me! They injured me!
- But they hit me and hurt me.

They beat me and bruised me: The watchmen beat the woman so that she was hurt. The beating caused her to be bruised or wounded. She did not expect the watchmen to do that because their job was to keep the people in the city safe. In 3:4 the watchmen did not help her find her beloved, but here in 5:7 they did worse than that and actually hurt her. Some scholars suggest that the watchmen thought that the woman was a prostitute because she was wandering around town at night. If that is true, the text may imply that they thought that she was a bad person and thought that punishing her was part of their job.

Some other ways to translate 5:7c are:

They beat me, they wounded me (RSV)

They hit me and hurt me (NCV)

In some languages it is more natural to use a single emphatic phrase to translate 5:7c. For example:

they caused me great injury

they hurt me badly

5:7d

they took away my cloak, those guardians of the walls.

- They took my coat/robe away from me. That is what those city guards did to me!
- Then those men who should guard people in the city took away the veil that covered me.

they took away my cloak: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as cloak occurs only twice in the OT. It refers to an item of clothing that is used to cover a person's head or body. It is sometimes translated as "mantle," "robe," or "veil." In the woman's culture it was the custom for women to wear such a cloak or veil in public. By taking it away from her, the watchmen insulted and embarrassed her, in addition to beating her.

Some other ways to translate they took away my cloak are:

and stripped off my cloak (REB)

tore off my veil (NLT96)

those guardians of the walls: The phrase, those guardians of the walls, refers again to the watchmen whom the author introduced in 5:7a. He refers to them again here at the end of the verse to emphasize that their actions were wrong. They were supposed to watch for dangers and keep people safe, but instead they injured a person whom they ought to protect. The repetition emphasizes that such actions by watchmen are unjust. Some other ways to translate 5:7f are:

This is what those watchmen of the city walls did to me!

Emphasize this phrase in a natural way in your language.

General Comment on 5:7

The way that the watchmen treated the woman and the way she responded are probably symbolic actions. They imply that love has power to overcome everything that tries to end it. The watchmen wounded the woman while she searched for her beloved. But she endured danger and pain to search for the man because she loved him. This theme is repeated in 8:6-7, which is part of the Song's climax.

Song of Solomon 5:8

Section 5:2-6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2-7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10-16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2-3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2-7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2-7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
2. Section 3:6-5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman. Does Section 5:2-6:3 tell about a time after they married? Although 3:6-5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman, 5:2-6:3 may not refer to a time after the wedding. It may describe something they experienced more than once. In other sections also, the man and woman were apart at the beginning but together at the end (as in 1:2-2:7). If 5:2-6:3 refers to a time before their wedding, Some scholars view the whole book, Song of Songs, as a large chiasm. (For example, Dorsey suggests *abdc b'a'*, (1999, p.200.)) So, the section, 3:6-5:1 is the central and climactic part of the chiasm, and what comes before and after are related to the center, not chronologically but thematically.

So, the material both before and after, may be pointing to the grand central climax, the wedding. What follows the wedding, 5:2-8:14, may actually repeat much of the material in 1:2-3:5. Again, this is more of a cyclical rather than chronological way of understanding the book. It describes the woman's hopes and fears as she imagined her future with the man (as in 3:1-4). The dream might indicate that she feared that he had stopped loving her, but at the end of 6:2-3, she realized that he continued to love her faithfully. Some scholars believe that this section follows chronologically after the wedding. Some of these scholars interpret it as describing a time of conflict for the newly married couple. But the theme of marital conflict does not seem to fit the overall message or tone of the Song.

3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see "Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song" in POEM 4:1-7.)

Paragraph 5:2-8 The woman spoke to the women of Jerusalem

There are different ways to interpret what the woman said in 5:2-8:

1. She told about something that she dreamed or imagined. She described her feelings for the man in a poetic way.
2. She told what happened when the man actually came to her. She was sleeping, but she woke up when she heard him knocking on her door.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The verses probably describe something that the woman dreamed or imagined, since some of the descriptions seem unreal or dreamlike. They are a poetic way to express the woman's feelings for the man.

Does 5:2-8 describe sexual relations between the woman and man?

There are two views about whether 5:2-8 implies that they had sexual relations:

1. The verses indicate romantic feelings, but they do not describe sexual relations between the man and woman. He stood outside her house knocking, but she was already in bed. She delayed in opening her door, and he left before she opened it.
2. The verses have a double meaning. For example, in 5:4 they interpret the man's "hand" and the door "latch" (literally "hole" in Hebrew) as referring to

male and female sexual organs. Pope and some other modern commentators follow this view. The man was outside the room knocking on the door. He was also outside the woman's body, wanting to enter and have sexual relations with her.

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Common themes

This section has similar themes (motifs) that were part of earlier sections. You should translate such themes in a similar way throughout the book. This helps readers understand the unity of the Song. For example, as in 3:1-4, also here in 5:2-8, the author told about the woman having a dream and searching for her beloved in the town at night. Also, in 2:8-14, the young man stood outside the woman's house, but she was inside behind a locked door. This theme of the woman being hard to reach is also found in 2:9; 2:14; 4:8; and 4:12.

5:8a

O daughters of Jerusalem, I adjure you,

- Women of Jerusalem, "Swear to me
- You women of Jerusalem, promise me,
- Then I said to the young women of Jerusalem, "Swear/Take an oath that

O daughters of Jerusalem, I adjure you: The phrase O daughters of Jerusalem, I adjure you, repeats 2:7a-b. It is good to translate it as you did there. For more information, see the Notes on 2:7a-b. This phrase also occurs in 3:5 and 8:4.

In some languages it is more natural to begin the verse with the direct address to the daughters of Jerusalem. For example:

Jerusalem women, I adjure you...

5:8b

if you find my beloved,

- that if you find/see my beloved,
- if when searching you see my love,

5:8c

tell him I am sick with love.

- you will tell him that I feel faint with love."
- tell him that I am lovesick.
- you will say to him, "Your beloved is overwhelmed with love for you."

5:8b-c

if you find my beloved, tell him I am sick with love:

When the woman said to the Jerusalem women, if you find my beloved, she implied that she wanted them to help her search for him. She told them a message that they should tell the man if they see him. The words of the message are in 5:8c.

Some other ways to translate 5:8b-c are:

if you find the one I love, please say to him, "She is weak with desire." (CEV)

if you find my beloved, tell him that I am faint from wanting his love.

tell him I am sick with love: In some languages it may be helpful to translate this indirect quote as a direct quote. For example:

tell him, "The woman you love says that her desire for your love is so strong that she feels faint/sick."

Say to him, "Your beloved says that she is faint with desire for you."

sick with love: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sick can refer to a feeling of weakness or to an actual sickness. In this context the woman indicated that she was so overwhelmed by her feelings of love that she felt weak. She did not imply that she was sick with an illness. She might feel faint or dizzy because of her strong feelings of love. She could be "cured" by seeing her beloved again and enjoying his love.

Some other ways to translate this are:

faint with love (NRSV)

lovesick (NASB)

weak with desire (CEV)

The phrase sick with love also occurs in 2:5c.

General Comment on 5:8

It is possible that 5:8 is still part of the woman's dream. The dream may continue to the end of the section in 6:3.

Song of Solomon 5:9

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2–7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2–7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
2. Section 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman. Does Section 5:2–6:3 tell about a time after they married? Although 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman, 5:2–6:3 may not refer to a time after the wedding. It may describe something they experienced more than once. In other sections also, the man and woman were apart at the beginning but together at the end (as in 1:2–2:7). If 5:2–6:3 refers to a time before their wedding, Some scholars view the whole book, Song of Songs, as a large chiasm. (For example, Dorsey suggests *abdc'b'a'*, (1999, p.200.)) So, the section, 3:6–5:1 is the central and climactic part of the chiasm, and what comes before and after are related to the center, not chronologically but thematically. So, the material both before and after, may be pointing to the grand central climax, the wedding. What follows the wedding, 5:2–8:14, may actually repeat much of the material in 1:2–3:5. Again, this is more of a cyclical rather than chronological way of understanding the book. It describes the woman's hopes and fears as she imagined her future with the man (as in 3:1–4). The dream might indicate that

she feared that he had stopped loving her, but at the end of 6:2–3, she realized that he continued to love her faithfully. Some scholars believe that this section follows chronologically after the wedding. Some of these scholars interpret it as describing a time of conflict for the newly married couple. But the theme of marital conflict does not seem to fit the overall message or tone of the Song.

3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see "Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song" in POEM 4:1–7.)

Paragraph 5:9–16 The woman described her beloved

In 5:9 the Jerusalem women asked the woman in what ways the man was so much better than other men. In 5:10–16 the woman answered with a poetic description of her beloved that uses many metaphors and hyperbole. Some verses describe the man as though he were a statue.

These verses are similar to 4:1–7 in which the man described the woman's body. Here in 5:9–16 she described his body. It was rare in ancient Israel for a woman to describe a man's body in detail like this. In 4:1–7 where the man described the woman, he spoke directly to her. However, in this section where the woman described him, she did not speak directly to him. She spoke to the women of Jerusalem about him.

The description in 5:9–16 has the similar phrases *My beloved* (5:10) and *This is my beloved* (5:16) near its beginning and end, forming an *inclusio*. It also mentions his golden head (5:11) near the beginning and his legs on bases of gold (5:15) near the end. The woman began by describing his head, then the rest of his body, and ended by mentioning his head again. In the description (5:11–16), four of the six verses describe parts of the man's head (5:11–13, 16), which shows that the woman focused especially on his head. Her description of him may seem strange to modern readers, but she intended her description to show that he was completely desirable.

5:9a–b

In this verse the Jerusalem women asked two similar questions. The second question repeats the first one and adds a reason clause. The Hebrew text is more literally:

^{9a}How is your lover more than a lover, most beautiful of women? ^{9b}How is your lover more than a lover that thus you make us swear?

In some languages it is more natural to translate the phrase “How is your lover more than a lover” only once. For example:

What makes your loved one so special that you make us swear this, most beautiful woman?

How is your beloved better than others, O most beautiful among women?: Here the Jerusalem women asked the woman a real question. They used the phrase O most beautiful among women as a praise name for her. In some languages it is more natural to begin the sentence with this praise name. For example:

Most beautiful of women, what makes your beloved better than any other beloved? (GW)

5:9a

How is your beloved better than others,

- How is your beloved better than any other person’s beloved,
- What makes your man so special,

How is your beloved better than others: Scholars differ about the meaning of than here:

1. It means “better than.” For example:

How is your beloved better than others (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NRSV, ESV, GW, REB, NLT, NET, NCV, NJB, NJPS)

1. It means “different from.” For example:

is your lover different from everyone else? (GNT) (GNT, CEV, NASB, NLT96, NAB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Interpretations (1) and (2) are similar, but the women wanted to know what caused the woman to consider her beloved so much better than any other man.

Some other ways to translate this question are:

What makes your lover better than other lovers

What is it about your loved one that makes you think that he is better than any other lover?

why is the one you love more special than others? (CEV)

5:9

(reordered) Most beautiful woman, why should we swear/promise you that? How is your man better than any other man?

5:9b

O most beautiful among women?

- O fairest among women? (RSV)
- most beautiful of women?

O most beautiful among women?: The phrase most beautiful among women also occurred in 1:8, and you should translate it the same way in both verses. It is more literally “the beautiful one among women.” The man used this phrase to show his admiration for the woman. He compared her to other women, and indicated that she was more beautiful than any of them.

Translate this comparison in a natural way in your language. In some languages it may not be natural to use a phrase like this as direct address. Some other ways to translate it are:

- As a statement. For example:

You are the most beautiful of women. (NCV)

You are very beautiful. Other women are not beautiful beside you.

- As an exclamation. For example:

Oh very beautiful woman among all other women!

Translate the phrase in a natural way in your language.

5:9c

How is your beloved better than another,

- How is your beloved better than another beloved,
- What makes your man so special,

5:9d

that you charge us so?

- that you make us swear to do that?
- that we should promise you?

5:9c–d

How is your beloved better than another, that you charge us so?: In 5:9c the author repeated the question in 5:9a and added the clause in 5:9d. With this added clause, the question implies that 5:9c is the reason for 5:9d. Because her beloved was better than

other lovers, she made the women swear to tell him that she longed for him.

Some other ways to translate this question are:

How is your beloved better than others that you want us to swear such an oath?

What is so wonderful about your lover that you make us swear to tell him that?

Why do you want us to swear that? What makes your lover so special?

that you charge us so?: The phrase that you charge us so means “that you want to make us swear that oath.” It implies that the woman wants them to swear to give him her message because he is especially wonderful and important to her. The logical relation between 5:9c and 5:9d is probably grounds-conclusion. [0] Most English versions use the connector word that. Another way to translate 5:9c–d is:

How is your lover better than other lovers? Why do you want us to promise this? (NCV)

charge: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as charge means “to place/put under oath.” It indicates that someone requires another person to take an oath. Often, the oath requires the person to do something (or not to do something). Here the oath requires the women to give the woman’s message to her beloved if they see him.

In some languages oaths are connected with evil spirits that torment people who fail to perform the oath. That is not the meaning here. So if that is true in your language, use a different word that does not imply that.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

adjure (RSV)

make us promise

General Comment on 5:9

Some scholars suggest that in 5:9 the Jerusalem women teased the woman. They seemed to doubt that the man was so special. Their question gave the woman an opportunity to describe her beloved for them in 5:10–16. Other scholars suggest that the women wanted her to describe him to help them in

their search. However, the women probably knew what he looked like. (In 1:3 the woman mentioned that they loved him.)

When the woman described the man in 5:10–18, she used figures of speech. For example, she said that “His lips are like lilies” (5:13c) and “His eyes are like doves” (5:12a). She used these figures of speech to imply her feelings about him. She did not use realistic descriptions.

Song of Solomon 5:10

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2–7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2–7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
2. Section 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman. Does Section 5:2–6:3 tell about a time after they married? Although 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman, 5:2–6:3 may not refer to a time after the wedding. It may describe something they experienced more than once. In other sections also, the man and woman were apart at the beginning but together at the end (as in 1:2–2:7). If 5:2–6:3 refers to a time before their wedding, some scholars view the whole book, Song of Songs, as a large chiasm. (For example, Dorsey suggests $abcdcb'a'$, (1999, p.200.)) So, the section, 3:6–5:1 is the central and climactic part of the chiasm, and what comes before and after are related to the center, not chronologically but thematically. So, the material both before and after, may be pointing to the grand central climax, the wedding. What follows the wedding, 5:2–8:14, may actually

repeat much of the material in 1:2–3:5. Again, this is more of a cyclical rather than chronological way of understanding the book. It describes the woman's hopes and fears as she imagined her future with the man (as in 3:1–4). The dream might indicate that she feared that he had stopped loving her, but at the end of 6:2–3, she realized that he continued to love her faithfully. Some scholars believe that this section follows chronologically after the wedding. Some of these scholars interpret it as describing a time of conflict for the newly married couple. But the theme of marital conflict does not seem to fit the overall message or tone of the Song.

3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see “Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song” in POEM 4:1–7.)

Paragraph 5:9–16 The woman described her beloved

In 5:9 the Jerusalem women asked the woman in what ways the man was so much better than other men. In 5:10–16 the woman answered with a poetic description of her beloved that uses many metaphors and hyperbole. Some verses describe the man as though he were a statue.

These verses are similar to 4:1–7 in which the man described the woman's body. Here in 5:9–16 she described his body. It was rare in ancient Israel for a woman to describe a man's body in detail like this. In 4:1–7 where the man described the woman, he spoke directly to her. However, in this section where the woman described him, she did not speak directly to him. She spoke to the women of Jerusalem about him.

The description in 5:9–16 has the similar phrases *My beloved* (5:10) and *This is my beloved* (5:16) near its beginning and end, forming an inclusio. It also mentions his golden head (5:11) near the beginning and his legs on bases of gold (5:15) near the end. The woman began by describing his head, then the rest of his body, and ended by mentioning his head again. In the description (5:11–16), four of the six verses describe parts of the man's head (5:11–13, 16), which shows that the woman focused especially on his head. Her description of him may seem strange to modern readers, but she intended her description to show that he was completely desirable.

5:10a

My beloved is dazzling and ruddy,

- My beloved is radiant and healthy,

- My love is handsome and strong.

My beloved is dazzling and ruddy: The clause *My beloved is dazzling and ruddy* probably refers to the man's whole body, not to one particular part. The statement indicates that the man's skin showed that he was healthy. Languages have different ways to describe a person's skin and his good health. It is important to use a natural way in your language to praise a person's skin or his healthy appearance.

Some other ways to translate 5:10a are:

My beloved is radiant and healthy

My lover glows with good health

He is handsome and healthy (CEV)

My beloved: The words *My beloved* here in 5:10a and in 5:16c form an inclusio.

dazzling and ruddy: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *dazzling* means “bright” or “shining.” It is used in 5:11–15 to describe the metals, liquids, and jewels that the woman mentioned. When the word describes skin, as it does here, it indicates that the skin glows. (The word *dazzling* does not mean “white” here.) This description using *dazzling* may also be hyperbolic rather than realistic. It describes the man in greater than life-like splendor, like a golden statue.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *ruddy* probably indicates that the man's complexion was healthy and well-tanned from being in the sun. Such ruddy skin indicates excellent health.

The words *dazzling* and *ruddy* both imply that the man was in excellent health; he was handsome and young. Use natural ways in your language for a woman to describe these qualities in her beloved. Some other ways to translate them are:

My beloved is clear-skinned and ruddy (NJPS)

My beloved is dazzling, and his skin is beautiful.

My lover is handsome and strong (GNT)

5:10b

outstanding among ten thousand.

- the best man among ten thousand others.

- He is more excellent/outstanding than any other man.

outstanding among ten thousand: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as outstanding indicates here that the man is “superior” to all other young men. The number ten thousand is the highest number that is used for comparisons in Hebrew poetry. It is not used in a literal way here, but simply indicates a very large number. The woman meant that no other man could compare to him—he was superior to all of them! Many languages have a figurative expression like this (such as “one in a million” in English).

Some other ways to translate this figure of speech are:

he is the best among ten thousand others.

he is more desirable than all other young men.

no other man is excellent like him.

Song of Solomon 5:11

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2–7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2–7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
2. Section 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman. Does Section 5:2–6:3 tell about a time after they married? Although 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman, 5:2–6:3 may not refer to a time after the wedding. It may describe something they experienced more than once. In

other sections also, the man and woman were apart at the beginning but together at the end (as in 1:2–2:7). If 5:2–6:3 refers to a time before their wedding, some scholars view the whole book, Song of Songs, as a large chiasm. (For example, Dorsey suggests *abcdc b'a'*, (1999, p.200.)) So, the section, 3:6–5:1 is the central and climactic part of the chiasm, and what comes before and after are related to the center, not chronologically but thematically. So, the material both before and after, may be pointing to the grand central climax, the wedding. What follows the wedding, 5:2–8:14, may actually repeat much of the material in 1:2–3:5. Again, this is more of a cyclical rather than chronological way of understanding the book. It describes the woman's hopes and fears as she imagined her future with the man (as in 3:1–4). The dream might indicate that she feared that he had stopped loving her, but at the end of 6:2–3, she realized that he continued to love her faithfully. Some scholars believe that this section follows chronologically after the wedding. Some of these scholars interpret it as describing a time of conflict for the newly married couple. But the theme of marital conflict does not seem to fit the overall message or tone of the Song.

3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see “Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song” in POEM 4:1–7.)

Paragraph 5:9–16 The woman described her beloved

In 5:9 the Jerusalem women asked the woman in what ways the man was so much better than other men. In 5:10–16 the woman answered with a poetic description of her beloved that uses many metaphors and hyperbole. Some verses describe the man as though he were a statue.

These verses are similar to 4:1–7 in which the man described the woman's body. Here in 5:9–16 she described his body. It was rare in ancient Israel for a woman to describe a man's body in detail like this. In 4:1–7 where the man described the woman, he spoke directly to her. However, in this section where the woman described him, she did not speak directly to him. She spoke to the women of Jerusalem about him.

The description in 5:9–16 has the similar phrases My beloved (5:10) and This is my beloved (5:16) near its beginning and end, forming an *inclusio*. It also mentions his golden head (5:11) near the beginning and

his legs on bases of gold (5:15) near the end. The woman began by describing his head, then the rest of his body, and ended by mentioning his head again. In the description (5:11–16), four of the six verses describe parts of the man’s head (5:11–13, 16), which shows that the woman focused especially on his head. Her description of him may seem strange to modern readers, but she intended her description to show that he was completely desirable.

5:11–15

In 5:11–15 the author gives a series of comparisons, using both metaphors and similes. In 5:11–13 the woman began her specific descriptions of the man by describing his head (hair, cheeks, eyes, and lips). More than any other part of the body, the head represents the whole person and his uniqueness.

5:11a

His head is purest gold;

- His head is like pure gold/bronze.
- His face shines like the purest gold, and

His head is purest gold: This clause is a metaphor. It indicates that the man’s head is like fine gold in some way. Since 5:11b refers to the man’s black hair, here in 5:11a His head probably refers to the golden skin of his face and neck. The phrase purest gold probably also has a symbolic meaning. It may imply that the man himself is very precious. He is more valuable to her than anyone else.

Some other ways to translate the metaphor in 5:11b are:

His head is like gold, pure gold (NASB)

His head is as beautiful and precious as pure gold

His face is smooth and clean/shining like bronze

purest gold: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as purest gold consists of two different words for gold. Together these two words imply that the gold is very pure and valuable. So the two words can be translated as an emphatic phrase, as in the BSB.

In the OT, gold is frequently used to symbolize beauty, value, or rarity. Here the woman probably used the phrase purest gold as an emphatic way to symbolize the man’s great worth. Here is another way to translate this:

the finest gold (RSV)

5:11b

his hair is wavy and black as a raven.

- His hair is wavy, and it is as black as a raven’s.
- his wavy/curly hair is as black as a black bird’s feathers.

his hair is wavy: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as wavy occurs only here in the OT. There are two ways to interpret it here:

1. It indicates that the man’s hair is “wavy.” For example:

his hair is wavy (NIV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, RSV, GNT)

1. It indicates that his hair is like “buds or fronds of a palm tree.” For example:

his locks are like palm-fronds (REB) (NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English versions.

wavy: The word that the BSB translates as wavy refers here to curves or curls in the man’s hair. His hair was not straight, but the strands of hair curved gently on his head.

black as a raven: A raven is a certain large black bird. The man’s hair was just as black as the feathers of a raven. Black hair was considered to be beautiful. The contrast between the gold of the man’s face and neck and his black hair made him especially handsome.

The author mentioned a raven here because it is very black. In some languages people may dislike ravens. They may think that they bring bad luck or that they do other bad things. If that is true in your language, you may want to substitute another bird, animal or something else that is known in your area for its blackness.

raven: A raven is a large black bird that is part of the crow family. See the picture above.

Song of Solomon 5:12

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to

him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2–7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2–7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
2. Section 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman. Does Section 5:2–6:3 tell about a time after they married? Although 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman, 5:2–6:3 may not refer to a time after the wedding. It may describe something they experienced more than once. In other sections also, the man and woman were apart at the beginning but together at the end (as in 1:2–2:7). If 5:2–6:3 refers to a time before their wedding, some scholars view the whole book, Song of Songs, as a large chiasm. (For example, Dorsey suggests *abcdc'b'a'*, (1999, p.200.)) So, the section, 3:6–5:1 is the central and climactic part of the chiasm, and what comes before and after are related to the center, not chronologically but thematically. So, the material both before and after, may be pointing to the grand central climax, the wedding. What follows the wedding, 5:2–8:14, may actually repeat much of the material in 1:2–3:5. Again, this is more of a cyclical rather than chronological way of understanding the book. It describes the woman's hopes and fears as she imagined her future with the man (as in 3:1–4). The dream might indicate that she feared that he had stopped loving her, but at the end of 6:2–3, she realized that he continued to love her faithfully. Some scholars believe that this section follows chronologically after the wedding. Some of these scholars interpret it as describing a time of conflict for the newly married couple. But the theme of marital conflict does not seem to fit the overall message or tone of the Song.
3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see "Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song" in POEM 4:1–7.)

Paragraph 5:9–16 The woman described her beloved

In 5:9 the Jerusalem women asked the woman in what ways the man was so much better than other men. In 5:10–16 the woman answered with a poetic description of her beloved that uses many metaphors and hyperbole. Some verses describe the man as though he were a statue.

These verses are similar to 4:1–7 in which the man described the woman's body. Here in 5:9–16 she described his body. It was rare in ancient Israel for a woman to describe a man's body in detail like this. In 4:1–7 where the man described the woman, he spoke directly to her. However, in this section where the woman described him, she did not speak directly to him. She spoke to the women of Jerusalem about him.

The description in 5:9–16 has the similar phrases *My beloved* (5:10) and *This is my beloved* (5:16) near its beginning and end, forming an inclusio. It also mentions his golden head (5:11) near the beginning and his legs on bases of gold (5:15) near the end. The woman began by describing his head, then the rest of his body, and ended by mentioning his head again. In the description (5:11–16), four of the six verses describe parts of the man's head (5:11–13, 16), which shows that the woman focused especially on his head. Her description of him may seem strange to modern readers, but she intended her description to show that he was completely desirable.

5:12

The clause in 5:12 is a simile that has several parts. Scholars interpret the simile and its parts in different ways. The meaning of dove metaphors are difficult to resolve. It is difficult to know the point of similarity, especially because in the OT doves are described in different ways in different verses. They are described as silly and without sense (Hosea 7:11) and as nesting in the rocks (many references). They moan mournfully (Is 59:11), and they can be fearful or shy. There are also other characteristics that are not unique to doves, such as beating their wings, flying, and being lively. There seems to be no consistency in their color. One cannot definitely assume that the reference to milk (Song 5:12b) refers to their white color, since many doves are not white. It is what the doves are bathing in that is white, not necessarily the doves themselves. The simile is a poetic way for the woman to describe her feelings about her beloved's eyes. It implies that when the woman looked at the man's eyes, they seemed as beautiful and gentle to her as doves bathing in milk beside a flowing stream. There is something unusual and profound about many images in the Song. Many commentators have noted how the images often take on a life of their own in the

sense that they become almost a living extension in the realm of nature of the beauty of the beloved. In other words, the beloved's beauty inspires a reverie or daydream. For example, as someone thinks about her own husband and the refreshment his love provides, she may drift off into a beautiful daydream of a mountain meadow with rushing streams. This may be similar to how the author thought of some of the Song's metaphors. She did not imply that the man's eyes actually looked like doves.

5:12a

His eyes are like doves

- His eyes are doves
- His eyes are as gentle as doves

5:12a-b

His eyes are like doves beside the streams of water, bathed in milk and mounted like jewels: Here the woman compared the man's eyes to doves bathing in milk beside a stream. Doves are beautiful, gentle birds. The word streams probably implies a beautiful place. The phrase bathed in milk implies luxury and beauty. It does not imply that the man or the dove really bathed in milk.

It is also possible that the doves represent the pupils of the man's eyes, since 5:12c says they bathe in milk (the white part of the eye). There is something about the man's eyes that reminds the woman of doves bathing in milk.

Some other ways to translate the comparison are:

His eyes are a pair of doves bathing in a stream flowing with milk. (CEV)

His eyes are like doves beside the water-courses, bathing themselves in milk (NJB)

His eyes have the charm of doves perched/sitting beside a stream. Their centers/irises seem to swim in milk.

doves beside the streams of water: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as streams of water probably refers to smaller bodies of moving water, rather than to springs or a well.

The doves are beside streams of water, (The man's eyes are not beside streams of water.) The phrase streams of water may imply that the man's eyes seemed deep, fresh, or transparent in some way.

5:12b

beside the streams of water, bathed in milk

- bathing in milk by streams full of water,
- that bathe in milk beside water springs.

bathed in milk: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as bathed is an active verb, and it refers to an action. It is not a passive verb, so it is helpful to translate the word as an action (done by the doves). For example:

bathing in milk (GW)

Because the BSB uses a passive verb, the NJB will be used as the source text for 5:12b.

The figure of doves being bathed in milk is probably a poetic way to describe the pupils/irises surrounded by the white part of the man's eyes. There is much variation in the coloration of doves. There are not only white doves but also, for example, gray, brown or blue. It may also be a symbol of abundance. The doves probably represent the pupils/irises of the man's eyes swimming, or "bathing", in the whites of his eyes. This is similar to the hyperbole of abundance in Job 29:6 "...when my steps were bathed in cream and the rock poured out for me streams of oil!" The image of "bathing in milk" alludes to abundance. We use the term "allude" since the simile seems unusually focused on the dove and only alludes to the man's eyes. As many commentators note, the image of the metaphor seems to take on a life of its own. In other words, the literal eye seems to almost totally surrender to this hyperbolic description of doves. Translate this figure of speech in a natural way in your language.

5:12c

and mounted like jewels.

- They sit by a brimful pool.
- They seem to perch/sit on the rim of a pool.

mounted like jewels: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as mounted like jewels is literally "sitting on fullness." The meaning of this phrase is uncertain. There are two main ways to interpret it:

1. The phrase refers to doves sitting beside a pool, stream, or other source of water. It may also refer figuratively to the man's eyes. For example:

sitting beside a full pool. (ESV) (ESV, NJB, NJPS, GNT)

1. This phrase refers to the man's eyes. They are set in his face (or in his eye sockets) like jewels. For example:

mounted like jewels. (NIV) (BSB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Hebrew form of the word that means “sitting” agrees with the form of the word for doves. The grammatically feminine participle that means “sitting” matches the gender of the word for “doves.” Also, the phrase “sitting on fullness” (sitting beside a pool) is parallel to “beside springs of water” (5:12b). These forms in 5:12b–d seem to fit best in the natural setting of the dove. If this does allude to the man’s eyes it may imply that his eyes have a quiet steadiness in the midst of movement. Because the BSB follows interpretation (2), the NJPS is used for the source line for 5:12d in the Display.

Song of Solomon 5:13

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2–7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2–7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
2. Section 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman. Does Section 5:2–6:3 tell about a time after they married? Although 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman, 5:2–6:3 may not refer to a time after the wedding. It may describe something they experienced more than once. In other sections also, the man and woman were apart at the beginning but together at the end (as in 1:2–2:7). If 5:2–6:3 refers to a time before their wedding, Some scholars view the whole book, Song of Songs, as a large chiasm. (For example, Dorsey

suggests abcdc'b'a', (1999, p.200.)) So, the section, 3:6–5:1 is the central and climactic part of the chiasm, and what comes before and after are related to the center, not chronologically but thematically. So, the material both before and after, may be pointing to the grand central climax, the wedding. What follows the wedding, 5:2–8:14, may actually repeat much of the material in 1:2–3:5. Again, this is more of a cyclical rather than chronological way of understanding the book. It describes the woman’s hopes and fears as she imagined her future with the man (as in 3:1–4). The dream might indicate that she feared that he had stopped loving her, but at the end of 6:2–3, she realized that he continued to love her faithfully. Some scholars believe that this section follows chronologically after the wedding. Some of these scholars interpret it as describing a time of conflict for the newly married couple. But the theme of marital conflict does not seem to fit the overall message or tone of the Song.

3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see “Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song” in POEM 4:1–7.)

Paragraph 5:9–16 The woman described her beloved

In 5:9 the Jerusalem women asked the woman in what ways the man was so much better than other men. In 5:10–16 the woman answered with a poetic description of her beloved that uses many metaphors and hyperbole. Some verses describe the man as though he were a statue.

These verses are similar to 4:1–7 in which the man described the woman’s body. Here in 5:9–16 she described his body. It was rare in ancient Israel for a woman to describe a man’s body in detail like this. In 4:1–7 where the man described the woman, he spoke directly to her. However, in this section where the woman described him, she did not speak directly to him. She spoke to the women of Jerusalem about him.

The description in 5:9–16 has the similar phrases My beloved (5:10) and This is my beloved (5:16) near its beginning and end, forming an inclusio. It also mentions his golden head (5:11) near the beginning and his legs on bases of gold (5:15) near the end. The woman began by describing his head, then the rest of his body, and ended by mentioning his head again. In the description (5:11–16), four of the six verses describe parts of the man’s head (5:11–13, 16), which

shows that the woman focused especially on his head. Her description of him may seem strange to modern readers, but she intended her description to show that he was completely desirable.

5:13

In 5:11–12 the author described what the woman saw. Here in 5:13 he describes what she smelled. In 5:13a–b, he used a simile, and in 5:13c–d he used a metaphor.

5:13a

His cheeks are like beds of spice,

- His cheeks are like a garden where spice plants grow
- His face smells wonderful, like a farm

5:13b

towers of perfume.

- and spread their fragrance.
- full of sweet-smelling plants.

5:13a–b

His cheeks are like beds of spice, towers of perfume: Here the woman compared the man's cheeks to beds of spice. Some scholars recommend the translation "his beard." They indicate that the word often translated as "cheeks" can also refer to a person's chin. However, no English version consulted follows this interpretation. The word cheeks also occurred in 1:10, where it referred to the woman's cheeks. BDB suggests the meaning "cheek" in this context. HALOT suggests the conjectural meaning 1. "chin" or meaning 3. "cheek." It can refer to various parts of the sides of a person's face. Here the woman described the perfume of the man's cheeks. They smelled like sweet-smelling spices. The woman probably did not imply that the man's beard looked like a garden of spice plants.

Some other ways to translate the comparison are:

His face is a garden of sweet-smelling spices
(CEV)

His cheeks smell as sweet as a garden filled with
spice plants.

His cheeks are like a garden of spices, a garden
that produces scented herbs. (GW)

beds of spice: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as beds is singular. It refers to a garden or part of a garden. The word spice refers to herb plants that have a pleasing smell. The phrase beds of spice can also be translated as "garden of spices." See the preceding note for translation examples.

spice: The word spice was also used in 4:16. There it also referred to spice plants.

towers of perfume: There are two ways to interpret the phrase that the BSB translates as towers of perfume. The difference of interpretation is based on a textual issue. The textual issue is based on a disagreement about which Hebrew vowel should be supplied.

1. The phrase means "yielding fragrance." The Greek Septuagint version has the meaning "yielding fragrance." For example:

yielding perfume... (NIV) (GW, NET, NIV, NLT, RSV)

1. The phrase means "banks/towers of perfume." The Hebrew Masoretic text has the meaning "towers of perfume." For example:

Banks of perfume... (NJPS) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Interpretation (2) is not natural in many languages, since perfume does not form banks or towers. English versions that follow interpretation (2) usually do not translate "tower" literally because of this difficulty. The ancient Greek version (LXX) also follows interpretation (1). A change of the vowel points in the Hebrew Masoretic text gives the meaning "yielding fragrance" which is followed by the Septuagint. HALOT and BDB also follow option (1).

5:13c

His lips are like lilies,

- His lips are lilies
- His lips remind me of lilies;

His lips are like lilies: Here the woman used a simile. She compared the man's lips to lilies. The simile implies that the man's lips are like sweet-smelling lilies. The thought of the sweet smell of his lips probably reminded the woman of his kisses. Some other ways to translate this figure of speech are:

- Use a metaphor. For example:

His lips are lilies

- Use a simile and indicate the meaning. For example:

His lips smell as sweet as lilies

- Translate the meaning more directly. For example:

His lips smell sweet

Translate the meaning in a natural way in your language.

lilies: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as lilies also occurred in 2:16 and 4:5. It occurred in the singular form in 2:1–2. Refer to how you translated it in those verses.

5:13d

dripping with flowing myrrh.

- that drip myrrh perfume.
- they smell as sweet as perfume.

dripping with flowing myrrh: The phrase dripping with flowing myrrh is a hyperbole. Here it probably refers to the man's lips being moist. It is similar to the phrase "my fingers dripped with flowing myrrh" in 5:5c.

However, since the context here is lips (instead of fingers), you may need to translate the phrase in a slightly different way here. For example:

wet with liquid myrrh (GNT)

that drip with myrrh (GW)

they are/smell as sweet as fine perfume

flowing myrrh: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as flowing myrrh is literally "myrrh flowing," as in 5:5c. The man's lips were like lilies and myrrh because of the pleasure that his lips gave the woman. This way that the woman compared his lips to myrrh is similar to the way he compared her lips to dripping honey in 4:11. Translate this phrase in the same way here and in 5:5.

Song of Solomon 5:14

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2–7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2–7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
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Paragraph 5:9–16 The woman described her beloved

In 5:9 the Jerusalem women asked the woman in what ways the man was so much better than other men. In 5:10–16 the woman answered with a poetic description

of her beloved that uses many metaphors and hyperbole. Some verses describe the man as though he were a statue.

These verses are similar to 4:1–7 in which the man described the woman's body. Here in 5:9–16 she described his body. It was rare in ancient Israel for a woman to describe a man's body in detail like this. In 4:1–7 where the man described the woman, he spoke directly to her. However, in this section where the woman described him, she did not speak directly to him. She spoke to the women of Jerusalem about him.

The description in 5:9–16 has the similar phrases My beloved (5:10) and This is my beloved (5:16) near its beginning and end, forming an inclusio. It also mentions his golden head (5:11) near the beginning and his legs on bases of gold (5:15) near the end. The woman began by describing his head, then the rest of his body, and ended by mentioning his head again. In the description (5:11–16), four of the six verses describe parts of the man's head (5:11–13, 16), which shows that the woman focused especially on his head. Her description of him may seem strange to modern readers, but she intended her description to show that he was completely desirable.

5:14–15

In 5:14–15 the author compared the man to a statue, and he used poetic figures of speech. He did not intend for readers to interpret the figures of speech literally.

5:14a

His arms are rods of gold

- His arms are like golden rods,
- His arms are strong like bronze cylinders/bars

His arms are rods of gold: This clause is a metaphor that compares the man's arms to rods of gold. The word rods implies that the man's arms were well-shaped and powerful. The word gold implies that his arms were precious like gold. It may also imply that the color of his skin was beautiful like gold.

Some other ways to translate the metaphor are:

- Use a simile. For example:

His arms are like rounded bars of gold (NLT)

- Use a simile and make the meaning more explicit. For example:

His arms are as precious/beautiful as golden bars/poles.

Translate the metaphor in a natural and appealing way in your language.

arms: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as arms can refer to either a person's hand (from the wrist to the fingertips) or to his arm (from the shoulder to the fingertips). NIDOTTE, Volume 2, page 402, indicates that this word “covers the semantic range of ‘hand’ and ‘arm.’” (Manfred Dreytza). Scholars differ about whether it refers to the man's arms or to his hands in this context.

1. It refers to his arms. For example:

His arms are rods of gold... (NIV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, NET, NIV, NLT, REB, RSV)

1. It refers to his hands. There are several commentators who think that “hand” is a sexual euphemism for the man's genitals. However, it is better for translators to translate the image as it is without translating sexual meanings that are probably not implied here. For example:

His hands are golden, rounded... (NJB) (GW, NASB, NCV, NJB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The meaning arms fits the description of being like rounded gold. It is also more parallel to “legs” in the next verse (5:15), since both arms and legs are larger limbs of the body.

5:14b

set with beryl.

- decorated with precious/expensive stones/jewels.
- that are beautifully decorated.

set with beryl: The phrase set with beryl indicates here that jewels, such as beryl, were embedded in the gold. Some other ways to translate this phrase is:

covered with jewels (CEV)

with inlaid jewels

adorned/decorated with jewels

beryl: The exact meaning of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as beryl is uncertain. Some English versions use a general term, such as jewels (RSV). Other versions use a specific type of jewel, such as chrysolite, beryl (BSB), or topaz. In this verse the author did

not focus on a specific jewel but on the beauty and value that the jewels added to the gold and to the man's glory. It is fine to use a general term here.

5:14c

His body is an ivory panel

- His abdomen is like polished ivory, (NET)
- His torso/chest is as beautiful/precious as carved ivory

His body is an ivory panel: In this phrase the author continued to compare the man's body to a statue. People sometimes used ivory to carve statues. Ivory comes from the tusks (teeth) of elephants, and it is valuable and beautiful. The phrase His body is an ivory panel indicates that the man's body was as beautiful as ivory.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

His body is like polished ivory (NIV)

His body is beautiful/precious like the tusk/teeth of elephants

His body: Some commentators think that "stomach" actually refers to the loins in the area of the man's genitals. This interpretation is speculative and should not be followed. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as His body has several meanings. In this context it probably refers to the outside of the man's body, especially the stomach or abdominal area, possibly up to the chest. Some other ways to translate it are:

His abdomen (NET)

His torso/belly

an ivory panel: The phrase ivory panel indicates that people work on the ivory in some way to make it more beautiful. They may polish it or carve it. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

polished/shining ivory

carved/decorated ivory

5:14d

bedecked with sapphires.

- inlaid with lapis lazuli.
- inlaid with expensive blue jewels.

bedecked with sapphires: The phrase bedecked with sapphires indicates that the ivory in 5:14c was decorated with the blue jewels called sapphires. It probably implies that the sapphires were embedded in the ivory. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

decorated with sapphires (CEV)

covered with sapphires (GW)

adorned with beautiful/precious stones

glowing with lapis lazuli (NLT)

sapphires: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sapphires refers to a blue gem stone, probably "lapis lazuli," as in the NLT. If lapis lazuli is not known in your area, some other ways to translate it are:

- Use a different precious stone that is blue or bluish. For example:

sapphires (RSV)

- Use a general term for jewels. For example:

blue jewels

precious stones

Song of Solomon 5:15

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2–7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2–7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order,

and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.

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Paragraph 5:9–16 The woman described her beloved

In 5:9 the Jerusalem women asked the woman in what ways the man was so much better than other men. In 5:10–16 the woman answered with a poetic description of her beloved that uses many metaphors and hyperbole. Some verses describe the man as though he were a statue.

These verses are similar to 4:1–7 in which the man described the woman's body. Here in 5:9–16 she described his body. It was rare in ancient Israel for a

woman to describe a man's body in detail like this. In 4:1–7 where the man described the woman, he spoke directly to her. However, in this section where the woman described him, she did not speak directly to him. She spoke to the women of Jerusalem about him.

The description in 5:9–16 has the similar phrases *My beloved* (5:10) and *This is my beloved* (5:16) near its beginning and end, forming an inclusio. It also mentions his golden head (5:11) near the beginning and his legs on bases of gold (5:15) near the end. The woman began by describing his head, then the rest of his body, and ended by mentioning his head again. In the description (5:11–16), four of the six verses describe parts of the man's head (5:11–13, 16), which shows that the woman focused especially on his head. Her description of him may seem strange to modern readers, but she intended her description to show that he was completely desirable.

5:15a–b

In 5:15a–b the woman continued to describe the man as if he were a statue. The statement "His legs are pillars of marble set on bases of pure gold" is a metaphor and also a hyperbole.

5:15a

His legs are pillars of marble

- His legs are like tall columns of alabaster/marble,
- His legs are as strong as tall posts made of finest stone,

His legs are pillars of marble: This clause is a metaphor. It indicates that the man's legs were straight and strong, and they were beautiful like the precious stone called marble. Some other ways to translate this description are:

His legs are like columns made of alabaster

His legs are as tall and beautiful as marble columns

His legs are like tall posts made of beautiful stone

His legs: Some commentators think that "legs" may refer to the man's genitals. Following this interpretation is not recommended. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *His legs* probably includes the entire legs from the thighs down to the ankles.

pillars of marble: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as *pillars of marble* indicates that the man's legs were straight and strong, like tall, rounded posts made of carved marble.

marble is a stone that is made of a certain mineral. The color of the stone can be various shades of white and a light rust color. The stone is strong and durable. Sculptors used it to carve statues or other valuable objects such as vases.

Some versions translate this word as “alabaster.” Marble and alabaster are similar, and marble is the harder of the two stones. The Hebrew word can refer to either of these two stones. Use the term that communicates best in your language.

Some other ways to translate the phrase pillars of marble are:

tall posts made of valuable stone

alabaster columns

5:15b

set on bases of pure gold.

- set on bases/feet that are made of gold.
- and his feet are as precious as gold.

set on bases of pure gold: Statues were set up on a strong base (foundation), which balanced the statue and kept it from falling over. Bases were often made of stone, but here the bases were made of gold. The phrase set on bases of pure gold probably implies that the man’s feet were like bases of gold. So the author indicates that the man’s head (5:11a) and his feet were valuable like gold.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

on feet of gold. (CEV)

placed in bases made of gold.

5:15c

His appearance is like Lebanon,

- His appearance is awesome like Lebanon,
- He is as majestic/wonderful as the region of Lebanon.

5:15d

as majestic as the cedars.

- as esteemed as its cedar trees.
- People admire him as they admire the tall/towering cedar trees there.

5:15c–d

The phrases in 5:15c–d are similes. They compare the man’s overall stature to the region of Lebanon and to

the cedars in Lebanon. These similes are also hyperboles.

His appearance is like Lebanon, as majestic as the

cedars: The phrase His appearance refers to the way the man seemed to the people who saw him. He seemed as wonderful and fascinating as the region of Lebanon, which has majestic mountains and tall cedar trees. Some other ways to translate 5:15c–d are:

He is majestic, like the Lebanon Mountains with their towering cedars. (GNT)

He looks as magnificent as the Lebanon Mountains and their tall cedar trees.

Lebanon: Lebanon was a rugged mountainous region north of Israel. It was famous for its tall cedar trees and was known as a beautiful and wild place. So when the woman described the man as being like the cedars of Lebanon, she implied that he was the tallest and strongest among all the other men. This description is like the phrase in 5:10 that describes the man as “outstanding among ten thousand.”

In earlier chapters the man also praised the woman by comparing her to Lebanon. He said that the fragrance of her garments was like Lebanon (4:11c), and he described her as being like streams that flow from Lebanon (4:15c). So here she responded to his praise in a similar way.

Lebanon was discussed in 4:8 and 4:15. Refer to the Notes there for more information.

as majestic as the cedars: Here the woman compared the man to the cedar trees in Lebanon. The word majestic indicates that the trees are of very good quality. The cedars of Lebanon were large and tall, and people valued their lumber highly. Cedars of Lebanon were also fragrant trees.

Here the woman compared the man to those cedars. He was tall, noble, and strong like the cedars of Lebanon. He was the choice man among all the other men. Some other ways to translate the comparison are:

like the cedars of Lebanon that everyone chooses as the best/finest trees.

as the cedar trees in Lebanon, which people admire/consider as the best of all trees.

Song of Solomon 5:16

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

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5:16

This verse is a climax to the woman's long description of the man. She answered the teasing question that the Jerusalem women asked in 5:9.

5:16a

His mouth is most sweet;

- His mouth is delicious/delightful to kiss.
- His kisses delight me.

In 5:15c–d the woman summarized her description of the man's body. Now in 5:16 she again described the man's mouth.

His mouth is most sweet: There are different ways to interpret the word mouth and the whole clause here:

1. His “sweet mouth” refers to his kisses. For example:

His mouth is sweet to kiss (GNT) (CEV, NCV, GNT)

1. His “sweet mouth” refers to his speech. For example:

His conversation is sweetness itself (NJB) (NJB, RSV)

Most English versions translate literally and do not make the meaning of “sweet mouth” explicit. These versions include BSB, ESV, NASB, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, and REB. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). His “sweet mouth” probably refers to his kisses, since that fits with his physical description better than interpretation (2).

Some ways to translate this meaning are:

- Use a figure of speech in your language that implies kissing. For example:

His mouth is delicious... (NJPS)

His mouth is delightful...

- Make the meaning explicit. For example:

His mouth is sweet to kiss (NCV)

His kisses are sweet/delightful

Translate the meaning in a natural way in your language.

most sweet: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as most sweet is a figure of speech. Here it indicates that the man’s kisses are delightful. It implies that it is sweet when the man kisses the woman or when she kisses him. Those kisses give great pleasure.

General Comment on “mouth” and “kisses”

The author refers to the theme of the couple’s mouths and their implied kisses often throughout the book. The first time was in 1:2, “Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth.” Since the woman began the book with the theme of kisses, it is not surprising that she focused here on her beloved’s mouth as she described his body. (Also see 8:1, and possibly 2:3.) The man referred to her mouth and kisses in 4:3, 4:11, and 7:9.

5:16b he is altogether lovely.

- He is desirable in every way. (NLT)
- Everything about him is delightful.

he is altogether lovely: This clause indicates that the woman considered her beloved to be precious and wonderful in every way. It is similar to what the man said to her in 4:7: “You are altogether beautiful, my darling; in you there is no flaw.” Some other ways to say this are:

everything about him enchants me (GNT)

he is altogether lovable (NJB)

he is desirable in every way (NLT)

5:16c This is my beloved,

- This is/describes my love.
- This is what the one I love is like.

5:16e O daughters of Jerusalem.

- O maidens of Jerusalem. (NJPS)
- for you as you asked, young women of Jerusalem.

5:16c–e

The clause “This is my beloved” here in 5:16c and the phrase “My beloved” in 5:10a form an inclusio. They occur at the beginning and the end of the woman’s description of the man (5:10–16). The woman emphasized that in 5:10–16 she answered the question that the Jerusalem women asked her in 5:9.

This is my beloved, and this is my friend, O daughters of Jerusalem: The two clauses in 5:16c–d, This is my beloved and this is my friend, have almost the same meaning in this context. The two clauses show that the woman has now answered the question that the Jerusalem women asked in 5:9—“How is your beloved better than others?” Indicate in a natural way that this clause answers that question. For example:

That is what my beloved and friend is like, women of Jerusalem.

Now I have told you what my beloved and friend is like, Jerusalem women.

Some other ways to translate 5:16c–e are:

- Change the order of phrases in 5:16c–e. For example:

O women of Jerusalem, now I have told you about my lover. That is what my dear one is like.

- Translate the similar meanings of 5:16c and 5:16d only once. For example:

This is what my lover is like, women of Jerusalem.
(GNT)

5:16d and this is my friend,

- I have described my beloved man,
- Now I have described this dear one of mine

and this is my friend: This is the only place in the Song where the woman (or the man) used the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as friend to describe their relationship. The plural form “friends” was used in 5:1 to refer to the wedding guests.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as friend can have different meanings, depending on the context. It can be used to describe different types of friendly relationships. Here the meaning is similar to the meaning of the word “beloved.” In some languages it may be more natural to translate this meaning only once. For example, the GNT translates the two statements in 5:16c–d as:

This is what my lover is like (GNT)

Other ways to translate friend here are:

darling (REB)

companion (NET)

Song of Solomon 6:1

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2–7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2–7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
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3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see “Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song” in POEM 4:1–7.)

Paragraph 6:1–3 The man was in his garden

In 5:10–16 the woman answered the women's question by describing the man. Here in 6:1, the women

responded with another question. They asked the woman where the man went, and they offered to help her find him (6:1). When she responded in 6:2–3, she said that her beloved was in his garden. (He was not missing.) Maybe she realized where he was when she praised him to the women. She realized that she and her beloved were still committed to each other, as she said in 6:3, “I belong to my beloved and he belongs to me.”

The “garden” in 6:2 is probably a metaphor for the woman. In 4:12–5:1 the man described the woman as a “garden.” In 4:16–5:1 she described herself as “his garden.”

Although 6:1 begins a new chapter, the poetic section continues until 6:3. It is helpful to show in some way that the chapter division does not indicate the end of the poetic section. This may be done with section headings, line breaks, or a footnote.

6:1a

Where has your beloved gone,

- Where has your love gone,
- Where did your true love go,

Where has your beloved gone: In 5:8 the woman asked the other women to give her beloved a message if they saw him. Because of what she said, the other women thought that she did not know where he was. So in 6:1 they offered to help her find him. They asked her where he went, because they wanted to know where to start their search. This clause is parallel to 6:1c. Some other ways to translate the question are:

where has your lover gone? (GNT)

Which way did your beloved turn (REB)

tell us where he has gone (CEV)

6:1b

O most beautiful among women?

- fairest of women?
- O woman of rare beauty? (NLT)

O most beautiful among women: The phrase most beautiful among women also occurred in 1:8 and 5:9, and you should translate it the same way in all three verses. For more information, see the notes on 5:9a–b.

6:1c

Which way has he turned?

- Tell us which way your true love turned,
- Which direction did your love go?

6:1d

We will seek him with you.

- so that we may search for him with you?
- Tell us, so that we^(excl) can help you find him.

6:1c–d

Which way has he turned? We will seek him with you: In 6:1c–d the Jerusalem women repeated the question that they asked in 6:1a, and then they told their purpose for the question: They wanted to help the woman search for her beloved. They implied that she should tell them which way he went when he left her. Some other ways to translate 6:1c–d are:

Where has your beloved turned? Tell us, that we may seek him with you. (NET)

What direction did he go/take? We want to help you search for him.

Which way has he turned: The clause Which way has he turned is parallel to 6:1a and has a similar meaning. It means “in which direction” or “which way did your beloved go?” Some other ways to translate the clause are:

Tell us which way your lover went (GNT)

Which way did he turn...? (NLT)

General Comment on 6:1

Scholars have different ideas about why the Jerusalem women wanted to help the woman search for the man. Some scholars think that their motives were good, and they wanted to help their friend find him. Other scholars think that they were teasing or mocking her. Others think that they were jealous, or that they only wanted to look at this handsome man. In the context, it seems most likely that their motives were pure and they really wanted to help the woman.

Song of Solomon 6:2

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16).

Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2-3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2-7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2-7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
2. Section 3:6-5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman. Does Section 5:2-6:3 tell about a time after they married? Although 3:6-5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman, 5:2-6:3 may not refer to a time after the wedding. It may describe something they experienced more than once. In other sections also, the man and woman were apart at the beginning but together at the end (as in 1:2-2:7). If 5:2-6:3 refers to a time before their wedding, Some scholars view the whole book, Song of Songs, as a large chiasm. (For example, Dorsey suggests *abdc b'a'*, (1999, p.200.)) So, the section, 3:6-5:1 is the central and climactic part of the chiasm, and what comes before and after are related to the center, not chronologically but thematically. So, the material both before and after, may be pointing to the grand central climax, the wedding. What follows the wedding, 5:2-8:14, may actually repeat much of the material in 1:2-3:5. Again, this is more of a cyclical rather than chronological way of understanding the book. It describes the woman's hopes and fears as she imagined her future with the man (as in 3:1-4). The dream might indicate that she feared that he had stopped loving her, but at the end of 6:2-3, she realized that he continued to love her faithfully. Some scholars believe that this section follows chronologically after the wedding. Some of these scholars interpret it as describing a time of conflict for the newly married couple. But the theme of marital conflict does not seem to fit the overall message or tone of the Song.
3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see "Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song" in POEM 4:1-7.)

Paragraph 6:1-3 The man was in his garden

In 5:10-16 the woman answered the women's question by describing the man. Here in 6:1, the women responded with another question. They asked the woman where the man went, and they offered to help her find him (6:1). When she responded in 6:2-3, she said that her beloved was in his garden. (He was not missing.) Maybe she realized where he was when she praised him to the women. She realized that she and her beloved were still committed to each other, as she said in 6:3, "I belong to my beloved and he belongs to me."

The "garden" in 6:2 is probably a metaphor for the woman. In 4:12-5:1 the man described the woman as a "garden." In 4:16-5:1 she described herself as "his garden."

Although 6:1 begins a new chapter, the poetic section continues until 6:3. It is helpful to show in some way that the chapter division does not indicate the end of the poetic section. This may be done with section headings, line breaks, or a footnote.

6:2a

My beloved has gone down to his garden,

- My darling has gone down to his garden,
- My love went to his garden

6:2b

to the beds of spices,

- to his spice beds
- where the spice beds are,

6:2a-b

My beloved has gone down to his garden, to the beds of spices: Literally, this clause indicates that the man went down to his garden where there were flowers and spice plants. The phrases in 6:2a-b do not indicate that he went to two different places. The word garden and the phrase beds of spices refer to the same place. The beds of spices probably refers to a specific part of the garden.

Some other ways to translate 6:2a-b are:

My darling has gone down to his garden of spices
(CEV)

My beloved has gone down to the beds of spices
in his garden

My dear one has descended to his garden where
the spice plants are.

My beloved has gone down: The author probably used the word down here because most people's gardens were located on a lower level than their houses. They often planted gardens near sources of water like springs or streams, which were in a valley. In some cultures it may be confusing to use the word down here. If that is true in your language, you may omit it. For example:

My beloved went to his garden (GW)

his garden: The phrase his garden is used here as a metaphor to refer to the young woman herself. In 4:12–5:1 the man described the woman as a “garden.” In 4:16–5:1 she is described specifically as the man's garden, and in 6:2–3 it is clear that their love is mutual.

It is not clear whether the text implies that the man and woman had sexual relations at this time. During her dream (5:2–7) she feared that she had lost her beloved and that maybe he had stopped loving her. But this metaphor implies that their love for one another was still strong. That is clear from her statement in 6:3a–b, “I am my beloved's and my beloved is mine.”

the beds of spices: The phrase the beds of spices is parallel to “his garden” (6:2a). beds of spices further describes “his garden.”

6:2c

to pasture his flock in the gardens

- to delight in the garden
- to enjoy his garden

to pasture his flock in the gardens: Here the BSB has supplied the phrase his flock, which is not in the Hebrew text. There are different ways to interpret the phrase to pasture...in the gardens:

1. It is a figure of speech to refer to the man himself “grazing” or “browsing” in the garden. For example:

to browse in the gardens... (NIV) (NIV, NLT, NCV, NET, NJPS, ESV)

1. It has the literal meaning that the man pastures his flock in the garden. For example:

He is feeding his flock in the garden (GNT) (BSB, RSV, GW, GNT, CEV, NASB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Earlier in the Song (2:8–9; 2:17) the author compared the man to a gazelle. In the similar phrase in 2:16b the Notes also recommended the meaning “graze,” as

in interpretation (1) here. It is true that the same verb can also be used to refer to grazing sheep as in 1:7b. However, in that context, it clearly referred to sheep, whereas here it is used to refer directly to the man. Because the BSB follows interpretation (2), the NIV will be used as the source text here in 6:2c.

(NIV) to browse in the gardens: The clause to browse in the gardens is a metaphor. Its exact meaning is uncertain, but it probably implies that the man will enjoy the woman and experience the delight that she will give him. Other ways to translate the metaphor are:

to delight in the gardens (REB)

to enjoy his gardens

(NIV) in the gardens: Here the word gardens is plural, but in 6:2a the author used a singular form to refer to his garden. Both forms probably refer to the same garden. They do not imply that there were many gardens. If a plural form is confusing here in your language, it is fine to refer to only one “garden,” as in the GNT.

6:2d

and to gather lilies.

- and gather lilies there.
- and pick beautiful, fragrant flowers.

and to gather lilies: The phrase to gather lilies is a metaphor. The word lilies probably refers to the delights that the woman gave. (In 2:1–2 she compared herself to a lily of the valley, and the man responded that she was like a lily among thorns.) It is uncertain exactly what gather lilies implies here. However, its meaning is similar to 6:2c, which refers to the man loving the woman and enjoying her love for him.

Some other ways to translate the metaphor are:

and take some of its sweet-smelling flowers.

and pick some of the beautiful lilies.

lilies: As in 2:1b, the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as lilies refers here to a common wildflower that was usually red or purple.

Song of Solomon 6:3

Section 5:2–6:3: At night the woman searched for the man and praised him

Scholars differ about the meaning of this section and how it relates to the rest of the Song. In 5:2–7 the woman told the Jerusalem women that the man came to her door at night but went away. She told them that now she longed to see him and was searching for him. Then she asked them to give him a message if they saw him (5:8). They asked why she was so attracted to him (5:9), and she replied by describing him (5:10–16). Then they asked her where he went (6:1), and she told them that he went down to his garden (6:2–3).

The section contains several interpretation issues:

1. In 5:2–7 did the woman describe a dream or a real event, or is 5:2–7 a poetic way to describe her feelings and thoughts about the man? The woman described one type of event (probably dreamed or imagined) as she and the man related to each other. The author did not always tell about events in order, and he repeated certain themes to examine them from different points of view. The Song is not a simple story but a poem, and it uses various ways to describe the romantic love.
2. Section 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman. Does Section 5:2–6:3 tell about a time after they married? Although 3:6–5:1 told about the wedding of the man and woman, 5:2–6:3 may not refer to a time after the wedding. It may describe something they experienced more than once. In other sections also, the man and woman were apart at the beginning but together at the end (as in 1:2–2:7). If 5:2–6:3 refers to a time before their wedding, Some scholars view the whole book, Song of Songs, as a large chiasm. (For example, Dorsey suggests *abdc b'a'*, (1999, p.200.)) So, the section, 3:6–5:1 is the central and climactic part of the chiasm, and what comes before and after are related to the center, not chronologically but thematically. So, the material both before and after, may be pointing to the grand central climax, the wedding. What follows the wedding, 5:2–8:14, may actually repeat much of the material in 1:2–3:5. Again, this is more of a cyclical rather than chronological way of understanding the book. it describes the woman's hopes and fears as she imagined her future with the man (as in 3:1–4). The dream might indicate that she feared that he had stopped loving her, but at the end of 6:2–3, she realized that he continued to love her faithfully. Some scholars believe that this section follows chronologically after the wedding. Some of these scholars interpret it as describing a

time of conflict for the newly married couple. But the theme of marital conflict does not seem to fit the overall message or tone of the Song.

3. How should a translator interpret the figures of speech in this section? Some scholars interpret these figures as euphemisms for sexual organs and sexual activity. However, such interpretations may cause a translator to refer more explicitly to sexual matters than is normal or justified in the Song. (For more information, see “Standards for respectful speech and actions in the Song” in POEM 4:1–7.)

Paragraph 6:1–3 The man was in his garden

In 5:10–16 the woman answered the women's question by describing the man. Here in 6:1, the women responded with another question. They asked the woman where the man went, and they offered to help her find him (6:1). When she responded in 6:2–3, she said that her beloved was in his garden. (He was not missing.) Maybe she realized where he was when she praised him to the women. She realized that she and her beloved were still committed to each other, as she said in 6:3, “I belong to my beloved and he belongs to me.”

The “garden” in 6:2 is probably a metaphor for the woman. In 4:12–5:1 the man described the woman as a “garden.” In 4:16–5:1 she described herself as “his garden.”

Although 6:1 begins a new chapter, the poetic section continues until 6:3. It is helpful to show in some way that the chapter division does not indicate the end of the poetic section. This may be done with section headings, line breaks, or a footnote.

6:3a

I belong to my beloved

- I am my beloved's, (RSV)
- My love, I am your^(sing) own,

6:3b

and he belongs to me;

- and my beloved is mine. (RSV)
- and you^(sing) are my own.

6:3a–b

I belong to my beloved and he belongs to me: The sentence, I belong to my beloved and he belongs to me is similar to 2:16a (“My beloved is mine and I am his”), except that there the order is reversed.

As in 2:16a, the woman probably spoke directly to her beloved here. However, the sentence sounds as though she spoke to someone else. In Hebrew poetry it is common to speak indirectly like that. In some lan-

guages it is more natural to indicate that the woman spoke directly to the man. For example:

My beloved, I am yours and you are mine.

Her words indicate that she and the man were strongly committed to each other. She implied that they have romantic love only for each other (and for no one else). It does not imply that they owned each other, but it implies that they were loyal to each other. Other ways to translate this sentence are:

I belong to my beloved, and he belongs to me.

My love, I am your own, and you are my own.

6:3c

he pastures his flock among the lilies.

- He grazes in fields of lilies.
- You^(sing) feed yourself where the fragrant flowers grow.

he pastures his flock among the lilies: The clause he pastures his flock among the lilies is identical to 2:16b. As in 2:16b, the interpretation issue is the same. This issue is also similar to the one in 6:2c. As in these previous verses, there are two ways to interpret the verb that the BSB translates as he pastures:

1. It means “he grazes” or “browses,” implying that he feeds himself. For example:

he grazes among the lilies. (NET) (NET, ESV, NAB, NCV, NIV, NJPS, NLT)

1. It means “he pastures (his flock),” implying that he feeds his flock. For example:

he pastures his flock among the lilies. (RSV) (BSB, RSV, CEV, GW, NASB, NJB, REB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as in 6:2c and 2:16b. This probably continues the gazelle theme as in 2:16. Because the BSB follows interpretation (2), the NET will be used as the source line for 6:3c.

(NET) he grazes among the lilies: As in 2:16b, this phrase literally means that the man stands among the lilies. It probably also implies that he eats them. Here the phrase has a figurative meaning, not a literal one. It may be helpful to include a footnote here to make the figurative meaning clear. It should be somewhat

different from the footnote in 2:16 because of the context. An example of a possible footnote is:

“Browsing/grazing among the lilies” has a figurative meaning here. The lilies are a symbol for the woman, especially for the ways that she delights the man.

(NET) among the lilies: The phrase among the lilies indicates literally that the man was located among the lilies in his garden. The garden and the lilies both refer figuratively to the woman. This figure of speech indicates that the man loves the woman and delights in her.

Song of Solomon 6:4

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 6:4–10 The man described the woman

In 6:4–10, the man spoke to the woman. In 6:4–7, he spoke directly to her with forms like “you” and “your.” But in 6:8–10, he spoke about her, using forms like “she” and “her.” In 6:10 the man probably quoted what the other women said to praise her beauty.

This section begins and ends with the same phrase. The BSB translates the phrase in 6:4c as “as majestic as troops with banners,” and in 6:10 it repeats this phrase. However, the context is different, so scholars are not certain whether the meaning of the phrase is the same or different in the two verses. The notes for 6:10 will discuss this issue.

In 6:4–10 the man sang his second praise song to describe the woman. This song is similar in some ways to his first praise song in 4:1–5, and it repeats some

portions of that song. However, here his words seem less intimate. In 4:9 the man indicated that she is superior to all other women.

6:4a-c

The two lines, 6:4a and 6:4b, are parallel. In each line the man compared the woman's beauty to the beauty of an important city. In 6:4a he compared her beauty to Tirzah, and in 6:4b he compared it to Jerusalem. In the third line, he compared the woman to troops carrying banners.

When the man compared the woman to cities and armies, he implied that she was beautiful, grand, splendid, and strong like those cities and armies. He felt awe when he was with her, just as he felt awe when he was in the royal cities or looked at the powerful armies. Be sure that your translation communicates this meaning.

6:4a

You are as beautiful, my darling, as Tirzah,

- You are beautiful like the city of Tirzah, my darling.
- My beloved/love, you are as beautiful as the city of Tirzah,

You are as beautiful, my darling, as Tirzah: Here the man used the phrase my darling as a loving name for the woman, as he did in 1:9. You can translate it in the same way here. In some languages it is more natural to translate the phrase in a different place in the sentence. For example:

My darling, you are as beautiful as Tirzah (NET)

You are beautiful, my true love, like Tirzah (GW)

You are as beautiful...as Tirzah: Here the man compared the woman's beauty to an important city called Tirzah. It had beautiful streets and grand buildings. The man implied that the woman was as grand and beautiful as that city. Some other ways to translate this comparison are:

as lovely as the city of Tirzah (GNT)

you are beautiful...like the splendid/magnificent city of Tirzah

beautiful: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as beautiful is a common word that is used often in the Song. It is used in the phrase "most beautiful of women" in 6:1. Here it compares the woman's beauty to the beauty of a city. In some languages it is natural

to use different words to refer to the beauty of a woman and the beauty of a city. For example:

You are as beautiful as the grand city of Tirzah

Tirzah: Tirzah was the name of a city that King Solomon favored. It was known for its royal splendor and beauty. It became the capital city of the northern kingdom of Israel soon after Solomon died. The breakup of Israel occurred during the reign of Rehoboam, Solomon's son. The northern tribes revolted under the leadership of Jeroboam I who made Tirzah his capital. To many people, the name Tirzah is not familiar, so it may be helpful to make explicit that it is the name of a city. For example:

as lovely as the city of Tirzah (GNT)

beautiful like Tirzah city is beautiful

my darling: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as my darling literally means "my friend" or "my companion." But in a context like the Song, it has a romantic sense. This word is the most common way the man used to refer to the woman in the Song. It was first used in 1:10-11, and you may translate it as you did there.

6:4b

as lovely as Jerusalem,

- You are grand/majestic like Jerusalem.
- and you are as lovely as the city of Jerusalem.

as lovely as Jerusalem: Here the man compared the woman to the city of Jerusalem. He used a different Hebrew word from the word "beautiful" in 6:4a. This word refers to a type of beauty that is appropriate for what is being described. In this situation it is the kind of beauty that is fitting for the woman and also for those great cities.

This word was also used in Song 1:4, 2:14, and 4:3. Refer to how you translated it in these verses. Some other ways to translate the comparison here are:

you are as comely as Jerusalem

you are awesome/grand like the city of Jerusalem.

Jerusalem: Jerusalem was the capital city of the southern kingdom of Judah. It was known for its royal splendor and was famous for its great beauty.

6:4c**as majestic as troops with banners.**

- You are powerful/terrifying like an army waving its banners.
- You are as majestic as troops/soldiers carrying their flags.

as majestic as troops with banners: In this clause the man continued to describe the woman. There are several ways to interpret the clause:

1. It refers to being as awe-inspiring as an army of soldiers, in which some of the soldiers carried large flags (banners). For example:

as majestic as troops with banners. (NIV) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, RSV)

1. It refers to being as awe-inspiring as the sky and all its stars. In 6:10 the context suggests this meaning. For example:

more powerful than all of the stars in the heavens. (CEV) (CEV, REB footnote).

1. It refers to the splendor of these cities without mentioning an army or banners. For example:

as breathtaking as these great cities. (GNT) (GW, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with most English versions.

majestic: In this context the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as majestic probably indicates that the woman was awesome and imposing. The man respected her and felt awed by her great beauty. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

awesome as an army with banners. (ESV)

as awe-inspiring as bannered armies! (NET)

In some languages it may be distracting or strange to compare a woman to an army. If that is true in your language, you may be able to compare her to a queen leading her army. For example:

You are as majestic as a queen coming with an army waving flags.

Song of Solomon 6:5**Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime**

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 6:4–10 The man described the woman

In 6:4–10, the man spoke to the woman. In 6:4–7, he spoke directly to her with forms like “you” and “your.” But in 6:8–10, he spoke about her, using forms like “she” and “her.” In 6:10 the man probably quoted what the other women said to praise her beauty.

This section begins and ends with the same phrase. The BSB translates the phrase in 6:4c as “as majestic as troops with banners,” and in 6:10 it repeats this phrase. However, the context is different, so scholars are not certain whether the meaning of the phrase is the same or different in the two verses. The notes for 6:10 will discuss this issue.

In 6:4–10 the man sang his second praise song to describe the woman. This song is similar in some ways to his first praise song in 4:1–5, and it repeats some portions of that song. However, here his words seem less intimate. In 4:9 the man indicated that she is superior to all other women.

6:5a**Turn your eyes away from me,**

- Look away from me,
- Please do not gaze at me.

6:5b**for they have overcome me.**

- because your beautiful eyes overwhelm me.
- I feel weak/helpless when I look into your eyes.

6:5a–b

Turn your eyes away from me, for they have overcome me: In the Song the man often referred to the

woman's eyes (1:15; 4:1; 4:9; 6:5; 7:4). Here he asked the woman not to look directly into his eyes, because that made him feel confused. The sentence is more literally, "Turn your eyes from me which they confuse me." Her beautiful eyes delighted him, but he could not see their beauty and still think clearly. However, he did not really want her to turn away.

Some other ways to translate 6:5a–b are:

Turn your eyes from me, because they excite me too much. (NCV)

Turn your eyes away from me—I am overcome when you gaze at me!

In some cultures people may not understand the reason for the man's request. They may think that the woman tried to use spiritual power to enchant him. If that is true in your culture, you should translate in a different way that will not imply that wrong meaning. Other ways to translate it are:

- Add implied information to make the meaning clear. For example:

Your eyes confuse me with their beauty. Turn them aside so I can think clearly!

- Use a saying or figure of speech that has the same meaning in your own language.

Turn your eyes away from me: This clause implies that the woman was looking directly into the man's eyes. He asked her not to gaze into his eyes, but at the same time, he did not really want her to look away. He implied that when she looked at him like that, he felt weak from love and desire.

In some languages there may be a special way to express this meaning. In other languages there may be a figure of speech to translate it. Translate the meaning in a natural way that will fit this context in your culture.

for they have overcome me: The phrase they have overcome me is similar to the phrase "You have captured my heart" in 4:9. In 4:9 the man felt helpless, but he also felt pleasure. Here in 6:5 the meaning is similar, but his feeling when he looked into her eyes was even stronger. Some other ways to translate it are:

they overwhelm me! (NRSV)

they are holding me captive. (GNT)

they overpower me. (NLT)

6:5c

Your hair is like a flock of goats

- Your hair looks like a flock of goats
- Your wavy hair is like many black goats,

6:5d

streaming down from Gilead.

- as it moves/flows down the slopes of Gilead.
- surging down from Gilead heights.

6:5c–d

Your hair is like a flock of goats streaming down from Gilead: The comparison here is identical to the one in 4:1d–e. Translate it in the same way here. For more information, see the notes on 4:1d–e.

Song of Solomon 6:6

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 6:4–10 The man described the woman

In 6:4–10, the man spoke to the woman. In 6:4–7, he spoke directly to her with forms like "you" and "your." But in 6:8–10, he spoke about her, using forms like "she" and "her." In 6:10 the man probably quoted what the other women said to praise her beauty.

This section begins and ends with the same phrase. The BSB translates the phrase in 6:4c as "as majestic as troops with banners," and in 6:10 it repeats this phrase. However, the context is different, so scholars are not certain whether the meaning of the phrase is

the same or different in the two verses. The notes for 6:10 will discuss this issue.

In 6:4-10 the man sang his second praise song to describe the woman. This song is similar in some ways to his first praise song in 4:1-5, and it repeats some portions of that song. However, here his words seem less intimate. In 4:9 the man indicated that she is superior to all other women.

6:6a

Your teeth are like a flock of sheep

- Your teeth are like a flock of white female sheep
- Your teeth are as white as sheep

6:6b

coming up from the washing;

- that have just been washed in the stream.
- just coming from their bath. (NCV)

6:6a-b

Your teeth are like a flock of sheep coming up from the washing: The clause Your teeth are like a flock of sheep is the same as 4:2a except that 4:2a includes the word “shorn,” which 6:6a lacks. Your translation should be the same here as in 4:2a, except that here it is not necessary to mention that the sheep were shorn. For example:

Your teeth are as white as a flock of sheep that have just been washed. (GNT)

Your teeth are as white as sheep that are freshly washed. (NLT)

For more information, see the notes for 4:2a.

6:6c

each has its twin,

- Your teeth are like twin lambs, coming up in pairs,
- Each of your teeth has its twin.

6:6d

and not one of them is lost.

- not a single one is missing.
- All are present.

6:6c-d

each has its twin, and not one of them is lost: The clauses in 6:6c-d are identical to the ones in 4:2c-d. They continue to describe the ewes in 6:6a-b. You should translate the clauses in the same way as you did in 4:2c-d. For more information, see the notes for 4:2c-d.

Song of Solomon 6:7

Section 6:4-8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4-10 and 7:1-10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11-13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13-7:13 in the BSB is 7:1-14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 6:4-10 The man described the woman

In 6:4-10, the man spoke to the woman. In 6:4-7, he spoke directly to her with forms like “you” and “your.” But in 6:8-10, he spoke about her, using forms like “she” and “her.” In 6:10 the man probably quoted what the other women said to praise her beauty.

This section begins and ends with the same phrase. The BSB translates the phrase in 6:4c as “as majestic as troops with banners,” and in 6:10 it repeats this phrase. However, the context is different, so scholars are not certain whether the meaning of the phrase is the same or different in the two verses. The notes for 6:10 will discuss this issue.

In 6:4-10 the man sang his second praise song to describe the woman. This song is similar in some ways to his first praise song in 4:1-5, and it repeats some portions of that song. However, here his words seem less intimate. In 4:9 the man indicated that she is superior to all other women.

6:7

Your brow behind your veil is like a slice of pomegranate.

- Your cheeks behind your veil are like pomegranate halves.
- Behind your veil your cheeks are rosy like two halves of a pomegranate.

Your brow behind your veil is like a slice of pomegranate: The clause, Your brow behind your veil is like a slice of pomegranate, is identical to 4:3c. There are different ways to interpret the verse. You should

translate it in the same way as you did there. Refer to the notes on 4:3c for a discussion of the interpretation issues and for other information on how to translate the clause.

Song of Solomon 6:8

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

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Paragraph 6:4–10 The man described the woman

In 6:4–10, the man spoke to the woman. In 6:4–7, he spoke directly to her with forms like “you” and “your.” But in 6:8–10, he spoke about her, using forms like “she” and “her.” In 6:10 the man probably quoted what the other women said to praise her beauty.

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In 6:4–10 the man sang his second praise song to describe the woman. This song is similar in some ways to his first praise song in 4:1–5, and it repeats some portions of that song. However, here his words seem less intimate. In 4:9 the man indicated that she is superior to all other women.

6:8–10

In the previous verses (6:4–7), the man spoke to the woman directly, using forms like “you” and “your.” He described her head and face. But here in 6:8–10 he spoke indirectly, using phrases like “the favorite of the mother who bore her.” He described her beauty, using words like “perfect one,” “unique,” and “fair.” In 6:10

he compared her beautiful face to the beauty of the sun, moon, and stars.

6:8–9

In 6:8–9 the man compared the woman to beautiful women in the royal court. The “sixty queens” and “eighty concubines” were wives of a king, but the particular king is not mentioned. It probably was not Solomon, since the author did not mention him here. Also, the numbers (60 and 80) do not match the number of Solomon’s wives in 1 Kings 11:3.

6:8a–9a

There are sixty queens and eighty concubines, and maidens without number: This statement gives a hypothetical situation. It does not imply that the king (or the man) really had 60 wives, 80 concubines and a very large number of maidens. The man used the statement to praise his bride and to indicate that she was unique. No queen, concubine, or maiden could ever be as wonderful as she was.

Some ways to translate this meaning are:

What if I could have sixty queens, eighty wives, and thousands of others! ^aYou would be my only choice.... (CEV)

Even if someone offered me 60 queens, 80 wives, and any number of beautiful girls, I would love only you.

In some languages the numbers 60 and 80 may be complex phrases, or the numbers may make the poetry seem dull or unnatural. If that is true in your language, you may use a more general way to refer to increasingly large numbers. For example.

If I could have many queens, more concubines, and countless girls, you would be my only choice, my perfect mate.

Translate the statement in a way that will imply this meaning in your language.

6:8

When the author mentioned the numbers “sixty,” “eighty,” and “without number,” he mentioned the lowest number first. But when he mentioned the status of the women, he mentioned the ones with higher status first: “queens,” “concubines,” and “maidens.”

The numbers “sixty” and “eighty” are a poetic way to imply that a person could compare the woman to any number of other women (even queens and concubines), but no one would be as perfect as she was. It

was common in Wisdom literature to use the phrase “there are three things....there are four.” This verse uses the numbers 60 and 80, which could be arrived at by multiplying 3 and 4 by 20 (3 times 20 is 60; 4 times 20 is 80), as Garrett suggests (page 229). The significance of these numbers is that there is no other woman at all who can equal the man’s beloved.

6:8a

There are sixty queens

- There may be sixty queens
- If I was the king and I could have many wives,

sixty queens: The word queens refers to the king’s wives. In Solomon’s time it was common in Israel and other countries for a king to have many wives. These queens sometimes had great power.

6:8b

and eighty concubines,

- and there may be eighty concubines
- and even more women to serve me

and eighty concubines: The concubines were also wives of the king, but they had less status and power than the queens. They were often chosen because of their beauty. In some languages there is no word for concubines and the idea may be offensive. If that is true in your language, you may be able to use a more general phrase. For example:

women to serve the king

6:8c

and maidens without number,

- and there may be maidens without number.
- and too many other girls to count,

and maidens without number: The phrase maidens without number is a hyperbole. It implies that there were so many young women that no one could count them. Other ways to translate the phrase are:

so many girls you cannot count them (NCV)

countless young women (NLT)

maidens: The word maidens probably refers to young women who are old enough to be married but are not yet mothers. There were many women who were probably associated with the king’s court but were not formally married. It is good to use a word in your language that refers to young unmarried women.

Song of Solomon 6:9

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 6:4–10 The man described the woman

In 6:4–10, the man spoke to the woman. In 6:4–7, he spoke directly to her with forms like “you” and “your.” But in 6:8–10, he spoke about her, using forms like “she” and “her.” In 6:10 the man probably quoted what the other women said to praise her beauty.

This section begins and ends with the same phrase. The BSB translates the phrase in 6:4c as “as majestic as troops with banners,” and in 6:10 it repeats this phrase. However, the context is different, so scholars are not certain whether the meaning of the phrase is the same or different in the two verses. The notes for 6:10 will discuss this issue.

In 6:4–10 the man sang his second praise song to describe the woman. This song is similar in some ways to his first praise song in 4:1–5, and it repeats some portions of that song. However, here his words seem less intimate. In 4:9 the man indicated that she is superior to all other women.

6:9a

but my dove, my perfect one, is unique,

- I would still want only one woman, my dove and perfect one.

but my dove, my perfect one, is unique: In the previous verse the man compared his beloved with many other women. Here he declared that there was no other woman as beautiful as his beloved. She was unique. Some other ways to translate this statement are:

There is only one for me. She is like a gentle dove,
and she is perfect.

But no one is like my perfect dove.

You would be my only choice, my flawless dove.
(CEV)

For me, there is only one woman in the world. She
is like a perfect dove.

my dove: The phrase my dove is an affectionate nickname for the woman. A dove is a beautiful and gentle bird that was a symbol for love. The phrase was also used in 2:14, where the man spoke directly to the woman. For more information, see the Notes on 2:14a-b.

my perfect one: The expression my perfect one is also found in 5:2. The meaning is also similar to 4:7, “You are all fair my love, there is no flaw in you.” It indicates that the woman was so beautiful that she seemed perfect to the man. To him, she seemed to have no defect or flaw. Translate this phrase in the same way as you did in 5:2.

is unique: Here the BSB uses the phrase is unique to translate the word that means “one” in Hebrew. In this context it indicates that there was no one like the woman. Here is another way to translate this:

is unique (NIV)

For more translation examples, see the first note on 6:9a.

6:9b the favorite of the mother who bore her.

- especially dear to the one who gave birth to her.
- and her mother has special love for her.

the favorite of the mother: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the favorite of the mother is literally “one she to her mother.” There are different ways to interpret this phrase:

1. She is her mother’s favorite daughter. For example:

She is the special daughter of her mother... (NET)
(BSB, CEV, GW, NET, NJB, NLT, RSV)

1. She is the only daughter or child of her mother. For example:

the only daughter of her mother... (NIV) (NASB,
NCV, NIV, REB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is not clear which interpretation ESV or NJPS follow since they translate this literally. In this context, being an only daughter is not in focus. It is more significant that her mother considered her special and unique. Its meaning is similar to the way the author used the word “one” in 6:9a to mean “unique.”

who bore her: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as bore means “gave birth to.” In some languages it may be more natural to refer back to her mother in a different way, as in the Display.

6:9c-d

In 6:8 the man compared the woman’s beauty to three groups of women in the royal court: queens, concubines, and maidens. Here in 6:9c-d, those same three groups of women also praised the woman. Here he began with the maidens before mentioning the queens and concubines:

^{9d}The maidens see her and call her blessed

^{9e}the queens and concubines sing her praises

Notice that the two lines, 6:9d and 6:9e, are parallel. The two phrases call her blessed and sing her praises have similar meanings.

6:9c

The maidens see her and call her blessed;

- The young women saw her and called her fortunate.
- Girls have seen her and proclaim her blessed. (NJB)

The maidens see her and call her blessed: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as maidens is literally “daughters.” However, here it refers to the same women as in 6:8, where they were called “maidens.” Other ways to translate this phrase are:

The maidens saw her and complimented her...
(NET)

Girls have seen her and proclaimed her blessed...
(NJB)

6:9d

the queens and concubines sing her praises.

- The primary wives and the secondary wives of the king also saw her and praised her, saying,

- The kings' wives and the women who served the king saw her and praised her. They said,

the queens and concubines sing her praises: The phrase the queens and concubines indicates that they also saw the woman, just as the maidens did (6:9c). In some languages it is necessary to make it explicit that queens and concubines saw her. For example:

The queens and concubines also see her, and sing her praises.

(See 6:8a and 6:8b for a discussion of queens and concubines.)

Song of Solomon 6:10

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 6:4–10 The man described the woman

In 6:4–10, the man spoke to the woman. In 6:4–7, he spoke directly to her with forms like “you” and “your.” But in 6:8–10, he spoke about her, using forms like “she” and “her.” In 6:10 the man probably quoted what the other women said to praise her beauty.

This section begins and ends with the same phrase. The BSB translates the phrase in 6:4c as “as majestic as troops with banners,” and in 6:10 it repeats this phrase. However, the context is different, so scholars are not certain whether the meaning of the phrase is the same or different in the two verses. The notes for 6:10 will discuss this issue.

In 6:4–10 the man sang his second praise song to describe the woman. This song is similar in some ways to his first praise song in 4:1–5, and it repeats some

portions of that song. However, here his words seem less intimate. In 4:9 the man indicated that she is superior to all other women.

6:10

This verse is a rhetorical question. Scholars differ about who asked the question. (Some versions indicate the speaker by punctuation or by headings, and some do not indicate the speaker.) The main views about who asked the question are:

1. The “maidens,” “queens” and “concubines” (6:9) asked the question. For example, the NCV has the heading:

The Young Women Praise the Woman (NCV) Other versions introduce the question with a colon or with a comma and quotation marks after mentioning the women as the speaker. For example:

queens and...concubines sing her praises: “Who is this, arising like the dawn...” (NLT) (CEV, NASB, NET, NJB, NLT ESV, RSV)

1. The man asked the question. For example, the GNT has a heading in 6:4 that indicates that the man speaks in 6:4–12. The heading says:

The Man (REB, GNT)

1. A chorus or friends asked the question. For example, the GW has the heading (4:10):

The chorus of young women (GW) (BSB, GW, NCV, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with a majority of English versions. Since 6:9 mentioned that the women praised the bride, it is natural for 6:10 to tell what they said when they praised her. Some versions that follow interpretation (1) indicate that the man speaks in 4–10, but in verse 10 he quoted what the women said to praise the woman.

6:10a–d

Who is this who shines like the dawn, as fair as the moon, as bright as the sun, as majestic as the stars in procession?: This verse is a long rhetorical question that has four parts. It functions as an exclamation to praise the woman and her beauty. Some ways to translate this long rhetorical question are:

- Translate it as a question and a response. For example:

Who is this young woman? She looks like the dawn. She is beautiful like the moon, pure like the sun, awe-inspiring like those heavenly bodies. (GW)

- Translate it as an exclamation and one or more statements. For example:

This lovely woman is amazing! She is glorious like the dawn, lovely as the moon, bright like the sun, and majestic like the stars arranged in the sky.

Translate the verse in a natural way in your language. In the question the Jerusalem women used four figures of speech to describe the woman. They compared her beauty to the dawn, the sun, the moon, and the stars arranged in the sky. They did this to indicate how glorious the woman was. They did not intend to give a realistic description.

For another example of how to translate this verse, see the General Comment on 6:10 at the end of the notes for 6:10d.

6:10a

Who is this who shines like the dawn,

- “Who is this woman who appears like the dawn,
- “She shines like the dawn!

Who is this who shines like the dawn: This is a rhetorical question. The first part of the question, Who is this, is also used to begin the rhetorical questions in 3:6 and 8:5. The form of the word this obviously refers to the woman. In 3:6 and 8:5 she came up from the wilderness.

Here the women praised her by comparing her to the way the dawn comes and shines in the sky. In some languages people do not say that the dawn “shines” or “looks down (forth)” from the sky. They use other ways to describe the dawn. For example:

like the sun brightening the sky in the early morning

glows/shines like the dawning day

brings light/whiteness to the earth

like the dawn: The dawn is the time of day before the sun rises. There is glowing light and color in the sky which show that the sun is about to come up. Languages have different ways to describe this time

of day. There may be poetic ways to describe the brightness and colors in the sky at this time.

Refer to the dawn in a natural and poetic way. See the preceding note for more translation examples.

6:10b

as fair as the moon,

- beautiful as the moon,
- She is as beautiful as the moon,

as fair as the moon: The expression fair as the moon indicates that the woman is as beautiful as the moon (probably a full moon). Some other ways to translate this comparison are:

glorious as the moon (CEV)

as lovely as the moon

As beautiful as the full moon (NASB)

6:10c

as bright as the sun,

- brilliant like the sun,
- and as radiant as the sun!

as bright as the sun: The phrase bright as the sun is a figure of speech. It compares the woman to the way the sun shines with strong light. It implies that she was beautiful and majestic like the sun.

The comparison does not imply that the woman really shone with a bright light or that she looked like the sun. It implies that she was like the sun that blesses people. The man felt blessed when he was with her.

Some other ways to translate the comparison are:

bringing light/blessing like the sun does

as radiant/dazzling as the sun

bright: The word that the BSB translates as bright is literally “pure” in Hebrew. But when it is used to describe the sun, it refers to a radiant light.

6:10d

as majestic as the stars in procession?

- majestic like the stars that fill the heavens/skies?”
- She is as awesome as the starry hosts!”

In the Hebrew text the phrase in 6:10d is identical to the phrase in 6:4c. The two phrases form an inclusio for 6:4-10. In Hebrew the phrase in both verses is lit-

erally “majestic as hosts with banners.” However, the contexts are different, and many scholars interpret the phrase in a different way here: There are different ways to interpret both the word “terrible” and the phrase “an army with banners:”

as majestic as the stars in procession: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as as majestic as the stars in procession is literally “hosts with banners.” The author also used it in 6:4, but he uses it a different way here. In 6:4 it referred to an army, but here it refers to the sun, moon, and stars. (For information on how it is used in 6:4, see the note on 6:4c.)

In Hebrew the same word is used to refer to many soldiers and to the many stars in the sky. In this context the author has already mentioned the dawn, the sun, and the moon, so it is best to translate “hosts” here as referring to the stars. In the OT when the sun and moon occur with another noun, that noun usually refers to the “stars.”

In many languages it is necessary to use a different word than you used in 6:4. For example:

awe-inspiring as the stars in procession (NET)

majestic as the stars in procession: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as majestic occurs only three times in the Old Testament. Two of those are in the Song, in 6:4 and here in 6:10. In 6:4 it referred to being as awe-inspiring as an army of soldiers, Here it refers to being as awe-inspiring as the stars as they are arranged in the sky.

It is important to use a word that is appropriate to describe stars. So in many languages it is necessary to use a different word here than you used in 6:4. For example:

majestic as the starry heavens (REB)

awesome as all the stars gathered in the sky

she dazzles like the groups/constellations of stars

Be sure to translate this as a compliment to the woman. The man used the word to indicate that the woman was awe-inspiring, and he respected and loved her. In the other OT context, Habakkuk 1:7, the word is used to describe an enemy army. But in this context it should be translated “awesome” (ESV) or “majestic” (NIV).

As the note on 6:10 explained, this verse is a rhetorical question that functions as an exclamation. It expresses praise and awe that the woman was so beautiful. In some languages it is more natural to translate this as an exclamation. For example:

You glow like the dawn!

You are as beautiful as the moon

and bright as the sun—

You are as awesome as the stars in the sky!

General Comment on 6:10

These comparisons of the woman with the beautiful lights in the sky do not imply that she actually looks like those lights. The comparisons imply that the woman made the man feel the same awe as he felt when he looked at the lights in the sky. Another way to translate this meaning is:

When I look at you, I feel awed/amazed like someone looking at the sunrise, or the beautiful moon, or the brilliant sun, or the amazing/splendid arrangement of stars in the sky.

Song of Solomon 6:11

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 6:11–13 She went to the orchard and imagined her beloved as a prince

It is difficult to be certain about who speaks in 6:11–13. There are also several ways to interpret the verses, and English versions vary greatly. The Notes recommends an interpretation that agrees with the author's themes throughout the Song, and in general it follows the BSB text. The Notes for these verses include suggestions for footnotes that translators may include to tell readers the different interpretation options.

6:11

The woman went down to the orchard to see if the trees and vines had new buds and blossoms. Buds and blossoms show that the season of new growth was beginning. This season is called by different names in different areas of the world. It may be called “rainy season” or “spring.” It is the time when plants grow quickly. This growth probably symbolizes that the love between the man and woman was growing.

6:11a

I went down to the walnut grove

- I went down to the walnut orchard/farm
- I walked down to the farm/grove where the nut trees are

I went down to the walnut grove: The woman walked down to the walnut grove. The word down implies that the grove was located on lower ground than the place from which she started walking. Probably a stream or a spring was there to water the garden.

The English phrase went down is one word in Hebrew. In some languages it is not natural to specify that the woman went down. If that is true in your language, it is fine to use a more general word or phrase. For example:

I went to the grove of nut trees

I went out to the farm/place where the nut trees grow

walnut grove: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as walnut grove is literally “garden of nuts.” The author used a Hebrew word for “nut” that occurs only once in the Old Testament. It probably refers specifically to the type of nut called walnut. Here is another way to translate this:

orchard of walnut trees (NET)

If walnuts are not known in your area, you may use a general term. For example:

nut trees

walnut: A walnut is a dry, edible, one-seeded fruit that usually is encased within a woody, hard shell.

6:11b

to see the blossoms of the valley,

- in the valley to look at the blossoms,
- so that I could see what is blooming there.

to see the blossoms of the valley: The clause to see the blossoms of the valley tells the woman's purpose for going down to the nut orchard in 6:11a. The text implies that the valley is the same place as the walnut grove in 6:11a. In some languages it may be confusing to use two different words to refer to the place. Other ways to translate the meaning are:

to see what is blooming there

blossoms: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as blossoms refers to “green shoots” or “new growth.” This is a general term for new plant growth that can refer to different types of blooms. It can refer to the type of buds that appear on vines (6:11c) and also to the blooms on pomegranates (6:11d). Some other ways to translate the term are:

new growth (NIV)

plants beginning to blossom

6:11c

to see if the vines were budding

- to see if the grape vines had budded,
- I wanted to look for buds on the grape vines

to see if the vines were budding: The phrase to see if the vines were budding is similar to 6:11b. It tells more about the woman's purpose for going to the nut grove. She went to see if buds were already on the grape vines. Such buds indicate that the season of new growth has started. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

to look for buds on the vines (NCV)

to see whether the grapevines were budding

Use a natural way in your language to describe this.

6:11d

or the pomegranates were in bloom.

- and if the pomegranate trees/bushes were in bloom.
- and blooms/blossoms on the fruit trees.

or the pomegranates were in bloom: This phrase is parallel to 6:11c. It tells something else that the woman wanted to see in the valley. She wanted to see if the pomegranate trees had started to bloom. Some other ways to translate it are:

and if the pomegranate trees were blossoming

and whether the pomegranate trees had flowers

and the blossoms on the pomegranate trees (GNT)

pomegranates: Here the word pomegranates refers to a type of small tree that produces red fruits. Both the tree and the fruits of the tree can be called “pomegranates.” In 4:3 and 6:7 the author compared the woman’s cheeks to this fruit.

Here the author focused on the time when the trees produce blossoms. Later these blossoms develop into fruits. For more information on pomegranate trees and a picture of pomegranates, see the note on 4:3c.

General Comment on 6:11a–d

In some languages it is more natural to combine some parts of this verse or to use more general expressions. For example:

^{11a-b}I went down to see if blossoms were on the walnut trees, ^{11c}grapevines, ^{11d}and fruit trees. (CEV)

Song of Solomon 6:12

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the

verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 6:11–13 She went to the orchard and imagined her beloved as a prince

It is difficult to be certain about who speaks in 6:11–13. There are also several ways to interpret the verses, and English versions vary greatly. The Notes recommends an interpretation that agrees with the author’s themes throughout the Song, and in general it follows the BSB text. The Notes for these verses include suggestions for footnotes that translators may include to tell readers the different interpretation options.

6:12

The meaning of the Hebrew text of this verse is uncertain. There are no explicit connectors in the Hebrew verse, and scholars have different views about how the meanings of the words and phrases are connected. There are also different ways to interpret the verse as a whole.

Because scholars are not certain about the meaning of the Hebrew text here, it is helpful to include a footnote in your translation, as several English versions do. For example:

The meaning of the Hebrew text of 6:12 is uncertain.

The Notes recommends that translators follow the interpretation of the BSB in this verse. It has good support among scholars and fits the context well.

6:12a

Before I realized it,

- Before I was aware, (RSV)
- Suddenly

Before I realized it: The phrase Before I realized it implies that what the woman described in 6:12b happened suddenly. She did not think about it in advance or plan for it. Other ways to translate this meaning are:

Before I was aware (RSV)

suddenly (CEV)

Before I knew it (NJPS)

6:12b

my desire had set me among the royal chariots of my people.

- my desire had put me in a chariot sitting beside my prince.
- I saw/imagined myself in a chariot next to my loving prince.

In the Song, the author often described dreams, as well as events. In 6:12 also, he probably referred to a dream or to something the woman imagined. The CEV makes this explicit:

But in my imagination (CEV)

I was suddenly riding

on a glorious chariot.

The verse implies that the woman took a walk to the garden. (6:11). Then while she was there, she imagined herself riding in the chariot with her beloved (6:12). This verse is probably an expression of the woman's romantic daydreaming about her beloved. She expressed her emotions through poetic language. This is an example of the "royal" motif. (Some other examples of the royal motif include 1:4; 1:9–14; 3:6–11; 4:4; 6:4; 6:8; 7:5; 8:11–12.)

my desire had set me among the royal chariots of my people: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as my desire had set me is more literally "my soul put me." The phrase probably indicates that the woman imagined the event in 6:12b. It implies that her desire for her beloved caused her to imagine being in a chariot with him.

Some other ways to translate the clause are:

I imagined that I was in a chariot of my people

in my mind/heart I was suddenly riding in a chariot of my people

Use a natural way in your language to describe an event that someone imagines. Many languages have idioms to describe this type of imagined event. For example:

I found myself in the royal chariot with my beloved.

among the royal chariots: A "chariot" was a cart with two-wheels. The cart was partly open and partly enclosed and was pulled by a horse or horses. The driver and passenger stood in it as they rode. Chariots

were used for different purposes in times of peace and also for warfare. Here the chariot that the woman imagined was probably beautiful and decorated. Use an appropriate word or phrase in your language. In Hebrew the plural form of chariot is used, and the NIV also uses that form. However, the author of the Song also used plural forms in other verses where he intended the meaning to be singular. For example, in 1:17 the Hebrew says literally, "beams of our houses," when it refers to a singular house.

of my people: In Hebrew this phrase literally says: "of-my-people noble." There are different ways to interpret the phrase that the BSB translates as of my people.

1. It means "my prince." For example:

in a chariot beside my prince. (NRSV) (ESV, NRSV, RSV)

1. It is used as a proper name, "Aminadib," as in some ancient Hebrew manuscripts and ancient versions. For example:

the chariots of Aminadib (NJB) (NJB, NJPS)

1. Other interpretations include: "among the royal chariots of my people" (BSB, NIV); "in the royal chariot" (NLT); "chariots of my noble people" (GW, NASB); and daughter of my princely people (NET).

Scholars are uncertain about the meaning of the phrase. It is recommended that you follow option (1), which is a fairly literal translation of the Hebrew phrase. You may want to include a footnote to list some of the other possible meanings in options (2) and (3).

Song of Solomon 6:13

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in

the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 6:11–13 She went to the orchard and imagined her beloved as a prince

It is difficult to be certain about who speaks in 6:11–13. There are also several ways to interpret the verses, and English versions vary greatly. The Notes recommends an interpretation that agrees with the author's themes throughout the Song, and in general it follows the BSB text. The Notes for these verses include suggestions for footnotes that translators may include to tell readers the different interpretation options.

6:13–7:13

The verse numberings were added to the Hebrew text by men who copied it hundreds of years after the text itself was first written. In this verse the numbering is different from the numbering in most English versions, including the BSB. The Hebrew text numbers this verse as 7:1, but the BSB numbers it as 6:13. Because of that, each Hebrew verse in chapter 7 is one number higher than the BSB text. The BSB's 6:13–7:13 are 7:1–14 in Hebrew. The Notes continues to use the numbering of the BSB.

6:13a

Come back, come back, O Shulammite!

- Return, return, O Shulammite, (RSV)
- Oh girl/woman from Shulam, please return!

Come back, come back, O Shulammite!: This line is parallel to 6:13b. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Come back occurs twice here and twice in 6:13b for emphasis. There are different ways to interpret the word in this context:

1. It means “return, come back.” For example:

Come back! Come back, young girl from Shulam... (NJB) (BSB, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB, RSV) The NET and the NABRE have “turn” here. For example, the NABRE says, “Turn, turn, O Shulammite.” In this context the word “turn” seems somewhat ambiguous. It may imply that the friends were asking her to turn around and return to them (as in the first interpretation) or that she should turn as a part of the dance they wanted her to do for them.

1. It means “dance.” For example:

Dance, dance, girl of Shulam. (GNT) (GNT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). But interpretation (2) is also acceptable. Although 6:13d refers to a dance, the text does not explicitly say that the woman actually danced. Interpretation (1) implies that the women were asking her to return to them and not to go away.

In some languages, repeating the phrase Come back may not emphasize it, or the repetition may not be natural. If that is true in your language, use a different type of emphasis. For example:

- Use punctuation for emphasis. For example, the NRSV has an exclamation mark:

Return, return, O Shulammite! (NRSV)

- Use a word or phrase that adds emphasis. For example:

Please return, O Shulammite!

Oh return to us, woman from Shulam!

- Use two different words or phrases. For example:

Come back, Shulam woman, return to us!

In some languages it may be more natural to begin the verse with the direct address to the woman. Use a natural way in your language to address her. Some other ways to translate 6:13a are:

Shulam woman, come back!

Please return, lady from Shulam!

Come back, return, Shulam girl!

O: The exclamation O in the BSB indicates that the women spoke directly to the Shulammite. It also adds emphasis to the women's request that she return. Use a natural way in your language to emphasize the request. See the examples in the preceding note.

Shulammite: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Shulammite probably indicates that the woman is from the town of Shulam. Most English versions follow this interpretation, including BSB, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB, RSV, and

GNT. However, the Hebrew word means “perfect one,” or “peaceful one,” and the NET translates, “Turn, turn, O Perfect One!” The CEV has, “Beautiful woman from Shulam.” Some scholars suggest that the Hebrew name Shulammite is the feminine form of the name “Solomon.” Another suggestion is that “Shulammite” refers to Abishag, the beautiful virgin from the village of Shunem who served King David (1 Kings 1:1–4). (Shulammite is not her name.) For example:

Come back! Come back, young girl from Shulam...
(NJB)

It is possible that the word Shulam is derived from the Hebrew root meaning “whole,” “complete” or “perfect.” However, in this context the word has the definite article, so it is more likely that it is a title indicating that she is from Shulam.

6:13b

Come back, come back, that we may gaze upon you.

- come back, come back so that we may gaze on you.
- Turn back and stay with us so that we may continue to look at you.

Come back, come back, that we may gaze upon you:

This line is parallel to 6:13a. It adds the new phrase that we may gaze upon you. The author repeated the friends’ request (Come back, come back) from 6:13a, so that the phrase come back occurs four times. This repetition emphasizes that the Jerusalem women really wanted the woman to return. They wanted to look at her and enjoy her beauty.

In some languages it may not be natural to repeat the phrase come back so many times. Use a natural way in your language to emphasize it. For example:

Please come back! We really want to look at you.

come back, that we may gaze upon you: The reason that the friends want the woman to return is so that they can look at her or “gaze at” her again. Some other ways to translate the reason for the request are:

please return so that we may enjoy/gaze-at your great beauty.

come back to us, so that we may gaze at you.

please return and let us have the pleasure of seeing you

6:13c

Why do you look at the Shulammite,

- Why do you want to gaze on me, a girl from Shulam,
- I am an ordinary woman from Shulam. I do not want you to stare/look at me

6:13d

as on the dance of Mahanaim?

- as though you were looking at a dance for two armies?
- as if I were dancing for two groups of soldiers.

6:13c–d

Why do you look at the Shulammite, as on the dance of Mahanaim?: Here the woman asked a rhetorical question. Scholars are not sure about what the question implies. Some motives that scholars suggest are modesty, insecurity, teasing, flirting, sarcasm, or rebuke. but the meaning is probably similar to the meaning of her statement in 1:6a, “Do not stare at me.” In 1:6 the woman expressed modesty by mentioning her sun-burned appearance. In 2:1 she also modestly compared herself to a common wildflower. She asked the chorus why they wanted to gaze at her. She did not think that she was so beautiful. Maybe she did not want to be the center of attention or a source of entertainment. The other women’s motive and interest in watching her was not like her beloved’s motive—he looked at her because he loved her. In 6:4–9 the man praised her, and in 6:10 the women praised her. In that culture, it often made a moral woman feel uneasy if she received too much praise. Following the woman’s modest statement in 2:1, the man lovingly contradicted her by praising her beauty in 2:2. In a similar manner following her modest statement in 6:13, the man went on to praise her beauty in 7:1–9. So this seems to be another example of the “modesty” motif. Looking back to 1:7 there might be another similarity. She did not want to go through the shepherds’ camp and be taken for an immoral girl. Perhaps here too she wanted to stay out of the limelight. She did not want to be viewed as a camp dancer or an entertainer.

In some languages a rhetorical question with Why may wrongly imply that the woman was angry with the other women. Some other ways to translate the meaning are:

- Use a different type of rhetorical question. For example:

Should you look at this girl from Shulam, as though I were an entertainer?

- Make the meaning more explicit with a statement and a question. For example:

What pleasure will you get from looking at me? I am only an ordinary girl from Shulam.

I'm only a girl from Shulam. Why do you look at me as if I were an entertaining dancer?

- Use a statement. For example:

There is no reason to keep looking at me, since I am just a young girl from Shulam.

You should not gaze at me as though I were a camp dancer. I am only a girl from Shulam.

Use a natural way in your language to communicate the meaning that the woman implied.

as on the dance of Mahanaim?: There is an ellipsis in this part of the verse. The full form is:

as though you are looking upon a dance before two armies

The woman used the phrase to describe the way the other women looked at her. The meaning of the Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as *as on the dance of Mahanaim* is uncertain. Some ways to interpret it are:

1. It means “a dance before two armies.” This implies performing a dance for soldiers. For example:

as upon a dance before two armies (ESV) (ESV, NCV, RSV, NASB)

1. The word “Mahanaim” refers to the name of a place. Although the place name means “two groups,” the whole phrase means “the dance of Mahanaim.” For example:

as on the dance of Mahanaim (NIV) (BSB, GW, NET, NIV, NJPS)

1. It means “two groups of dancers.” It refers to dancing with other people in two groups. (or to two rows of people watching the dance). For example:

as she moves so gracefully between two lines of dancers (NLT) (NJB, NLT, REB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). However, it is not possible to be certain about the correct option, and any of the three options is acceptable. Options (1) and (3) are fairly literal translations based on the Hebrew, “the dance of the two groups.” Option (2) is a transliteration of the Hebrew and indicates that this may be the name of the dance, probably named after a village called Mahanaim. In some languages interpretation (1) may be confusing, and a literal translation of 6:13c-d may imply an immoral action. If that is true in your language, you may follow interpretation (2) or (3) instead.

The dance that the woman referred to was probably beautiful and entertaining. But the woman did not want the other women to look at her as though she were an entertainer.

Song of Solomon 7:1

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 7:1–10 The man praised the woman and she responded

In 7:1–9a the man sang another praise song to the woman, and then she responded in 7:9b–10. Here the man used a different order to describe her beauty. He began with her feet and moved upward to her head as the final focus. In other descriptions (4:1–5, 5:10–16, and 6:4–7) he began with the head and moved downward. Here, he described several parts of her body that he described earlier in the book (neck, eyes, breasts, hair, and head), and he mentioned some other parts for the first time. Notice that 7:3 is identical to 4:5a.

Scholars differ about whether the woman was dancing in this section. In 6:13 the woman said that she did not want spectators to look at her as though she were a dancer. In 7:1-10 the man did not describe her movements, but only her physical features. So, she was probably not dancing in this unit. Some scholars think that she was naked or dressed in transparent clothing, but that idea is not supported in the text.

These verses have many metaphors and similes, and scholars differ about how to interpret some of them. The Notes will discuss each one and give translation suggestions.

7:1a-b

(reordered) My noble lady, your feet are beautiful in sandals!

- (reordered) You are like a queen/princess, and your feet in sandals are gorgeous/lovely.

How beautiful are your sandaled feet, O daughter of the prince: Here the man spoke directly to the woman, using the phrase daughter of the prince like a name for her. In some languages it is more natural to begin the verse with this phrase. For example:

Daughter/Child of noblemen, your feet are very beautiful in sandals.

For more information, see the note on 7:1b.

7:1a

How beautiful are your sandaled feet,

- Your feet are/look beautiful in your sandals,
- Your feet in sandals are so beautiful,

How beautiful are your sandaled feet: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as How beautiful are your sandaled feet is an exclamation. It is similar to the exclamation in 4:10. Here the man told the woman that her feet looked beautiful in the sandals that she wore. Some other ways to translate the exclamation are:

Your feet with sandals are so beautiful

Your sandaled feet are lovely!

Your feet look beautiful in your sandals

sandaled: The word sandaled indicates that the woman was wearing “sandals.” The word “sandals” refers here to leather footwear held on with straps. Sandals leave most of the top of the foot uncovered,

so when the woman wore sandals, the man was able to see much of her foot. The sandals also added to the natural beauty of her feet. In that culture sandals were often decorative, and they were sometimes used in ceremonies.

7:1b

O daughter of the prince!

- O prince’s daughter! (NIV)
- and you are a noblewoman.

O daughter of the prince: The word O is not in the Hebrew text. It is commonly used for direct address in English poetry, and the BSB and some other versions add it. In most languages it is more natural not to add it. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

noble daughter (GW)

you are a princess (CEV)

O queenly maiden (RSV)

The phrase daughter of the prince is used in a figurative way here. It indicates that the woman was a person of noble character, like a queen should be. It does not literally indicate that the woman was the child of a king and queen, princes, or other noble men and women. This is another example of the royalty theme. Here is another way to translate this:

What a magnificent young woman you are! (GNT)

Use a natural way in your language to describe a woman who is greatly respected for her good character.

7:1c-d

The curves of your thighs are like jewels, the

handiwork of a master: Here the man compared the woman’s thighs to jewels that were shaped by a skilled artist. The phrase the handiwork of a master describes the jewels, not the woman’s thighs. Jewels that are shaped by an expert are especially beautiful. The woman’s thighs were also beautifully shaped like such fine jewels. Their curves matched perfectly.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

The curve of your thighs is like the work of an artist (GNT)

Your thighs have beautiful curves. They are like jewels that a master craftsman shaped perfectly.

7:1c

The curves of your thighs are like jewels,

- Your rounded thighs are like jewels, (RSV)
- The rounded shape of your thighs is like ornaments

The curves of your thighs are like jewels: The clause The curves of your thighs are like jewels is a simile. It compares the woman's thighs to jewels. The text does not indicate exactly how the curves of her thighs were like jewels. However, it is likely that curves refers to the roundness of her thighs. Other ways to translate the simile are:

Your rounded thighs are beautiful like smooth/rounded jewels.

The curves of your thighs are like ornaments (GW)

The curves of your thighs: The phrase The curves of your thighs can also be translated "rounded thighs," as in the GNT. The word thighs refers to the upper part of the leg. Here the phrase The curves of your thighs probably refers to the curve of the outer part of the thigh. It does not refer to the whole leg.

Some ways to translate The curves of your thighs are:

rounded thighs (RSV)

Your well-shaped thighs

7:1d

the handiwork of a master.

- that were formed by a great artist.
- devised by a skilled craftsman. (REB)

the handiwork of a master: The phrase the handiwork of a master refers to the work that an expert does. Such an expert has the skill to create beautiful art. In this context the text implies that the curves of the woman's thighs were like beautiful jewels that were shaped by an expert artist. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the work of a skilled craftsman (NLT)

that were shaped by an artist

Song of Solomon 7:2

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 7:1–10 The man praised the woman and she responded

In 7:1–9a the man sang another praise song to the woman, and then she responded in 7:9b–10. Here the man used a different order to describe her beauty. He began with her feet and moved upward to her head as the final focus. In other descriptions (4:1–5, 5:10–16, and 6:4–7) he began with the head and moved downward. Here, he described several parts of her body that he described earlier in the book (neck, eyes, breasts, hair, and head), and he mentioned some other parts for the first time. Notice that 7:3 is identical to 4:5a.

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These verses have many metaphors and similes, and scholars differ about how to interpret some of them. The Notes will discuss each one and give translation suggestions.

7:2a

Your navel is a rounded goblet;

- Your navel is rounded like a drinking cup,
- Your navel is like a well-shaped glass/bowl

7:2b

it never lacks blended wine.

- and it is always filled with spiced wine.
- continually full of blended wine.

7:2a-b

Your navel is a rounded goblet; it never lacks blended wine: Here the man used a metaphor. He compared the woman's navel to a goblet that always has wine in it. It is the goblet that is filled with wine, not the woman's navel. Her navel is like the goblet because it is round and can hold liquid. The wine in the goblet is a symbol of romantic love. This metaphor implies that the woman's love excited the man, as if he were drinking wine.

Some ways to translate the metaphor are:

- Use the metaphor and adapt it for your culture. For example:

your navel is a wine glass filled to overflowing.
(CEV)

- Use a simile. For example:

Your navel is like a round drinking cup always filled with wine. (NCV)

Your navel is like a gourd filled with wine.

- Use a simile and indicate the meaning. For example:

Your navel is perfectly formed like a goblet filled with mixed wine. (NLT)

- Translate the meaning without mentioning the bowl or cup. For example:

Your navel is as exciting as the best wine.

navel: In ancient Israel and all the countries near it, a woman's navel was considered especially beautiful. Except for the GNT, all English versions refer explicitly to the navel. See the footnote. The Hebrew word translated as "navel" in the BSB (and most English versions) is interpreted as a euphemism for the woman's genitals by some commentators including Longman and Pope. (Pope bases his argument on a similarly spelled word in Arabic that means "vulva.") These commentators also argue that the sequence of description from the feet upwards requires this interpretation since the order thigh, navel and belly would be out of logical ascending order. They interpret belly as the region below the navel, and they also assume that the poetic

description would not avoid the genitals. However, according to Fox, the author was not strict about using an ascending order since, for example, the eyes are not lower than the nose (7:4). The order does not require a reader to reinterpret the word "navel." In fact, there is no exegetical reason for reinterpreting it, especially with a sexual connotation that does not fit the Song's modest tone. Mitchell comments: "All the philological evidence supports the meaning 'navel'... Sadly, over the last two centuries commentators have increasingly chosen to ignore the obvious meaning of the Hebrew text...." for more information.

rounded goblet: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as rounded goblet is literally "bowl the-roundness." This type of goblet was often wide and round. Here the man used it to describe the woman's navel. In some cultures it may not be appropriate to compare a woman's navel to a goblet. It also may not be natural to describe the navel as "round."

If that is true in your language, you may use a different comparison. For example:

your navel is like a wine glass

your navel is like a gourd for drinking

it never lacks blended wine: There are two main ways to interpret the Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as it never lacks blended wine:

1. It is a statement that describes the woman's navel. For example:

that never lacks blended wine... (NIV) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB, RSV, GNT)

1. It is a wish or desire. For example:

Let mixed wine not be lacking... (NJPS) (GW, NET, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English versions. The Hebrew verb is grammatically imperfect, but according to BART, it is jussive in meaning. This indicates wish or desire. Some commentators and a few English versions (GW, NET, and NJPS) follow this interpretation.

blended wine: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as blended wine is used only here in the OT. It probably refers to a special wine that is mixed with spices. Some other ways to translate it are:

spiced wine (GNT)

wine

delicious wine

For more information on how to translate wine, see the note on wine in 1:2b.

7:2c–d

Your waist is a mound of wheat encircled by the lilies: The statement in 7:2c–d is a metaphor. It indicates that the woman's waist was beautiful and nourishing like a pile of wheat surrounded by lilies. Wheat was used to make bread, which was an important food in Palestine. Lilies were very beautiful flowers.

Here wheat implies abundant food, and lilies imply beauty. Together these words imply that the woman's love was like food and beauty for the man. Her navel satisfied him like food and made him feel happy. Some other ways to translate the metaphor are:

- Use a simile. For example:

Your stomach is like a pile of wheat surrounded with lilies. (NCV)

- Use a simile and indicate the meaning of the comparison. For example:

Your belly is lovely, like a heap of wheat set about with lilies. (NLT96)

7:2c

Your waist is a mound of wheat

- Your stomach is like a pile of wheat (NCV)
- Your belly is as beautiful as golden grain

Your waist is a mound of wheat: Here the man praised the woman by comparing her waist to a mound of wheat. Scholars are not sure how her waist was like a mound of wheat. They are also uncertain whether the mound of wheat refers to a pile of wheat grains or to wheat sheaves before a farmer removes the grains from them.

The pile of wheat grains probably had curved sides. The author may imply that the woman's waist had similar curves and maybe also a golden color like ripe wheat grains or sheaves.

In some languages it may be necessary to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

Your belly curves like a heap of wheat

Your stomach is lovely like a golden pile of wheat

It is important that readers understand that the man said this statement to praise the woman.

waist: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as waist refers to the part of the abdomen that contains the stomach. It is curved and gently protrudes. Use an appropriate word in your language for this part of the body.

7:2d

encircled by the lilies.

- surrounded by lilies.
- that has beautiful flowers/lilies growing all around it.

encircled by the lilies: The phrase encircled by the lilies gives another detail about the waist in 7:2c. It indicates that the mound of wheat has lilies growing all around it. It does not imply that the woman's waist also has lilies around it. Rather, it indicates that the woman's waist is as beautiful as a mound of wheat surrounded by lilies.

lilies: For more information about lilies, see the note at 2:16b.

Song of Solomon 7:3

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 7:1–10 The man praised the woman and she responded

In 7:1–9a the man sang another praise song to the woman, and then she responded in 7:9b–10. Here the

man used a different order to describe her beauty. He began with her feet and moved upward to her head as the final focus. In other descriptions (4:1–5, 5:10–16, and 6:4–7) he began with the head and moved downward. Here, he described several parts of her body that he described earlier in the book (neck, eyes, breasts, hair, and head), and he mentioned some other parts for the first time. Notice that 7:3 is identical to 4:5a.

Scholars differ about whether the woman was dancing in this section. In 6:13 the woman said that she did not want spectators to look at her as though she were a dancer. In 7:1–10 the man did not describe her movements, but only her physical features. So, she was probably not dancing in this unit. Some scholars think that she was naked or dressed in transparent clothing, but that idea is not supported in the text.

These verses have many metaphors and similes, and scholars differ about how to interpret some of them. The Notes will discuss each one and give translation suggestions.

7:3a

Your breasts are like two fawns,

- Your breasts are like two, young deer.
- Your breasts remind me of fawns.

7:3b

twins of a gazelle.

- They are like twins of a gazelle.
- They are as beautiful and delicate as twin gazelles.

7:3

In 7:3 the author repeated 4:5a exactly. You should translate it in the same way as you translated 4:5a. Refer to the notes on 4:5a for more information. Here in 7:3, the author did not repeat the clause in 4:5c, which says, “grazing among the lilies.” The reason for this difference may be that he already mentioned lilies in 7:2d in a different comparison.

Song of Solomon 7:4

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text

are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 7:1–10 The man praised the woman and she responded

In 7:1–9a the man sang another praise song to the woman, and then she responded in 7:9b–10. Here the man used a different order to describe her beauty. He began with her feet and moved upward to her head as the final focus. In other descriptions (4:1–5, 5:10–16, and 6:4–7) he began with the head and moved downward. Here, he described several parts of her body that he described earlier in the book (neck, eyes, breasts, hair, and head), and he mentioned some other parts for the first time. Notice that 7:3 is identical to 4:5a.

Scholars differ about whether the woman was dancing in this section. In 6:13 the woman said that she did not want spectators to look at her as though she were a dancer. In 7:1–10 the man did not describe her movements, but only her physical features. So, she was probably not dancing in this unit. Some scholars think that she was naked or dressed in transparent clothing, but that idea is not supported in the text.

These verses have many metaphors and similes, and scholars differ about how to interpret some of them. The Notes will discuss each one and give translation suggestions.

7:4a

Your neck is like a tower made of ivory;

- Your neck is like an ivory tower. (RSV)
- Your neck is as beautiful and strong as an ivory tower.

Your neck is like a tower made of ivory: Here the man compared the woman’s neck to a tower, as he also did in 4:4. In 4:4 he compared her neck to the tower of David. Here he compared it to an ivory tower. Ivory is smooth and beautiful, so the comparison indicates that the woman’s neck was beautiful. A tower is straight and strong, and that comparison implies that she had a good character. She was firm and dignified.

Some other ways to translate the comparison are:

Your neck is as beautiful as an ivory tower (NLT)

Your neck is like a tower made of precious/pure ivory

7:4b**your eyes are like the pools of Heshbon**

- Your eyes are pools in Heshbon, (RSV)
- Your eyes are like the sparkling pools in Heshbon, (NLT)

your eyes are like the pools of Heshbon: In this clause the man compared the woman's eyes to pools (of water) of Heshbon. The text does not specify how her eyes were like pools. It may imply that her eyes reflected light like the water in the pools reflected it. The light shines on the water and makes it sparkle, and her eyes also sparkled like that. It is also possible that the comparison emphasizes the depth and mystery of her eyes, just as the pools in Heshbon are deep and mysterious. Here is another way to translate this:

Your eyes are like the sparkling pools in Heshbon.
(NLT)

Heshbon: Heshbon was a city located in the land of Moab. It was east of the Jordan River valley. It may be helpful in your translation to indicate that Heshbon is a city. For more information about Heshbon, see the article by Lawrence T. Geraty in *Anchor Bible Dictionary*, Volume 3, pages 181–82. For example:

in the city of Heshbon (GNT)

7:4c**by the gate of Bath-rabbim;**

- at Bath-rabbim gate.
- and like the beautiful pools beside the gate/entrance called Bathrabbim.

by the gate of Bath-rabbim: The phrase by the gate of Bath-rabbim is part of an extended metaphor that describes the pools in Heshbon in 7:4b. This phrase does not describe the woman's eyes. It tells where the "pools of Heshbon" were located. They were near the city gate called Bath-rabbim.

Some other ways to translate the phrase by the gate of Bath-rabbim are:

by the Bath-rabbim gate

near the city gate that people call Bath-rabbim
Gate

7:4d**your nose is like the tower of Lebanon,**

- Your nose reminds me of the tower in Lebanon
- Your nose is as lovely as the tower of Lebanon (GNT)

7:4e**facing toward Damascus.**

- that faces toward Damascus.
- from which a person can see the city of Damascus.

7:4d-e

your nose is like the tower of Lebanon, facing toward Damascus: The clause your nose is like the tower of Lebanon, facing toward Damascus is a simile. It compares the woman's nose to a tower in a particular place. Scholars have different views about what the word tower refers to here:

1. It refers to a particular tower at or near Damascus. For example:

Your nose is like the tower of Lebanon looking toward Damascus. (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NAB, NASB, NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT, GNT)

1. It refers to any tower in Lebanon that overlooks Damascus. For example:

Your nose is like a Lebanese tower facing Damascus. (GW) (RSV, ESV, GW)

1. It refers to a mountain near Damascus. For example:

Your nose is like the mountain of Lebanon that looks down on Damascus. (NCV) (CEV, NCV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with most English versions. Notice that the author also used a tower to describe the woman's neck in 7:4a. There he referred to any tower made of ivory, but here in 7:4d he probably referred to a specific tower.

your nose is like the tower of Lebanon: Here the author compares the woman's nose to a particular tower in the region of Lebanon. If a person stood on the tower, he could see the city of Damascus.

The author did not tell how the woman's nose is like that tower. However, the tower was probably elegant, beautiful, and majestic. In some languages it may be necessary to make the comparison more explicit. For example:

Your nose is as fine as the tower of Lebanon overlooking Damascus. (NLT)

Your nose is as lovely as the tower of Lebanon
that stands guard at Damascus.

tower of Lebanon: The phrase tower of Lebanon refers to a tower in the region of Lebanon. The word tower was used in 4:4. For more information on how to translate this word, see the note there.

Lebanon: Lebanon is mentioned in 3:9; 4:8, 11, 15; and 5:15. You should spell it in the same way in each of these places. For more information about Lebanon, see the note on “from Lebanon” in 4:8a–b.

facing toward Damascus: The phrase facing toward Damascus describes the tower of Lebanon, not the woman’s nose. This phrase indicates that the tower of Lebanon was near the city of Damascus so that people could look down from the tower and see the city. It may imply that the tower helped citizens to guard Damascus. When they climbed the tower, they could see whether an enemy was coming. Other ways to translate the phrase are:

from which guards/protectors can look down on
the city of Damascus

that stands guard at Damascus (GNT)

where a soldier/person can see if enemies are
coming and warn the people of Damascus

Song of Solomon 7:5

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 7:1–10 The man praised the woman and she responded

In 7:1–9a the man sang another praise song to the woman, and then she responded in 7:9b–10. Here the man used a different order to describe her beauty. He began with her feet and moved upward to her head as the final focus. In other descriptions (4:1–5, 5:10–16, and 6:4–7) he began with the head and moved downward. Here, he described several parts of her body that he described earlier in the book (neck, eyes, breasts, hair, and head), and he mentioned some other parts for the first time. Notice that 7:3 is identical to 4:5a.

Scholars differ about whether the woman was dancing in this section. In 6:13 the woman said that she did not want spectators to look at her as though she were a dancer. In 7:1–10 the man did not describe her movements, but only her physical features. So, she was probably not dancing in this unit. Some scholars think that she was naked or dressed in transparent clothing, but that idea is not supported in the text.

These verses have many metaphors and similes, and scholars differ about how to interpret some of them. The Notes will discuss each one and give translation suggestions.

7:5a

Your head crowns you like Mount Carmel,

- Your head is as majestic as Mount Carmel (NLT)
- Your head is like a crown for your body, as Mount Carmel is like a crown for the land,
- Your head completes your beauty, just as Carmel Mountain beautifies all the land around it.

Your head crowns you like Mount Carmel: The phrase Your head crowns you like Mount Carmel is more literally “your head upon you is like Carmel.” Mount Carmel refers to a majestic, tall mountain called Mount Carmel. The phrase implies that the woman’s head gave her majesty and beauty, as Mount Carmel adds majesty and beauty to the land of Israel.

Some ways to translate this simile are:

Your head is as majestic as Mount Carmel (NLT)

Your head shows your dignity/glory that is like Carmel mountain.

Mount Carmel: Mount Carmel is a mountain that is surrounded by flat land, so it is especially prominent and majestic. It is about 550 meters (1800 feet) high, and overlooks the Mediterranean Sea.

7:5b**the hair of your head like purple threads;**

- and your wavy/flowing hair is like a queen's purple tapestry.
- and the sheen of your hair radiates royalty. (NLT)

the hair of your head like purple threads: The clause the hair of your head like purple threads compares the woman's long wavy hair to the color purple. Purple dye was expensive, and people considered purple to be a royal color. In this verse the color purple probably suggests that the woman was as majestic as a queen. It may imply that her hair was a shiny black color as the sun shone on it. It is unlikely that she dyed her hair purple.

Some ways to translate the clause are:

and your hair is like purple cloth (NCV)

Your hair is like royal tapestry (NIV)

the sheen of your hair radiates royalty (NLT)

your locks are shiny black

7:5c**the king is captured in your tresses.**

- Its beauty captures/captivates a king.
- Your beautiful hair fascinates even a king.

the king is captured in your tresses: This clause is a figure of speech. It indicates that when a man, even a king, looks at the woman's hair (tresses), he is like a captive. He cannot stop looking at it because it is so beautiful. The man implies that he himself is like such a king. Some other ways to translate the clause are:

its beauty could hold a king captive. (GNT)

you have captured your king with its loveliness

your hair is so lovely that the king cannot escape its charms.

Song of Solomon 7:6**Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime**

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is

important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 7:1–10 The man praised the woman and she responded

In 7:1–9a the man sang another praise song to the woman, and then she responded in 7:9b–10. Here the man used a different order to describe her beauty. He began with her feet and moved upward to her head as the final focus. In other descriptions (4:1–5, 5:10–16, and 6:4–7) he began with the head and moved downward. Here, he described several parts of her body that he described earlier in the book (neck, eyes, breasts, hair, and head), and he mentioned some other parts for the first time. Notice that 7:3 is identical to 4:5a.

Scholars differ about whether the woman was dancing in this section. In 6:13 the woman said that she did not want spectators to look at her as though she were a dancer. In 7:1–10 the man did not describe her movements, but only her physical features. So, she was probably not dancing in this unit. Some scholars think that she was naked or dressed in transparent clothing, but that idea is not supported in the text.

These verses have many metaphors and similes, and scholars differ about how to interpret some of them. The Notes will discuss each one and give translation suggestions.

7:6

This verse is a summary of the description of the woman in 7:1–5. It emphasizes her great beauty.

7:6a**How fair and pleasant you are,**

- How beautiful you are and how pleasing, (NIV)
- You are so lovely and delightful.

How fair and pleasant you are: The clause How fair and pleasant you are is part of an exclamation. The man used it to tell the woman that she was beautiful and delightful. Use a natural way in your language to

give such a compliment to a woman. Some other ways to translate it in English are:

Oh, you are beautiful and delightful!

You are beautiful, so very desirable! (CEV)

You are beautiful beyond description! You are the one in whom my heart delights.

fair...pleasant: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as fair and pleasant have similar meanings. The word fair occurs often in the Song, for example, in 1:8; 4:1, 7, and 10; and in 6:4. It is good to translate the word in the same way or a similar way as you translated it in those verses.

The word pleasant refers to the woman only in this verse. It indicates that she is “pleasant, delightful, and lovely.” פְּעֻמָּה vb. “be pleasant, delightful, lovely.” BDB, page 653.

Some other ways to translate fair and pleasant here are:

beautiful and pleasant (ESV)

lovely and wonderful

In some languages it may be more natural to express the similar ideas with one emphatic phrase. For example:

You are incredibly beautiful...

You are so delightful

7:6b

O love, with your delights!

- beloved, with all your delights!
- You are completely charming, my love!

O love, with your delights: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as O love, with your delights:

1. The man addressed the woman as his beloved and then described her. For example:

my love, with your elegance. (GW) (BSB, GW, ESV, NAB, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NLT, REB, RSV)

1. The man spoke about love as a feeling or action. For example:

how complete the delights of your love (GNT)
(NET, NJPS, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions. The Song usually does not speak about love by itself as a quality. However, 2:7, 3:5 and 8:4 are possible exceptions. Here the man probably referred to the woman herself, as he spoke directly to her.

with your delights: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as delights means “delightful, charming.” It describes the woman herself, not the abstract quality of “love.” It implies that she gave the man great pleasure and delight.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

- Translate it as a statement. For example:

you are full of delights (NCV)

you delight me in so many ways

- Translate it as a direct address. For example:

my delight (NAB)

O wonderful Love/Beloved

- Translate it as an exclamation. For example:

how complete the delights of your love! (GNT)

what rapture/happiness you give me with your love!

Use a natural way in your language for a man to tell a woman how much her love pleases and delights him.

Song of Solomon 7:7

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 7:1–10 The man praised the woman and she responded

In 7:1–9a the man sang another praise song to the woman, and then she responded in 7:9b–10. Here the man used a different order to describe her beauty. He began with her feet and moved upward to her head as the final focus. In other descriptions (4:1–5, 5:10–16, and 6:4–7) he began with the head and moved downward. Here, he described several parts of her body that he described earlier in the book (neck, eyes, breasts, hair, and head), and he mentioned some other parts for the first time. Notice that 7:3 is identical to 4:5a.

Scholars differ about whether the woman was dancing in this section. In 6:13 the woman said that she did not want spectators to look at her as though she were a dancer. In 7:1–10 the man did not describe her movements, but only her physical features. So, she was probably not dancing in this unit. Some scholars think that she was naked or dressed in transparent clothing, but that idea is not supported in the text.

These verses have many metaphors and similes, and scholars differ about how to interpret some of them. The Notes will discuss each one and give translation suggestions.

7:7–9a

In these verses the man describes the woman with metaphors of a palm tree and various fruits. (In 5:15c–d she compared the man to a cedar tree.)

7:7a

Your stature is like a palm tree;

- Your stature/figure is like that of the date palm,
- You are tall and slender like a palm tree. (CEV)

Your stature is like a palm tree: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as Your stature is like a palm tree is literally “This your stature is-like a date-palm tree.” A date palm tree is taller and more slender than many other trees. The man implied that the woman was tall and slender, like a date palm tree.

Some other ways to translate the comparison are:

You are tall and slender like a palm tree (CEV)

Your figure/stature is like a palm tree

You are tall like a palm tree (NCV)

palm tree: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as palm tree refers specifically to the date palm tree. It is a type of tropical tree that produces sweet fruit called “dates.” In some languages the date palm tree is not known. If that is true in your language, some other ways to translate it are:

- Use a more general word that refers to a tree like the palm tree, as in the BSB.
- Refer more generally to a tree that is tall and slender and produces fruit. For example:

tall slender fruit tree

7:7b

your breasts are clusters of fruit.

- and your breasts are like its clusters of dates.
- and your breasts are as sweet/delicious as its fruits.

your breasts are clusters of fruit: The phrase your breasts are clusters of fruit compares the woman’s breasts to the bunches of fruit called “dates” on the date palm tree. These clusters of dates probably reminded the man of the full shape of the woman’s breasts on her tall slender body. Her breasts did not literally look like date clusters.

In some languages people are not familiar with the date palm tree and its clusters of dates. Some other ways to translate this comparison are:

- Use a more general term for clusters of fruit. For example:

your breasts are like bunches of fruit

- Substitute a different fruit that is known to people in your area and is appropriate for the comparison. For example:

your breasts are like clusters of grapes. (NET)

- Indicate how the woman’s breasts were like clusters of dates or other fruit. For example:

your breasts are as lovely as clusters of dates.

your breasts are well-shaped like beautiful fruit

Song of Solomon 7:8

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 7:1–10 The man praised the woman and she responded

In 7:1–9a the man sang another praise song to the woman, and then she responded in 7:9b–10. Here the man used a different order to describe her beauty. He began with her feet and moved upward to her head as the final focus. In other descriptions (4:1–5, 5:10–16, and 6:4–7) he began with the head and moved downward. Here, he described several parts of her body that he described earlier in the book (neck, eyes, breasts, hair, and head), and he mentioned some other parts for the first time. Notice that 7:3 is identical to 4:5a.

Scholars differ about whether the woman was dancing in this section. In 6:13 the woman said that she did not want spectators to look at her as though she were a dancer. In 7:1–10 the man did not describe her movements, but only her physical features. So, she was probably not dancing in this unit. Some scholars think that she was naked or dressed in transparent clothing, but that idea is not supported in the text.

These verses have many metaphors and similes, and scholars differ about how to interpret some of them. The Notes will discuss each one and give translation suggestions.

7:8–9a

These verses include several metaphors. In 7:8a–b the man continued to use the metaphor of the palm tree, which he began to use in 7:7. In 7:8c he used grapes

as a metaphor, in 7:8d he used apples, and in 7:9a he used wine.

7:8a

I said, “I will climb the palm tree;

- I said, “I will climb that palm tree
- I have decided that I shall climb this palm tree,

I said, “I will climb the palm tree: The clause I will climb the palm tree is a metaphor. The phrase I said tells the man’s intention. It indicates that he was determined to become more intimate with the woman. He wanted to embrace her. He did not literally mean that he was going to climb her as he would climb a tree. It implies that the top of a tall palm tree is difficult to reach, and it was also difficult to persuade the woman to be intimate with him. However, the man decided that he must try hard (climb) to persuade her.

Some other ways to translate the man’s intention and the metaphor of the palm tree are:

I have decided, ‘I shall climb the palm tree... (NJB)

I want to climb the palm tree... (NET)

I will surely come to you, even if it is as difficult as climbing the palm tree...

The difficulty of climbing the palm tree is another way to imply that the woman is sometimes hard to reach. The author used this theme in other verses, for example, in 2:14; 4:8; 6:4, and 6:10.

I said: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as I said indicates that the man was determined to accomplish his goal to come near his beloved woman. (The tree symbolizes the woman.) Translate this intention in a natural way in your language. See the examples in the preceding note.

7:8b

I will take hold of its fruit.”

- and grasp those clusters of fruit/dates.”
- and hold/enjoy its fruit.

I will take hold of its fruit: This clause implies that the man will touch and caress the woman’s breasts. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as fruit occurs only here in the Old Testament. Scholars interpret it in different ways:

1. It refers to clusters of dates (or stalks of fruit), which represent the woman’s breasts. For example:

I will take hold of its fruit. (NIV) (BSB, NIV, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NJB, NLT, GNT)

1. It refers to the arching branches of the palm tree, which represent the woman's limbs/arms. For example:

and cling to its branches. (CEV) (CEV, NJPS, RSV)

1. It refers to "fronds" (the leaf-like part of the palm), which may represent the woman's hair. For example:

Let me climb up into the palm to grasp its fronds. (REB) (REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with more English versions. In this description of the palm tree, the fruit stalks, and clusters refer to the same part of the tree as the phrase its clusters in 7:7b. Option (2) does not seem to fit the structure of the palm tree. Usually, palm trees do not have real branches. The trunk of the tree rises high without branches, and fruit, and palm leaves (fronds) are at its top.

7:8c

May your breasts be like clusters of the vine,

- I long for your breasts—they are like bunches of grapes
- How I want to taste your breasts, which are like sweet grape/fruit clusters!

May your breasts be like clusters of the vine: The Hebrew verb form that the BSB translates as May... be expresses the man's wish or desire. His beloved's breasts seem wonderful to him. He indicates that he wants to enjoy her breasts as he would enjoy grape clusters. Use a natural way in your language to express a strong desire like this.

Some ways to translate this desire are:

Oh let your breasts be like clusters of the vine for me!

I desire/long for the sweetness of your breasts as if they were grape clusters!

Your breasts are like clusters of grapes, and I really want to enjoy them.

your breasts...like clusters of the vine: Here the man compared the woman's breasts to clusters of grapes (instead of to clusters of dates). The phrase clusters of the vine, refers to bunches of grapes. As in 7:7b, the man compared the woman's breasts to the sweetness of the fruit, not to its shape. He referred to the way her beautiful breasts made him feel. Her breasts symbolize the sweetness and joy of love. The phrase may also imply that her love intoxicates like wine, since grapes are used to make wine (as referred to in 7:9a).

Some other ways to translate this simile are:

May your breasts be like sweet grape clusters.

Oh how I want your breasts to be like bunches of grapes for me!

clusters of the vine: Here the phrase clusters of the vine refers to bunches of grapes. The vine refers to a grapevine.

7:8d

the fragrance of your breath like apples,

- and the scent of your breath is like apples.
- I want to smell your breath. It has the sweet smell/fragrance of apples.

the fragrance of your breath like apples: Here the man compared the sweet scent of the woman's breath to the sweet smell of apples. The same verb ("may be like") that was used in 7:8c is also implied here. In some languages it is necessary to supply the same verb or a similar verb here in 7:8d. For example:

May your breath smell as sweet as apples

and your breath is like the scent of apples

Some languages have special idioms to describe the way a person's breath smells. Use a natural phrase in your language. Some other ways to translate the meaning are:

I want to smell your breath, which is as fragrant/sweet as apples

your breath is like the sweetness of apples; I want to enjoy/smell it

the smell of your breath like apples (NCV)

the fragrance of your breath: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as breath literally means “nose.” Some commentaries (including the UBS Handbook) understand the mention of “nose” here to be a possible euphemism for the woman’s nipples. But no versions follow this interpretation, and it is not recommended. In this context it probably refers to what the nose does—it breathes. This is why almost all English versions translate the word as your breath here. Other ways to translate the fragrance of your breath are:

your sweet breath

the smell when you breathe

apples: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as apples refers to a type of fruit from the “pome” family, which is still called by the same name in Israel today. In English this fruit is called “apples,” though some scholars (and the NET version) interpret it as referring to apricots. In spite of the NET footnote stating that most modern botanists and lexicographers now identify this word as “apricot” rather than the traditional “apple,” even the new versions CEB (2011), (NAB (2011) and NIV (2011) continue to translate this word as “apple.” The lexicon, HALOT, continues to identify the fruit as “apple.” It seems best to follow the vast majority of versions by translating this as “apple.” If people are not familiar with apples in your area, some other ways to translate it are:

- Use a more general term. For example:

as the sweetest smelling fruit

- Use the name of a sweet-smelling fruit in your area that people like to eat. It is also fine to include a footnote to describe the biblical fruit.

Song of Solomon 7:9

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text

are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 7:1–10 The man praised the woman and she responded

In 7:1–9a the man sang another praise song to the woman, and then she responded in 7:9b–10. Here the man used a different order to describe her beauty. He began with her feet and moved upward to her head as the final focus. In other descriptions (4:1–5, 5:10–16, and 6:4–7) he began with the head and moved downward. Here, he described several parts of her body that he described earlier in the book (neck, eyes, breasts, hair, and head), and he mentioned some other parts for the first time. Notice that 7:3 is identical to 4:5a.

Scholars differ about whether the woman was dancing in this section. In 6:13 the woman said that she did not want spectators to look at her as though she were a dancer. In 7:1–10 the man did not describe her movements, but only her physical features. So, she was probably not dancing in this unit. Some scholars think that she was naked or dressed in transparent clothing, but that idea is not supported in the text.

These verses have many metaphors and similes, and scholars differ about how to interpret some of them. The Notes will discuss each one and give translation suggestions.

7:9a

and your mouth like the finest wine.

- Your mouth also is like the best wine.
- I want to enjoy your kisses. They are as exciting/sweet as the finest wine.

and your mouth like the finest wine: This clause implies the same verb that was used in 7:8c:

and your kisses are like the best wine.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as mouth literally means “palate” or “mouth.” The man said this to imply that when he kissed the woman, her kisses were as exciting or sweet as wine.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

- Use a simile that refers to the woman’s mouth. For example:

and your mouth like the best wine. (NIV)

- Use a simile that refers to the woman's kisses. For example:

May your kisses be as exciting as the best wine... (NLT)

- Use a simile that refers to both the woman's mouth and her kisses. For example:

The kisses of your mouth are like fine wine.

The meaning here is similar to what the woman said to the man in 1:2b:

O that you would kiss me with the kisses of your mouth! For your love is better than wine. (RSV)

7:9b–c

There are several interpretation issues in 7:9b–c:

1. It is uncertain who speaks.
2. The Hebrew phrase “for my lover” is left out or changed in some versions.
3. The words “lips and teeth” are translated by some versions as “lips of sleepers.”

The Notes will help you choose an interpretation to follow on these issues.

7:9b

May it flow smoothly to my beloved,

- It flows smoothly to you, my love.
- I want our kisses to be like wine for you, my love,

May it flow smoothly to my beloved: The phrase that the BSB translates as to my beloved is literally “for my lover” in Hebrew, and its form indicates that the lover is male. Scholars have different views about who spoke this phrase.

1. The woman spoke to the man, and she indicated that he is her beloved. For example:

She: It goes down smoothly for my beloved... (ESV) (BSB, GW, ESV, NAB, NCV, NIV, NJB, GNT, NLT)

1. The man spoke. For example:

The Lover to His Beloved:...flowing smoothly for my beloved... (NET) (NASB, NET, NJPS)

1. The phrase “for my beloved” is omitted. (CEV, NLT96, REB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with about half of the English versions. The form of the word beloved is masculine, which indicates that the woman spoke to the man. It does not seem proper to change the Hebrew form to feminine, as in option (2), or to omit the word, as in option (3).

flow smoothly to my beloved: The phrase flow smoothly to my beloved describes the taste and feeling of the woman's kisses. Her kisses are as delightful to the man as delicious flowing wine. Use an appropriate phrase in your language to describe wonderful kisses. The phrase you use should also fit with the meaning of 7:9c. For examples of how to translate 7:9a–c, see the General Comment on 7:9 at the end of the note on 7:9c.

7:9c

gliding gently over lips and teeth.

- It moves gently over your lips and teeth.
- that spreads over your lips and teeth.

gliding gently over lips and teeth: Scholars differ about how to interpret the Hebrew phrase in 7:9c. The two major interpretations are:

1. The phrase refers to lips and teeth. For example:

flowing gently over lips and teeth. (NIV) (BSB, ESV, NAB, NCV, NIV, NLT, REB, RSV, GNT)

1. The phrase refers to the lips of sleepers. (GW, NASB, NET, NJB, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with the majority of English versions. It is also supported by important ancient manuscripts. However, since the Hebrew text follows option (2), it may be helpful to include a footnote in your translation. This footnote should include the ancient manuscripts that follow option (1). It should also include the literal Hebrew meaning. For example:

Here the translation follows the Septuagint, Aquila, Vulgate, and Syriac versions. The Hebrew text has literally “lips of sleepers.”

gliding: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as gliding is parallel with the phrase “goes down smoothly” in 7:9b, and it has a similar meaning. It compares the woman's kisses to how wine makes him feel as he drinks it. Use a natural way in your language

to compare these experiences. See the following General Comment on 7:9 for translation examples.

General Comment on 7:9

In 7:9a the man continued to tell the woman how much he desired her, and in 7:9b–c he responded. Some other ways to translate this verse are:

Man: Your kisses are like the finest wine. Woman:
Let them flow like wine and pass over your lips
and teeth.

Man: Let your kisses be like the best wine.
Woman: They will come smoothly and glide gently
over your lips and teeth.

Song of Solomon 7:10

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 7:1–10 The man praised the woman and she responded

In 7:1–9a the man sang another praise song to the woman, and then she responded in 7:9b–10. Here the man used a different order to describe her beauty. He began with her feet and moved upward to her head as the final focus. In other descriptions (4:1–5, 5:10–16, and 6:4–7) he began with the head and moved downward. Here, he described several parts of her body that he described earlier in the book (neck, eyes, breasts, hair, and head), and he mentioned some other parts for the first time. Notice that 7:3 is identical to 4:5a.

Scholars differ about whether the woman was dancing in this section. In 6:13 the woman said that she did not want spectators to look at her as though she

were a dancer. In 7:1–10 the man did not describe her movements, but only her physical features. So, she was probably not dancing in this unit. Some scholars think that she was naked or dressed in transparent clothing, but that idea is not supported in the text.

These verses have many metaphors and similes, and scholars differ about how to interpret some of them. The Notes will discuss each one and give translation suggestions.

7:10

I belong to my beloved, and his desire is for me.

- I belong to my lover, and he desires me. (GNT)
- I am my beloved's; he longs/thirsts only for me.

I belong to my beloved, and his desire is for me:

The sentence I belong to my beloved, and his desire is for me is a variation of the similar statements in 2:16a and 6:3a–b. All of these statements express the mutual romantic love that the man and woman have for each other, but the statement here in 7:10 focuses on the man's desire for the woman.

In the phrase I belong to my beloved, the woman did not imply that the man owns her as he owned property. It implies that she committed herself to him to love him. The phrase his desire is for me implies that he desired her romantic love because he also loved her in that committed way.

Some other ways to translate this verse are:

I belong to my lover, and he desires me. (GNT)

I am my beloved's, his longing is all for me. (REB)

I belong to my lover, and he desires only me. (NCV)

In some languages it may be more natural for the woman to say this directly to the man. For example:

My darling, I am yours, (CEV)

and you desire me.

his desire is for me: In the Hebrew text, this clause is more literally, “for me is his desire.” It emphasizes that his beloved is the only woman for whom the man feels romantic love. He does not desire any other woman in that way. Some other ways to translate this emphasis are:

I am the one whom he desires.

I am the only woman that he wants/loves.

desire: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as desire occurs only three times in the OT. The other times are in Genesis 3:16 and 4:7. In Genesis 4:7 the LORD said that sin desired to dominate Cain. In Genesis 3:16 the LORD told the woman that her desire would be for her husband. She would strongly desire him.

Here in the Song the woman said that the man's desire was for her. The Hebrew word indicates a strong, urgent longing. She was the one on whom he set his romantic love and desires.

Use a natural way in your language to express this type of romantic love and longing. In some languages there is an idiom or figure of speech to translate this meaning.

Song of Solomon 7:11

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 7:11–13 The woman invited the man to go with her to the fields and vineyards

In these verses the woman responded to the man's praise (in 7:1–9a) by inviting him to go out into the fields and vineyards with her to enjoy the springtime. As trees and flowers were blooming, their love for each other was also growing. Here she invited him to go there, as he also invited her in 2:10–13. It is also interesting to notice that 8:2a–b is similar to 3:4e–f.

In 7:11–13, all the events are probably not arranged in the order that they happened (as is common in poetry). It is also possible that these verses describe the woman's desires and feelings or a dream that she had before her wedding (3:6–5:1). Old Testament scholar,

David Dorsey, takes a non-chronological approach to the Song. In his book, *The Literary Structure of the Old Testament* (1999) he proposes a thorough-going symmetrical chiasmic structure for the book. (Also see his article, "Literary Structuring in the Song of Songs" in *Journal for the Study of the Old Testament* 46 (1990) 81–96.) The structure he proposes is a-b-c-d-c'-b'-a' where the central unit "d" describes the wedding day, the climactic portion of the Song. Some scholars differ on the details of his proposed chiasmic structure while agreeing in principle with the chiasmic approach, while other scholars question whether such a book-level chiasmic structure is actually present. But in spite of the disagreements, viewing the book chiasmically or cyclically does help to resolve some problems that chronological/narrative approaches tend to overlook. When we look at some of the material in the second half of the Song, much of it appears to be from a pre-wedding perspective (a wedding seems to be described in 3:6–5:1). A symmetrical chiasmic or cyclical approach may provide us with a better vantage point for addressing such challenging issues. In the case of this unit, the similarities with 2:10–13 seems fairly clear. So it seems possible, if not likely, that this unit could also be viewed as part of a courtship poem, rather than an event that happened in her life. The exact meaning of 7:11–13 is difficult to determine, but the verses do seem to look forward to the future.

7:11a

Come, my beloved, let us go to the countryside;

- Come with me, my love. We will go out to the fields together,
- My beloved, come with me into the countryside.

Come, my beloved, let us go to the countryside:

Here the woman invited the man to go out of the city with her to enjoy the countryside together. He was already with her as she spoke to him, so she was not calling him to come. She wanted him to go with her to the fields.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

Come with me, my love, and let's go out to the fields

My darling, let's go to the fields together

In some languages it is more natural to put the phrase my beloved in a different place in the sentence, as in the second example above. Use a natural way in your language to give an invitation like this.

my beloved: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as my beloved is the most common way that the woman used to address the man. It first occurred in 1:13. It is good to translate this word in the same way in all the verses where she used it to address him.

to the countryside: Here the woman invited/urged her beloved to go with her into the countryside. She wanted to go there to the fields to see the springtime blossoms and to be alone with the man. Other ways to translate this are:

let us go out into the fields... (REB)

let us go to the countryside... (NET)

7:11b

let us spend the night among the wildflowers.

- let us spend the night in the villages. (NIV)
- We will sleep in one of the villages tonight,

let us spend the night among the wildflowers: The word that the BSB translates as spend the night does not imply that the man and woman wanted to stay longer than one night. Other ways to translate this meaning are:

let us lodge in the villages. (RSV)

and stay overnight in one of the villages.

among the wildflowers: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as wildflowers can also mean “henna bushes,” as in 2:14. Scholars differ about what it means here:

1. It means “villages.” For example:

let us spend the night in the villages. (NIV) (CEV, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, RSV, GNT)

1. It means “henna bushes.” For example:

to lie among the henna bushes (REB) (BSB, GW, NJPS, REB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), with the majority of English versions. Some scholars think that the meaning “villages” is unlikely, because the man and woman wanted to be alone. However, the villages were not as crowded as the city. The villages were closer to the vineyards and pomegranate trees, so that

the man and woman could look at them in the early morning (see the following note in 7:12a).

Song of Solomon 7:12

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 7:11–13 The woman invited the man to go with her to the fields and vineyards

In these verses the woman responded to the man’s praise (in 7:1–9a) by inviting him to go out into the fields and vineyards with her to enjoy the springtime. As trees and flowers were blooming, their love for each other was also growing. Here she invited him to go there, as he also invited her in 2:10–13. It is also interesting to notice that 8:2a–b is similar to 3:4e–f.

In 7:11–13, all the events are probably not arranged in the order that they happened (as is common in poetry). It is also possible that these verses describe the woman’s desires and feelings or a dream that she had before her wedding (3:6–5:1). Old Testament scholar, David Dorsey, takes a non-chronological approach to the Song. In his book, *The Literary Structure of the Old Testament* (1999) he proposes a thorough-going symmetrical chiastic structure for the book. (Also see his article, “Literary Structuring in the Song of Songs” in *Journal for the Study of the Old Testament* 46 (1990) 81–96.) The structure he proposes is a-b-c-d-c’-b’-a’ where the central unit “d” describes the wedding day, the climactic portion of the Song. Some scholars differ on the details of his proposed chiastic structure while agreeing in principle with the chiastic approach, while other scholars question whether such a book-level chiastic structure is actually present. But in spite of the disagreements, viewing the book chiastically or cyclically does help to resolve some problems that

chronological/narrative approaches tend to overlook. When we look at some of the material in the second half of the Song, much of it appears to be from a pre-wedding perspective (a wedding seems to be described in 3:6–5:1). A symmetrical chiastic or cyclical approach may provide us with a better vantage point for addressing such challenging issues. In the case of this unit, the similarities with 2:10–13 seems fairly clear. So it seems possible, if not likely, that this unit could also be viewed as part of a courtship poem, rather than an event that happened in her life. The exact meaning of 7:11–13 is difficult to determine, but the verses do seem to look forward to the future.

7:12

Grape buds and blossoms show that spring (the season of new growth) has come. This new growth symbolizes the new love that was “growing” between the man and woman. This theme is also found in 2:10–13.

7:12a

Let us go early to the vineyards

- Let us get up early and go out to the vineyards, (NLT)
- and early in the morning we will go out to the grape farm/field.

Let us go early to the vineyards: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as Let us go early to the vineyards is literally “let us rise early to the vineyards.” It indicates that the woman wanted the man to go with her to the vineyards early in the morning.

Some other ways to translate the clause are:

We will get up early and look at the vines (GNT)

Let’s go to the vineyards early. (GW)

Then early in the morning we can visit the grape farms.

early: The word early here refers to early in the morning, just after daybreak. Use an appropriate word in your language to refer to this time of day.

to the vineyards: A “vineyard” is a farm where people plant and cultivate grapes. They often use the grapes to make wine. The vineyard was a quiet place. There the man and woman could be alone together and enjoy a beautiful spring morning.

Some ways to translate 7:12a are:

in the early morning we will go to the vineyards... (NJB)

Let us get up early and go to the vineyards... (NLT)

7:12b

to see if the vine has budded,

- to see if the vines have budded, (NIV)
- We will look for new growth/buds

7:12c

if the blossom has opened,

- to see if their blossoms have opened, (NET)
- and blossoms/blooms on the vines.

7:12b–c

In 7:12b–c the woman listed two things for her and the man to enjoy looking for when they are in the countryside together. They will look at the grapevines to see the buds and blossoms on them. The buds and blossoms are beautiful. They develop into grapes that are sweet to eat and are also used to make wine.

to see if the vine has budded, if the blossom has opened: This clause is similar to 6:11c (“to see if the vines were budding”). It gives a purpose for going to the vineyards. The woman suggested that she and the man should go to where the grapevines were planted to see whether the vines had buds and whether some of the buds had blossoms. Another way to translate this purpose is:

We will see whether the vines have new growth/buds

the vine has budded: The word vine refers specifically to a grape vine. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as has budded can refer generally to new signs of growth. The words budded and “blossom” (7:12c) refer to two stages that grapevines go through before they produce grapes. They produce small buds, and then the buds develop and open into blossoms. The woman wanted to see if the grapevines had new buds. Describe this in a natural way in your language.

Some translation options for 7:12c are:

to see if their blossoms have opened.... (NET)

to see whether the grapevines have blossomed yet.

7:12d

if the pomegranates are in bloom—

- and the pomegranates are in bloom. (RSV)
- We will see if the fruit trees are blooming.

if the pomegranates are in bloom: This clause tells another thing that the woman and the man can look at in the countryside. They can look at the pomegranate trees and see if they are blooming. Some other ways to translate the clause are:

We can also see if the pomegranate trees are blooming.

We can look for the first blooms on the pomegranate trees.

The phrase the pomegranates are in bloom is similar to 6:11d, and you may translate in a similar way in both places.

pomegranates: A “pomegranate” is a red fruit that grows on a small tree. In 4:3 and 6:7 the man compared the woman’s cheeks to this fruit. Here the mature fruit is not in focus, only its blossoms. The focus here is on springtime growth.

For a picture of pomegranate fruit, see the note on “pomegranates” in 4:3c.

7:12e

there I will give you my love.

- There will I give my love to you. (NJPS)
- While we are there, I will show you how much I love you.

there I will give you my love: The phrase there I will give you my love indicates that the woman will show her love to the man. She implied that they will enjoy love together there in the vineyards. Some other ways to translate 7:12e are:

There I will give my love to you. (NJPS)

I will show my love to you there.

Song of Solomon 7:13

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 7:11–13 The woman invited the man to go with her to the fields and vineyards

In these verses the woman responded to the man’s praise (in 7:1–9a) by inviting him to go out into the fields and vineyards with her to enjoy the springtime. As trees and flowers were blooming, their love for each other was also growing. Here she invited him to go there, as he also invited her in 2:10–13. It is also interesting to notice that 8:2a–b is similar to 3:4e–f.

In 7:11–13, all the events are probably not arranged in the order that they happened (as is common in poetry). It is also possible that these verses describe the woman’s desires and feelings or a dream that she had before her wedding (3:6–5:1). Old Testament scholar, David Dorsey, takes a non-chronological approach to the Song. In his book, *The Literary Structure of the Old Testament* (1999) he proposes a thorough-going symmetrical chiasmic structure for the book. (Also see his article, “Literary Structuring in the Song of Songs” in *Journal for the Study of the Old Testament* 46 (1990) 81–96.) The structure he proposes is a-b-c-d-c’-b’-a’ where the central unit “d” describes the wedding day, the climactic portion of the Song. Some scholars differ on the details of his proposed chiasmic structure while agreeing in principle with the chiasmic approach, while other scholars question whether such a book-level chiasmic structure is actually present. But in spite of the disagreements, viewing the book chiasmically or cyclically does help to resolve some problems that chronological/narrative approaches tend to overlook. When we look at some of the material in the second half of the Song, much of it appears to be from a pre-wedding perspective (a wedding seems to be described in 3:6–5:1). A symmetrical chiasmic or cyclical approach may provide us with a better vantage point for addressing such challenging issues. In the case of this unit, the similarities with 2:10–13 seems fairly clear. So it seems possible, if not likely, that this unit could also be viewed as part of a courtship poem, rather than an event that happened in her life. The exact meaning of 7:11–13 is difficult to determine, but the verses do seem to look forward to the future.

7:13a**The mandrakes send forth a fragrance,**

- The mandrake flowers give their sweet smell, (NCV)
- The “love fruit” plants smell sweet now,

The mandrakes send forth a fragrance: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as mandrakes refers to a certain kind of plant that has sweet-smelling flowers. The phrase The mandrakes send forth a fragrance indicates that the scent of the mandrake plants was in the air.

In that culture people believed that eating the fruit of the mandrake plant (or sometimes even smelling it) aroused sexual desire. They also believed that the fruit helped men and women to produce children. Mandrake flowers and fruit were often used as romantic symbols. In Hebrew, the word mandrake (*dudda'im*) sounds similar to the word for “my beloved” (*dodiy*). In Genesis 30:14–16 Rachel asked Leah to give her mandrakes to help her conceive a child. After that, Rachel did conceive and give birth to Joseph.

In some languages the mandrake plant is not known, or people do not know about its connection with love. If that is true in your language, you may need to indicate the plant’s function in some way. Some ways to do that are:

- Use a descriptive term for the plants. For example:

the love plants

- Include a footnote to explain the function of the plants. For example, the CEV has this footnote:

The Hebrew text has “mandrake,” a plant that was thought to give sexual powers. (CEV)

send forth a fragrance: The phrase send forth a fragrance implies that in the springtime; the mandrake plants produce flowers and fruits that smell sweet. Springtime was considered a special time for romantic love. Some other ways to translate 7:13a are:

You can smell the scent of mandrakes (GNT)

The mandrake flowers give their sweet smell (NCV)

The love fruits send out their perfume

7:13b**and at our door is every delicacy, new as well as old,**

- and all the best/exquisite fruits are near our entrance.
- and nearby are all the other delights

and at our door is every delicacy, new as well as old: This part of the verse is a metaphor. The phrase every delicacy, new as well as old refers to all the joys and pleasures that the man and woman have as they show their love to each other. The word that the BSB translates as at can also mean “near,” or “beside.” Some other ways to translate the metaphor are:

- Use metaphors. For example:

and the finest fruits are at our door, new delights as well as old (NLT)

- Use similes. For example:

The pleasures of our love are like all kinds of delicious fruit, new and old, growing right at our doorway.

- Translate the meaning without figures of speech. For example:

As we love each other, we enjoy every delight.

at our door: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as at our door is more literally “at/near our openings.” This phrase is part of the metaphor. It refers to whatever places the couple will meet to share their romantic love. In this context the place is the countryside itself, which is filled with the delights of springtime. This metaphor implies that a house in the countryside is similar to their house in the forest (1:16–17).

In some languages it is more natural to use a more general expression than door. For example:

all around us

near our place

at our openings/doors

every delicacy, new as well as old: The phrase every delicacy, new as well as old includes all the best kinds of fruit, those that ripen early in the season as well

as those that ripen later. The phrase probably includes other delights, as well as fruits. Some other ways to translate the meaning are:

all choice fruits, new as well as old (RSV)

new delights as well as old (NLT)

every delicacy: The phrase every delicacy refers to the very best quality and most delicious food. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as delicacy has a general sense that describes any choice thing. Literally, it probably refers specifically to the delicacy of fruits. However, it is also a metaphor that refers to the delights of love that the man and woman experience together. See the preceding notes for translation examples.

7:13c

that I have treasured up for you, my beloved.

- My love, I have saved them for you alone.
- that I have kept/reserved for you, my darling.

that I have treasured up for you, my beloved: The clause that I have treasured up for you, my beloved refers back to “every delicacy” in 7:13b. They represent the delights of love, so here the woman indicated that she keeps the delights of her love for the man she loves. Her romantic love is reserved only for him.

Some other ways to translate 7:13c are:

Darling, I have kept for you... (GNT)

which I have saved for you alone, my beloved.

Song of Solomon 8:1

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is

helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 8:1–4 The woman longed for more intimacy with the man

In these verses, the woman continued to speak to the man. She told him that she longed to express her love for him openly. She wished that her beloved were like a brother so that she could kiss him in public without shame. The section ends with a refrain that is also found in 2:6–7 and 3:5. Here she was probably thinking of a time before they married.

8:1a

O that you were to me like a brother

- If only you were to me like a brother (NIV)
- I wish that you were like a brother to me,

8:1

This verse indicates that the woman wanted the freedom to kiss her beloved in public without anyone blaming her. In that culture, it was not proper for a man and woman to kiss in public if they were not related by blood. Even married couples were not supposed to kiss in public. However, it was common for a brother and sister to greet each other with a kiss. So the woman wished that her beloved were like a brother to her so that she could kiss him in public.

The verse does not imply that the woman wanted to greet her own brother with a kiss that implies sexual interest or desire for sexual relations. That would be a sin of incest, which God forbids in the Bible. It is important to translate in a way that refers only to an affectionate public greeting.

O that you were to me like a brother: This clause is an idiom that tells what the woman wished. It is more literally, “Who will make you like a brother to me?” In this context it indicates that the woman wished that the man were like a brother to her so that she could kiss him in public. There are two ways to interpret the clause:

1. She wished that the man were like a brother to her.
For example:

If only you were to me like a brother (NIV) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NCV, NIV, NJPS, REB, RSV)

1. She wished that the man actually were her brother.
For example:

I wish that you were my brother. (GNT) (GW, NAB, NET, NJB, NLT, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). In that culture it was fine for a brother and sister to show affection for each other in public. The woman wanted to have that same freedom to kiss her beloved. She did not wish that the man was really her brother.

Some other ways to translate option (1) are:

If only you were to me like a brother (NIV)

If only it could be as with a brother (NJPS)

I wish that I could treat you like a brother in public

8:1b

who nursed at my mother's breasts!

- who fed at my mother's breasts. (NCV)
- like a son of my own mother.

who nursed at my mother's breasts: The clause who nursed at my mother's breasts indicates that the woman referred to a "brother" who had the same mother as she did. Use a natural way in your language to indicate that relationship. For example:

who fed at my mother's breast (NCV)

who has the same mother as I have

8:1c

If I found you outdoors,

- If I met/saw you in public,
- Then, when I see you on the street

8:1d

I would kiss you,

- then, I would kiss you,
- I could kiss you

8:1e

and no one would despise me.

- and no one would criticize me. (NLT)
- without anyone thinking badly of me.

8:1c-e

If I found you outdoors, I would kiss you, and no one would despise me: Here the woman told her reason for what she said to the man in 8:1a-b. She said that she wished he were her brother because she wanted to kiss him when she saw him in public. In that culture

it was a custom for a sister to greet her brother with a kiss, but otherwise, a man and woman did not kiss each other in public. If the woman kissed the man, other people would criticize them. In 8:1c-e the woman only desired to kiss him, but she did not do it.

Some other ways to translate 8:1c-e are:

Then, if I met you in the street, I could kiss you and no one would mind.

If I saw you outside, I could kiss you, and no one would criticize me.

Then I could kiss you when I saw you in public, and no one would say that I was bad to do it.

outdoors: The word outdoors refers here to a public place where other people may be present. See the translation examples in the preceding note.

and no one would despise me: The phrase and no one would despise me indicates that no person would think or say that the woman should not have kissed the man. They would not think that she was bad because she kissed him in public if he were her brother. However, because he was not her brother and she kissed him in public, they would think that she was wrong to do that. Some other ways to translate 8:1e are:

and no one would say I did wrong. (CEV)

without people thinking ill of me. (NJB)

Song of Solomon 8:2

Section 6:4-8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4-10 and 7:1-10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11-13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13-7:13 in the BSB is 7:1-14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow

the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 8:1–4 The woman longed for more intimacy with the man

In these verses, the woman continued to speak to the man. She told him that she longed to express her love for him openly. She wished that her beloved were like a brother so that she could kiss him in public without shame. The section ends with a refrain that is also found in 2:6–7 and 3:5. Here she was probably thinking of a time before they married.

8:2a

I would lead you and bring you to the house of my mother

- I would lead you and bring you into the house of my mother, (NASB)
- I could take you to my mother's house.

8:2b

who taught me.

- who used to teach me.
- She is the one who taught/nurtured me.

8:2a–b

I would lead you and bring you to the house of my mother who taught me: This theme of the “mother’s house” is also found in 3:4e. Scholars differ about how to interpret the phrase the house of my mother here. Most English versions indicate that it refers to the place where the woman’s mother lived. English versions which follow this interpretation are BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, ESV, CEV, GW, REB, NASB, NET, and NCV. It refers to the house where an unmarried woman lives. Some scholars mention that marriage plans were often made at the mother’s house, so that could be a reason why the woman wanted to bring him there. She may have wanted to make preparations for their marriage, which is described in the Song’s central section (3:5–5:1). Other scholars suggest that the house of my mother is the place of intimate relations. For example:

I would take you to my mother's house (GNT)

to the house of my mother who taught me: There is a textual issue concerning the word that the BSB translates as taught:

1. The Hebrew text has the word that means “taught.” For example:

taught (NET) (BSB, NET, NIV, CEV, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NJPS)

1. The Greek text has the word that means “conceived” or “bore.” For example:

conceived (RSV) (RSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with most English versions. A similar verse is found in 3:4, which has “to the chamber of the one who conceived me.” It is possible that an LXX translator or copyist thought that 8:2 had the same meaning as that verse.

who taught me: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as who taught me:

1. It means “she teaching me,” and it refers to the woman’s mother. For example:

my mother, who taught me all I know. (CEV) (BSB, NIV, ESV, CEV, NASB, GW, NET, NCV, KJV)

1. It means “you teaching me,” and it refers to the man. For example:

there you would teach me. (NLT) (NLT, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

my mother, who used to instruct me (NASB)

She is the one who was my teacher. (GW)

8:2c

I would give you spiced wine to drink,

- I would give you spiced wine.
- There I could give you love as exciting as fine wine,

I would give you spiced wine to drink: The phrase spiced wine refers to wine that is mixed with spices. Here “spiced wine” may be a symbol for kisses. Notice that in 7:9a the author compared kisses to fine wine, and kisses are also in focus in 8:1d.

8:2d

the nectar of my pomegranates.

- I would give you the juice of my pomegranates.
- flavored with the most delicious fruit juice.

the nectar of my pomegranates: The phrase the nectar of my pomegranates is parallel to 8:2c. Probably it describes the spiced wine in 8:2c. That implies that the woman mixed pomegranate juice with the wine.

It is also possible that the pomegranate juice was a separate drink in addition to the wine in 8:2c. The pomegranates are a symbol of romantic love.

Some other ways to translate the nectar of my pomegranates are:

with pomegranate juice

my sweet pomegranate wine (NLT)

If pomegranates are not known in your area, you may use a more general word or phrase. For example:

with nectar/juice from the love fruit

flavored with fruit juice

pomegranates: pomegranates are a red fruit with reddish pulp and seeds. It makes a delicious sweet drink. For more information about pomegranates, see the note on 4:3c.

Song of Solomon 8:3

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 8:1–4 The woman longed for more intimacy with the man

In these verses, the woman continued to speak to the man. She told him that she longed to express her love for him openly. She wished that her beloved were like a brother so that she could kiss him in public without shame. The section ends with a refrain that is also

found in 2:6–7 and 3:5. Here she was probably thinking of a time before they married.

8:3–4

Here the author repeated what he said in 2:6 and 2:7. You should translate in the same way here. See the notes on 2:6–7 for translation advice.

This repetition suggests that the author carefully planned the Song to have a special structure called a “chiasm.” It is not arranged like a story, which tells events in the order they happened.

8:3a

His left hand is under my head,

- His left hand is under my head,
- The left arm of my love/beloved is a pillow for my head,

His left hand is under my head: As in the Hebrew text for 2:6a, there is no verb in 8:3a. It is literally “his left hand under my head.” This clause probably indicates that the man supported the woman’s head with his left arm as she lay in his arms. Some other ways to translate it are:

His left arm/hand is the place where I rest my head

His left arm pillows my head

8:3b

and his right arm embraces me.

- and he uses his right arm to embrace me.
- and with his right arm he holds me close to him.

and his right arm embraces me: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as embraces can refer generally to any embrace or specifically to a sexual caress. Most English versions translate it in a general way. Use an appropriate expression in your language. Some other ways to translate it are:

his right arm is round me. (REB)

he holds me lovingly with his right arm.

Song of Solomon 8:4

Section 6:4–8:4: The man praised the woman and sang about springtime

In this section the man described the woman in two separate speeches (6:4–10 and 7:1–10). Some verses are difficult to understand, especially 6:11–13, and it is important to think about them carefully. The woman

responded to the man in 7:11 and continued to speak to the end of the section at 8:4.

The verse numbering in the Hebrew text is different from the BSB and a majority of English versions. The Hebrew text begins chapter 7 where the BSB begins 6:13, so in chapter 7 the verses in the Hebrew text are one number higher than the verse numbers in the BSB. For example, 6:13–7:13 in the BSB is 7:1–14 in the Hebrew text (and also in the NJB and NJPS). It is helpful to be aware that some commentaries follow the Hebrew verse numbering. The Notes will follow the verse numbers in the BSB (along with the majority of English versions).

Paragraph 8:1–4 The woman longed for more intimacy with the man

In these verses, the woman continued to speak to the man. She told him that she longed to express her love for him openly. She wished that her beloved were like a brother so that she could kiss him in public without shame. The section ends with a refrain that is also found in 2:6–7 and 3:5. Here she was probably thinking of a time before they married.

8:4a

O daughters of Jerusalem, I adjure you:

- I charge/urge you, women of Jerusalem,
- You women of Jerusalem, promise me,
- Swear/Take an oath, young women of Jerusalem,

8:4b

Do not arouse or awaken love

- do not cause romantic love to arise
- that you will not stimulate feelings of erotic love
- Swear/Promise that you will not excite someone to love you

8:4c

until the time is right.

- until that love can be satisfied.
- before the proper time.
- until you can satisfy his love.

8:4

8:4 is similar to 2:7 and 3:5. The only difference is that 8:4 lacks the phrase, “by the gazelles and does of the field,” and it should not be included here. The CEV and a previous version of NAB includes this phrase, but the NAB 2011 revision has now corrected this. Except for this phrase, you should translate 8:4 in the same way as you translated 2:7 and 3:5. See the Notes on 2:7a–b for more information. As in 2:7 and 3:5, 8:4 is a refrain, which indicates the end of a section.

Song of Solomon 8:5

Section 8:5–14: Love has great power

In this final section, there are many key words and statements that repeat themes from earlier parts of the Song. For example, 8:5a mentions the woman coming up from the wilderness, as in 3:6. The author also repeats the themes of vineyard (8:12; 1:6), orchard (8:5; 2:3), and garden (8:13; 4:12–5:1). In the final verse of the Song, the author repeats the theme of a gazelle on the mountains, which was mentioned in 2:17. This final section also contains what many scholars consider a climax of the Song in 8:6–7.

Some other headings for this section are:

Homecoming (NRSV)

The Young Woman’s Love for Her Beloved

Paragraph 8:5–7 The woman spoke about the power of love

In this unit the speakers, location, and topic change (from the previous unit 8:1–4). But it is uncertain exactly how 8:5 relates to 8:6–7 and the rest of the Epilogue.

8:6–7 is a climax and conclusion of the Song, as it describes the great power of love.

8:5a

Who is this coming up from the wilderness,

- Who is this young woman coming from the wilderness, (GW)
- Who is she who is coming up from the deserted places,

Who is this coming up from the wilderness: In Hebrew the clause here in 8:5a is identical to 3:6a. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as this is feminine and refers to the woman. For example:

Who is this young woman coming from the wilderness? (GW)

See the notes on 3:6a for further discussion. As with the question in 3:6, this question is probably rhetorical. It helps to draw attention to the woman. In some languages it is more natural to translate this rhetorical question as a statement or exclamation. For example:

What a wonderful woman this is who is coming up from the wilderness...!

Look at this beautiful woman coming from the wilderness!

this: The word *this* refers here to the woman, as it did in 3:6. In 3:6 she was coming as a bride to her wedding, so some versions may refer to her there as a bride. Since the focus is different here in 8:5, it is good to refer to her in a more general way in this verse. For example:

this young woman (GW)

coming up from the wilderness: The phrase coming up from the wilderness may refer back to 7:11–13. Those verses indicate that the woman wanted the man to go with her to the countryside. The text may imply that they went there and now in 8:5 they are returning to their home. However, this is not certain. In most languages it is fine to translate this phrase as you did in 3:6a.

8:5b leaning on her beloved?

- leaning on the one she loves?
- and leaning on the shoulder of the one she loves? (CEV)

leaning on her beloved: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as leaning on her beloved implies that the woman trusts the man and depends on him. It also implies that the man and woman love each other.

In some languages a phrase like leaning on may wrongly imply that the woman was tired or injured, so she needed to lean on the man. If that is true in your language, use a different phrase that will not imply that. For example:

walking close to her beloved

with her arm around her beloved (GW)

In some languages there is a special way to describe this. For example:

arm in arm with her lover (GNT)

Use a natural way in your language to describe a couple walking affectionately together.

leaning: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as leaning occurs only here. Scholars are not certain exactly what it means, but it implies here that the woman walked with the man in a way that showed

trust and affection. Use a natural way to imply that in your language.

8:5c

I roused you under the apple tree;

- It was under the apple tree that I awoke you.
- Under the apple tree I woke you up, (GW)

I roused you under the apple tree: This clause implies that the man was under an apple tree, and the woman woke him up. The word roused may have two meanings here. It may indicate that she woke the man from sleep, and it may also imply that she caused him to have feelings of love for her. Some ways to translate the clause are:

- Use a general phrase that can imply either that she woke him from literal sleep or that she caused him to feel romantic love for her. For example:

I aroused you.

I awakened you to love.

- Use a specific phrase that implies that she aroused the man's desire to express love toward her. For example:

I stirred up your passions. (CEV)

Use a natural way in your language to imply that the woman caused the man to realize that he felt romantic love for her. (Also see the discussions of the verbs “arouse” and “awaken” in 2:7c–d and 8:4.)

the apple tree: In this verse it is likely that the apple tree is a symbol for love. It may also refer to a literal apple tree. The fragrance and sweetness of the apple and other fruits are often associated with love in the Song. In 2:3a–b, the woman compared the man to an apple tree.

An apple tree is mentioned three other times in the Song (2:3, 5; and 7:8). It only occurs two other times in the whole OT. You should use the same term to refer to the apple tree in all of these verses.

8:5d

there your mother conceived you;

- There your mother was in labor with you, (ESV)
- where your mother gave you birth, (NLT)

there your mother conceived you: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as conceived in 8:5d:

1. It refers to the effort (labor) and pain that a woman experiences in giving birth to a child. For example:

There your mother was in labor with you. (ESV)
(CEV, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NLT, REB, RSV, GNT)

1. It refers to conceiving a child. For example:

there your mother conceived you (NIV) (BSB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with a majority of English versions. See the following note on 8:5e for translation examples.

8:5e

there she travailed and brought you forth.

- there she who was in labor gave you birth. (NIV)
- where in great pain she delivered you. (NLT)

there she travailed and brought you forth: The phrase brought you forth refers to “your mother” in 8:5d. However, it makes explicit that her labor pains were successful and she gave birth to him.

Some ways to translate 8:5d–e are:

It was there that the pains of childbirth came to your mother and she gave birth to you.

where your mother gave you birth, where in great pain she delivered you. (NLT)

There your mother went into labor with you. There she went into labor and gave birth to you! (GW)

Song of Solomon 8:6

Section 8:5–14: Love has great power

In this final section, there are many key words and statements that repeat themes from earlier parts of the Song. For example, 8:5a mentions the woman coming up from the wilderness, as in 3:6. The author also repeats the themes of vineyard (8:12; 1:6), orchard (8:5; 2:3), and garden (8:13; 4:12–5:1). In the final verse of the Song, the author repeats the theme of a gazelle on the mountains, which was mentioned in 2:17. This final section also contains what many scholars consider a climax of the Song in 8:6–7.

Some other headings for this section are:

Homecoming (NRSV)

The Young Woman’s Love for Her Beloved

Paragraph 8:5–7 The woman spoke about the power of love

In this unit the speakers, location, and topic change (from the previous unit 8:1–4). But it is uncertain exactly how 8:5 relates to 8:6–7 and the rest of the Epilogue.

8:6–7 is a climax and conclusion of the Song, as it describes the great power of love.

8:6–7

Some scholars consider these two verses to be the climax of the Song. It is different from the rest of the book. Most other parts of the Song focus on the couple’s love for one another, but in 8:6–7 the author praised love itself and described what love is like. He used three comparisons: Love’s power is like the power and persistence of death. Love is also like two other powerful forces in nature: fire and water.

8:6a

Set me as a seal over your heart,

- Place me like a seal over your heart, (NIV)
- Close your heart to every love but mine. (GNT)
- Show everyone that I am the one whom you love.

Set me as a seal over your heart: The clause Set me as a seal over your heart is a figure of speech. A literal seal was an object that had a mark on it which represented the seal’s owner. (For more information, see the following note on seal.) The figure of speech indicates that the woman wanted the man to always love only her. She wanted to be sure that he would not have a romantic relationship with any other woman.

In many cultures people do not use seals. If that is true in your culture, some other ways to translate the meaning are:

- Use a different figure of speech that has the same meaning. For example:

Write my name on your heart.

Always keep me in your heart (CEV)

- Translate the meaning in another poetic way without the figure of speech. For example:

Close your heart to every love but mine (GNT)

Promise that you will faithfully love me alone.

seal: A seal was a small object (usually made of stone, wood or metal). It had a special design on it to represent the owner. Sometimes the seal was worn like a ring on a person's finger or hung around his neck on a cord.

The owner of the seal could mark an object as his by putting clay or wax on the object and pressing his seal into the clay or wax to mark it with his design. The woman wanted to be like a seal on the man's heart that showed that he was hers. (His romantic love should be given to her alone).

over your heart: This seal may have been hung literally around the neck, and therefore close to the man's heart. In that culture people spoke of the heart as the part of a person that feels love. In many languages people use a different part of the body to speak of love, or they may not use a part of the body at all. Use a natural way in your language to speak of the feelings and commitment to love another person.

8:6b

as a seal upon your arm.

- like a seal on your arm. (NIV)
- Let me be like a ring on your hand that you always remember,

as a seal upon your arm: The phrase as a seal upon your arm is parallel to 8:6a. It is also a figure of speech, and it has a similar meaning. Because it is so much like 8:6a, a shorter form is used. The full form is:

or set me as a seal upon your arm.

The woman said this to emphasize that she wanted the man to be committed to love only her. In some languages this figure of speech may not be natural or it may have a wrong meaning. Some other ways to translate the meaning are:

- Use a different figure of speech that has the same meaning. For example:

hold no one in your arms but me. (GNT)

- Translate the meaning in another poetic way. For example:

Promise that you will faithfully love me alone.

wear this bracelet to remember me by. (CEV)

Show everyone that I am the only woman for you.

upon your arm: The phrase upon your arm indicates that the woman wanted the man to wear the symbol of his commitment to her on his arm. This symbol could be worn as a bracelet or armband or in another way that would remind him of his commitment to her. For example:

like the signet ring on your hand. Translator's Handbook on TW.

8:6c

For love is as strong as death,

- Love is as powerful as death. (GNT)
- because loving you overcomes me like dying overcomes someone.

For: The word For introduces the woman's explanation for her requests in 8:6a-b.

love is as strong as death: The expression love is as strong as death is a simile that compares love to death. In this context love probably refers to romantic love. The statement indicates that romantic love is extremely powerful. It is like the power of death. Death overcomes a person so that the person must die. In a similar way, love can overcome a person so that he must love his beloved. He cannot stop loving by his own will or power.

Other ways to translate this meaning are:

The passions of love are as powerful as the approach of death.

Romantic love can overpower a person as death does.

In many languages it is more natural to translate love and death as verbs or statements. For example:

Loving someone is as hard to resist/stop as dying.

It is as hard to prevent/keep myself from loving you as it would be to prevent/keep myself from dying.

8:6d

its jealousy as unrelenting as Sheol.

- Devotion is as persistent as the grave/afterlife.
- It makes me want to hold/keep you as the grave holds/keeps dead people.

its jealousy as unrelenting as Sheol: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as jealousy as unrelenting as Sheol is parallel to 8:6c, but the meaning of the two clauses is not exactly the same. There are two ways to interpret the word jealousy here:

1. It refers to a lover's passionate devotion to the person whom he or she loves. He refuses to give up his devotion to his beloved, just as a grave does not let a person leave it. For example:

passion is as unrelenting as Sheol. (NET) (GNT, NRSV, CEV, NET, REB, NJB, NJPS)

1. It refers to the feeling of anger and injury that a lover has when his beloved is unfaithful to him. This jealousy will continue, just as the grave continues to hold a dead person. For example:

its jealousy unyielding as the grave. (NIV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, ESV, NLT, NCV, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). However, the interpretations are similar, since jealousy is a specific type of "passion." Since both interpretations have good support, it is good to include a footnote to mention interpretation (2). For example:

The Hebrew word can also mean "jealousy."

Since the BSB follows interpretation (2), the GW will be used as the source text for 8:6.

(GW) Devotion is as unyielding as the grave: Here the word Devotion refers to a lover's strong commitment to his or her beloved. The statement Devotion is as unyielding as the grave is a figure of speech called personification. It speaks of Devotion and the grave as though they were human beings. Here this personification indicates that a person who is devoted to his beloved will continue to be devoted to her, just as a dead person continues to be dead.

Some ways to translate this figure of speech are:

- Keep the personification. For example:

passion is as strong as death itself. (GNT)

fervent/ardent love does not give up its loved one, just as death does not give up a dead person.

When a person is devoted to his beloved, he will hold on to her like a grave holds a person buried in it.

- Translate the meaning without the personification. For example:

A person who is devoted to his beloved continues to be devoted, just as a dead person continues to be dead.

8:6e

Its sparks are fiery flames,

- It burns like blazing fire, (NIV)
- It feels like a hot fire inside me.

Its sparks are fiery flames: The phrase Its sparks are fiery flames is a metaphor. The woman compared love to flames. She also continued to use the type of personification that was used in 8:6d. She implied that a man and woman who are devoted to each other as in 8:6d must not show romantic love to anyone else. If they love anyone else in that way, it violates their commitment to each other. Devotion causes a lover to be strongly determined to protect the love between him and his beloved.

Some ways to translate this figure of speech are:

- Keep the personification. For example:

Commitment consumes like a raging fire.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

I am totally determined to protect our love.

8:6f

the fiercest blaze of all.

- like a mighty flame. (NIV)
- I am completely committed to you.

the fiercest blaze of all: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the fiercest blaze of all is a compound word that is more literally "flame-of-Yah." The word "Yah" is sometimes used as a short form of "Yahweh," which is the Hebrew name for the LORD. Here the phrase the fiercest blaze of all is parallel to 8:6e and emphasizes its meaning. There are two different ways to interpret it.

1. It refers to a very hot, strong flame. For example:

like a mighty flame. (NIV) (BSB, NAB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJPS, NLT, REB, RSV, GNT)

1. It refers to the flame of Yahweh (the LORD). For example:

the very flame of the Lord. (ESV) (ESV, GW, NASB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with the majority of English versions. There is no other reference to God in the entire book. So some scholars argue that certainly there must be an explicit divine reference here. Others, however, argue the other way. The fact that there are no other direct references to God makes it doubtful that God is referred to here with a mere suffix on a noun. However, option (2) is also acceptable. Both options make sense in the context.

Some other ways to translate this part of the verse are:

and burns like a hot fire. (NCV)

fiercer than any flame. (REB)

with complete determination.

Song of Solomon 8:7

Section 8:5–14: Love has great power

In this final section, there are many key words and statements that repeat themes from earlier parts of the Song. For example, 8:5a mentions the woman coming up from the wilderness, as in 3:6. The author also repeats the themes of vineyard (8:12; 1:6), orchard (8:5; 2:3), and garden (8:13; 4:12–5:1). In the final verse of the Song, the author repeats the theme of a gazelle on the mountains, which was mentioned in 2:17. This final section also contains what many scholars consider a climax of the Song in 8:6–7.

Some other headings for this section are:

Homecoming (NRSV)

The Young Woman's Love for Her Beloved

Paragraph 8:5–7 The woman spoke about the power of love

In this unit the speakers, location, and topic change (from the previous unit 8:1–4). But it is uncertain exactly how 8:5 relates to 8:6–7 and the rest of the Epilogue.

8:6–7 is a climax and conclusion of the Song, as it describes the great power of love.

8:7a

Mighty waters cannot quench love;

- No amount of water can extinguish/affect the fire of love,
- Many troubles cannot make people stop loving each other.

Mighty waters cannot quench love: The clause Mighty waters cannot quench love is a metaphor. It continues the metaphor in 8:6e–f, which states that love is like fire. The fire of love cannot be quenched even by many waters. Mighty waters represent troubles or difficulties. Just as a huge fire is not overcome even by much water, true lovers do not stop loving each other even if they have many difficulties and troubles.

Some ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Keep the metaphor (of water not putting out the fire of love). For example:

Water cannot put it out (GNT)

Raging water cannot extinguish love... (GW)

- Use similes. For example:

Love is like a big fire. Even if troubles come like many waters, they cannot extinguish the fire of love.

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

When a man and woman truly love each other, even many troubles cannot overcome their love.

Mighty waters: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Mighty waters refers to much water. Since 8:7b refers to “rivers” the waters here in 8:7a probably also imply waters that are strong and forceful. Some other ways to translate the phrase are:

Even much water (NCV)

Surging waters (NET)

quench: The word quench in this context refers to the way water extinguishes (puts out) a fire. Here is another way to translate this:

Love cannot be drowned by oceans or floods. (CEV)

8:7b

rivers cannot sweep it away.

- even a flood cannot destroy it.
- Even disasters will not stop them from loving.

rivers cannot sweep it away: The expression rivers cannot sweep it away is parallel to the metaphor in 8:7a and has a similar meaning. Literally, it means that even floodwater cannot overcome love.

In a flood, water rushes in and overcomes people. The author used flood as a figure of speech to refer to the difficulties and dangers that people face when they love each other. The phrase rivers cannot sweep it away indicates that even a flood (or other disaster or difficulty) cannot cause people to stop loving each other. In this context the author referred especially to romantic love.

Some ways to translate the metaphor are:

- Translate the metaphor in a literal way, if it communicates the right meaning in your language. For example:

floods cannot drown love.

no flood can stop people from loving each other.

- Use a simile. For example:

Even if troubles come like a flood, they cannot wash love away.

- Translate the meaning without a figure of speech. For example:

No troubles can cause a man and a woman to stop loving each other.

When people love each other, no troubles can destroy that love.

8:7c

If a man were to give all the wealth of his house for love,

- If someone offered everything he owned to purchase love,
- If a person tried to buy love with all of his riches/money,

8:7d

his offer would be utterly scorned.

- his offer would be completely rejected/despised.
- people would only laugh at him.

8:7c–d

If a man were to give all the wealth of his house for love, his offer would be utterly scorned: The statement in 8:7c–d implies that true love is precious. That is why no one can buy it with money or other wealth. There is nothing that a person can offer to get true love in return, because it is worth more than any riches.

Some other ways to translate this statement are:

If a man offered everything in his house for love, people would totally reject it. (NCV)

If someone offered to give everything he owned to buy love, everyone would only laugh at him.

The clause that begins with “If” in the preceding two examples mentions an action that probably would never really happen. It is a condition that is not real. In some languages there is a special way to indicate that an action is unlikely to happen. For example:

Even if someone wanted to buy love with all his wealth, surely he would receive only scorn.

If someone were to offer all his riches to buy love, people would just ridicule him.

Translate this meaning in a natural and emphatic way in your language.

a man: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as a man can be interpreted in two ways.

1. It means “an adult male.” For example:

Were a man to offer all his family wealth to buy love (NJB) (BSB, ESV, GW, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, RSV)

1. It means “a person” (of either gender). For example:

If someone were to offer all his possessions to buy love (NET) (NET, NIV, NRSV, REB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). In this context the woman was thinking about the man. However, either option is a valid translation here.

were to give...for love: The phrase for love means “tried to purchase love.” For example:

But if any tried to buy love with their wealth... (GNT)

all the wealth of his house: In this context the phrase all the wealth of his house emphasizes the fact that there is nothing that a person can give to buy love. It does not refer specifically to the wealth inside his house or to the wealth of his family. The context implies that no amount of wealth could ever buy love. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

everything he owned (NLT96)

all his wealth (NLT)

it cannot be bought, no matter what is offered (CEV)

his offer would be utterly scorned: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as his offer may refer either to the man himself or to the offer of his wealth.

1. It refers to the man’s offer and his wealth. For example:

the offer would be utterly despised. (NET) (BSB, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NLT, REB, RSV)

1. It refers to the man himself. For example:

he would be utterly despised. (ESV) (ESV, GW, NAB, NJB, NJPS, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The man’s offer is rejected because he tried to buy love with wealth, showing a wrong attitude. However, both options are acceptable. In some languages option (2) may be more natural. If that is true in your language, it is fine to follow it. Some ways to translate this part of the verse are:

the offer would be utterly despised. (NET)

people would totally reject the offer.

General Comment on 8:7

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of 8:7c and 8:7d. For example:

^{7d}Love is so precious that no one can buy it ^{7c}even if he offers great riches.

^{7d}it cannot be bought, ^{7c}no matter what is offered. (CEV)

Song of Solomon 8:8

Section 8:5–14: Love has great power

In this final section, there are many key words and statements that repeat themes from earlier parts of the Song. For example, 8:5a mentions the woman coming up from the wilderness, as in 3:6. The author also repeats the themes of vineyard (8:12; 1:6), orchard (8:5; 2:3), and garden (8:13; 4:12–5:1). In the final verse of the Song, the author repeats the theme of a gazelle on the mountains, which was mentioned in 2:17. This final section also contains what many scholars consider a climax of the Song in 8:6–7.

Some other headings for this section are:

Homecoming (NRSV)

The Young Woman’s Love for Her Beloved

Paragraph 8:8–10

In these verses the young woman and her brothers had a conversation about her physical maturity. Her brothers said that she was young, physically immature, and not ready to be married. They referred to a wall and a door, which symbolize that she was chaste (a virgin). In 8:10 she responded to their comments, agreeing that she was chaste and saying that she was also mature and ready for marriage. She referred to the man whom she loved as one to whom she was bringing peace. The quoted speech of her brothers here forms a possible book-level inclusio with 1:6, where her brothers were also mentioned.

8:8a

We have a little sister,

- We have a young sister,
- Our sister is still young,
- You know that our sister is not yet mature,

8:8b

and her breasts are not yet grown.

- and her breasts are not very large yet.
- and her breasts are still small.

8:8a-b

We have a little sister, and her breasts are not yet grown: Here the woman's brothers referred to her as their little sister. Some scholars believe that this statement about a little sister refers to a younger sister of the woman. The phrase probably implies that they thought of her as though she were still a young girl, yet she was a grown woman. They believed that it was their responsibility to protect her and to make marriage arrangements for her. The phrase her breasts are not yet grown probably implies that they considered her too young for marriage.

Some other ways to translate 8:8a-b are:

- Use a natural way in your language to indicate that a woman is still young and her breasts are still developing. For example:

Our sister is still young, and her breasts are not fully developed/grown.

Our sister is young, and her breasts are still small.

- Use a more general way to indicate that the woman is not yet ready for marriage. For example:

Our sister is too young to marry.

Our sister is not yet ready for marriage.

a little sister: Here the phrase a little sister refers to the woman in the Song. The brothers implied that she was still a young girl. They implied that she was not an adult and had not yet developed sexually. The brothers probably exaggerated because they did not want her to be married yet.

her breasts are not yet grown: The phrase her breasts are not yet grown indicates that the girl's breasts were not as large as they would be when she became a little older. Ezekiel 16:7 says, "You grew up and matured and became very beautiful. Your breasts were formed..." Here, "breasts" are referred to in describing physical maturity in a woman. The reference in the Song seems to be assuming a similar meaning, that is, an indicator of physical (and probably sexual) maturity. In some languages a literal translation of this phrase may wrongly imply that the woman's breasts were abnormal or deformed. If that is true in

your language, it is better to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

her breasts are still small (GNT)

her breasts have not yet fully developed

In some languages it may not be proper to speak of a woman's breasts in this way. There may be a different way to indicate that a girl is not yet physically ready for marriage. For example:

We have a little sister; she is not yet a grown woman.

We have a sister who is still young.

8:8c**What shall we do for our sister**

- What will we do for our young sister
- What will we do to help her,
- What do you^(plur) think that we^(incl) should do for her

8:8d**on the day she is spoken for?**

- when someone asks to marry her?
- when a young man comes to us^(incl) to say that he wants to marry her?

8:8c-d

What shall we do for our sister on the day she is spoken for: The question in 8:8c-d implies that the brothers were responsible for helping to arrange the marriage of their sister. The phrase the day she is spoken for refers to the time when a man will come to the brothers to tell them that he wants to marry their sister.

In that culture a woman's brothers felt responsible to be sure that their sister was prepared for marriage. They wanted to know that she was ready to be a good wife, and they wanted to protect her from any man who would not be a good husband for her.

Some other ways to translate the question are:

What will we do to help our sister when someone wants/asks to marry her?

What will we do for our sister if someone asks to marry her? (NLT)

In some languages it is more natural to change the order of 8:8c and 8:8d. For example:

^{8d}When a man wants to marry our sister, ^{8c}what shall we do for her?

Song of Solomon 8:9

Section 8:5–14: Love has great power

In this final section, there are many key words and statements that repeat themes from earlier parts of the Song. For example, 8:5a mentions the woman coming up from the wilderness, as in 3:6. The author also repeats the themes of vineyard (8:12; 1:6), orchard (8:5; 2:3), and garden (8:13; 4:12–5:1). In the final verse of the Song, the author repeats the theme of a gazelle on the mountains, which was mentioned in 2:17. This final section also contains what many scholars consider a climax of the Song in 8:6–7.

Some other headings for this section are:

Homecoming (NRSV)

The Young Woman's Love for Her Beloved

Paragraph 8:8–10

In these verses the young woman and her brothers had a conversation about her physical maturity. Her brothers said that she was young, physically immature, and not ready to be married. They referred to a wall and a door, which symbolize that she was chaste (a virgin). In 8:10 she responded to their comments, agreeing that she was chaste and saying that she was also mature and ready for marriage. She referred to the man whom she loved as one to whom she was bringing peace. The quoted speech of her brothers here forms a possible book-level inclusio with 1:6, where her brothers were also mentioned.

8:9a–d

If she is a wall, we will build a tower of silver upon her. If she is a door, we will enclose her with panels of cedar: In this verse the woman's brothers discussed what to do for her when a man wants to marry her. They used two parallel figures of speech to describe what they planned to do. The parallel phrases in these figures are indicated with similar typing:

^{9a} If she is a wall, ^{9b}**we will build a tower of silver**

^{9c} If she is a door, ^{9d}**we will enclose her with panels of cedar.**

There are different ways to interpret these figures of speech. The Notes for 8:9 will discuss how to interpret and translate them.

8:9a

If she is a wall,

- If she is like a wall,
- If she guards/protects herself like a city with a wall around it,
- If she is chaste, (NLT96)

If she is a wall: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as If she is a wall is more literally “if a wall she.” There is no verb like is. The woman's brothers used the word wall here as a figure of speech to describe the woman. It implies that the woman had not had sexual relations with anyone.

The figure of a wall contrasts with the figure of a door in 8:9c. A wall blocks people from entering a room, but a door allows them to enter. In that culture a wall was often built around a city to protect the people there from enemies. In other places people build walls around their houses and land to protect their families and possessions.

Some other ways to translate this figure of speech are:

- Use a simile. For example:

If she is like a wall/barrier

If a wall is what she resembles

- Use a figure of speech and indicate the meaning. For example:

If she protects her purity like a wall protects a city/home

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

If she is chaste/pure

If she has kept/protected herself from having sexual relations with anyone

8:9b

we will build a tower of silver upon her.

- we will build towers of silver on her. (NIV)
- we will reward her like people who build a silver tower on their city wall.
- we will reward her.

we will build a tower of silver upon her: A tower was a type of barrier that was placed on top of a city wall. It gave extra protection to the city. silver is a precious metal, and a battlement made of silver would be expensive and beautiful.

The phrase tower of silver is used in a figurative way here. The woman's brothers implied that they planned to reward the woman for being sexually pure and to continue to protect her. They would decorate her with silver so that she would be very appealing and beautiful to any man who wanted to marry her. A man would see the silver and also realize that she was precious to her family.

Some ways to translate the figure of speech in 8:9b are:

- Keep the figure of speech of a silver barrier and indicate its purpose to protect a city or a person. For example:

we will build a silver barrier around her. (GW)

we will give her a silver shield to defend her.

we will protect her with a silver tower. (NLT)

- Translate the meaning more directly without the figure of speech of a tower. For example:

we will decorate her with silver jewelry to show that she is precious and guarded

If she is chaste, we will strengthen and encourage her. (NLT96)

8:9c

If she is a door,

- However, if she is like a door,
- But if she is as welcoming as a gate that is open for people to enter,

8:9d

we will enclose her with panels of cedar.

- we will barricade her with cedar boards. (GW)
- we will protect her like people who make a fine cedar/wooden fence around a beautiful house.

8:9c-d

If she is a door, we will enclose her with panels of cedar: Here the brothers used a door and panels of cedar as metaphors to contrast with the metaphor of a wall in 8:9a-b. A woman who is like a door is too

willing to allow men to be intimate with her. If the woman was like a door, she would need even more protection.

Some ways to translate the metaphor here are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

But if she is a gate, we will protect her with panels of cedar. (GNT)

if she is a door, we shall bar it with a plank of cedarwood. (REB)

- Use a simile. For example:

But if she is like a door that opens to men too freely, we will prevent them from entering, as though we blocked the door with cedar panels.

If it is a gate that she resembles, we will prevent men from entering, as though we blocked a gate with fine wooden boards.

- Translate the meaning more directly without the figure of speech. For example:

But if she welcomes men too freely, we will protect her by preventing them from coming.

In 8:10 the woman affirmed that she was like a wall by saying clearly, "I am a wall." She did not compare herself to a door.

we will enclose her with panels of cedar: The clause we will enclose her with panels of cedar implies that the brothers would block the woman's doorway with wooden boards to protect her against intruders. It does not indicate that the brothers would imprison her.

panels of cedar: cedar wood is a hard wood which was beautiful and expensive in Israel. It may imply here that the brothers wanted to enhance the woman's beauty, in addition to protecting her. It may also imply that the brothers wanted to attract a rich man who would bring wealth to the family when he married their sister.

In some areas cedar trees are not known or are not common. If that is true in your area, you may use a more general term. For example:

beautiful, expensive wood

the beautiful wood called “cedar”

Song of Solomon 8:10

Section 8:5–14: Love has great power

In this final section, there are many key words and statements that repeat themes from earlier parts of the Song. For example, 8:5a mentions the woman coming up from the wilderness, as in 3:6. The author also repeats the themes of vineyard (8:12; 1:6), orchard (8:5; 2:3), and garden (8:13; 4:12–5:1). In the final verse of the Song, the author repeats the theme of a gazelle on the mountains, which was mentioned in 2:17. This final section also contains what many scholars consider a climax of the Song in 8:6–7.

Some other headings for this section are:

Homecoming (NRSV)

The Young Woman’s Love for Her Beloved

Paragraph 8:8–10

In these verses the young woman and her brothers had a conversation about her physical maturity. Her brothers said that she was young, physically immature, and not ready to be married. They referred to a wall and a door, which symbolize that she was chaste (a virgin). In 8:10 she responded to their comments, agreeing that she was chaste and saying that she was also mature and ready for marriage. She referred to the man whom she loved as one to whom she was bringing peace. The quoted speech of her brothers here forms a possible book-level inclusio with 1:6, where her brothers were also mentioned.

8:10a

I am a wall,

- I am like a wall
- I am chaste, (NLT96)

8:10b

and my breasts are like towers.

- and my breasts are like towers on the wall.
- and my breasts are fully mature.

8:10a–b

In 8:10a the poet used the image of a “wall” to imply that the woman was pure and chaste. In 8:10b he used the image of a “tower” to indicate that she was physically mature.

I am a wall: Here the young woman responded to what her brothers said. She used a wall as a figure of speech in the same way as her brothers did to indicate that she was chaste. She did not allow men to be sexually

intimate with her. It is good to translate this figure of speech in a similar way to what you did in 8:9a. For example:

- Use a simile. For example:

I am like a wall

I am like a barrier

- Use a figure of speech and indicate the meaning. For example:

If I protect my purity like a wall protects a city/home

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

If I am chaste/pure

If I have kept/protected myself from having sexual relations with anyone

and my breasts are like towers: The woman used a hyperbole, my breasts are like towers, to respond to what her brothers said in 8:8. (They said “she has no breasts.”) Here in 8:10 the woman disagreed with them. She said that her breasts were large and beautiful like towers. She implied that she was fully mature and ready for marriage.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

- Translate the hyperbole and indicate its meaning. For example:

My breasts are large like towers/buildings.

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

My breasts are fully mature.

- Use an appropriate figure of speech or other way to describe mature breasts in your language.

My breasts show that I am ready for love.

am...are: The BSB includes the verbs am and are. In Hebrew, there is no verb. Scholars differ about the time that the woman referred to.

1. She referred to the time period when she was speaking. At that time, she was like a wall, and her breasts were mature. For example:

I am a wall, and my breasts are like towers. (NIV) (BSB, CEV, GW, NAB, NCV, NIV, NJB, NJPS, REB, GNT)

1. She referred to a time before she was speaking. At that time, she was like a wall, and her breasts were mature. For example:

I was a wall, and my breasts were like fortress towers. (NET) (ESV, NASB, NET, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). She was probably telling her brothers that now she is mature, yet still chaste.

8:10c

So I have become in his eyes like one who brings peace.

- So he thinks of me as someone who makes him content/happy.
- Thus he now has pleasure/contentment from being with me.

So: In this context the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as So introduces the result of the woman's being chaste ("like a wall") and being ready for love (implied by her mature breasts). He could be confident that she was completely true to him. He was the only one who would enjoy her love.

Some other ways to translate the connection between 8:10b and 8:10c are:

So (GW)

As a result

Thus (NIV)

I have become in his eyes like one who brings peace: This clause tells about what the man thought about the woman. There are two ways to interpret it:

1. The man thought that the woman caused him to have peace. For example:

Thus I have become in his eyes like one bringing contentment. (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NRSV, CEV, NLT, NCV, NJB, REB)

1. The man thought that he caused the woman to have peace. For example:

My lover knows that with him I find contentment and peace. (GNT) (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). To the man the woman was a person who caused him to have peace. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

So he thinks of me as a person who makes him feel content.

So I was to him, as one who brings happiness. (NCV)

so he looks at me and thinks, "She makes me happy/content."

one who brings peace: This phrase indicates that the woman caused the man to feel peaceful, contented, and happy. For translation examples, see the preceding note on "I was in his eyes as one who brings peace."

peace: The Hebrew word *shalom* that the BSB translates as peace refers to well-being, contentment, and completeness. It does not indicate only that a person does not have conflict with other people. It implies here that the woman made him content, complete, and blessed.

Song of Solomon 8:11

Section 8:5–14: Love has great power

In this final section, there are many key words and statements that repeat themes from earlier parts of the Song. For example, 8:5a mentions the woman coming up from the wilderness, as in 3:6. The author also repeats the themes of vineyard (8:12; 1:6), orchard (8:5; 2:3), and garden (8:13; 4:12–5:1). In the final verse of the Song, the author repeats the theme of a gazelle on the mountains, which was mentioned in 2:17. This final section also contains what many scholars consider a climax of the Song in 8:6–7.

Some other headings for this section are:

Homecoming (NRSV)

The Young Woman's Love for Her Beloved

Paragraph 8:11–12

In these verses the author mentioned a vineyard, as he did in 1:6. The verses probably imply that the value of true love (see 8:7c–d) is much greater than the value of wealth and power. King Solomon symbolized that type of power and riches. The text implies that a person should value love more than any amount of money.

Scholars differ about who spoke in 8:11–12.

1. The woman spoke. For example, the NIV identifies the speaker as:

She (NIV) (BSB, CEV, ESV, GW, NAB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB)

1. The man spoke. For example, the GNT identifies the speaker as:

The Man (GNT) (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English versions. This interpretation fits well with the woman's comments about her vineyard in 1:6.

8:11a**Solomon had a vineyard in Baal-hamon.**

- Solomon has a vineyard at Baal-hamon, (NLT)
- Solomon has a grape farm in a place called Baal Hamon.

Solomon had a vineyard in Baal-hamon: Many scholars believe that the statement Solomon had a vineyard in Baal-hamon has two meanings. It refers to a literal vineyard, and it also refers figuratively to the large number of wives that King Solomon had. Solomon spent much money to keep his many wives safe. He put them in a special place reserved only for them. Here the woman compared this place to a vineyard.

The author probably mentioned Solomon here as a contrast to the young man whom the woman loved. Solomon's vineyard is a good example of the fact that wealth cannot buy love (as stated in 8:7c–d).

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Solomon owned a large grape farm at Baal-hamon

Solomon has a vineyard in a place called Baal Hamon (GNT)

vineyard: The word vineyard is used eight times in the Song. It is good to translate it in a similar way

in each place where it is used. For more information and translation examples, see the note on vineyard at 1:6e. In the Song the word sometimes has both a literal and a figurative meaning. It refers literally to an actual vineyard with vines and grapes, and figuratively to a human body and to sexuality, especially to women's sexuality.

Some other ways to translate it are:

a grape farm

a farm with delicious fruit

Baal-hamon: The name Baal-hamon is the name of a place, but the location of the place is unknown. The name literally means “master (Baal) of wealth,” “wealthy master,” so the author may use this name because of its meaning. A “master of wealth” contrasts with a person who has true love. Money cannot buy love.

English versions write Baal-hamon as a name without translating its meaning. It may be helpful to include a footnote in your translation to tell the meaning of the name. An example of a possible footnote is:

The name Baal-hamon means “master of wealth, wealthy master.”

8:11b**He leased it to the tenants.**

- which he leases out to tenant farmers. (NLT)
- He rents it to other people to take care of it for him.

He leased it to the tenants: The clause He leased it to the tenants means that Solomon, the owner, rented his vineyard to tenants so that the tenants would care for it. Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

He rented the vineyard for others to tend

he has hired people to care for his vineyard

He entrusted that vineyard to caretakers. (GW)

There are farmers who rent it from him (GNT)

Figuratively, the “vineyard” in this clause may refer to the harem of King Solomon, where his many wives lived. If that is the meaning of “vineyard” here, the

clause implies that Solomon hired people to take care of his wives in the harem.

to the tenants: The word tenants refers here to tenant farmers. Such farmers paid rent money so that the owner would allow them to farm on his land. They received some of the fruit of the land as their payment. The rest of the fruit belonged to the owner, along with the land itself. Use a natural way in your language to refer to such workers. Some other ways to refer to them in English are:

some farmers (NLT96)

other people to take care of it

tenant farmers (NLT)

8:11c

For its fruit, each was to bring a thousand shekels of silver.

- Each of them pays a thousand pieces of silver to harvest its fruit.
- Each person pays him a large amount of money to be allowed to pick its fruit.

For its fruit, each was to bring a thousand shekels of silver: This part of the verse tells what each tenant farmer must pay for the right to farm Solomon's land. Each farmer was required to pay Solomon a thousand pieces of silver. That gave the tenant the right to work Solomon's land and receive some of its produce.

Some other ways to translate this meaning are:

Each of the farmers pays a thousand silver coins for the right to harvest its fruit.

For its fruit one would have to pay a thousand silver pieces. (NAB)

its fruit: The phrase its fruit refers to the fruit of Solomon's vineyard (grape farm). The grapes of that vineyard were expensive, and the tenants had to pay a fee of 1000 silver pieces.

a thousand shekels of silver: The phrase a thousand shekels of silver refers to a thousand silver coins. The name of this coin was the shekel. The phrase may also be used figuratively to refer to a very large amount of money. In some languages people are not familiar with silver or they do not use pieces of it as money. If

that is true in your language, another way to translate the meaning is:

a thousand silver coins

Song of Solomon 8:12

Section 8:5–14: Love has great power

In this final section, there are many key words and statements that repeat themes from earlier parts of the Song. For example, 8:5a mentions the woman coming up from the wilderness, as in 3:6. The author also repeats the themes of vineyard (8:12; 1:6), orchard (8:5; 2:3), and garden (8:13; 4:12–5:1). In the final verse of the Song, the author repeats the theme of a gazelle on the mountains, which was mentioned in 2:17. This final section also contains what many scholars consider a climax of the Song in 8:6–7.

Some other headings for this section are:

Homecoming (NRSV)

The Young Woman's Love for Her Beloved

Paragraph 8:11–12

In these verses the author mentioned a vineyard, as he did in 1:6. The verses probably imply that the value of true love (see 8:7c–d) is much greater than the value of wealth and power. King Solomon symbolized that type of power and riches. The text implies that a person should value love more than any amount of money.

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1. The woman spoke. For example, the NIV identifies the speaker as:

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1. The man spoke. For example, the GNT identifies the speaker as:

The Man (GNT) (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English versions. This interpretation fits well with the woman's comments about her vineyard in 1:6.

8:12a

But my own vineyard is mine to give;

- But my own vineyard belongs only to me.

- As for my vineyard, I am the one who takes care of it.

But my own vineyard is mine to give: In this verse the phrase my own vineyard is a metaphor. It does not refer to a literal vineyard. It refers to the woman herself and especially to her sexuality. When she said that the vineyard was for herself, she implied that she owned it. She alone would decide who to love, since she was now mature. Her brothers no longer controlled her [0](see 1:6 and 8:8–9).

Some ways to translate this part of the verse are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

But I tend my own vineyard myself. (NJB)

I, too, have a vineyard, and I myself decide what to do with its fruit.

- Use a simile. For example:

I myself am like the owner of a vineyard, and I decide what to do with all its fruit.

- Make the meaning of the metaphor more explicit. For example:

I alone decide whom I will love, just as the owner of a vineyard decides what to do with its fruit.

But my own vineyard: The phrase But my own vineyard is similar to the phrase in 1:6, where the woman referred to her body as “my own vineyard.” In that context her brothers made her work in the fields, and she was not able to take care of her body. Here in 8:12, the woman also compared her body to a vineyard. In this context she indicated that her own body belonged to her.

is mine to give: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as is mine to give is literally “is before me.” It implies that the woman should be the one to decide who to give her love to.

For more examples, refer to the first note on 8:12a.

8:12b

the thousand shekels are for you, O Solomon,

- Solomon can keep his thousand pieces of silver,
- I do not need a lot of money/silver to hire someone as Solomon does,

the thousand shekels are for you, O Solomon: The word O is not in the Hebrew text here. The BSB seems

to use it here to imply that the woman spoke what she thought of saying to Solomon. If a phrase like O Solomon wrongly implies that he was with her, you should translate in a different way. For example:

Solomon can keep his silver (CEV)

Solomon can take the thousand pieces of silver from others

That 25 pounds is yours, Solomon (GW)

the thousand shekels: The phrase, the thousand, refers to the thousand shekels of silver in 8:11c. The tenants paid these silver pieces to Solomon. The text may also imply that the tenants paid this amount for the opportunity of caring for his harem.

Some other ways to translate the thousand shekels are:

his thousand coins... (GNT)

a thousand pieces of silver (NLT)

for you, O Solomon: Here the woman seemed to speak directly to Solomon, but he was not with her when she spoke. She was thinking about what she would like to say to him. It is important to remember that the woman’s beloved contrasts with Solomon. He was not Solomon. In many languages it is more natural not to use direct speech or not to use a word like O. See the note above for translation examples.

In some languages it may be more natural to place Solomon at the end of the clause. For example:

The thousand shekels can remain with Solomon

keep your thousand pieces, O Solomon (REB)

Remember that the author mentioned Solomon here only as an illustration. He was not the woman’s beloved.

8:12c

and two hundred are for those who tend its fruit.

- and two hundred for the caretakers of its fruit. (NAB)
- and I do not need to pay anyone to care for it and pick its fruit.

and two hundred are for those who tend its fruit:

This clause is similar to 8:12b, and it includes some implied information from 8:12b and from 8:11d:

and the keepers of the fruit may have two hundred shekels of silver.

Some other ways to translate this part of the verse are:

and two hundred shekels belong to those who maintain it for its fruit. (NET)

and two hundred are for those who tend its fruit. (NIV)

and two hundred for the caretakers of its fruit. (NAB)

for those who tend its fruit: The phrase those who tend its fruit refers literally to men who take care of the grapevines and grapes in the grape farm. However, here it probably refers figuratively to the men who take care of women in Solomon's harem, who were Solomon's wives and concubines.

Some other ways to translate those who tend its fruit are:

those who take care of its fruit (GW)

those who guard the fruit

those who care for its vines (NLT)

Song of Solomon 8:13**Section 8:5–14: Love has great power**

In this final section, there are many key words and statements that repeat themes from earlier parts of the Song. For example, 8:5a mentions the woman coming up from the wilderness, as in 3:6. The author also repeats the themes of vineyard (8:12; 1:6), orchard (8:5; 2:3), and garden (8:13; 4:12–5:1). In the final verse of the Song, the author repeats the theme of a gazelle on the mountains, which was mentioned in 2:17. This final section also contains what many scholars consider a climax of the Song in 8:6–7.

Some other headings for this section are:

Homecoming (NRSV)

The Young Woman's Love for Her Beloved

Paragraph 8:13–14

These verses are a brief conversation between the man and woman that shows their deep desire for one another. It repeats themes from early in the book, including gardens, the voice of the beloved, and gazelles. It closes the book by repeating 2:17 with a gazelle bounding over the mountains.

8:13a**You who dwell in the gardens,**

- You who live in the gardens, (NCV)
- My love, you love to be/stay in the gardens,

You who dwell in the gardens: The man referred to the woman here as You who dwell in the gardens. In previous chapters, the woman was often in a garden or connected with a garden (and nature in general). A good example is the garden imagery of 4:12–5:1.

The phrase You who dwell in the gardens probably implies two meanings. The woman was in the gardens and she herself was like a garden. Figuratively, she was like a private garden for the man. The fragrances and tastes of the garden symbolize the pleasure that the woman gave him.

Some other ways to translate You who dwell in the gardens are:

you who sit in the gardens (NASB)

you love to be in gardens

Here the word You refers to the woman. In some languages it is helpful to make this clearer. For example:

my beloved, lingering in the gardens (NLT96)

My bride, you stay/linger in the gardens

gardens: Some English versions have “garden” referring to only one garden, but the Hebrew word is plural. The plural form probably implies that the man did not refer to one specific garden. In some languages it is more natural to use a singular form.

In 4:12, the man called the woman a garden locked up and a fountain sealed. Refer to how you translated “garden” there.

8:13b**my companions are listening for your voice.**

- my friends are listening for your voice.

- my companions are waiting to hear you speak. (GNT)

my companions are listening: Scholars have different views about who the word companions refers to in 8:13b.

1. The companions were male friends of the man. For example:

my friends are listening (REB) (BSB, NASB, NCV, NET, NJB, REB, RSV, GNT, NJB)

1. The companions were friends of the woman. For example:

your friends are listening (GW) (CEV, GW, NIV, NLT, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with more English versions. In the Hebrew text “friends” is masculine here (there is no word for my). The man’s male companions probably correspond to the woman’s female companions in 1:3–4. That helps the preface and epilogue of the Song to form an inclusio. This inclusio indicates that the Song is a unified poem.

are listening for your voice: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as are listening for your voice:

1. It indicates that the man’s companions want to hear the woman speak. They are alert so that they can hear her when she speaks. For example:

listen for your voice (NJB) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NET, NIV, NJB, NJPS, RSV, GNT)

1. It indicates that the man’s companions are listening to the woman’s voice as she speaks. For example:

are listening to your voice (GW) (GW, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English versions. However, interpretation (2) also has good support from commentaries. Some other ways to translate interpretation (1) are:

wait to hear you speak

want to hear your voice

8:13c

Let me hear it!

- Let me hear your voice! (NIV)
- I also want to hear you speak!

Let me hear it!: The phrase Let me hear it contrasts with 8:13b. The man’s companions were listening for the woman’s voice, but the man wanted to be the person that she spoke to. The phrase clearly repeats the theme of 2:14d, which says, “let me hear your voice.” Translate in a similar way here. See the notes for 2:14d–e for further discussion.

it!: The word it refers to the woman’s voice.

Song of Solomon 8:14

Section 8:5–14: Love has great power

In this final section, there are many key words and statements that repeat themes from earlier parts of the Song. For example, 8:5a mentions the woman coming up from the wilderness, as in 3:6. The author also repeats the themes of vineyard (8:12; 1:6), orchard (8:5; 2:3), and garden (8:13; 4:12–5:1). In the final verse of the Song, the author repeats the theme of a gazelle on the mountains, which was mentioned in 2:17. This final section also contains what many scholars consider a climax of the Song in 8:6–7.

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8:14a

Come away, my beloved,

- Come quickly, my love,
- Hurry, my beloved, (NJPS)

Come away: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as Come away has several meanings. BDB (page 137–138) lists the following meanings: 1. go or pass through, 2. flee, 3. hasten, come quickly. BDB indicates that here in Song 8:14, it has meaning 3, “to hasten.” Here it means “hasten.” The woman urged the man to hurry away from where he was and go to the mountain

of spices (8:14c). She probably wanted to be with him there.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

Hurry (NASB)

Come quickly to me

my beloved: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as my beloved occurs 19 times in the Song. It first occurs in 1:13a–b. There the woman used it to refer to the man, and here she used it to address him directly. It is good to translate this word in the same way in all the verses where she used it to refer to him.

8:14b

and be like a gazelle or a young stag

- like a gazelle or a young stag
- run as fast/swiftly as a deer, a strong young deer

and be like a gazelle or a young stag: This clause is a simile that compares the man to a gazelle or young stag. “Gazelles” and “stags” (male deer) are beautiful animals that run fast and are sure-footed in the mountains. The woman implied that she wanted the man to come just as quickly (and joyfully) to their meeting place. In some languages it is helpful to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

Move like a swift gazelle or a young deer (NLT96)

Run like a gazelle or a young stag (GW)

See the notes on 2:9a–b and 2:17c–d for more discussion.

8:14c

on the mountains of spices.

- on spice-covered mountains.
- to the hills of spices! (NJPS)

on the mountains of spices: The phrase mountains of spices has both a literal and a figurative meaning. Literally, it refers to a gazelle or stag bounding across mountains where spices grow. As a metaphor, it refers to the woman herself as the mountains of spices. That implies that the woman was as delightful and beautiful as the mountains where many delightful spices grow.

See the note on 4:6c–d for a discussion of a closely related statement: I will make my way to the mountain of myrrh and to the hill of frankincense.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

on the mountains of precious spice plants.

on the mountains where spices grow. (NCV)

spices: The author referred to spices throughout the Song (for example, 4:6; 4:10; 4:14; 5:1; 6:2). Most of these verses refer to the woman. They imply that she was beautiful and exciting, especially in the ways that she showed her love to the man. Translate the word as you translated it in previous verses.

General Comments on Song of Songs

This is a summary of important points to remember as you interpret and translate the Song.

1. The genre of the Song is “love poetry.” It describes the love between a woman and a man. (The Song is not an allegory, drama or marriage manual.)
2. The Song is part of Scripture, and it is inspired by God. God created men and women with sexual natures. It is a good part of our humanity and is blessed by God.
3. It is important to assume the same moral principles and reserved tone that the author used. He rarely referred to sexual activity, and he always used subtle ways to refer to it (for example, in 5:1). He focused on the ways that the man and woman committed themselves to each other more than on their sexual relations.
4. Since the Song is poetry, try to translate it as poetry, rather than as a story or drama. Seek artistic ways to translate its poetry and emotional impact into your own language.
5. The Song is not arranged as a story. It repeats themes and imagery in a creative way.
6. Translate the Song’s poetic images in ways that communicate the same effects in your language. The author used plants, animals, flowers, gardens, streams, and mountains to show that the man and woman were in harmony with the world that God created.
7. The Song has a message for all people. It illustrates that sexual relations within marriage are right and good, and God blesses them. People should honor marriage and be grateful for it. The Song reminds people that it is God who created human beings to love each other. It also reminds us that God created us to love him and to have a close and satisfying relationship with him.